Kingdom of Blood

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34536886.

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Explicit

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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by Faded_Glory

Summary

The corruption of the First Ones continues to threaten Etheria. As Adora begins to unravel the roots of her magic and the true extent of the power she wields as She-Ra. The bonds of love, family and friendship are pushed to their limits as our hero's struggle onward to heal the scars of the past.

Notes

Welcome back to another instalment of my story. I am really enjoying writing this thing. I am very devoted to updating every week and have been diligent so far. So it does take up a-lot of my time and brain power...I have maps...drawings....and plotlines...timelines...tons of research! So I had decided just to acknowledge all my comments at the end of each part instead of individually. I hope that's ok. I have finished this part and am now in the process of editing and making sure the storyline stays consistent and exciting. Feedback is always appreciated. Anyways, on with the pain and suffering. LOL..and always a happy ending...eventually...

Andromeda's Children

The crew of children kept to themselves for the rest of the day. While Brojee wandered around the battered, smoking remains of their ship, surveying the damage. Caz and Drissi donned heavy tool belts and hauled out various pieces of scrap, tubing and boxes of smaller, high tech components. The two boys worked together to pound out dents and wield together metal sheeting to patch the holes in the outer hull. Reattaching broken tubes and rewiring conduits, replacing various other ports and tech casings along the outer hull. While Litha had retreated inside the ship, sulking or repairing the Etherian's never knew. Bow had offered to help Brojee with repairs, but was quickly turned down. He remained nearby, sitting on the beach tinkering with his trick arrows. While Entrapa crouched beside him, scanning the readings from the beacon on her data pad, while keeping a close eye on Brojee and the other boys whenever they left the ship. Glimmer had retreated into Darla, hauling Adora along with her for the afternoon. Picking up on Catra’s rising ire at the blonde’s reckless behavior and interceding before an argument took place. So now Catra and Melog scouted down the coastline. Wanting to make sure their camping spot for the night would be secure. She was so furious with Adora, she needed some time alone to sort out her feelings. Thankful that Sparkles was highly observant to her moods, more so than Adora who had at first insisted on going with her. Until Glimmer intervened, thank the Seven Kingdoms. Stating that if Adora wanted to eat this evening, then she needed to help her track down some of Mara's rations...if there was anything left in the hold after the refugee's from Mystacor had been in there. In truth Adora's supper was never in jeporady since Bow and Entapta had already stocked the ship with supplies. But it was enough of a threat to get Adora to relent and trudge after Glimmer. Catra was very thankful for the queen. Her fear and anxiety was knotted so tight inside her. She doubted she would

have been able to hold her tongue if Adora had come with her. Resulting in a torrent of very honest, yet hurtful words to spew from her mouth.

The sun was beginning to set, as Catra crossed the beach back towards the two ships. Her anger had softened into bitter acceptance as she walked. Working through her conflicted feelings with Melog had helped. She had come to understand that it wasn't only the trauma from the Northern Reach that drove her fear and anxiety over a corrupted She-Ra. But also her residual resentments towards that magic that had stolen her best friend. Placing a destiny, a responsibility upon Adora's shoulders that slowly crushed her, until she was willing to sacrifice herself to see it through. Now again, that power was changing...seeking to take more from her...more then any person should have to give up.

Their last conversation at the Steam Grotto, had left her shaken. Adora's self worth had always hinged on what she could do for others, how useful she was. But compared to the amazing things, She-Ra could accomplish, Adora herself just didn't rate. Those brutal thoughts were there...seeded deep inside her like a spreading bruise. Tarnishing the beauty that was Adora herself. If she had a chance to be She-Ra and give up being Adora...kill the human side of her...would she do it?

This Despara persona of the Magic was it a virus left over from the infected disk? Or was it part of the primordial magic? A darker, more violent and vengeful version of She-Ra that was now awoken since the power within the Heart had been released?

This version of She-Ra was a part of Adora herself. The magic was no longer bound to the First Ones relic. It was now being channeled through Adora's body, pure and unfiltered by runes or glyphs. She had witnessed the intensity of that raw power glowing behind Adora's eyes more than once. It had been awe inspiring and frightening at the same time. It changed her so drastically, yet it was not like before. With the relic, the magic overpowered

Adora and changed her into something else entirely. Something strange and alien and unnatural and not Adora at all. Without the relic, the magic flowed through Adora's own body. Changing her into a more powerful, ethereal version of herself. So if she changed into Despara...would she be an enraged, out of control beast like back at the Northern Reach...or just another incarnation of a more powerful Adora? A goddess like being driven by different intentions then hope and love?

These turbulent thoughts ebbed and flowed from her like the sea, as she mulled over all the aspects of her worries with Melog. She cast her somber gaze out over the shimmering water, admiring how the sea seemed to glow with the mirror image of the sky. The iridescent hues of the sunset clouds above shimmered upon the waves. Yet the image it cast was more vibrant than the sky above, the cresting waves sparkled like starlight, as the fiery ball of Adarion sank upon the watery horizon. For being in such an eerie, scary place the water that surrounded the island was beautiful, almost magical. It gave one a false sense of normalcy. As if this place was just like the rest of Etheria and not trying to kill them. Catra took a deep, cleansing breath and began the evening song. Deciding to sing the love song she had been working on in secret since their brief time back in the Fright Zone.

"I watched you walk away,

You never heard me say,

I need you, I love you.

Stay with me...

I don't want to let you go. " She turned her face towards the setting sun. Adarion seemed to flare as the star sank into the waves, bathing Catra's serene face with it's eternal flame.

"What's left of me,...

What's left of me,

Now your gone, " Her voice echoed mournfully in the falling twilight, as she walked down the beach. Her hands curling into fists as she relived and purged the hurt and pain from those moments. Laying bare her heart towards Adarion and seeking comfort.

"I'm falling...

I'm drowning...

in my rage,

in my sins,

in my lies.

I'm broken inside." Catra's voice began to change as she sang. No longer just the simple harmony of song, but now vibrating with magic. Her body began to glow, with the same Immortal flame as Adarion itself. As she began to commune with the essence of

her magic.

"When your all, I ever needed.

When your all, I ever wanted.

Your smile,

your laugh,

Your are everything...

Your are everything....

that makes me whole.

Your my sanctuary, my sanctuary..." Her words echoed brokenly into the coming night, full of love and regret. Melog's mane glowed in the same magical state as Catra. As their feline body hummed with the cadence of her voice. The mist of their mane and tail, vibrating and rippling as she sang. A pleased smile spread upon the creature's slender muzzle as their ears swiveled to listen avidly to her twilight serenade. As her song ended, Melog's gentle voice spoke in her mind.

(Your voice is truly amazing...it has... power, master.)

"Really?" Catra glanced down at them with a curious if cautious expression. She was just getting used to having magic, she wasn't ready to deal with more powers. "Don't call me master, we're friends. Please call me Catra, anything but master. I don't like it.

Alright." She chastised Melog.

(I am sorry, it is merely a habit. I have only formed a link with my masters. I shall try harder to call you by name.) Melog nodded, as Catra gave them a gentle pat on the top of the head.

"How many master's have you had?" Catra inquired a few minutes later.

(Several...I remember each one vividly. I was not always on Krytis, I traveled the cosmos with my masters. Long before Prime started his conquests.) Melog began, Catra gasped in shock. She knew Melog was old having lived on Krytis over a thousand years ago during Prime's Occupation. But from the sounds of it, they were far older...an ancient being...something Immortal?

"My last master died in the Great Unrest….Mara's war. He gave me the power to drive Prime off Krytis. Then he merely faded away

along with all life on Krytis.) Melog's voice was matter of fact, as if reciting historical events. As if they had no real attachment to the past. It was unsettling and Catra wondered if they would outlive her? If they would recount their time together with so little emotion.

Melog picked up on her unease and sat down, blinking up at her in confusion.

"Do you even miss them…" Catra released a long, drawn out breath. Rolling her shoulders and confronting them with a slightly affronted air.

(I mirror the emotions of my master's, so that I may better aid them. I am incapable of feeling's myself.) Melog stated.

"You seemed rather upset about me not sleeping and almost getting killed back in the Whispering Woods." Catra braced her hands on her hips, a knowing smile pulling on her lips. They might profess not to have emotions of their own, but she knew better. It wasn't the first time Melog had called her out on her destructive behaviors. At the end of the war. They let her run away for a short time, but then stopped and forced her to confront her true feelings about Adora. Ultimately she turned around and went back and thank the stars, she did. Her happy ending would have never happened if Melog had let her keep running.

Melog huffed, their cheeks vibrating against their teeth indignantly. As they reviewed Catra's memories of them acting very protective and rather parental towards her on several occasions.

(Perhaps, my link with you and your magic is changing me, more than I know?) They conceded.

"Or, you are not just a tool. Melog. You are your own being, capable of feelings and wants and needs just like the rest of us. I will never treat you like a servant, or a tool, like you have been treated in the past. I am not your master...I am your friend." She

crouched down in front of them and wrapped her arms around their slender neck. Drawing them into a warm, affectionate embrace. Melog's purr was loud and full of appreciation. They had never been treated like an equal. It was odd but not unwelcome.

Catra found Adora sitting on the sand several yards away from the ships. Just beyond the gently lapping waves of the low tide. She had her legs pulled up slightly, resting her crossed arms over her knees. Her chin tucked into the cross of her arms. Her demeanor was quiet, reflective. Curled in on herself, as if trying to contain all the emotions and destructive thoughts that were seeking to pull her apart. Her maroon cape fluttered behind her in the warm breeze, which encroached from the ocean in sudden bursts. Tossing her long, blonde ponytail over her shoulder, only to flip it back over her front a few moments later. A few loose strands of hair, curled down her cheeks. Snapping across the bridge of her nose, when buffeted by the wind. She ignored them, far too deep in her contemplations to care. She was staring out over the darkening water, her steel blue eyes were moist. As the light of day faded below the ocean in the distance, the deeper blues of nightfall washed the sky high above. Stars began to twinkle within that darker backdrop. As the gentle ambiance of the first greater moon was rising over the horizon, casting the cresting waves in a silver gleam.

Catra settled herself down beside Adora, a silent companion to her troubled thoughts. Adora swallowed a few times, refusing to look away from the moon rise.

"Before we made it back to the Velvet Glove to rescue you, Darla had to make an emergency landing on the remains of a planet Horde Prime had destroyed. The ship needed more Thulite Crystals." Adora slid her gaze briefly to Catra, her arms falling to her sides. Her hand now resting upon the sand between them. Catra met her brief look with a concerned frown, reaching out and curling her fingers around Adora's hand in subtle support.

"We met a group of travelers trying to get Thulite for their own ship. They called themselves the Star Siblings... " Adora took a deep breath, seeking to calm her voice as it suddenly started to tremble.

"We talked a bit, before the planet started tearing itself apart. They were just like these kids... jaded, full of bitterness and hopelessness...just struggling to survive. They lived each day like it might be their last, they had no goals for the future. They didn't trust anyone. They attacked me, expecting the worst from strangers. They barely had enough food...but Starla shared her rations anyway. They had been jumping from star system to star system trying to stay as far away from Horde Primes occupied worlds as they could. " Adora sighed and dug the heel of her boot into the sand, carving a short canal that was quickly filled with water as the tide rushed in.

"I don't know what happened to those three growing up, but they didn't have a good childhood. Horde Prime must have destroyed their planet. They must have grown up hopping planets, scavenging what remained of other worlds just like these kids. I thought growing up in the Horde was hard. But we at least had adults that kinda looked out for us, teaching us useful skills and making us study. We had a roof over our heads and food every day. We had to earn it, but we had a safe and secure place to call home. Those three grew up depending only on each other. Tall Star was the oldest and she was also the most cynical and overly protective of her younger siblings. She had lost both her arms and both her legs, somehow. She had them replaced with Cybernetics. It frightens me to think of what terrible event must have left her body so broken? Jewel Star was missing his right eye and had it replaced with a piece of cybernetic tech...he wore a visor over his eyes to help him see. Something must have happened to him too. I don't think they would willingly have parts of their bodies replaced unless they had too. Starla was the only one whose body was still intact. At least as far I could see." Adora was silent for a long time, Catra gripped her hand tight. Watching her expressions change from grim melancholy to fierce determination.

“I just wanted to give Brojee and those kids something to believe in. Someone to...believe in. Who could make things better...fix things so that their lives would improve.” She cast her eyes to the stars above, flopping backwards onto the sand, pulling Catra down with her. Catra squeaked as she was suddenly yanked backward. Landing on her side, staring at Adora’s profile fondly. She curled up instinctively against the blondes' side, growling playfully as if disgruntled.
“Angry, cuddles...really?” Adora chuckled, gripping her more firmly and rubbing her shoulder tenderly. It wasn’t the first time Catra had made that low, growling purr. Adora had been on the receiving end of that sound many times in the past. Usually whenever she didn’t take Catra’s feelings into account before doing something reckless.

Catra huffed, resting her chin on Adora’s collarbone. Tracing over the fabric of her long sleeve shirt, where the FailSafe scar would be hidden beneath.

“I get it, Adora. I do.” Catra breathed, “She just scares me sometimes.” She admitted weakly.

“She-Ra?” Adora breathed, her tone sad, resigned.

Catra merely nodded.

“Oh, Catra.” Adora moaned, placing a sweet kiss to the top of her head. “I wish I could take away your fear. It’s my fault you're scared of her. But I can’t just stop being She-Ra...she’s been a part of me for nearly three years. I have got to figure out what is going on with my magic and fix it!” She snarled, pounding the sand with the fist of her free hand.

Catra sighed, “Patience is a virtue.” She advised with a bit of snark.

“Which I do not possess.” Adora reminded her, turning her body slightly, to cup her cheek with her free hand.

“I am sorry I scared you by calling on my sword.” Adora offered, “It was reckless. I get that.”

Catra grunted in affirmation, “We will fix your magic. I promise. But until then you need to practice some restraint. She-Ra is not the cure for every problem.”

Adora chuckled, arching an eyebrow at Catra with incredulity. Then huffed and thumped her head back down in resignation. Her flippant disregard was not appreciated, with the serious frown Catra was offering her. Her girlfriend did not like how dependent she was on her magic, as if Adora was incapable of being useful.

“I need to help them...I need to get out there and make things better, help the other...what did Brojee call us?” Adora muttered, as she popped herself up on her elbow.

“Masters of the Universe.” Catra huffed in a clipped tone.

“Yeah...I can bring magic back and heal the Universe.” Adora breathed, an eager, hopeful smile pulling on her lips as she stared down at Catra.

“There is so much out there...Adora...it could take years to heal the universe from thousands of years of war.” Catra sighed heavily.

“But I’m not alone...I’ll find that He-Man and maybe the other Masters and we can all work together?” She flopped back down on her back. Casting her gaze upward to the blanket of starlight spreading over the clear night sky. Her eyes are shining with hope and yearning to get out there and do some real good.

Catra rolled away, leaning the back of her head against Adora’s shoulder. Staring up at the night sky. Her mind churned with anxiety at the unknown that lay ahead of them, when they left the planet. Wishing that she could be as obliviously hopeful that things would all work out like her beloved blonde.

“Supper!” Glimmer’s voice rang out over the beach.

Adora's stomach growled on cue and she giggled. Gently extracting herself from Catra and climbing to her feet. She offered the feline a hand up and they walked back to the ships in silence. Catra had been given her own mission, to bring her people home. To rebuild their kingdom and give them back the security and future stolen from them a thousand years ago. She wondered bleakly if her mission could coincide with Adora’s, or if that might be the catalyst that might tear them apart again. She was having a hard time believing that the moments of happiness she enjoyed now would last.

Melog snapped their tail, flicking Catra with it in the side as they padded ahead. Catra cringed at the sudden sharp pain, rubbing her side ruefully as her feline companion cast her a stern look over their shoulder. Chastising her silently for brooding on what if’s. Catra rolled her eyes and smiled, jogging towards the fire glyph glowing in the sand between the two ships. Glimmer, Bow and Entrapta were already sitting around the glyph sharing a plate of Glimmers now famous ‘Darla Dumplings’. They had eaten those at least once every week during their trip home. It had become a cherished meal that they all shared together...just the five of them. She promised herself she would try and be happy, enjoy the time she had with Adora, with her friends and stop worrying about a future she couldn’t control. Take each day as it came and appreciate the good she had.

“You're welcome to join us?” Bow offered, standing just beyond the group, crowded around the fire glyph. Caz and Drissi were sitting at the top of their cargo ramp, now dressed in regular clothes. The red headed boy, had on a pair of light green cargo pants with lots of pockets and simple cotton long sleeve shirt. He had the sleeves bunched up over to his elbows, he had pair of scuffed up white shoes that looked old and grey. Drissi was

dressed in dark blue pants and black boots. With a white tank top with a leather vest over top. He was a slightly portly boy, his stomach rolled over the waist of his pants as he sat on the ramp. His thick bare arms flexing, as he was popping little brown balls of something into his mouth from a tin bowl. The two boys shared a look then shook their heads, no. Bow's shoulders slumped in dejection but he accepted their answer. Returning to their fire glyph and sitting down next to Glimmer. Pulling his lute into his lap. He began to strum, tuning the frets. Allowing the dumplings to cool before digging in.

Glimmer listened absently, smiling and laughing at Adora and Catra as they bemoaned to each other how much trouble they would be in with Lonnie when they got back.

"What kind of punishment do you think she has in mind for our defection?" Adora mused, lifting her cloak up inviting Catra to snuggle against her side. Then reached down and plucked a hot dumpling off the plate. Cringing as it burned her fingers, tossing it briefly from hand to hand, then blowing on it and taking small bites. Keeping it moving inside her mouth, too impatient and hungry to let it cool.

"Depends on how long we're gone. Either way, it will be cruel and unusual, knowing Lonnie." Catra chuckled, sharing a meaningful look with Glimmer. Who was giggling at Adora. Catra shook her head, watching with amusement, as her idiot girlfriend fought to swallow the hot food.

"I'll get you guys back in a blink, after we get this First Ones ruin locked down again." Glimmer responded, turning to confront Entrapta. Who was seated on the far side of the glyph, with her portable computer system. Engrossed in the readings scrolling over her screens.

"I can't seem to use my backdoor to get into the mainframe like last time. The Security Protocol has sealed all routes into the system. It's stuck in a feedback loop…" Entrapta scratched her head, then typed again on her keypad.

“So we gotta access the system from the main terminal?” Bow muttered bitterly.

“Great.” Catra huffed.

“You got it!” Entrapta exclaimed eagerly.

“We have a small army of Laser Bears to deal with before we can even get close to that beacon.” Adora waved an disgruntled arm towards the shadowed silhouette of the jungle in the distance.

“I could just blink you guys past them?” Glimmer offered.

“You’ve never been there?” Bow started, “You need a visual to concentrate on or a person who is already there to hone in on to blink accurately.”

Glimmer growled and cast Bow, a disgruntled scowl. “Thanks…for the support.”

“My spine can not take another six or seven tries for you to teleport randomly to a location you’ve never seen.” Bow responded back, reminding Glimmer of the fiasco of teleporting out of that hole in the Crimson Waste.

Catra frowned in confusion, as Adora started to laugh. Remembering how badly Glimmer struggled to blink them out of that hole Huntara had trapped them in.

“So we gotta be stealthy.” Adora nodded, once she calmed down.

“Which is where me and Melog come in. If I can get past those bears and into the ruin, then Glimmer can blink the rest of you to my location.” Catra nodded, pulling away from Adora knowing she would not like that plan at all. Snatching up a dumpling and nibbling on the outer shell. Humming with pleasure as she enjoyed something that had become comfort food for her over the last few seasons.

Glimmer took note of her pleasure over her food and smiled proudly.

“I like it!” Glimmer raised a hand in agreement. While Bow nodded.

“You're not going anywhere without me.” Adora stated, her eyes stern and broaching no argument.

“Didn’t think I could.” Catra smirked, bumping her shoulder against hers. “But that will limit my abilities to sneak past them. I was hoping to use the trees to climb over their heads?” She added, trying to deter Adora.

“No ones stopping you, I’ll just be trailing you on the ground and if any of those beasts get a bead on you. I’ll distract them so you can keep going.” Adora responded.

“You are going to need more than just that long stick of yours to get those beasts' attention.” Brojee’s voice cut into their meeting, as he nodded towards Adora's quarter staff on her back. He was also out of his space suit, dressed in a pair of shiny black pants made of a thin, breathable material and dark combat boots. With a simple marron shirt, that hung low over his well muscles chest and a tan leather aviator's coat with a fur lined hood. The arms sported all kinds of patches and the chest was full of all manner of pins and broaches from his travels across the galaxy. He dropped a crate full of blaster’s like what they used to defend themselves from Michelle earlier.

“I could have Michelle draw them away as well.” Entrapta offered, finishing off her dumpling in a couple bites then crawling over to the crate to inspect the weapons. Her face alight with eager curiosity.

“What are these?” Adora leaned over the crate and pulled out a blaster. The gun had a balanced weight, with a short barrel and chunky trigger. The power-pack for the energy shots was housed

in the grip. The narrow seams of the magazine glowed with a bright green light, similar to a stun baton.

“These are Thulite energy pistols.” Brojee crouched down and pulled out a gun. He quickly dismantled the casing, setting each piece down in front of Entrapta who inspected the pieces avidly. “We can easily recharge the battery packs with our engines. So they are used by most Scrapper’s out there.”

“Our engine has a Thulite drive…” Entrapta picked up the square energy pack, her magenta eyes narrowing in interest. “Why do the bolts glow green, when the Thulite crystals are pink?” She asked.

“Oh, it’s all part of the refraction conversion between the Thulite and the blaster battery-pack.” Brojee dismantled the battery showing Entrapta the micro circuitry inside.

“Oh…” Entrapta nodded, as Bow moved in to try and learn this new technology.

“Could I adapt those bolts into my bow?” He asked, pointing to the glowing balls inside the magazine.

“No, attached to an arrowhead, your bow’s draw is too slow. Those bolts would explode and kill you if you tried.” Brojee stated. “You would need a more powerful, faster draw from your bow to get those projectiles moved far away enough to explode where you want them.”

Bow nodded, his sight drawing inward as he began to calculate and develop new ways to power up his bow’s draw. He was going to need a stronger weapon, eventually. He already felt rather outgunned against Primes bots during the war. When they went out into the universe again, he would need a better arsenal to call upon to be useful.

“Do those bolts stun or kill?” He asked, setting the magazine down lightly.

“Either, you can set the power frequency of the charge.” Brojee picked up an intact blaster and showed Bow the tiny button that set the gun’s charge.

“Are you offering us these weapons?” Glimmer asked

“Hell, no. These are in trade for the scrap we took.” He answered with a roguish smile.

“I want to go over your inventory first, make sure it’s a good deal.” Entrapta stood up, heading for the ramp to Brojee’s ship.

Brojee palmed his face in frustration.

“You will return those data crystals though! Those are not part of our trade.” She finished in a sharp, uncompromising tone.

Brojee rolled his eyes and followed Entrapta up the ramp, since she just stormed into his ship like she owned the place.

The next few hours passed, as they watched Entrapta barter enthusiastically with Brojee. Taking all manner of strange tech from the other worlds out of his hold and into Darla in exchange for the tech they had scavenged from the ruin.

A strange echoing tone sounded from the speakers inside Brojee’s ship. Caz and Drissi, who had been helping Brojee barter tech inside the hold, stopped opening crates and got comfortable on the floor of the hold. Brojee moved swiftly to Entrapta, who was digging through yet another crate of tech components and spoke in a hushed voice.

“If you want, you can go get the others. This is the Andromeda Frequency, we tune into it every time it streams over the com’s. It’s important you guys start listening to the universal com’s as well.”

"Ok." Entrapta strode out of the hold by her hair, returning moments later with Glimmer, Bow, Adora and Catra. Glimmer and Bow sat on the floor near the ramp. While Adora and Catra leaned against the wall beside them.

"What is the Andromeda Frequency?" Glimmer inquired as the odd, ethereal tones faded away.

"You'll find out." Brojee crossed his arms over his chest and leaned against a large crate taller than him on the other side of the hold.

The tones shifted into a slow beat, slowly turning into soft music. With a graceful melody of strings and the light airy sounds of flutes. In moments a gentle voice began to sing.

(Do you still have faith in me...Do you believe I can save….what's left of us...

Don't give up, Don't give in…

Open your heart...Take the moments as they come…Hold love close.

Don't lose hope, Don't lose yourself …

Do you still have faith in me...Do you believe I can save...what's left of us…)

The soft, melancholy beat faded, as the voice grew silent. A few moments passed before an elegant, gentle baritone echoed from the speakers within the hold.

"Hello, my cosmic children. Andromeda Stardust here, speaking to you from the depths of the void once again. To offer you respite from your struggle. Sit back, relax and enjoy these moments for what they are. Know that you are not alone out there. I am here for you, to give you strength, to give you hope. That the reality that surrounds you is not as dark and cold as you have come to believe."

Another song played, it was more upbeat and catchy. Mostly strings and drums with no lyrics. The voice returned, speaking softly about the song and what planet it came from. Then leading into another song, the playlist was eclectic and ranged from slow, sad ballads to fast paced rock songs. After each song, Andromeda would explain what planet it came from and a brief antidote about the people who created it. Some of the songs came from long dead worlds, others barely alive and struggling, some were scarred like Etheria able to heal. In time Glimmer, Bow, Adora and Catra settled on the floor of the hold. Entrapta sat on a cushion of her hair, listening to the music but had divided her attention to her data pad as well.

The music faded away. Replaced by Andromeda's soothing voice. "Got some shout outs from the Tri- Solar System for anyone willing to lend a hand. Prince Joel of Antares has a small robot uprising on his hands. He could use some scrappers and mechanics to help repair and subdue rouge machines."

Entrapta interest was instantly peeked, she looked up from her pad. An eager gleam in her eyes to go to Antares and investigate the tech herself.

"Entrapta?" Glimmer warned, catching the tech crazy princesses eye.

"Right, right...focus, Entrapta...Patience Entrapta." Entrapta muttered, nodding and resuming her work on her pad.

Adora smiled, she was eager to get out there too. This com channel they were listening to was making the wider universe all too real. Adventure awaited them and she was more than ready to get back out there and do some real good.

Catra looked wary, brooding at her feet with her arms crossed over her stomach. Melog chirped and butted their head against her thigh. Catra sighed and gave them a scratch behind the ears. The unknown out there in the universe made her uneasy.

“Minister Cloudfoot, of the island of Purrsia on Eternia has reached out on the com’s. The magicat's are seeking aid, several ancient Horde bots from the Uprising. That they had been using as harvesters, went berserk. They have burned their crops and their food supply is now very low. His people need supplies of any kind and medical aid as well.” Andromeda pleaded.

Catra’s ears twitched and she raised her head in interest. Those would be the kidnapped descendants of her people. The ones her mother wanted her to bring home...to Serenia.

“Why isn’t King Randor helping?” Catra asked, Brojee. Listening to Jitsu’s conversations with Adora about her family gave her some idea of Eternia’s royalty. Adora’s father had the most power and available resources to help.

“The House of Grayskull and Purrsia do not get along, they have been at odds for generations.” Brojee shrugged. “Eternia barely has enough resources right now to care for its own people on the mainland. The Up Rising a thousand years ago, left their sky scorched. It’s difficult to grow food, most of the land is barren. “ Brojee explained.

Adora’s expression fell into a grim frown of understanding, of the struggle her family must be going through right now. Trying to survive on a slowly dying world, ravaged by the First’s Ones war with Prime.

“What about...Prince Adam? He couldn’t possibly have the same prejudice as his father. Would he offer aid to the Magicats?” Adora asked.

“Prince Adam has been missing for over three years.” Brojee responded.

Adora gasped, her eyes suddenly filling with tears. The sudden realization that her long lost brother had disappeared hitting her hard.

Catra quickly clasped her hand, offering comfort. As Glimmer and Bow looked uncertainly up at her. The timing of the Princes disappearance was rather coincidental to the time frame in which Adora found the Sword of Protection.

“What about this He-Man...could he help?” Catra offered.

He-Man and his rebels mostly survive on the charity of the planets they save. Hopping from planet to planet, offering aid and fighting off Skeletor’s forces. Doing whatever is needed to free us from his tyranny. They were last on Primus, overseeing ceasefire negotiations between two rival military groups. It will be a-lot easier to free Horde occupied worlds, now that Horde Prime is gone.” Brojee nodded towards Adora with a grateful smile. Adora did not look up to see his offer of support, still staring forlorn down at the deck trying to come to terms with the fact she might never get the chance to meet her brother.

“If he listens to the Andromeda Frequency and is able to travel back to Eternia, most likely he will go and help the Magicats.” Brojee nodded.

“Have you ever met He-Man?” Adora swallowed her grief slowly raising her head as she asked, her expression hopeful once more.

“No, we grew up on an outer world known as Spira. It was destroyed in our war with a mutant overlord called Maxis. Our people were enslaved and forced to mine the Ice planet of Omega-4. I was able to escape a few years back, got my sister Litha and two other kids off that planet. We’ve never gone back, that would be instant death.” Brojee responded, casting Caz and Drissi a small smile. They had all left family and friends back there and they all had regrets about saving only themselves.

“What’s a mutant?” Bow asked.

“They are like a Hybrid” Drissi nodded towards Catra.

“But their all ugly and mostly look like beasts.” Caz shrugged.

“Mostly?” Glimmer inquired.

“Their second in command looks human enough, but she’s a mutant.” Drissi shrugged.

“I ran into an insect-man, Modoluk.” Catra stated. “Is he a mutant?”

“He’s King Randor’s head scientist.” Brojee responded. “Was he your Eternian problem?”

“He was harvesting our people and animals.” Catra spat back with contempt.

“Well, that’s normal. Eternia harvests other planets for resources and their slave trade.” Brojee nodded.

Glimmer went pale and Adora gasped, casting her eyes downward in shame this time. This dark discovery suddenly made her rather disgusted with her heritage. It seems her family was not something to be proud of. They were callous and uncaring towards other people who shared their planet. Ruthless, opportunistic rulers who preyed upon other worlds to better themselves. Catra gave her hand a quick squeeze of reassurance. Adora glanced over to her and offered her a small, weak smile. Her mind is churning...with these unpleasant revelations.

“Sorta, We captured a guy named Jitsu and we got some other guy called Tri-clops causing trouble with Seeker Drones.” Glimmer nodded.

“Those guys work for Skeletor, I think we need to get off planet quickly. Sorry, but we can’t get mixed up in that kind of trouble.” Brojee was suddenly very scared, glancing back at the two boys who looked just as stricken.

A cold dread blanketed Adora as she saw how frightened the three boys looked.

“Who is this Skeletor?” Catra inquired.

“He was Horde Primes, right hand for the last several hundred years. He enforced order and subdued many uprisings on Horde controlled worlds. He’s supposed to be undead, a very scary and evil Sorcerer and his minions can’t be defeated. Their tech is powered by dark magic and they can’t die.`Brojee stated, “At least that’s what I’ve heard.”

“No, they can die.” Catra snapped back smugly. “I took out a small army of Husks already.” She gave Brojee a toothy grin as she released Adora’s hand, flexing her claws for emphasis of how deadly she could be.

Glimmer cast her a concerned look, killing was not something to be proud of. While Bow glanced at Adora. Finding the blonde blinking at her feet, staring in horror at the ground. Not really paying much attention, still reeling from Brojee’s words.

Andromeda’s voice drew them all away from their grim thoughts. “I have found a very spooky tale for you all. Dragged from the depths of the Phantos historical archive.” She began to recite an epic tale of love, loss and betrayal. That centered around a spurned lover and their quest for revenge. That ended up creating a plague that ravaged the village that the story was set in. Eventually, the lover who betrayed the protagonist died. The spurned woman who’s need for revenge caused all this strife, was cursed to become a wraith. That was forced to walk the land of the living for all eternity. Never to know the love or affection of another person ever again.

“That was worse than the scary stories Shadow Weaver would tell us at bedtime.” Catra muttered, her ears pinned back and trembling slightly.

Adora nodded, wrapping an arm around her shoulders seeking comfort herself. Bow was pale and wide eyed, he never liked ghost stories. Glimmer was huddled beside him, just as unnerved by the creepy story, her arms wrapped protectively around his bare waist. While Entrapta was completely unfazed, so absorbed

in her research on her pad she had barely paid attention to the story.

“Superstition is silly. There is no reason to be scared of something that scientifically can not exist.” Entrapta stated, shaking her head in disbelief.

“Perhaps wraiths do not exist here on Etheria, but on the planet of Phantos. Who’s magic is governed by the Dark Dimension and who’s queen is supposed to be a She-Demon. It is very possible.” Drissi commented, his eyes wide with fear.

“We are never visiting Phantos.” Bow stated.

Glimmer nodded in agreement.

Catra rolled her eyes, pretending to not be affected by the ghost story any longer.

While Adora nodded enthusiastically along with Glimmer.

"Interesting..." Entrapta muttered, suddenly very intrigued by this planet Phantos.

“It’s been a while but I’ve got some good news for you this time, my children. The scuttlebut out here in the far reaches is that He-Man has liberated Omega-4. Zark has been defeated and taken into custody. As we speak he is tucked away on an Eternian cruiser headed for Primus’s high security prison moon, Enos.”

Caz and Drissi were on their feet, charging for Brojee. Who’s dark blue eyes were wide with surprise and wonder, he quickly pulled out an amulet he had hidden beneath his spacesuit. It was a simple oval pendant of pale opal, encased in gold. The stone was glowing a vibrant blue, pulsing in the rhythm of a heart beat.

“Brojee!” Litha dashed into the hold, from a set of airlock doors at the front of the large storage area. She was also out of her spacesuit, now in a pair of pink overalls and a soft yellow t-shirt with tiny blue flowers all over it. Her bare feet slapped the metal

floor in short, bursts as she sprinted across the hold. Brojee turned and knelt to catch his sister, who ran bawling into his arms.

“We can go home! Mom and Dad are free!” She exclaimed, pulling out a similar pendant from under the collar of her own shirt.

Brojee was crying silently as he held his little sister.

“That’s wonderful!” Glimmer exclaimed.

“We’ll get your ship ready for launch as quickly as we can.” Bow promised, grinning brightly. As he climbed to his feet, offering Glimmer a hand up. The Queen took the offered hand, as she basked in the relief and joy passing between Brojee and his sister.

More music played for a while, as the four kids made plans with Bow and Entrapta to speed up the repairs.

“Remember, my children, stay safe out there and look out for one another. This has been Andromeda Stardust, signing off.” Andromeda finished, her voice faded away into that eternally lonely tone of deep space.

The Power of Song

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra found Adora just before daybreak, further down the beachfront, perched on the edge of a rugged cliff that overlooked the ocean. She stood facing the water, her arm outstretched as if focusing on conjuring her sword. She had left her cloak back in her room. Dressed now only in her white long sleeve training shirt and grey pants, her long travelling boots were scuffed and dull from walking for a long time in the sand. Taking slow, shallow breaths as she sought to focus inward. The wind howling up from the sea below, lashing her ponytail violently across her back. The cliff overlooked a small cove. Corroded pieces of metal jutted out of the water. According to Brojee, were the hulls of ancient Starships, or fragments of war machines. Abandoned along the coast of Beast Island and left to rust. Since the time of Etheria's Uprising, during Mara's rebellion. There must have been a huge battle fought along this beach front to account for so much debris. The sharp edges had been worn down and smoothed by the constant waves, from a thousand years of erosion. The metal glinted in the coming dawn, flashing among the crashing waves.

Catra stood quietly, scanning the ancient wreckage that sprawled out to sea. The sky high above was still dark and full of starlight, a narrow band of fire was just starting to glow on the horizon. Daybreak would be upon them in moments.

"Hey, Adora?" Catra announced herself, softly as she approached, not wanting to startle her. Dressed a bit more appropriately for the cool morning air. In her black leggings, white training shirt and leather coat. She crossed her arms behind her back, with an impish giggle. Twisting her tail around the blonde's waist, as she ducked beneath her outstretched arm, casting her a coy smile, as she tried to get her attention. They had discussed Adora's magic in detail last night before bed, as they cuddled on Catra's bed in

her quarters. Adora had explained when she had finally managed to heal the poison from her. That she had gone to a place beyond Etheria in which only magic existed.

Catra had nodded and stated she had gone there too, when she spoke to her Guardian, Ouroboros. How she could see the ribbons of magic floating in the mist. Adora had nodded and spoke in length about how, when she had finally been able to heal Catra from the poison. She had seen the weaving that existed within her. How it had been the most exhilarating and beautiful experience of her life. Catra had blushed and bowed her head, at Adora's reverent compliment. Adora explained how she had been able to see the poison killing her and used She-Ra's healing magic with precision. To grab that strand of alien poison and destroy it. She wanted to try and do that again, to find that discordant knot in the weave of She-Ra's magic, that was the virus and destroy it. Catra had reluctantly agreed to let her try, but in the morning. She was exhausted and needed to sleep. Adora wasn't given an option to refuse and went to sleep herself, to the gentle purr of both Catra and Melog. Who had flanked her on either side of the cot. Their combined weight pressed against her. as she lay comfortably between them until reluctantly, sleep claimed her, too.

Catra knew what her girl was trying to do and had bitterly accepted that she just couldn't stop trying to fix her magic herself. She never had any real guidance when it came to She-Ra, that magic had always been a struggle of trial and error. So she was willing to take the risk, to summon that power, because it was needed. She was stubborn, hard headed and single minded when she was on mission. She-Ra had never let her down before, she had hoped that this time as well. That magic would come to her aid and give her strength to protect her friends. Adora wasn't going to wait to seek her answers back at the Crystal Castle, she needed to transform into She-Ra now!

Adora grunted in response to Catra, keeping her eyes closed as she struggled to focus. She couldn't help the fear that spiked threw her every time she sought to grasp onto that magic. It was like reaching blindly into murky water, to try and grab a lighting

rod at the bottom of the sea. She was frustrated and becoming short tempered at how difficult it was. The faint, uncertain grasp she had on She-Ra was just like after Mystacor. She hated how unreliable her magic had become. It had been so much easier with the First Ones relic. It didn't matter how confused or upset she was, she could call the power through the sword. Now...since she was the vessel to hold the magic it had become unreliable and twisted. Because she was weak, unfocused and unreliable...unworthy perhaps? But she was also desperate for answers. She just wanted some kind of certainty that if she did call upon She-Ra, that she wouldn't end up transforming as Despara...She wanted her control of the magic back!

Catra settled herself down on a nearby boulder, waiting for the sunrise. After singing her first draft of her song last evening. She had found the lyrics and overall tone of her first attempt too simple. It only scratched the surface of who she was...what she went through...the darkness she wished to leave behind her. She needed to be truly honest with Adarion, as scary and heart wrenching as that was for her. The source of her magic had to know her....all of her. So she had spent the early morning reworking her lyrics, digging deeper into the emotions that have been the driving force in her life. Unlatching her communication pad from her belt. Her reflective frown was replaced by a slow affectionate smile. As she watched Melog padding down the stony beach below the cliff. Sniffing the air and investigating the nooks and crannies of standing pools and shoals within the cove.

As the sun began to ascend over the crashing waves in the distance, Catra began to sing. Her voice was soft, as she gazed out towards the warming horizon with a lost, sad expression. A soft blue fire, flared over her body. Her eyes shone with power, her large dark pupils. Mirroring the warming glow of the sunrise with her own magic.

“I watched you... walk away,

You would never... hear me say,

That, ..I need you,

That, ...I love you.

I don't want... to let you go.”

Adora lost her focus instantly, her eyes snapping open, hearing a new song. She took several calming breaths as she walked over and sat down on the dried yellow grass beside Catra’s boulder. To enjoy the slow, sorrowful melody. Resting her aching back against the warmth of the stone, she had been out here for hours already with no luck. She had barely slept more than a couple hours, with a weary sigh she turned to watch the brilliant dawn as well.

“What's left of me,...

What's left of me,

Now your gone,”

Catra’s voice faltered, breaking slightly with the sad, lonely memories her lyrics were based on. Adora closed her eyes, a tear falling unchecked down her cheek as she slowly bowed her head. Reliving those tragic days, when they fought on opposite sides of the war. Both yearning to be with each other, but unable to move beyond the hurt and betrayal.

“I’m fighting..my rage.

I'm falling...into sin...after sin...

I'm drowning...in my lies.

My heart is breaking...

All these regrets have.. left me broken inside.”

Catra’s voice picked up speed and vigor. As the lyrics turned from sorrow to grim acceptance. Adora’s breath evened out, her focus drawing deeper inside herself. Her consciousness slowly sinking, willingly into the realm of pure magic

“I’ve become...so numb…

I’ve become..so afraid…

That I’ve lost myself... to this darkness…

That there is…

no, turning back,

no, forgiveness..

no, hope for me now…”

Catra’s voice was low and crooning. Like she was singing a dirge for the dead. Her song was so full of sorrow and regret. Adora was entranced by it, her focus narrowing to a point that was solely on the grief carried in her voice.

“When you’re all, I've ever needed.

When you're all, I’ve ever wanted.

I miss...your smile,... your laugh,

I crave... your warmth...your touch…”

She could still hear Catra’s voice, but it was distant and ethereal. Floating aimlessly with the rolling fog that surrounded her. Adora felt adrift for only a moment, twisting and turning in place as she sought to ground herself.

“You were everything...

No,

You are everything.... that makes me whole.”

The lyrics held such desperation and loss. Adora suddenly lost her bearings in that timeless void. As a sickening feeling overwhelmed her. She retched and fell to her knees, as the starlight that always hovered just out of reach began to streak over the heaven’s as if she was moving very fast, passing through eons upon eons of time and space.

“Your my sanctuary, my sanctuary…”

Catra’s voice remained the only constant, she could stay latched onto. But as quickly as she had found reassurance that she wasn’t alone or lost to this unrelenting current of magic. Her heart lurched in terror, as she heard Catra’s song fade away. She lost

hold of her anchor, the lyrical rope that was grounding her in the real world vanished.

"CATRA!" Adora screamed in her mind, as the timeless void swallowed her whole.

Her return to awareness was a slow and disconcerting process. The first sense to come alive was the soft sound of footfalls, then she felt her legs moving, the muscles once nonexistent flexed and stretched as she walked. Then finally the twilight world began to form around her. As she found herself moving through the shadows of tall trees, both ancient and grand. Her thoughts felt sluggish, as if she was slowly waking up from a very long slumber. She was deep in the heart of the Whispering Woods and moving north. Soon the ancient oak trees gave way to the tall pines and birch of the Northern Highlands, far beyond Bright Moon. The narrow footpath before her was long worn from daily travel. The locals must use it to traverse between villages.

She felt the gentle presence of grazing animals nearby, hidden within the undergrowth that surrounded the ancient woods. Moving quietly through the naturally trimmed glade, full of berry bushes picked clean of all the ripe fruit. The withered leftovers, rotting on the branches. This area looked both familiar and alien at the same time. The sky overhead, at least what she could make out of it. From within the webbing cracks between the dark green needles of the branches high in the canopy. Was a flat, listless hue, but glowed with a layer of energy hidden underneath. It was just like before, as if she was walking just behind the veil of life. The Whispering Woods stretched out around her, muted and grey.

Adora moved like a specter, unseen but not undetected by the wild life. Who would acknowledge her with wary looks and flickering ears. As she silently passed deer and boar, grazing

peacefully along the mossy banks of a slow moving stream. She had hiked through most of the valleys and orchards that surrounded Bright Moon over the last few years. She felt she knew her way around the Whispering Woods, at least a good chunk of it. But this area was strange to her, the stream was a branch off Half Moon lake. But by the snowy peaks of the Barrier mountains looming so close in the distance beyond the tree line. She was much further north, past the Palace and near Netossa and Spinnerella's fiefdoms. If she continued on her course she would come to the steppes before the vast mountain range. That cut the Whispering Woods away from the harsher, more wild climate of the Northern Reach. The highlands were full of small farms and trading posts. This close to the barrier mountains the outlying land was just hardy scrub grass and wild wheat, used for grazing small herding animals, such as sheep or goats. The land wasn't lush like Bright Moon, capable of maintaining orchids and grand gardens. This area lay just before the rugged belt of mountains that bordered the arctic sea and snowy wasteland of the Northern Reach and far, far to the west lay the Kingdom of Snows.

It was only good for hunting and trapping. The largest village in this northern part of Bright Moon, was known as Skara. It was nestled in the rolling hills at the base of the mountain range. Netossa and Spinerella's kingdoms were rugged but not barren, their people were hardy, hunting and working the rocky land. Creating many small communities amid the steppes and mountain passes that surrounded Skara.

Adora kept to the stream, intending to follow it to Skara. In time the woods shifted, the pines replaced by more thirsty types of trees, such as weeping willows who's curtain of leaves obscured the bank. Fat oaks curved themselves over the stream, along with spruce, standing tall behind their counterparts. Adora couldn't say if she was still in the northern part of the forest, she couldn't place where she was at all anymore. So she kept to the only constant landmark she had, the river.

Glancing into the clear water from time to time, watching the silvery scales of fish glinting beneath the surface. As they raced the current over the kaleidoscope of shiny stones of the river bed. The branches overhead tossed in the sudden gust of wind. Adora stopped, as two voices whispered faintly. From the lush tree line on the other side of the stream. Turning towards the other side of the bank, she searched the line of tall, ancient trees and thick river weed. That grew on the other side, for the voices. Her gaze fell on two glowing forms, leaning against the rough bark of a massive oak tree. A thick bow had twisted over the river, creating a natural bridge. It's many delicate branches dip into the cool water, breaking its surface in thousands of tiny ripples.

*(**This one is different from the rest.**) The slightly smaller, indigo figure stated. She had short hair that tossed in the ethereal wind that always surrounded their presence. The sharper outlines of her shoulder pauldrons was the most apparent difference in the two figures. She leaned casually against the trunk, her arms crossed. Surveying Adora on the other side of the stream with a calculating air. Her voice had a deeper cadence, but she sounded just like her?*

*(**She has real potential.)** The golden figure standing next to her advised. She was at least a head taller than her counterpart. With incredibly long hair that fluttered behind her like a wild cape. The silhouette of her armor was more bulky and her pauldrons were heavier and more gently sweeping over her broad shoulders. Her voice as well sounded similar to Adora's, but had a lighter, airy tone.*

It didn't take much for Adora to place the two god-like beings currently taking her measure from the other side of the stream. She had met both of them in her dreams.

The golden goddess was the dream incarnation of She-Ra, who had visited her in many a stress induced state during the war. The other darker goddess was the demon who had been haunting her current restless sleep...Despara.

*(**Aye, it has been a millennia since a vessel held the fortitude to summon us naturally** .) Despara commented, nodding toward Adora. Acknowledging her presence for the first time.*

*(**She has a noble heart and a strong, selfless devotion to protect others** .) The golden presence nodded towards her, the ethereal voice heavy with pride.*

*(**But she has become unbalanced and thus her connection is now untrustworthy. Distracted by her attachments and unwilling to let go. She has forsaken us once already**.) The indigo glow seemed to narrow her eyes as she scrutinized Adora, her voice dripping in judgement.*

"Yes, but she is not completely governed by them!" Razz shouted, as she appeared in a flash of sparkles upon the curving bow of the tree that spanned the river.

"You are far too dramatic and misinterpret her too often, she has never forsaken either of you!" Rass shouted back over her shoulder. The old crone skipped and hopped over spindly branches that snaked across the natural bridge. With an ease and dexterity, Adora never knew she could possess. With her skinny arms outstretched to keep her balance, cackling with amusement as she made her merry way across the river towards Adora. Jumping onto the bank and regarding her with a proud smile.

"She understands better than most that she serves a greater purpose. A destiny of her own choosing, now that the meddling relic is gone. She may succeed where the other's could not. "

Razz, patted Adora affectionately on the arm. Regarding the two glowing figures with a stern, protective glare. "You will show restraint and patience, as she prepares her loom. Her tapestry has just begun to be woven."

Adora was confused, again, Razz was talking about weaving?

The two figures flashed then faded away.

"Razz...what is going on with my magic?" Adora pleaded with the old woman to offer her advice. Whenever she had felt lost and overwhelmed by her magic, Razz had always showed up to guide her. Her instructions were not always easily deciphered but eventually they made sense.

"Your magic is free, for the first time in over a thousand years. They are excited but wary. Give them time to trust in you, dearie." Razz gave her a reassuring pat on the hand. Before turning on her heel and scuttling off down the bank of the river.

"What is my magic, what is She-Ra?" Adora shouted, as she scrambled to catch up to her. For an old woman, she could be rather quick and agile in these woods.

"She-Ra is you." Razz stopped and turned back. Regarding her with a warm, patient, slightly amused smile. As if she was a forgetful child who needed to be reminded of her true purpose.

"I get that...but who are those two!" Adora waved a hand sharply back towards the tree bridge. Her voice was high pitched and exasperated.

"You know who they are, silly." Razz chuckled, shaking her head with amusement.

"Yes...kinda...I have theories but no real answers. Please Razz, I am so tired of trying to figure out my magic on my own." Adora moaned, slumping her shoulders and trudging after her.

Razz sighed and nodded. "They are woven within many things." Razz stated, sagely. Squatting down by the river and dipping her fingertips into the cold water. "They surround us, bind us together and protect us for all eternity," A graceful, reflective smile pulled upon the old woman's lips as thousands of magical orbs floated up and around them from the water.

Adora approached her cautiously and crouched down, following the old woman's wrinkled hand as she moved it lightly through the water. The ripples around her wrist began to glow, as if she was

tapping into the magic of the stream. The water was clear, she could see the multi colored stones on the bottom of the river bed. The surface shimmered as Razz's hand drew the current towards her.

"Magic is everywhere, Mara understood that." Razz bowed her head in remembrance. "But her connection was bound to the relic. Her weave was not naturally woven, her threads were forced into the tapestry. The magic was shackled, enslaved to serve that wretched project." Razz snarled. "It is free now and rather excited about it! But still nervous and scared...unable to trust…you must be patient as well. Give Etheria time...to heal."

Adora reached out and placed a comforting hand on Razz's hunched shoulders.

"What happened to Mara, wasn't fair." She consoled gently.

"My poor, poor, Mara. She was just a tool, used, broken and thrown away." Razz heaved a shuttering breath. As two serpents, slithered gracefully up to the surface from the depths of the river. Coiling playfully around Razz's wrist, as she glided her hand threw the water.

Adora's eyes were transfixed on the two serpents, one's scales were a pure white the other a deepest black. Their bodies were smooth, long and slender, with sharp angled heads and no eyes. Except for the runestone embedded into their flat foreheads. The white serpent had a blue gemstone, the black a red stone. That resembled the rune stones in both her sword and her crown. Their movements were elegant, coiling around each other in an endless pattern.

"They are known as Sheana and Despara….they are the eternal forces that govern the universe. The Alpha and the Omega, Light and Dark..the Beginning and the End of all things. " Razz snapped her hand out of the water and the two serpents faded away as if they had just been a trick of the light.

"You are She-Ra." Razz turned and poked her squarely in the chest. "If you are to bring balance to the magic…you must reclaim what you have lost." Razz grunted and stood up. Her old bones snapping and popping as she moved. She cringed and pressed the palm of her hand to the center of her back. Tutting to herself. While Adora remained crouched. The shorter woman at her full height was now level with Adora as she knelt before her. She regarded the young blonde fondly, her dark eyes mirrored behind her glasses were warm but sad.

"Everyone you hold dear is weaved into your magic, my dear." Razz reached out and pointed to Adora's feet. "Glimmer...is your determination, she gives you wings, so that you remain steadfast upon your goals. " She grasped her wrists, "Mara...is your courage. She guides your hands, so that they will be both strong and compassionate, when confronted by adversity." She tapped her collarbone. "Bow...is your heart. He gives you the strength to persevere no matter the odds." Then clasped her weathered hands on either side of Adora's face. "Catra…..She is your hope. She reminds you to never give up on someone...perhaps you need to heed her advice." Razz was silent for a long time, as Adora's focus drew inward. Her thoughts spinning over what Razz had said. Then Razz patted her cheeks, her brows furrowed in concern, offering her a small, confused smile. "You have weaved everyone you love into your magic...but where is Adora?" She finished, then flashed away in a swirling storm of starlight.

Adora cried out in alarm and snapped her head up, finding Catra hovering inches away from her face. Her mismatched eyes glistened with worried tears, her hands clutching Adora's shoulder's tight.

"I have been screaming your name for a half hour!" Catra cried, giving her shoulders a firm, infuriated shake before standing up and taking a deep breath. Valiantly trying to calm down.

“Did I fall asleep?” Adora muttered in confusion, raking a hand through her hair poof, loosening some of the strands. Glancing around trying to regain her bearings, finding that she was still slumped against the boulder.

“Your singing...I started to focus on it...and it pulled me to that place…between realities?” She confessed, in both awe and trepidation. Her heart still hammering in her chest from the exhilaration of the experience.

“The Heart of Etheria?” Catra spun back, her expression grim but her eyes shone with hope..

“Yes, I think so...but I never saw the threads of magic...It was like I was dreaming...I was far up north of Bright Moon in the Whispering Woods. ” Adora muttered, “Razz was there...and Despara...and...Sheana?”

Catra was confused, she plopped down in front of her on the grass. Silently waiting for her to continue.

Adora explained what she could remember, about what Razz had told her. It was all still so muddled and confusing in her memory. It would take some time to get it all sorted out. Razz’s revelation about Adora not being a part of her transformation into She-Ra was startling but not surprising. Adora never put herself first, she would never think that she deserved to be a part of the magic that saved the universe. Catra had been trying to prove to Adora since they were kids that she mattered, her wants and desires were valid and deserved to come true. That she was worth more than what she could do for others. That she was loved for who she was, with no strings attached. Adora needed to find value in herself...to balance the magic. Catra never realized till recently how little Adora thought of herself. Always reaching for validation from others, idolizing others, such as Huntara...or She-Ra. With a groan she flopped backwards onto the grass, figuring out how to get Adora to value...perhaps love herself was a tall order.

She still wasn’t capable of it herself...thanks to Shadow Weaver...

“Melog said my voice had power….” Catra spoke softly, as they headed back to Darla down the beach, hand in hand.

“Yeah, I started to focus on your voice and then it was like something just grabbed me and pulled me away.” Adora took a deep breath.

“That’s kinda scary.” Catra groaned.

“But you helped...I was having so much trouble focusing. I wanted answers..and I was able to get some. Even if I still don’t trust my magic. At least I know Despara isn’t a virus from that disk. She is actually a part of my magic...I really angry, scary part...but still…she is supposed to be there.” Adora was nervous and started to laugh weakly.

Catra picked up on her unease and grasped her other hand, turning Adora to face her.

“It’s going to be ok, if she’s supposed to be a part of your magic. Then she can’t be evil..cause She-Ra is not evil. She’s something good, something pure and powerful...she always shows up when we need her most, to help, to protect and fix all the bad stuff. So there can’t be anything really evil inside that magic.” Catra glanced nervously to the side, she wanted to soothe Adora’s worries. But this Despara aspect of her magic still really, really frightened her. She was having a hard time trusting that the darker aspect of She-Ra wouldn’t try to kill them all in some fury filled rage.

Adora offered her weak smile in return. Understanding Catra was trying to cheer her up. She didn’t want to dwell on it. Her words were kind, but she couldn’t believe in them. When she had been Despara in her dreams, she had been anything but good.

Adora nodded, “That was a new song?” Resuming their walk down the beach.

“Yeah, I started writing it back in the Fright Zone. Got time to tweak it a bit more this morning, when I woke up and found you gone.” Catra chastised, giving her a teasing smirk. To ease Adora’s obvious guilt at disappearing on her. Then Catra adjusted her hold on Adora’s hand, rethreading their fingers.

“It was kinda sad.” Adora commented, turning her gaze out over the sparkling dawn illuminating the ocean. The guilt and melancholy dampening her mood is very apparent.

“Well, it’s not done yet. It’s only the beginning.” Catra bumped her shoulder against hers, with a fond smile. Insinuating that her song would have it’s happy ending, just like they did.

The sun was high overhead, by the time Catra had walked deep enough into the jungle to take to the trees. Melog slunk behind her as she slowly navigated from one overhanging branch to the next. Her movements were methodical and precise, as she calculated each step. Lunging with the grace and natural agility of her race, from branch to branch. Adora kept a close eye on her from the undergrowth, jogging a few paces behind. Once more in her maroon cape, with her quarterstaff sheathed against her back. A new utility belt was strapped along her waist with a Thulite blaster holstered against her hip. It bounced against her thigh as she ran. Brojee was keeping pace just behind her, with his two younger companions grumbling in toe. Litha had been ordered by her older brother to stay back and monitor their progress from their ship's command deck. The little girl begrudgingly agreed.

It took no time at all for Catra to out pace her guards on the ground. Moving out of their eyesight, as she leaped away through the overgrown canopy.

“Be safe...I’ve got your back.” Adora breathed heavily into her ear piece, as she lost sight of Catra. Her pace never faltered, jogging ever onward. Her blue eyes determined to maintain her heading towards the First Ones ruin, that housed the Beacon.

“You stay safe too, Princess.” Catra’s tender voice filtered through the earpiece. Adora smiled and nodded, her focus straight ahead prepared to confront danger and protect her love with everything she had. Even if she could only rely on the meager strength of Adora this time, she would never give up!

Entrapta was also monitoring them, via their ear pieces back on Darla. She was at the front panels on the command deck, keeping a close eye on the readings coming from the Beacon as well. Glimmer and Bow waited on the Command Deck with her. Bow was sitting on the deck, rechecking all his trick arrows and packing them in his quiver wanting to be ready. While Glimmer paced behind the captain’s chair, tossing her staff from hand to hand. Waiting for the signal to teleport Entrapta and Bow to Catra’s location. Their final plan to keep Catra safe was far more simple. Adora, Brojee, Drissi and Caz were going to fan out once they got close to the Beacon. If Catra communicated that she had gotten into trouble they would fire their blasters into the air. Drawing the Laser Bears away from her. Giving Catra a clear avenue to sneak in through Entrapta’s hidden back door and down to the Beacon's server room. Once Catra got into the server room she would signal Darla. Glimmer, who would transport Entrapta and Bow to her side. Then Entrapta would hack the security system from the inside and shut down the protocol currently manufacturing Laser Bears. Right now, Adora, Drissi, Brojee and Caz were following Catra deeper into the jungle. Fanning out behind her in a defensive pattern. Since she was the only one able to navigate through the dense maze of corrupted tech and smothering trees from her vantage point high above. They all moved at a steady rate of progress throughout the afternoon. The jungle was strangely silent, the monster’s who usually roamed the island were laying low. The only sign that the jungle was still inhabited by Pooka, Spider’s and other beasts. Was their faint glowing eyes, observing them from the branches then darting away. Or the rustle of sharp talon’s hidden out of sight in the thick underbrush, that stilled and grew silent as they past. With out the

signal, the beasts on the island seemed far more skittish then aggressive.

It was closing in on evening, the sun was glinting off the towers of dark, jagged metal in the distance, blinding her from time to time. Slowing Catra's progress through the treetops and forcing her to move even more cautiously. So she hadn't noticed the Bear, lurking just below the winding branch she was slinking across. Melog chirped at her sharply and Catra stopped, crouching low and then laying on her stomach along a thick branch. Catching sight of the Laser Bear sniffing the air a few meter's ahead, its back spines are already raised and quivering. She gasped and tried to slow down her breathing. Her heart was hammering in her chest, she had nearly walked over top of it. Casting the jungle ahead, a quick survey, finding the looming dark monolith of the beacon. Rising up over the treetops a few more miles away, at the very apex of the island. Slightly hidden behind a knotted clusters of dark creeping vines, that snaked up it's surface.

She still had a long way to go...

"Ok, I got a Bear on my scent. I'm gonna need one of you to lure it away." Catra pressed her fingers to the ear piece. Whispering anxiously for aid, as the Bear had now reared up on its hind legs. It's razor sharp claws protruding from its front paws digging into the black bark of the tree just below her.

She could feel the heat of its breath puffing against her bare toes, she quickly pulled her legs up further, tucking them tight against the branch.

"Anytime….now!" She hissed.

Melog was crouched low on their stomach on a nearby branch, ears folded back as they kept a close eye on the Bear. Their body had darkened, their mane tinting a pale yellow with Catra's fear and anxiety.

As the bear took tentative sniffs of the air. Honing in on Catra's scent, it reached up with a massive claw and swiped at her from a few feet below.

Catra bit down on her lower lip to stop herself from crying out in fright. Those huge claws were coming way to close! If those razor sharp claws connected, the bear had the power and speed in that strike to rip her leg right off!

When suddenly a loud abrasive humming echoed over the tree line. Then a bright green bolt of energy erupted out of the canopy. The Bear howled and galloped away in the direction of the shot. Exploding into the thorny brambles, intent on hunting down the intruder. Whoever stepped in to lure the monster off, was going to have an angry Bear on their ass pretty fast. But they had a plan, they would call Glimmer for a teleport as soon as they heard the Bear headed their way. She would safely blink them back to the beach. So Catra knew she only got four saves, so she needed to be observant and stay undetected for as long as possible.

"You ok?" Adora's worried voice whispered over the com.

"Yeah, Melog warned me in time." Catra muttered back, with relief. Hugging the branch and trying to stop her trembling. "Give me a sec to reassess my position then I'll keep going." She tried to sound aloof, as if that scary near death experience had been nothing...but she knew Adora wouldn't be fooled by her false bravado.

"Be careful." Adora scolded.

"Always, Princess." Catra smirked, then rose up on all fours and continued down the branch. Leaping in one fluid movement across to another branch, swinging herself around the trunk of another tree. Heading down a more narrow and twisting branch, her feet light and quick, always keeping the dark tower in view. It didn't take much longer for Catra to spot the carnage of several clones. Their pale bodies were crumpled against the trunks of trees, their

white clothing drenched in green ichor. Several had been mauled severely, their bodies shredded and nearly unrecognizable. Green ichor was splattered over the bark of the trees, one clone was embedded into the trunk by a spine through the gut. Hanging like a broken doll, with their green blood soaking into the bark behind them. Entrapta and Hordak must have sent them here nearly a week ago to check on the beacon. The poor clones, were not prepared to defend themselves against such powerful beasts. Catra sat back on her haunches, her feelings towards the grizzly sight rather conflicted. Should she tell Entrapta? She had a soft spot for the clones, while Catra was rather indifferent to them.

(Catra?) Melog inquired curiously, padding along a nearby branch. Glancing down at the gory remains with an apathetic, bland expression. They had no love for the clones, their grudge against them over a thousand years old.

(Does this sight hurt?) They asked, mildly curious about the tortured frown adorning her face.

Catra cleared her throat, offering them a weak smile. "No, not really." Then she groaned and scrubbed a hand down her face in frustration. "But it will hurt Entrapta….I think? She and Hordak sent them here to investigate."

(Ah, so you are conflicted then.) Melog nodded in understanding.

"I don't know if I should tell her...but keeping things to myself didn't pan out very well for me last time." Catra cringed at the memory of how angry Glimmer had been and how anxious and scared she was that she had wrecked their friendship.

(You need a clear head today. You can tell Entrapta after we fix the beacon.) Melog answered, moving forward slowly. (Then she will have time to grieve for her pets at her leisure.)

Catra sucked in a shocked breath, at the venom in Melog's statement. Melog had zero compassion when it came to Horde Clones, even less for Eternians. She understood Melog's hatred,

even if they wouldn't admit they felt such emotions. They had shared with her through their bond, the decades of war Krytis had endured. How Melog had been unable to protect their planet from the First Ones. Who they viewed as a fatal disease. Forced to sit by and watch the slow destruction of the planet as its magic was mined. The First Ones took all the life and vitality from their world, leaving it sick and weakened. Then Horde Prime came to finish the job of killing Krytis. Melog had spent most of their life fighting clones and First Ones. Then their prize for triumphing over Horde Prime. Was to be the final witness to the slow death of everyone they knew as the planet and survivors began to slowly die. Enduring nearly a thousand years all alone on a corpse of a world, until Catra and the others had found them. That kind of trauma would leave anyone jaded and apathetic about the people who hurt them.

These clones were not innocent, but they also did not possess free will at the time. She was also quite intimate at how powerless that felt. To be forced to hurt those you loved and have no way to fight back. They had been puppets with no choice over what Prime made them do. They were just tools….like Melog….like she had been...

This time though, the clones had free will and chose to come to Beast Island to help protect the planet and people who were now harboring them. Their fate was like some kind of sick joke or karmic reckoning. Did a tragic fate like that await her someday? Catra cringed and took a shuddering breath, trying to shield her emotions from Melog. She was both sympathetic for the living hell Melog went through, but also hurt by their cruel words. Melog knew she had also been a puppet for Prime to use? Knew that she was in love with a First One? Where did Melog stand in regards to her and Adora? But..she also distrusted Eternians because of what they did to her people a thousand years ago...the unjust suffering they were still enduring on Eternia. Yet she loved Adora. She trusted Adora and never saw her as an Eternian. But would that all change once she reclaimed her heritage, met her real family...would she change...would she leave her again for them?

(Catra…) Melogs worried voice penetrated the spiraling thoughts crashing through her head. She snapped her head up, finding her companion several branches away staring back at her in anxious confusion.

(Now is not the time to be stuck in your head, let those worries go for now. We will talk it all out when we are safe. I need you to focus.) Melog chided gently.

Catra's ears drooped and her tail hung low, swaying nervously. There was no way to keep her hurt, her confusion and anxiety contained. Melog felt them all and was responding to her needs. Their eyes shone with remorse, but their tail snapped anxiously.

"Right!" Catra nodded, leaping for the next branch. Pushing all of those distracting feelings aside to deal with later. She had been trying so hard not to grow attached to Melog. But she had to admit it was a lost cause. Over the last few months. Since, Melog had entered her life. They had become someone she could always depend on. A silent support she could open up to, she felt safe to be vulnerable and bear her soul completely to them as often as she needed to. Purging all her emotional poison into them. They in return would listen quietly, offer advice when needed. Soothing her with subtle, gentle affections she understood as a cat hybrid. It was almost like she had a version of her parents at her side. She had never loved someone as hard or as completely since Adora. If Melog was to die or leave her...she would be absolutely devastated.

A stiff breeze picked up just as the sun began to set. Catra bowed her head, asking for Adarion's forgiveness. She would not be able to sing this evening, as she was currently hovering on a thin, smooth branch overlooking a narrow, winding path near the summit of the island. The purple foliage that curtained the hatch Entrapta used to access the Beacon lay several yards up this narrow path. She could hear the low howls of several Laser Bears patrolling around the perimeter. She had ended up getting into

trouble once more before finally arriving at the Ruins. Leaving only two others covering her back from a few miles further south. She gave the wind a quick sniff, gauging how far away the Bears might be. Calculating how quickly she could sprint to the opening if she dropped to the ground here. Melog made sharp chirping sound from a branch just above her head.

(I will cover you...my friend.) They offered, seeking to reassure her.

"Thanks, buddy. But I think I need you to cloak us." Catra glanced right then left, leaping from the branch when she felt her surroundings were clear. She was quite high up and needed to cushion her fall by a forward roll as her feet hit the uneven terrain. Melog growled and leaped after her, as soon as their four paws hit the ground behind her. They both shimmered away, sprinting together along the overgrown trail, heading for the curtain of strange purple foliage a few meters up.

The incline was covered with loose stones and dried bramble, it was a struggle to keep her footing as she ran full speed towards the curtain. Thanking her natural agility and perfect balance, as the loose shale that covered the path, slipped under her bare feet. Catra's toe claws compensate for the sudden slide by digging into soft ground. Now revealed by the disturbed flat stones that once covered the path. Catra ducked into the opening, pushing the heavy purple vines aside with her elbow as she pressed her fingers to the ear piece.

"We're in!" She stated in a rough whisper, heaving for breath. She had never run so fast in her life!

"Alright!" Glimmer exclaimed, Bow's and Entrapta loud cheers echoing through the ear piece.

Catra cringed at the sudden burst of sound and then proceeded down the poorly lit corridor. Taking note of how the First Ones writing carved into the walls was flickering. This temple was

nearly out of power, thanks to the security protocol manufacturing Laser Bears constantly for weeks. That might be a problem…

As she went deeper into the tunnel, the light dimmed even more, becoming a faint dying glow. She had no trouble seeing in the near darkness, but the others would be teleporting in blind.

“We got no light in here.” She spoke softly into her ear piece.

“Noted.” Entrapta responded. “I’ll grab some of my Thulite torches…just invented them last night...there is so much tech I can adapt with these new blaster packs...” She added absently.

Catra was now wondering bleakly if she had slept at all last night?

The corridor widened into an intersection, branching off into three different directions. Catra sighed and pulled her communication pad off her belt. She tapped on the screen activating the schematic Entrapta had downloaded last night from her own collection of files. Putting the map on all their pads. Stating that, "It's better to be prepared for anything!”

Catra smiled fondly, that woman could be so fearless. She had come here all by herself and explored the temple, headless of the danger. She had mapped the whole structure during her months here on Beast Island. Catra groaned as guilt stabbed her hard in the chest. Quickly pushing it aside and locking it up tight behind her need to stay on task. She cleared her throat and studied the map now glowing on her screen. Before choosing the left corridor and heading deeper into the ruin.

Melog growled low, clamping their teeth into the hem of Catra’s leather coat.

“Owwww.” She growled back, as their fangs accidentally scraped against her skin at the side of her hip. “What the hell, Melog.”

Then she caught the musky scent and grew silent, her ears folded back as she pressed herself up against the side of the narrow

tunnel.

A Laser Bear padded heavily across the intersection they had just left, Catra held her breath, staring wide eyed with terror. As the bear slowed to a stop, sniffing the air. It's fierce red eyes glowed with interest as it slowly lowered it's head towards the corridor they were hiding down.

"Crap, crap, crap…" Catra hissed, tip-toeing sideways down the corridor as quickly as she could. Not wanting to make a single sound. Even with Melog cloaking them, she knew that apex predator could still track them by scent alone. She glanced back, her heart leaping into her throat as its massive head slowly bowed down. Sniffing the floor and prowling towards them. It's toothy maw dripping with saliva, as it honed in on its prey.

"Catra!" Adoras voice shouted through the earpiece in fright. Catching on to how quickly Catra's breath had hitched and began to pant anxiously.

"Laser Bear!" Catra spoke harshly, picking up her pace down the corridor.

"We're coming!" Glimmer exclaimed, while Entrapta complained about not having enough time to retrieve her torches from the Engine Room.

"I'm just outside the Temple! I'll be there in a couple minutes!" Adora shouted, her breath puffing loudly into Catra's ear piece as she ran at full speed up the path towards the back entrance.

"Hurry!" Catra exclaimed, breaking into a sprint down the corridor as the Bear howled for it's companion to join the hunt.

"NO TIME!" Adora bellowed, "Blink now, Glimmer!"

Entrapta's voice was a sharp exclamation of fright as Glimmer blinked them away.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry about the cliff hanger...but the chapter was running long.

The Secret of Beast Island

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra was running blind, pumping her arms and legs with everything she had. Seeking to gain a bit of ground. But it wasn't enough, her survival instincts were primed and screaming at her. The threatening presence of the predator bearing down on her was too close! Her heart was like a drum beating against her ribs, her breath was labored and bursting out of her open mouth in sudden gasping pants. She took a chance, knowing it would falter her speed for a moment and glanced quickly over her shoulder. As she skidded through another cavernous intersection. Lunging to the left on all fours, desperate to evade the bear. Which was charging behind her, it's deadly paws thundering against the metal floor as it closed the distance. With a cry of terror, she urged her legs to move faster. Changing her course in an instant, lunging down another side corridor instead of keeping on a straight path. Disappearing into the gloom, as the Bear slammed into the wall with a loud resounding boom. It was not as agile, it's weight crashing it's bulk into the panels like a tank. The thin metal was bent and twisted from it's impact, as it scrambled off the wall and continued it's pursuit without taking any damage.

Catra never believed for even a second that she had a chance to get away. It didn't take long for her to sense it closing in again. Catra chanced another glance over her shoulder. As the snarls and hot puffs of the bear's breath rolled over her, as it effortlessly bore down upon her.Catra twisted as she leaped to the side, when she heard the high pitched whine of the creature's laser, powering up. Digging all four sets of claws into the smooth metal, as she then rebounded off the wall. Just as several spines whistled past her face. Moving on instinct alone, she spun her body in mid air, between the projectiles. As they embedded themselves deep into the corridor's floor a few yards past her previous position. The creature was unnaturally fast, but Catra's instincts and agility once

again saved her life. The resounding clang of the spines tearing through the metal, rang in her sensitive ears.

Catra hung by her claws, at the top of the wall, near the roof of the corridor. Heaving for breath, eyes wide in horror at how narrowly she evaded that attack. Her breath caught in her throat as the monster’s laser eye began to open. The glowing orb was humming upon its forehead, as energy built and rebounded inside. Catra had no time to formulate any kind of reasonable plan of escape. She was pinned down and fighting for her life! Her eyes were darting frantically across the narrow, empty corridor for any kind of inspiration. She needed to gain the upper hand here.

It was then Melog leaped onto the beast's backend, they were twice their normal size. Their body is a dark blood red, brilliant flame red mane and tail flaring and snapping menacingly. Crimson eyes burning with a crazed feral rage. Throwing itself at the beast with absolutely no thought about self preservation. Snarling and biting into it’s thick hind quarters, their razor sharp claws penetrating and ripping through the fur and into the muscle. Black ichor bled from the deep wounds, coating Melog's paws. The beast howled in pain, as Melog strove to maul even more of it's backend. But their claws were now slick from the bears blood, the fur of it's rear end was now soaked and slippery. They hung on with all their strength, as the beast bucked and slammed them against the wall valiantly trying to dislodge them.

Catra needed more than the magical parlor tricks. That she had managed to conjure for the princess’s, to show off that she was now one of their ranks. She needed to find that limitless inferno that she had ignited back in the swamp, to save Adora. But she could barely take a moment to focus.

“Melog!” She screamed in terror as her companion recklessly leapt upon the bear's back, just like last time. Melog was throwing themselves into harm's way to keep her safe.

She could not lose them!

Screaming in rage, she released her claws from the roof. Dropping towards the bear's head, just as it released a bolt of energy. It tore through the roof, rending and melting the metal. Before snarling and swinging its snapping jaws towards Melog. It growled low and menacing, as it attempted to latch onto Melog's neck. Trying to rip the alien cat off it's hind quarters.

"Get away from them!" Catra bellowed, her eye's starting to glow. Flaring, as if the sun itself had ignited inside of her soul. Her need to protect Melog, summoning the full might of her magic. Her whole body burst into a brilliant orange flame, just as she landed on the top of the bear's head. The inferno she had become had an instant and very painful effect. She ignited it's fur, engulfing its head in her living flame. It howled in agony, bucking and clawing at it's forehead frantically. As the fire began to consume its whole face. Melog leaped off before they got burned. While Catra ran down the length of the beast, her fire roared behind her. Engulfing the beast's body as she flipped off it's backend. Wanting to make sure she set the whole beast on fire.

Piercing howls of pain echoed from further up the corridor, followed by the pounding steps of its hunting partner heading right for them. Catra stood in the middle of the corridor, eyes wide with alarm. Staring over her shoulder in fear. As the other bear charged out of the darkness, barreling down upon her. Snarling and howling in pain, intent on ripping her apart. She quickly snuffed out her flame and raced back down the corridor with Melog on her heels.

"Is it too much to ask that the universe just cuts me a break sometime!" She snapped bitterly as she lunged forward on all fours, rounding the corner and racing at top speed down another dimly lit corridor.

"FUCK!!" Glimmer's shrill curse and scream of sudden terror. Stopped Catra in her tracks. She spun around, catching sight of

the last shimmer of Glimmer's blink, as her magic faded away from the intersection Catra had just sprinted through.

“Duck!” Bow shouted, his voice cracking.

[Charging arm cannon!] Rodak’s deep, robotic voice echoed after. Followed by a loud whine of it's arm cannon powering up, and then the sharp snap of rending metal.

“NO! Hordak!” Entrapta wailed in alarm, then the wet, thunk of something large and sharp impacting with flesh. Sent a sickening shiver down Catra’s spine before she charged back down the corridor. To find the Laser Bear that was once in pursuit, laying on its stomach. It’s jaws clamped tight around Rodak’s metal body. The robot’s body was crushed within it’s toothy maw, its helmet shaped head hanging low between two massive canines. The lights in its eyes flickered as it’s power core started to lose containment. Thanks to an energy beam from Glimmer, the bears left eye was burnt to a fleshy unrecognizable mess. With Entrapta’s shield that she once used as a seat back on the skiff. Was now embedded in the bears neck, nearly severing the beasts head from its shoulders. Black ichor pooled in the rounded, divet of the underside of the shield, dripping over it’s angled sides and onto the floor.

Catra stood in shock at the brutal carnage Entrapta had just caused. The woman had never been a fighter, she would run away and hide when under attack. To strategize a way to out think her opponents, as she ensured hers and her friends safety. She had never killed anything in her life. Catra was concerned now, by the swift and rather gruesome way in which Enrapta had used her magic to execute the beast. Glancing over to the scientist, desperate to gauge her emotional state. Finding her standing nearby, hunched over, heaving for air, her eyes cast down and to the side. Seeking to avoid eye contact with them and the gruesome death she had just inflicted on what may be a living creature. Her amber eyes were shadowed with dread and wide with surprise at what she had done. Her mind spinning, as she mulled over the consequences of her actions. Guilt...but strangely

not regret, washed over her for taking her first life. Those powerful, complex emotions were hitting her hard. She was having difficulty dealing with them…at the moment. Seeking to reduce the amount of unwanted stimuli, she swallowed over and over, staring at the ground. Tapping her thumbs against all of her fingers in a frantic sort of rhythm.

Bow stood nearby an arrow notched, staring at the dead bear in just as much shock and horror. Glimmer gagged, pressing her hands to her mouth. She had survived three years of war and had seen many gruesome sights but the gore of death still made her stomach flip sickeningly.

A low whine started to hum from within the bear's bloody maw.

"Run!" Entrapta screamed, snapping her head up and taking action. Grabbing Bow and Catra by their forearms with her gloved hands. Wrapping a tendril of purple hair around Glimmer's waist and hauling the Queen off her feet and carrying her high over their heads. As she rushed them full speed back down the corridor, Catra had just come from. Making it only a few feet, before a massive explosion sounded, followed by a blinding fireball now chasing after them.

Glimmer was quick to swing her staff, tracing a magic shield. A glowing disc of indigo, runic glyphs flew out of the celestial talisman on top of the staff. The shield grew in both size and strength behind them. As the fireball hit the shield with a deafening boom! They screamed in terror, worried that it wasn't going to hold. Entrapta never slowed down, dragging Catra and Bow behind her, as Melog kept pace. While Glimmer hovered over them still wrapped up tight in Entrapta's hair, eyes closed as she focused her magic into the barrier. Fortifying it, as the blast sought to break through. Within seconds the fireball had dissipated along with the concussive force once pushing upon the magical shield.

"You guys ok!" Brojee's worried voice echoed through their earpieces. As the shield faded behind them. Having served its

purpose by absorbing the explosion.

“Yeah, but barely.” Bow responded as they finally slowed to a stop in an intersection.

“Good, cause you nearly killed Adora!” Brojee snapped back. “Seriously, woman do you have a death wish!” They heard him chastising the reckless blonde.

“Yes, she does!” Bow and Glimmer snapped back in unison.

“Adora!” Catra exclaimed in fear, her heart now leaping into her throat.

“I’ll go get them.” Glimmer nodded towards Catra, noticing how pale and scared she looked. She blinked away in a cascade of sparkles only to reappear a second later with Brojee and Adora. Brojee was fine, but Adora’s hair was slightly singed and her clothes were covered in a fine layer of ash.

“Adora!” Catra cried in relief, leaping at her and tackling her to the ground. Adora yelped in both alarm and joy as they crashed to the floor. Wrapping her arms around Catra. As the feline embraced her tightly, hanging onto her as if she were a life line.

“We were running up an adjoining corridor. I heard the whine of a power overload and slowed down, but not Adora. That crazy woman just kept on running, reaching the intersection just as it exploded.” Brojee stated. “Blew us both back down the corridor, but Adora, she got the brunt of it.”

A low growling purr of displeasure issued from deep in Catra’s throat, as she overheard Brojee. Adora sighed deeply, petting a hand down the back of Catra’s head, giving the back of her ears a light scratch. Comforting her and seeking forgiveness all at once.

“I know, I know….stop being so reckless…” Adora muttered softly against the light grey fluff of the inside of Catra’s ear.

Catra nipped her in the soft part of her neck just behind her ear as punishment. Catra understood that Adora was so scared that she was going to lose her, that she wasn't thinking clearly. She was focused only on getting to her girlfriend's side, at all cost. So she as unwilling to carry a grudge this time...but she would not stand for this kind of reckless, self sacrificing behavior in regards to her. They would be having a conversation about this later. Adora needed to start thinking things through and stop coming in hot every time people she loved were in danger. She mattered too!

Adora yelped in response, her eyes flying wide in alarm. As her insides clenched with arousal at the sudden sharp pain of Catra's canines pinching her skin. Pulling Catra off of her chest and giving her an apologetic pout. Catra merely sat up on her stomach, glowering down at her, crossing her arms over her chest in frustration.

"You are not invincible! I don't want to lose you either, Dummy!" Catra huffed.

"I'm sorry…" Adora cupped Catra's, velvet soft cheek with a palm. The relief and warmth in her blue eyes quickly calming Catra's ire.

"I'm glad you guys are alright." Bow sighed, setting the arrow he had knocked, back in it's quiver and thumbing through his arsenal. Adjusting the arrows order, now that he knew what they were dealing with. His firing sequence needed some tweaking.

Glimmer released a relieved breath, turning and finding Entrapta crouching in the far corner of the intersection with her mask down. Tapping at a data pad harshly with trembling fingers. The queen glanced at Catra uncertain as to how to help.

Catra's ears twitched, hearing how angrily Entrapta was pressing on the screen.

“Trapta…?” She quickly stood up, leaving Adora flat on the floor. Adora stared at her with a mixture of concern and confusion. As Catra slowly approached Entrapta. Her expression was soft, thoughtful, as she crouched down before the lavender haired princess. Gently, brushing one hand down a ponytail, her claws extended. Combing through Entrapta’s incredibly long hair with her claws, seeking to comfort her in the ways she knew she liked.

“I’m fine…” Entrapta snapped, tapping furiously at the screen.

Catra nodded, not taking Entrapta’s curt response personally. Understanding her need to hide her grief and deflect her concern with irritation. Entrapta coped very similarly to herself, seeking to hide when she felt vulnerable. Never wanting others to pity her, she felt a connection to her in that way.

“But, do you need a second?” Catra asked quietly, pulling her hand back and giving Entrapta space.

‘No!” Entrapta shouted out indignantly, standing up and pointing down the furthest corridor. “The quickest way to the server room from here is that way. I’ll lead” She stormed off, not waiting for any of them.

They ended up circling around and were walking down the side corridor that Catra had fought the first Laser Bear.

Catra scrunched up her nose, her ears folding down in distress as the thick caustic smell of burnt flesh assaulted her nose. Entrapa caught sight of the charred remains and darted for the corpse, finally flipping her mask back up. Her need to see and investigate fully, drawing her back out.

The beast had laid down on its stomach as Catra’s flames overtook it’s body, succumbing to the inferno quickly. By the time Catra’s magic had dissipated, it left a large blackened husk behind. It’s spines had melted down it’s back, fur singed away to blackened flesh. Its face twisted into an agonizingly, unrecognizable shape. The flesh and muscle of it’s muzzle had

been eaten away by the flames. Leaving a truly gruesome grin of yellowed bone and sharp, pale white teeth. As it had clamped its mouth shut in death. Its arms and legs were tucked tight to its body, its paws curled inward as the fire had burned so hot it had cooked its thick bones.

Catra narrowed her eyes as she caught sight of something strange. A silver metal collar glinted in the half light of the hall, partially hidden in the melted folds of seared flesh around its neck. Everyone else kept their distance, their expressions ranging from appalled disgust to bland acceptance of the grotesque remains. Catra swallowed several times, as she slowly lowered her gaze. Shocked and more than a little frightened at how mercilessly her fire had devoured that beast. In truth it had been trying to kill her, she had been terrified and her actions were fueled by fear and adrenaline. Her chances of survival had been slim, to none. Being trapped in such a tight space with nowhere to run or hide. She had to fight back with everything she had, she truly felt she had no choice. So her magic had responded, giving no quarter as it blazed forth like the sun itself, to protect its wielder and those she loved.

"Catra...you did this…" Bow gapped at the ghastly carnage. He had a horrified expression, casting Catra, brief, fearful glances. As he sought to make peace with the brutal ways in which his friends had just disposed of two living creatures.

"Yes…" Catra answered in a small voice, reaching up with one hand and rubbing her upper arm nervously. Keeping her eyes downcast in shame at the cruel, painful death she had inflicted upon that beast. Her stomach was roiling and she didn't want to be here.

(Your guilt and remorse is misplaced. This beast would not feel such emotions if it had killed you.) Melog, huffed. As they rubbed against her thigh, craning their long neck upward to stare at her. Their wise blue eyes, locking with hers. Seeking to pull her away from her self loathing and towards a more logical understanding of the circumstances.

“Catra?” Adora wrapped a comforting arm around her shoulder, drawing her in. Catra grumbled, but accepted the embrace. Hiding her face in Adora’s chest, taking deep breaths as she grounded herself in Adora’s scent. Wanting it to replace the disgusting smell of burnt flesh that was lingering in her nose.

Melog sought to refocus her, by casting their thoughts into her mind.

(You had no choice, survival of the fittest... it was a fight to the death….kill or be killed...this beast has no higher capacity for thought than that.)

Catra moaned, she understood their logic but she was just so tired of the ceaseless round of conflict and consequence her life had become.

Then Melog sat behind her, watching Entrapta. Cocking their head quizzically, as the Princess of Dryl pulled a couple slender, lockpicking tools from her hair. Deftly tapping into the locking mechanism of the collar, popping it off.

“Interesting!” She exclaimed, as the huge collar fell to the floor with a clatter then shrank in size. She quickly bent down and picked it up, carrying the now bracelet sized collar back to the group.

“This control collar was just like the one on Melog, Casta gave it to me a few days ago to take apart.” Entrapta stated.

Melog growled, their body flaring a bright red as their mane snapped angrily.

Catra turned to face Entrapta, when Adora moved to investigate the collar in Entrapta’s hands.

“That collar was around the Laser Bear we encountered in the woods.” The blonde stated, while Catra merely nodded.

“I didn’t get a good look at the Bears out beyond the Beacon to notice any collars on them.” Catra mused, crossing her arms as she puzzled this discovery out. “But I would assume we’re not alone here.” She arched an eyebrow.

“Eternian’s.” Glimmer spat, gripping her staff tighter.

Catra nodded, as Adora pulled her quarterstaff out from behind her back and extended it to its full length.

Brojee moved in close to study the collar. “These are Control Collars. Nothing special about them. Lots of Slave trader’s and Bounty hunters across the universe use them. They are not exclusive to Eternian’s. ”

“Good to know.” Bow muttered bitterly, casting Glimmer a horrified look.

“One would think the Horde blockade, hovering around the planet would deter people.” Glimmer commented dryly.

“It was concerning, but we scanned the ships and they were all dormant so we knew it would be safe to land.” Brojee shrugged. “There are lots of Horde occupied planets that are now abandoned. So running into a fleet of dead horde vessels is not uncommon.”

“So this hypothetical someone, could have set off the security system as well.” Catra quipped.

Brojee gave her a small nod, a vindicated grin spreading over his face.

“Data crystals were still stolen.” Entrapta stated, shaking her data pad at Brojee.

“But perhaps not by my crew.” Brojee spat back.

“Ok, ok...let’s stay focused.” Adora interceded, striding ahead and forcing everyone to fall in line behind her. As they continued to

make their way to the Server room.

“When Jitsu put a collar like that on Melog, he needed to be close by to control them. Whoever is controlling these Laser Bears, they can’t be very far away.” Catra warned, as Melog flared a brilliant red. Their mane crackled with agitation and rage.

Bow nodded and then notched an arrow, moving forward near the front of the line next to Adora. Adora gripped her quarterstaff more tightly, her eyes scanning the dimly lit corridor ahead.

Entrapta veered off at the next intersection, moving to a smooth panel. With a set of blinking lights set in a circular binary pattern, embedded into the wall. She tore it off with her hair and quickly plugged in her data pad to a conduit.

“Entrapta...what?” Glimmer noticed Entrapta's abrupt departure first, since she was walking just ahead of her. Jogging over to her and standing guard with her staff. A few moments later the rest had noticed they were missing people and jogged back.

“Can you warn us the next time you just take off.” Catra groused, leaning against the wall by the open panel, with her arms crossed.

“Yes,yes. Of course.” Entrapta nodded absently. “I’ve tapped into the security grid and I am currently scanning the beacon for life signs.”

“That’s a really good idea.” Bow exclaimed with a grin.

“That’s why, I’m doing it.” Entrapta gave him a quizzical look before returning her attention to her screen.

Entrapta moaned softly, as a map of the beacon came to life on her screen.

“What?” Catra leaned sideways, expecting exactly what she saw. Her ears pinned back in dread, as the others gathered around them.

“That’s not good…” Bow whined, his eyes wide with horror at the amount of red dots currently roaming the halls.

“Are those all Laser Bears?” Brojee commented, fingering the hilt of his blaster on his hip holster, nervously.

“That data is inconclusive.” Entrapta muttered, tapping on the digital keypad on the lower part of the screen. “These are just life signs...could be Laser Bears, could be native creatures just wandering inside the beacon. With the mind altering transmission no longer functioning, the creatures are not trying to avoid the area anymore. Or it could be invaders, much like yourself.” Entrapta finished, with a pointed look right at Brojee.

Brojee did not react to Entrapta’s snarky remark.

“Either way, we need to get moving. Find a way to get to the server room undetected.” Glimmer huffed.

“We could use the service tunnels underneath the beacon, then climb up into the vents as we get closer to the Server Room.” Entrapta offered.

Melog stood before the group, slowly closing their eyes to summon their cloaking magic. Brojee shuttered and clenched his teeth. As a strange tingling sensation of cloaking magic fell over his body.

“You’ll get used to it.” Adora gave his shoulder a reassuring squeeze before following Entrapta. Who was now attempting to avoid the life signs, by taking alternate routes. Making their trek to the server room, longer and far more complicated.

They found themselves in a crypt-like room, the light along the walls flickering weakly. With a roof that curved overhead out of view. Fading into complete darkness high above. Reminding Catra strangely of the creepy lab inside Hordak's sanctum. The walls were lined with monitors and terminals, all blank and dormant. Metal tables full of smaller scientific equipment, tools and vials were lined up beside the terminals. All covered in dust, the substances once held in the vials now dried and decomposed. Leaving only a yellowed stain on the glass. But what made her heart jump sickeningly into her throat. Was the eerie, green glow of containment cylinders, mounted on the other side of each terminal. Filled with that same green embryonic liquid, Prime had used to create his clones and hold her prisoner while he defiled her mind.

Painful, unwanted memories washed over her, accompanied by the suffocating trauma of what Prime had done to her. She stopped in her tracks, ears folding back as her heart began to pound. Suddenly she couldn't breathe, curling her arms around her stomach as her tail dropped to brush the dusty floor. A dull roar was humming in her ears as she felt an anxiety attack overwhelming her.

(I am here…) Melog brushed against her hips, arching their back and rubbing their cheeks against her side. Drawing her attention away from her drowning anxiety and onto them, grounding her instantly back into the present. She crouched down, folding herself against their side. Wrapping her arms around their slender neck, taking long, steady breaths as she sought to calm down.

Bow and Glimmer gasped in horror as they slowly approached a container, finding a rotted, blob of flesh floating inside.

Brojee hung back, arms folded. Glaring in both hatred and revulsion at the row of container's. That held varying degrees of mummified, half formed bodies floating inside. Creating a macabre display of the monstrous and grotesque. This was some new and horrifying nightmare fuel. He did not need to witness in his lifetime! With a shiver, he averted his eyes unable to take

anymore. He knew what kind of lab they were in, but kept his peace for now. Allowing the Etherian's to investigate and come to their own conclusions about what the First Ones had been up to so long ago.

Entrapta had plugged in her data pad to the nearest terminal and was now squealing with delight at the ancient research she found.

"Fascinating!" She exclaimed, darting her eyes up from the pad to take in the row of containers. As everyone but Brojee and Catra crowded around her seeking an explanation.

"The lower half of the beacon was a genetics lab...the First Ones were genetically modifying Etherian animals...for what purpose I don't know. The native beasts that were once trapped on the island, the Pooka...the Scorpers, the Razor Fins...they were created here in this lab!" Entrapta's excitement was building as her voice got louder and louder. " They were also developing a brand new procedure to splice hybrid D.N.A with their own...in the hopes of creating a soldier as powerful as She-Ra…" Entrapta began to read.

"Mutants." Brojee commented bitterly.

"Your sister thought I was a mutant." Catra stood up, having gathered her composure she was ready to re-engage with the others.

"There isn't much difference between a hybrid and a mutant. Besides the fact that a mutant was a human once." Brojee shrugged.

"Why?" Adora was appalled.

"I doubt those who were experimented on had a choice." Catra grumbled, her thoughts falling inward. Hordak had tried similar experiments, when his attempts at creating a clone for himself had failed. When Catra had become his second in command, she had gained more clearance. Able to access top secret reports of those failed experiments on his own soldiers. He thought he might

be able to modify a hybrid or a human’s body with his own Horde D.N.A and create a healthy vessel for himself in that way. His experiments upon those chosen subjects had been excruciatingly painful and ultimately fatal for some. Their own Staff Sergeant Lazlo and Force Captain Grizzlor had survived his experiments. Her squad mates...Ami and Arron she didn’t know for sure, but she figured they had not been as lucky. Catra cringed and ducked her head, gritting her teeth. Hordak's obsession with creating a mutant, had thankfully been brief.

“How many mutants are there?” Catra suddenly snapped her head up and asked Brojee.

He shrugged. “I don’t know...the mutants who enslaved my people and forced us to mine the ice moon were from the planet Denebria. I never knew they were created by the First Ones..but it makes sense.”

“Enough to populate a whole planet, I guess.” Bow shrugged, scrubbing a hand down his face in exasperation.

Adora heaved a great sigh and rubbed the back of her head. It seemed the deeper they went into the past, the more sins they uncovered about her people. It has gotten increasingly harder for her to rationalize all the damage they had done, in the name of winning a war. They were power hungry and tyrannical to the native species of other planets. At this point their atrocities were as unforgivable as Primes. Worse it seems her people, back on Eternia were still no different then the First Ones from the past.

“Let’s keep going.” Catra moved briskly to Adora’s side, linking her arm with hers and pulling her away from the containers. She could see her girl starting to spiral, back into that crushing guilt she shouldered as the only living First One on Etheria.

Entrapta led them down less used avenues, taking more narrow corridors that resembled service tunnels for repair crews. It didn't take long for the faint glow along the halls to slowly fade away into solid darkness.

"Entrapta….where did you take us?" Glimmer hissed, from her position in line a few paces back.

"Well, I had just started exploring the compound that spread out beneath the Beacon when Adora and Bow came and got me...so...I really have no idea where we are." Entrapta responded, her straightforward honesty as always sending everyone's anxiety into overdrive.

"The First Ones had left so many of their secrets...hidden on and beneath this island. I have barely started to uncover them. The data stored in the mainframe I hacked into, was corrupted. Not like back at Arxia. Due to age. But someone had disabled the A.I….here with a virus. They may have been covering something up...something more than just the Heart of Etheria Weapon."

"Well, that's ominous." Brojee commented bitterly,

"I could light a fire in my palms?" Catra offered, the darkness didn't bother her at all, as she could still see clearly. The corridor was the same as all the other's but more narrow.

"That could draw attention to us." Bow commented. "Can Melog cloak your magic? I thought that his ability only worked on objects and people?"

(Bow is correct, I might in time be able to cloak your fire. But I haven't adapted myself fully to your magic aura yet.) Melog advised, through their link.

"Yeah, Melog says they can't cloak my fire yet." Catra sighed dejectedly, giving Melog a scratch behind their ears to let them know she was disappointed but also understood.

“Well, do we even need to be cloaked? If we can’t see, neither can the intruder’s. So if any of them are down here, we’ll see their light source just as well as they would see ours.” Brojee offered, cracking a glow stick without asking for approval.

“Seriously, man?” Bow’s disapproving frown filled the meager lime green glow of the stick in Brojjee’s hand.

Glimmer merely shrugged and cast a light spell to hover above her palm. Her brighter light, illuminating the tunnel just a bit more around them.

“Ok, well. I guess we’re doing this.” Catra commented from near the front of the line, igniting her palms with bright orange flames. The corridor in front of them was instantly illuminated in warm, flickering light.

“That’s amazing..” Brojee commented in awe, gazing with obvious admiration at both Glimmer and Catra. “There are so few planets with magic...I have never seen elemental manipulation before.”

Glimmer smiled modestly. While Catra blushed and nodded, fighting down the urge to show off.

They stood frozen, scanning the strange, natural tunnel that had replaced the metal corridor unnoticed while they had walked in the complete darkness.

“Where the hell are we!” Glimmer’s panicked voice screeched.

Catra glanced over Entrapta’s shoulder, as the scientist zoomed out, expanding her schematic of the area on her screen.

“We have gone below the beacon’s main compound...to an uncharted area.” Entrapta offered. “Which is exciting!” She beamed, turning around to confront several scowling faces. “But also... bad…” She frowned and nodded, taking the hint that how she was interpreting the dire situation was socially incorrect.

“Good news, though. No life signs down here but us.” She offered, wishing to ease the anxiety.

With the more vibrant light Catra had provided they all got a good look around.

The walls of the tunnel were damp, smooth and deathly pale. Mottled with a sunless green hue. Dark, bruise colored, bulbous knots, jutted downward towards them from the roof. Disappearing into the gloom of the shaft ahead, was a canopy of fine, fibrous roots. That glowed faintly with sickly hues of yellow, green and pale white. They looked very similar to the dark vines that webbed across the island above.

Catra’s eyes flared wide in sudden fright as she watched the roots twitch and writhe, now that light and faint warmth was being cast upon them.

“Sparkles, we might need some back up.” Catra started to say.

“On it!” Glimmer shouted, noticing the roots, slight movements as well.

The group fanned out as Glimmer blinked away in a shower of starlight.

Needing to give each other room to defend themselves if the roots decided to attack.

“Are those the roots that tried to kill us the last time we were here?” Bow asked nervously, pointing up at the webbing fibers.

“Lets just keep moving...we don’t really have enough room in here to fight.” Adora jogged ahead of them, her quarterstaff held against her chest.

Catra ran beside her, along the far side of the shaft. Holding her hands outward, casting her firelight ahead of them. Illuminating the strange, writhing walls of the corridor in warm, flickering light.

Entrapta used her hair to stride right down the middle of the tunnel far ahead of them all. Scanning the roots and walls with her data pad. Her expression was full of awe and fascination at the readings she was getting. These roots had attacked her before, so she was wary but did not have enough information yet to decide if she should be scared.

Bow and Brojee guarded their rear, in the same flanking positions on either side of the tunnel. Brojee's glow stick was now hooked into his belt, the eerie green light bouncing along the corridor. Creating an erratic strobing backdrop to the strange tunnel surrounding them. The smooth tunnel they traveled along was alien and creepy. The light from Catra's flame illuminated the whole of the tunnel now. That was thick with those same fibrous roots that had once only been on the roof. A murky, stagnate smelling liquid was pooling under their feet. The same ropy strands of roots, twisted through the thick, muck. The air had grown heavy and musky, carrying a strange, dank stench that clung to Catra and Melog's nose. The two cats sneezed and shook their heads, trying to clear away the unclean smell. The air clung to their fur, making it damp from the amount of moisture it contained. It made Catra shiver, as her whole body had become clammy and cold.

"Is it just me...or are we just going straight downwards." Catra commented, with a hiss. As she darted her eyes upward to the twitching roots. Suddenly feeling rather confined. All of her instincts were screaming at her that this was a bad situation that was only going to get worse. That they needed to stop, turn around...run back!

They had not gone much further before a flash of light announced Glimmer had returned. Perfuma was with her, already getting a short briefing of the situation from the Queen, before they blinked. She had come in prepared to deal with the strange roots surrounding them. She scanned the fibrous webs, knotting and twisting around the walls and floor. Her usually warm eyes,

darkening with confusion. As her delicate eyebrows furrowed and her mouth fell into a deep frown of concentration. When she got close to the slick translucent wall, she stood stiffly for a moment. Her finger's twitching and curling near her chest in revulsion. As she deliberated what she was not sensing through her magic. Then slowly raised her arms, her trembling fingers reaching towards the web of roots cautiously. Seeking to verify her theory the only way she knew how, by touch.

"The Beast...of Beast Island..." Perfuma moaned softly. Her peoples epic tales of She-Ra defeating the Monstrous Beast upon this island, spinning through her mind.

"Perfuma…?" Glimmer gripped her staff, sensing her unease.

"My day so far has been… rather trying." Perfuma ground out, "Finding a peaceful place for meditation in the Fright...I mean...Scorpania right now is… difficult.."

Catra's ears twitched, as she looked at Perfuma more closely. The woman looked tired, she had exhaustion bruises under her eyes and her shoulders were tense. She was leaving a lot unsaid about what was happening back at the Hordes old base.

"I fear my fragile mental state is rather too unsettled to be dealing with this...oddity right now." Perfuma muttered, as she lightly brushed her fingertips along a fibrous cluster. Then sighed and pulled her hand back, turning to regard the others. "But these threads I am afraid are not roots…" She sucked in a stuttering breath of both awe and fear.

"What do you mean?" Bow asked, coming in close to Perfuma to scrutinize the wall full of thin, green and purple fibers.

"These are...veins…" Perfuma stated, curling her fingers against her chest again.

"So we are not in a tunnel?" Catra squeaked, her apprehension and anxiety rising ten fold.

“We are, but it’s a living tunnel. ” Perfuma swallowed, looking around the dimly lit area with new found wonder. With just a hint of disgust shadowing her lingering gaze.

Everyone’s jaws dropped as unease, disbelief and confusion washed over them.

“Oh, Fascinating! That explains my readings! We’re inside a living creature…. an artery to be exact.” Entrapta spoke up, now scanning the walls with her data pad. Gazing at the glistening walls and knots of twisting nerves and thicker veins with wonder.

“So the secret of Beast Island...is that it’s alive….” Bow reasoned in a hushed whisper. His eyes widening in awe at the prospect of being inside a creature this massive. But the cold logic of also being inside something that large, made him shutter in terror.

“Why are things with you guys so weird…” Catra ground out, palming her face in irritation. Fighting back all her instincts to run, as far away as possible from this gruesome, unnatural situation.

“We should get out of here.” Perfuma offered weakly. Several others nodded in agreement. While Adora kept staring down the dank, murky tunnel, her eyes wide and unfocused.

“Awww.” Entrapta whined, like a disappointed little kid. “But we could learn so much...”

“We need to get back on mission.” Bow stated, turning on his heel. “We do not have any time for….for...whatever this is.”

“Agreed. I’ll get us back up to the beacon.” Glimmer nodded as the rest crowded around her.

Catra moved into the group, her stomach already flipping nervously. When she noticed Adora was missing.

“Where’s Adora?” She gasped, instantly back stepping out of Glimmer’s range and scanning the tunnel behind them. Her

firelight casting the murky depths in a flickering half light that only made the tunnel look more gross and daunting.

“It’s not like her to just go off...on her own?” Glimmer muttered, with dark humor. Because it was totally plausible for Adora to do just that! She had done it on their way to the Heart. Leaving all of her friends behind, believing that she had to handle the burden of delivering the Fail Safe on her own. Not willing to risk her friends any further.

“I’ll go find her.” Catra groaned and tossed them a curt wave.

She had jogged down the tunnel a few meters when Entrapta dashed up beside her.

“What are you doing?” Catra snapped.

“Coming with you, the others will be fine. Bow’s got the schematic on his Tracker pad. As long as they avoid the red dots. No problems.” Entrapta asserted, in a perky, positive manner.

Catra raised an disbelieving eyebrow.

Entrapta merely shrugged her shoulders and smirked.

“You know these dummies can’t stay out of trouble for very long.” Catra commented sarcastically.

Entrapta laughed. “That’s why we’re here, to save them.”

Catra nodded and laughed in agreement.

Chapter End Notes

I know...I did it again...LOL. Happy Halloween.

Corrupted Core

(**Pain….)**

The sensation struck her hard, like a sudden punch in the gut. Adora's eyes widened in alarm, as she turned away from the group and clutched her stomach. Seeking to soothe the intense ache, that was now roiling deep inside her abdomen. Making her feel suddenly nauseous and ready to heave the contents of her stomach.

(So…..hungry…..)

The languishing agony of slow starvation penetrated her body. Along with the seething rage and anguish of a lost and forgotten soul. Locked away in a cage, unable to free itself...growing more weak and more fragile as the endless years pass. It was not capable of understanding the reasons it had been treated so unfairly. It's thoughts are so innocent and childlike. It couldn't understand why those who once cared for it had left it so abruptly, uncaring that it was going to slowly starve to death in its prison cell. Its fear and pain was overpowering. Making her cringe and clutch her head. As the frantic unhinged emotions pounded inside her brain. Of a creature that had lost all hope and gone insane. Followed by a numb sort of emptiness that was so profound and all encompassing, it left her breathless. Adora couldn't concentrate on what the group was discussing any longer. The broken voice inside her head was weak, barely a whisper as it seemed to be near death. But the emotions it was casting into her were brutal, unrelenting in its desperate calls for help. Begging her for relief in any form, from the never ending agony of living.

Whatever was reaching out to her, it had formed a link with her very similar to Swift Winds.

(All….alone….)

(Forgotten….)

(Scared…..)

Adora couldn’t focus on anything, beyond finding the source of these anguished emotions. She turned from the group and broke into a full sprint, disappearing down the murky tunnel, focused on a singular mission. This creature had been wallowing in its misery for hundreds of years. Unable to communicate to anyone of its suffering. She needed to help it, save it. It needed her...it needed She-Ra!

In the minutes it took for Catra and the others to notice Adora was gone. The heroic blonde had managed to put a great distance away from them. Disappearing into the depths of the living tunnel. Something had drawn Adora away from them. That would be the only reason she would just take off without telling anyone. How long they delved deeper down that dark tunnel, Catra had no idea. But she had been following Adora by scent alone for a very long time. When the blonde had taken off, she had done so at a full sprint. These First Ones structures liked to mess with the people who entered them. Catra cringed briefly in remorse at how she had allowed the Crystal Castle to manipulate her memories, to turn her against Adora. She figured that the beacon, as soon as it sensed the presence of a First One. Had lured Adora away.

For what purpose she didn’t know, but she was not going to allow some ancient tech to control Adora, again. Her girl was finally free

to make her own choices. No longer shackled by some fabricated destiny, to be used as a weapon….the war was over and they would all create their own legacies from now on. She would fight for that right until her dying breath. Catras' magic flame was perched upon a raised palm, snapping and pulsing with warmth and flickering light. She was arching her back, raising her head high with her eyes closed, sniffing the air as she focused on that soft, gentle scent she knew so well.

"That is amazing.." Entrapta blurted out in a hushed whisper, as if apprehensive about breaking Catra's concentration. Catra opened her eyes, giving Entrapta silent permission to continue her observations.

"I saw you use your hybrid abilities back in the Horde, but never got the chance to really study them. Cause stuff happened…" Entrapta voice faded, her eyes focused inward on grim memories for a moment. But she quickly shunted those unwanted recollections aside. "How many other heightened senses do you have...I want to know everything!" She rattled on eagerly.

Catra cut her gaze to Entrapta briefly, her expression pained. Wanting to apologize again for how cruelly she had treated her, but held her tongue. Hating those bad memories she created, that seemed to creep up and hurt Entrapta still. Repeating words of regret would do the scientist no more good. Entrapta knew she was remorseful and was working on being a better friend, a better person. She would continue to be kind, thoughtful and compassionate to Entrapta. To show her in action, that she was someone who she could count on, someone who truly understood her and accepted her. Eccentricities and all.

"I'll give you a full interview, after we find Adora and get the hell out of this hall of horrors." Catra responded crisply, her attention more focused on their eerie environment now, then Entrapta. Jogging off down the tunnel. Entrapta merely grunted in acknowledgment and dashed after her, needing to stay focused because she didn't want to be left behind.

Along with Adora's scent, Catra was also tracking the faint, fluttering heartbeat of another creature. It thrummed on the weak current of stale air that wafted through the living tunnel. The fact that she could hear it, spoke of how massive this creature may be. The beating echoing at the very edge of her hearing like a palliative whisper in the dark. That could easily dull your senses into a numb kind of stupor if you focused on it for too long. The hairs on the back of her neck were starting to rise as she resisted it's insidious pull. Suddenly she could sense an undercurrent of magic, so similar to what she felt when she was close to She-Ra. It shimmered in the essence of everything that surrounded them. Pulsed in those strange root-like veins that covered the whole of the tunnel. She couldn't help but think that whatever lurked at the end of this gross passage was connected to She-Ra in some way.

As they moved deeper, the heartbeat became an odd thumping that was now pulsing beneath their feet. Entrapta's human hearing finally noticed it and she had her voice recorder out. Her magenta eyes wide with curious awe. But her forehead was furrowed deeply in apprehension.

"Odd…" she muttered, moving towards the veins as if the sound was emanating from them. Before vocalizing more of her inner dialogue quietly to herself.

"This is an artery...yes...but the heartbeat...perhaps it is a part of an umbilical cord?" Then she turned to Catra, her mind still silently spinning over various theories as she spoke.

"The First Ones, were exceptional scientists. They sought to explore and understand every aspect of the universe. Unfortunately they also wanted to harness and control the universe as well." Entrapta finished, glancing down at her data pad in her other hand.

"Including creating new life…" She finished ominously.

"I am starting to believe the First Ones made an even bigger mess of Etheria before leaving. It wasn't some fluke that Adora had been stolen and sent here...she was chosen for far more than just becoming the new She-Ra. That sorceress who kidnapped her. She must expect Adora to clean up the mess the First Ones made and maybe not just on Etheria, perhaps they expect her to go out and fix the whole universe. Maintain order and bring peace. Like that other Master of Universe is doing?....He-Man." Catra's voice was soft and reflective. Adora still had a destiny...to fulfill. That was far greater than anything she could comprehend. It scared her as much as it filled her with pride. This power was something Adora had always wanted. She had always wanted to be able to protect others, to fix the world and make everything better.

Entrapta merely stared at her. As her keen mind switched from her current mystery to that of She-Ra. Reviewing all the data she had collected thus far in her research of the First Ones.

"Adora...has always been the key to unlocking the secrets of the First Ones. As She-Ra she was powerful enough to withstand the full brunt of Etheria's magic. The First Ones created the sword to control her...to control She-Ra, so that they could use her, to channel that universal magic and focus it into a beam. Forcing her to fire it at some unknown target far out in space...with the sword destroyed. They no longer have any power to control She-Ra. It is up to Adora now...she can choose to use that magic anyway she wishes." Entrapta nodded, working out some of her thoughts verbally.

Catra narrowed her eyes, Entrapta spoke of She-Ra like it was a simple elemental force of magic, like her fire. But she has had some very long and deep conversations about She-Ra with Adora over the last few months. She was a part of a long line of vessels… Catra swallowed hard, perhaps...hosts...that this magic inhabited... this symbiosis reached far into the past. Further than even her birth, a thousand years ago? Mara had disrupted that line when she stranded Etheria in Despondos. She never wanted another She-Ra to be called. Why? Was it just to stop the weapon or was there more to it?

With the current nightmares Adora was having about Despara and the new information Razz had given her. During her dream just this morning. About the entity known as Sheana and her dark counterpart...Despara. Catra was even more terrified about the primordial magic Adora tapped into. It wasn't elemental..it was something far greater..it was sentient. A sentient person was driven by emotion...good or bad. They had their own wants, needs and moral compass that does not always align with other peoples. She-Ra was all powerful and most likely eternal. With the sword of protection destroyed, Adora was now the tool to be used. That magic might seek to manipulate and control Adora for its own purposes. Forcing her to be nothing more than a puppet doing it's bidding...

"Let's go, we need to find Adora!" Catra shouted, darting off with new found urgency.

The cave became more damp, the air thick with the stale scent of mold and mildew. The further down they went the colder it got, soon Catra had an arm wrapped around herself. Her other hand was still slightly outstretched, but was now trembling violently. The flame in her palm is a tiny, flickering sputter. Hunched over, teeth chattering and shivering from the moisture that was now freezing upon her fur. Entrapta had wrapped her hair around herself in an attempt to keep warm, her breath puffing out in a burst of fog as she walked briskly beside her. Thankfully the fleshy walls gave off a faint, eerie green glow so they were not in complete darkness. It was unsettling and the crypt like atmosphere of being so deep underground. Was causing Catra to become agitated and short tempered.

"Why is it getting so damn cold?" Catra sniped, as Melog chirped in agreement. A shiver rippled down their sleek body.

"I don't know...scientifically speaking the only benefit to extreme cold temperatures upon living tissue is to freeze it. To force hibernation or stop the metasitization of rogue cells?" Entrapta

stated, glancing nervously around the eerie semi darkness the tunnel had become.

Even Catra's flame was struggling to remain alive in her palm due to the intensity of the cold.

In time they were met with a choice, as the lightless flesh thinned along one side replaced by the rough basalt stone of an earthen shaft. A crack in the stone revealed a narrow tunnel that would take them deeper. Or they could continue along the strange living tunnel that now twisted away into the darkness. Catra quickly made the decision to leave the strange organic tunnel for the more narrow earthen one. Any sort of normal surroundings was welcome at this point. Without the eerie glow infused in the flesh of the living tunnel. They were soon swallowed into complete darkness. She reignited the flame in her palm, casting the passage into a flickering half light. That just made everything more unnerving. Revealing that even down here, so deep beneath the Island. The fleshy knots and twisting veins remained upon the earthen walls, still clinging to the stone, pulsing and glowing in those same grotesque hues.

Entrapta pulled out a wand with a blinking sensor at the tip, from the side of her data pad and began to run it down the length of a vein.

"Fascinating…" she whispered.

Catra's ears twitched, giving up on her flame again. Shivering far too hard to keep it alive. Rubbing her arms up and down as she cautiously approached Entrapta, seeking further explanation. The only light now was the soft glow of Entrapta's screen, illuminating their dower faces.

"These veins have the exact same biosignature as the vines that crawl up the trees and scrap metal topside. I had wondered if they were more than just vegetation. They had tried to entangle me more than once, during my exploration of the island. If they got a hold on you, they would slowly bind you and pin you to the

ground. The beacon's signal would sap all of your will to live and then the island would simply devour you. I had observed it doing that to other animals and found several carcasses, in various stages of decay. With the beacons, signal sapping your will to live...it was a perfect trap to kill everything on Beast Island…..but why would the First Ones want to destroy all their living research...it makes no sense." Entrapta muttered, her eyes darkening with bleak memories of when she had almost succumbed to the vines herself. Giving up...and wallowing in her own self loathing at being different….never truly fitting in with others. Her despair at not understanding other people, unable to connect and never being able to have real friends. She had believed that she belonged on Beast Island, left behind, forgotten and alone...Entrapta quickly gave her head a sharp shake, refusing to allow those tragic thoughts to take hold. Forcing herself to remain on track. None of that was true!

Catra huffed, as Entrapta continued to ramble under her breath, her various theories about the biolab they found, the beacon above and the strange sub-structure they were currently lost in. Quickly moving into a short history lesson about the civil war on Etheria that was raging during Mara's time.

Catra had been a baby then, but she remembered how insecure and scared she had felt. As she travelled and hid with her parents, witnessing the war and the devastation ripping the kingdoms of Etheria apart. She cringed as those vague memories which were more emotions than any concrete image. Sadness, hopelessness all washed over her as she listened. With a growl, she refocuses on Entrapta. When she began to theorize about what the First Ones intentions might be and the true purpose of Beast Island, might have been. Her rambling was getting tedious and the sense of doom laced in her theories was beyond scary. Increasing Catra's panic ten fold. Losing her patience, Catra reignited her flame in her palm then grabbed Entrapta by a pony tail and dragged her along. They had no time for this. They needed to find Adora and disable the security system and get the hell off this cursed Island and never come back. Entrapta squeaked at Catra's sudden rough treatment, but took it in stride. Content to allow

Catra to lead her for now, let her use her ponytail as a tether. As it was beneficial, so she could focus on the data scrolling over the screen of her data pad and not worry about walking into a wall.

Catra noted how patches of decaying flesh clung to the stone, peeling away like a healing scab. The veins still crawled in clusters along the rough, earthen roof and walls. While other patches of flesh looked newly formed, still pink and pulsing with life. Enclosing them in an odd half formed tunnel that didn't know if it was flesh or stone. Stuck in a stalemate between decay and regrowth. As a thin layer of ice had formed over the flesh and stone, freezing it in that strange in between state. It was gross and unnatural.

"I don't like this…" Catra muttered to Melog, who growled in agreement. Catra's gaze was transfixed upon the icy darkness ahead. The intensity of her anxiety was affecting Melog. Their dark lavender body was molted with yellow undertones, their mane and tail having turned a dull yellow. Summoning the last vestiges of her courage to keep trekking lower. Catra heaved a deep breath and walked forward. Her emotions were also affecting her magic. The fire in her palm now smothered to a faint flickering spark, that was basically useless. The narrow tunnel quickly began to widen, as they crept into a vast cavern. Its walls stretched out of view. Disappearing into the frozen gloom. The ceiling is so high above them, to be nonexistent. Catra paused at the entrance, releasing Entrapta's hair as she gauged the rapid, sharp decline in the floor. The angle was so steep and severe it could have easily been the edge of a cliff.

Suddenly her heart leapt into her throat and she rushed to the edge.

"ADORA!" She screamed down into the void below. Waiting anxiously for a response.

"Catra! I'm down here….I sorta slid, sorta fell down here..." Adora's faint voice echoed back, her tone nervous and embarrassed.

“I’m on my way, stay where you are!” Catra shouted back.

Adora’s bitter chuckle echoed from the depth of the hole.

“Don’t really have a choice here!” She shouted up, sardonically.

Catra turned to regard Entrapta sternly. “Stay here!” she commanded.

The scientist merely nodded absently, staring at the new data now scrolling over the pad.

With her claws extended, Catra moved forward on all fours. Swinging her legs over the edge and clinging to the lip of the cliff. Before starting to climb down, moving as carefully and as swiftly as she could. Melog kept pace, inching down after her in the same manner Catra was using. By clinging to the nearly sheer rock face. Using the narrow, ledges of roughly hewn stone. That barely jutted out of the frozen layers of flesh and clusters of veins. The route down was painstakingly slow, but soon Catra caught sight of Adora’s silhouette. Standing a few meters below her, with her back hunched, arms wrapped around her middle as if she was feeling nauseous. It was the most fragile and timid she had ever seen her. Fueled by terror and relief, Catra dropped the last few meters, straight down. To land in a crouch upon a strangely stiff yet pliant floor. It was smooth, clusters of veins webbed over the surface and a thin layer of ice, cracked under her fingertips and toes.

“Are you insane!” Catra leaped at her, grasping Adora around the upper arms and shaking her. “Do not just run off alone! In a crazy place like this!” She continued to rant, inches away from Adora’s face. When her scolding tirade fell silent instantly. Noticing how pale and clammy Adora’s face looked. How her blue eyes looked glazed and unfocused.

“Adora?” She cocked her head sideways in confusion.

“It’s cold….and scared...and it hurts….so bad...” Adora’s expression crumpled into anguish, as she released a painful sob. Tears flooding her eyes and then falling down her cheeks.

Catra was beyond confused, glancing nervously around the icy, dark pit they were now in. Searching for the source of Adora’s pain. It was so dark, her night vision was little help in gleaning any real details of their environment.

With a snarl, Catra let go of Adora and thrust both of her arms upward, igniting her magic. She needed light and a good source of it. Sparkles could create light...by casting her magic upwards to form floating balls. Could she do the same with her fire? Or would her fire balls just set the whole cavern a blaze. Her magic could be so very destructive...she was nervous about using it in such a closed environment.

Catra ground her teeth as caution and fear set in, her arms aflame.

(Set me on fire instead.) Melog offered, nudging her hip with their muzzle.

“Hell no!” Catra countered, with an appalled grimace down at Melog. The brutal carnage her fire had caused the Laser Bear flashing in her mind. The last thing she wanted was to put Melog in any danger or cause them pain.

(I am a vessel made of magic… I am fully capable of withstanding and holding a charge of your magic within me for a certain amount of time. I can become your light...for however long you might need it.) They huffed stubbornly, as Catra crouched down, extinguishing her fire. Her expression is grim and uncertain. Melog merely bunted their head against Catra’s. Reassuring her silently that it would be alright.

“I can’t lose you…” She whispered, her voice trembling with fear as she finally embraced them.

Melog merely started to purr. (Fill me with your magic…..my friend.)

Catra swallowed hard, feeling their fierce determination through their link. Nodding against their neck, willing her flame once more into her palms. The dark lavender fur under Catra's palms began to spark. As she funneled an intense heat into Melog. It took only a moment for Melog's dark fur to pulse a brilliant orange, their flowing mane changing into a vibrant white flame. That snapped and flickered like a warm campfire. Their eyes had changed from the once tranquil blue to a fierce red inferno that glowed so intensely they were blinding. As if her magic was barely contained inside their body. The whole cavern flared into brilliant clarity as Melog padded a few meters away, to sit somberly in the dead center of the pit. Illuminating the sickly looking flesh and stone walls, warming the icy air, to a damp, balmy state. That sucked away their breath and made them briefly light headed.

"Adora…" Catra turned back to her with concern.

Finding her stormy blue eyes staring down at her feet, moist with concern and so full of fear. Catra looked down, her mouth dropping open and sucked in a startled breath. Her expression twisting into a stricken mirror of Adora's.

"What the hell is that?" Catra hissed. They were standing on a fleshy sack, with the same pulsing veins as the tunnel webbing across it. Beneath the sack, an immense body disappeared into the murky green fluid within. Its scaly hide was a pale white, with similar dark veins webbing across it's skin. That pulsed with the malicious red glow of corruption, very similar to the veins that once crawled across She-Ra, when she had been infected by that First Ones disc. The berth and width of the monster beneath was so incomprehensible in scope. That Catra was instantly terrified.

"It called to me...in my mind. I couldn't fight it...it is in so much pain." Adora whispered, her voice weak and frightened. "The First Ones...created it...then left it to die…" She finished her voice brittle with loathing.

“Oh…..this is amazing!” Entrapta’s excited bellow echoed from further in the pit.

Both Catra and Adora snapped their heads up, to find the lavender haired scientist. Scuttling across the flesh sack on her hair, taking readings. Then kneeling and pressing her face right up against the sack, eager to see the monster that lay within. Making all manner of excited squeals and muttering.

“My theory was correct...we were traveling down an umbilical cord...this must be the womb it’s connected too…is there anything inside?” Entrapta breathed in awe, then stopped dead in her tracks blinking in horror. As an alarm sounded from her pad.

‘Oh….that's not good.” Entrapta huffed, curling her hair under her butt and sitting down right beside Melog so she could use their light.

“What the Hell, 'Trapta!” Catra shouted in exasperation. “I told you to stay up there.”

“I know..” Entrapta quipped back, her eyes flicking across her screen frantically. “I decided not to listen….you get that.” She finished with a sly wink and a smirk. Because Catra did as she pleased and so did Entrapta.

“Why am I not surprised?” Catra released a tired, unimpressed laugh of complete defeat. Flapping her arms in exasperation. She couldn’t counter Entrapta. When she threw her own stubborn independence not to listen to others in her face.

“We’re not alone down here…” Entrapta moaned ominously. Catra was instantly on high alert, her ears swiveling in search of any small sounds. Eyes slowly scanning the cavern above for movement. Adora had her staff posed near her chest in a defensive stance, scanning the lip of the pit high above as well.

“How many…” Catra called, as Adora took up a position against her back. So they could defend one another if anyone attacked.

“Two….down here….and more are enroute to our position.” Entrapta stated.

“Where!” Adora shouted, the impending threat having snapped her out of the dazed state she had been in. She was totally focused on their environment, muscles primed to react at the slightest threat.

The creature below them shifted, sending massive bubbles to the surface of the now warm, fleshy shell. The air beneath burbled against the flesh, causing it to ripple like waves under their feet. The slick, glossy skin heaved upward slightly as the massive body beneath twisted and rolled. Suddenly becoming more alert and active, as if it sensed the coming invader’s as well.

“Where are the two down here?” Adora shouted, snapping her head back and forth trying to find the two interlopers along the walls. The pit was barren and open so there was nowhere for them to hide? How could she not see them?

“ugh….I found them…” Catra groaned in disgust, toeing lightly away from their position and closer to the security of the side of the pit.

Adora glanced down, gasping in horror as two half digested bodies floated to the surface beneath the flesh shell they were standing on.

Entrapta was quick to stride over by her hair to scan the corpses, staring avidly down at the gruesome sight, humming with interest. She seemed completely unaffected by the grizzly remains, able to distance herself from the horror and view it only at a purely scientific level.

“The creature seems to feed off the flesh of other organisms….living inside the bowels of the island like a parasite...” Entrapta started to theorize.

“We need to get out of here!” Catra exclaimed, her skin was crawling, muscles twitching with the need to run. Her nerves were

on edge, her tail was bristled and standing up, as her instincts screamed at her that they were in very serious danger and needed to flee or they were going to die here.

“No….we need She-ra….she can fix this…” Adora latched her staff onto her back, then rushed to Catra’s side. Her marron cape fluttered behind her, as she strode forward. A strong sense of purpose in her crisp, commanding stride. When she closed in, she grasped Catra’s hands. Staring down at her, the desperation in her eyes, freezing the cat girl in place. Adora’s blue eyes were firm and pleading for her to understand. To consent and give her the power to heal this wretched, misunderstood creature. That had never been given a proper chance at life. Never experienced kindness or known a shred of happiness in its entire life. It deserved better...

“What are you…” Catra barely got the words out, before Adora slammed her lips against hers. There was a ferocity to the kiss that was almost violent, seeking to force her to reciprocate.

“Adora!” Catra wailed and jerked away from her, suddenly very embarrassed by her inappropriate behavior. Now was seriously not the time for PDA!

Adora was being so aggressive and demanding, Catra was suddenly very distressed by the shift in her lover’s behavior. Her heart was now slamming against her chest, her ears folded back and tail standing straight and bristled to twice it’s normal size. Uncertain and frightened she didn’t know how to deal with the panic now overwhelming Adora.

“Its the only way I can be certain that I will transform correctly…” Adora’s arms now folded around Catra’s shoulders, felt like iron. Holding her in place and not allowing her to lean away. Catra stared up at her, her mismatched eyes searching Adora’s. Finding only fear and desperation staring back at her.

“It’s always been you…” Adora whispered, her voice husky. Her lips inches away from Catra's again. Seeking to claim her lips in

another passionate, yet forceful kiss.

"On Primes ship….at the Heart….even back in your Force Captain's Quarters….your love gives me the power to summon She-Ra…."

"Adora…?" Catra was so confused. Adora was putting all this pressure on her, as if she had become the living replacement for the First Ones relic...the Sword of Protection. But she did not possess that kind of power. She-Ra was Adora's magic and it was up to her to learn how to summon that power correctly. She understood that...the other princesses understood that. Why was Adora so adamant that she wasn't the key to her own magic?

"On the Velvet Glove, I was willing to risk it all... to save you. I had failed to get through to you at Thaymor...then again in the Portal. I had to save you this time, I promised myself that I would never leave you behind ever again. When you took your last breath in my arms. I had never been so scared... that I was going to lose you…forever. I was so angry...at what Prime had done to you. So scared...that you were dead... that She-Ra woke up. She came back for the first time, since I destroyed the sword. My connection was more solid than it had ever been. " Adora easily overpowered her. Pushing Catra backwards up against the wall. Catra whined, glancing over her shoulder as the sheer rock face pressed into her back. She felt caged and for the first time, frightened by Adora's strength.

"The Crystal Castle showed me my true desire. It showed me you...through all the moments I had known you. You have always been the only person who has known the real me...and you still wanted me...for me. I never had to prove myself to you. You never expected more from me than I was willing to give. I... was enough... I knew, I loved you...long ago...back when we were kids. But I kept those feelings close, locked away in a box, I refused to allow them out...I couldn't believe we could ever be more than just Best Friends. Shadow Weaver would never allow it...anyway. Then we were over….I chose my side and you chose yours. I had lost my chance and I had to learn to live with it. I was a coward....but when I was dying and you confessed. I

couldn’t afford to hold myself back from what I truly wanted...when you kissed me. I had never experienced such a powerful connection with She-Ra before. The magic was like a star, pulsating and exploding out of me…” Catra’s ears flickered with interest, as her confession rocked her to her very core. Adora’s eyes were firm and unyielding as she gripped Catra’s chin and held her in place.

“In your Force Captain's quarter's….I wasn’t having a bad dream...it was a good dream….a very erotic dream about you...about us…” She whispered, her lips ghosting over Catra’s ear. Adora was being so forthright with her feelings. Confessing the deepest most vulnerable parts of her heart. But she was also being...so forceful...so commanding…Catra was scared and nervous, also kinda turned on...but ultimately. She didn’t know how to deal with this situation. She didn’t want to hurt Adora’s feelings, or reject her...but here...now. This just felt so wrong. She was not asking for permission or consent....she was going to take from her what she needed. She was going to do what she felt needed to be done to achieve her goal. So desperate to transform correctly. Believing Catra was some magical catalyst, some simple, on switch for her magic.

Adora leaned forward, her lips hovering over Catra's. It as then Catra’s calm and indecision broke.

“Adora….don’t…” Catra pleaded, as tears crept out of the corners of her eyes and rolled down her cheeks. The scared tremble in her voice, the hurt in her eyes, the sight of her tears. Was like a bucket of ice cold water. Adora sucked in a startled breath and pulled back in shame. Turning on her heel, she scrubbed her hands down her face, as she paced away. Growling and groaning under her breath, so terrified and overwhelmed at their situation. She had acted reprehensible towards her one true love.

“It is not in my power to turn you into She-Ra, Adora….that's on you. You have to figure out what within you...summons the magic.” Catra began, reaching out for her. “I draw my fire from the desire to protect you.” She grasped Adora’s upper arm and

turned her back. Silently showing her that her previous actions were forgiven, by cupping her cheeks and pulling her down so they could rest their foreheads together.

"It's just a baby….its been imprisoned for a thousand years...it does not deserve to suffer like this…I can heal it, destroy the virus that is corrupting it. I could set it free... " Adora whispered, her voice trembling as she was near tears. She pressed her forehead lovingly against Catra's, grasping her hands that were cupping her cheeks in remorse.

"No…." Catra pulled back, appalled and disgusted by the idea of healing a monster of this magnitude. "It's unnatural...and monstrous….its a predator that feeds off of living creatures." She gasped, "You can't be serious...the devastation it could bring to Etheria if it's set free, is beyond comprehension."

Adoras eyes were wide, shimmering with hurt and betrayal.

"I agree with Catra in some respects." Entrapta added, "This creature is huge and unnatural...it should not exist...but it does. I think we should save it and keep it contained to the island, so I can study it. Figure out what the First Ones were really doing in that genetics lab. In time I could uncover all the secrets to Beast Island." She was ecstatic and practically shivering with excitement.

'She-Ra can control it...it spoke to me...through a link just like the one I have with Swift Wind. My magic is connected to this creature...somehow. I can make sure it doesn't feed off people." Adora pleaded.

"Can you hear yourself….right now? Are you Insane!... absolutely not!" Catra reeled, yanking her hands out of Adora's grip and starting to climb out of the pit. "I will not be a part of this!" She huffed, as Melog started to pad across the now softened surface of the shell to leave with their master. Taking the glow and warmth of Catra's magic with them, sending the pit back into an eerie, icy half light.

Adora's eyes began to glisten with frustrated tears as she slowly bowed her head. Her arms lowered in defeat, hands balling into tight fists.

“Stay! I need you! I can’t turn into She-Ra without you!” She heaved a shaky breath and called out to Catra in despair.

Catra paused, hanging a few meters up the cavern wall. Staring down at her in sad confusion. They had been in this situation before...months earlier when she had run away. Unable to deal with Adora choosing to sacrifice herself, choosing Shadow Weaver over her. She had been a coward then, running from her feelings, her promise. She would never do that again! If Adora needed her, asked for her to stay. She would always stay…

Catra groaned and reluctantly started to climb back down. Slowly approaching her, a tentative air in her movements. As if Adora was now made of the most fragile glass. Worried that if she moved too fast or was even a little forceful with her touch she would shatter completely. She moved in close to Adora, placing her palms flat against her collar bone, over the scar of the Failsafe. That lay just below the soft cotton of her long sleeve shirt.

“Yes...you can...Adora...I am not your connection to She-Ra...you are...believe in yourself….find the truth within yourself that unlocks that power.” Catra leaned up and whispered into her ear.

Adora shivered as her hot breath tickled over the shell of her ear. Her voice was so full of confidence, she believed in her with all her heart.

“I love you….” Adora whispered, her voice soft but fierce. An unspoken apology for how she acted layered beneath her words. But also a farewell, in case things went terribly wrong when she tried to transform. She knew it was going to be a great risk and there could be a very painful price if she did it wrong.

“I love you too…..dummy.” Catra gave her a tender kiss to her cheek. Her forgiveness was spoken silently through the sweet gesture, before taking a step back. Offering her a bright reassuring smile. She had faith in her, a faith that Adora did not share.

It was the rumble of the earth that shattered their sweet moment completely. Catra sprang away from Adora, claws raised in defense. As Melog flared, using the magic Catra had imbued into their flesh as a living torch. Casting the entire cavern in a brilliant, iridescent orange glow. As they shone like a blinding living flame. Standing a few feet away upon the fleshy shell, their elegant head craned upward towards the lip of the pit. A howling growl of warning erupting from their throat. Eyes glaring at the impending threat now converging above them.

“Intruder’s!” A green scaled lizard hovered over the lip of the pit. His muzzle was shorter, more stout than the lizard kin of Etheria. Wearing old, mismatched pieces of rusty armor. Holding an ancient, slightly dented energy rifle against his hip. His yellow eyes squinted into the piercing glow that was Melog.

Melog’s light swiftly overwhelmed all the darkness that had been lingering in this cavern, heating the air in a burst of flame and illuminating the cavern into a fake daylight.

Catra hissed and moved closer to Adora. As a couple more strange armored creatures converged around the rim of the pit. All wearing mismatched pieces of armor and training energy rifles at them. Adora was now standing in a ready stance with her staff held close across her chest. Glaring up at the lizard and his armed goons, flicking her eyes around the sheer sides of the pit searching valiantly for cover of any kind or a way out. Finding quickly that they were trapped, out in the open with no way to escape. If the lizard commanded his men to start firing down at them, they would be killed easily.

“This is not good..” Entrapta muttered, lunging across the softening floor of the shell. The long strands of her hair had to web out to maintain her balance as the shell dipped and swayed under her slight weight.

“What’s going on?” Catra spat in frustration, when Entrapta got close. Having to hold out her arms to maintain her balance, as the shell was now rocking more violently. As if the sea itself lay below them, throwing waves against the sides of the pit.

As more strange otherworldly, warriors, all dressed in different kinds of armor moved into position around the pit. A burly man with purple skin and a ratty black beard, scowled at them. His right eye was so damaged, there was nothing left but a disfigured mess of melted skin. He wore a massive helmet with metal pronged horns on his head.

“Staghorn...get Crita on the com line. Let her know, Etherian’s have breached our security.” The lizard barked his order, now training this rifle down upon them.

“What going on, Lizzor...who are those guys?” The purple man rumbled, in a low guttural voice.

“Dead.” The lizard spat, glancing at the contingent of soldiers and raising his arm up to command them to fire.

Adora narrowed her eyes, her heart slamming hard against her chest.

This was bad...this was really bad….

They needed She-Ra….desperate and fueled by a seething rage and overpowering fear that her loved ones were going to die here. That Adora was never enough! She was weak, foolish and her bleeding heart had led her friends into a trap. With all the terrible revelations she had come to learn about the First Ones over the years. From Light Hope, Shadow Weaver, Entrapta...and now Catra. That guilt and self loathing that had been festering in her thoughts. Had amplified with each atrocity she uncovered,

growing more toxic. Poisoning her once good heart, with bitterness and revulsion at her heritage. Her people had created this monster...traumatized it and left it to die. Leaving it to suffer in pain and loneliness for a thousand years. She was a First One, it was her responsibility to heal the sins of her ancestors. She needed to fix this!

A righteous fury screamed inside of her, as she closed her eyes. Demanding justice, wishing vengeance upon the long dead people who tortured this poor creature. Willing that indomitable magic to come forth. Take what it needed from her so that it could do the impossible.

The high pitched whine of far too many energy rifles powering up, echoed throughout the cavern.

Adora clenched every muscle in her body, preparing to absorb the magic. Adora was nothing...just the sacrifice...so that everyone else could have that happily ever after. She was resigned to her fate. She didn't care what happened to her, she would willingly pay the price. She needed to save everyone no matter the cost.

"Fire!" Lizzor bellowed.

"We need to get the hell out of here!" Catra shouted her voice high pitched in panic, as Entrapta responded with a cry of distress.

Then everything became a blur of frantic movement and terrified screams.

The rumble of the earth got louder, followed by an eerie gurgling beneath their feet.

"Adora, we gotta get out of here." Catra pulled on her elbow, but Adora was now standing rigid. Head bowed, eyes closed and focused upon the infinite well of magic. Allowing it to pull her away, leaving her body an empty vessel for a greater power to

inhabit. Begging for it to consume her and save her friends. Purify that poor, twisted monster beneath their feet and right the wrongs her people had inflicted upon Etheria.

The lizard above had a clear shot right at Adora, the muzzle of his gun was starting to glow as the energy built.

“Sparkles we need an evac….like now!” Catra pressed a couple fingers to her earpiece, screaming for aid. As she was greeted by only static. Her eyes darted upward to the lizard, muscles clenching as she prepared to push Adora out of the way.

“Scary….” Entrapta’s trembling voice took Catra’s attention instantly.

She glanced sideways, finding the purple haired princess was now cowering behind Adora. Staring down at her feet, her amber eyes wide in both terror and awe.

Catra looked down, her breath catching as pure unadulterated terror washed over her.

Finding a very large, very familiar, if more elongated face staring up at her from the depths of the murky green liquid beneath the shell. Two large glowing green eyes focused on her and Adora, while the two smaller eyes that grew above and below the large left eye. Focused on Entrapta. Then the lower eye twitched and focused on the lizard and his small army now ready to fire. While the pupils of the larger eyes were dark, the pupils of the smaller eyes were a brilliant white. Like the clones when they were possessed by Prime.

Catra snapped her gaze back up and stood in shock as Adora lit up. With a pulsing red glow. Her mismatched eyes flared wide in fright, anguish clenching hard in her chest. Heart leaping into her throat, choking her as the worst possible transformation began to take hold over Adora.

While at the same time, the lizard above screamed in agony, as dozens of the root-like vines shot off the walls on the roof and

latched around him. Binding his arms and pinning him to the floor above. His rifle clattered down the side of the pit, landing on the shell a few yards away. More roots shot out from the darkness, accompanied by the strangled screams of the lizard's men being bound.

Entrapta dashed for the rifle as it landed on the pliant shell. Firing madly at the clusters of predatory veins now barreling towards them as well. Valiantly, trying to protect her friends. As Catra recoiled from the piercing red light now engulfing Adora.

The blonde rose into the air a few feet, her head cast back in supplication, welcoming the dark magic now consuming her.

More veins unlatched from the walls of the pit and shot towards them. Entrapta screamed, laying down a swath of cover fire. Vaporizing a few fibrous tendrils trying to grapple them. Melog howled and purged the fire magic from their body in a wall of flame that incinerated the last of the roots attempting to grab them. Casting them back into the eerie demi green light as before. Entrapta quickly backed up towards Catra. Who was incapable of defending herself right now. So consumed by regret and guilt at not helping Adora tap into She-Ra. Doubt gnawed at her, that perhaps Adora had been right. Maybe she was the key to guide her to her powers and she should have let her take what she needed from her.

This was all her fault...

Long black leather boots with sharp silver accents on the toes appeared on Adora’s feet. The accents looked very much like the Horde sigil. Primes smooth chest armor with a silver, sharper version of She-Ra’s eight sided star flared upon the chest piece. The prongs were slender, flaring upward like the Horde’s demonic symbol. The star's elongated points were emblazoned like the fierce blades of swords over her chest. Along with Primes, long armored robes skirting her waist. Twin swords hung on silver metal sheathes on her armored hips. Hordaks, heavy armored gauntlets appeared over her wrists, embedded with red rune

stones. Along with the sharp shoulder guards of a Horde soldier. As a darker version of Light Hope's iridescent cape fluttered at her back and Shadow Weaver’s mask flared to life over her face. Then faded away, leaving only a dark smudge of black over Adora’s eyes. That were now a deep, glowing red. Far more piercing and malevolent that before. Her long hair, was now pale almost a platinum blonde in appearance. It had shortened into a crisp military cut, with the back and sides of her head shaved. As the malicious light faded, Catra swallowed hard. As she could see the scars she made upon Adora’s face were now more prominent. The slashes on her jaw and across her nose were an angry pink and far more visible.

More screaming echoed from above, as Catra and Entrapta snapped their stricken gaze away from Adora’s dark transformation. As the lizardman and several other goons were now hovering down towards them. All bound and ensnared in the now slick, oozing vines that were starting to melt and absorb their flesh. They writhed and screamed in agony, as the vines pulled them down onto the fleshy shell. The shell itself softened even more, becoming translucent. So their bodies could pass through the thin barrier and into the digesting acid below.

Entrapa gasped, in grim fascination. As Catra gagged, squeezing her eyes shut, unable to deal with all the horrific gore surrounding her. She curled into herself, shivering with revulsion and grief. As the monster was devouring its prey alive, below her feet. The burbling and bubbles of it consuming those poor people, trembling under her toes claws. Her true love had just transformed into the dark version of She-Ra that she had been so terrified of becoming. Her armor was a mixture of all the people who had hurt and tormented her….and Catra was also part of that transformation.

That wretched fact was tearing her up inside...

“That’s not She-Ra….” Entrapta moaned, Catra never opened her eyes until she felt Entrapta’s hair encircle her shoulders in a timid yet commanding embrace. Seeking her to confront what was

happening and confirm for her how wrong everything had become.

“No…..That’s Despara.” Catra’s voice was weak, taking a deep breath to settle her trembling voice. As silent tears of despair streamed down her face.

Despara stood before them, as tall and broad as She-Ra. In a powerful frame of well packed muscle. A cold pride glowing in her red eyes. She had no crown, but wore the black markings across her eyes of Shadow Weaver’s mask. Her smooth visage was marred by thick scars across either side of her jaw and across the bridge of her nose. Her pale blonde hair cut short over her ears and buzzed high at the back. Her armor was black, with silver accents. Catra and Entrapta couldn't help but tremble under her penetrating gaze. Her aura was as fierce and all powerful as She-Ra’s, but a chaotic, menacing rage had replaced the calm, controlled essence they were used to.

Despara regarded them briefly, then sneered in disgust at the vile creature below. She unsheathed both her blades and thrust them down into the shell. The blades ignited with a red pulsing light that pierced deep into the monstrous womb below the shell.

An otherworldly, demonic howl issued from beneath them as the red light flared and consumed what lay within. The light was so bright, it made the shell look like lava. Dwarfing the vast amounts of light Melog had once given off, to send the cavern into a brilliant midday glow. Catra and Entrapta cried out in pain, cowering and throwing their arms over their eyes in a vain attempt to block out the light now burning their eyes.

“What the hell!” Glimmer’s frantic voice called to them.

“Get us out of here.” Catra screamed back.

“Who?” Glimmer’s voice was softer and more confused.

“All of us..Sparkles...now!” Catra commanded, her voice breaking.

When the light faded, replaced by a somber blue glow. Catra slowly uncurled herself from her crouching position. Taking in the new environment, refusing to give into the sick feeling Glimmer’s blink had caused. They were standing in a vast room. Upon a central dais, with what looked like a grand, pearl white spire ascending upward into the darkness above. Bow was standing at the controls before the spire, with Brojee leaning casually against the side of the pillar. He raised his eyebrows in surprise at the brooding appearance of Despara. Who regarded each of them for a moment before striding for the controls. Pushing Bow out of the way harshly. He cried out indignantly and stumbled away. Taking Despara in with wide fearful looks, retreating quickly to Glimmer’s side. Brojee backed up as well, taking cues from the others that he should be cautious.

Catra whimpered and sank to the floor, crushed by the consequences of her refusal to help Adora. Rocking back and forth as all that she had lost came into cruel and unwanted focus.

The Darkness Within

Glimmer had created a giant ball of light and sent it to float high overhead. The ceiling in this chamber was cavernous. Arching out of view high above the massive shimmering orb of Glimmer's magic. Its gentle silver glow cast the nearly barren room below in an artificial twilight. The dimly lit walls were covered in the same, smooth angular panels as all First Ones Temples. The intricate patterns of symbols, etched upon the panels, flickering faintly with the last remaining power. But also covered in the same vile, crawling 'vines' as the rest of Beast Island. The living tendrils of the monster that had grown and fed off the creatures of this island for the last thousand years. The group huddled at the edge of the simple stone, raised walkway. That connects the large, hexagonal shaped dais in the center of the room, to the rest of the beacon.

A ghostly white pillar dominated the dais, ascending upward out of view into the darkness beyond the ball of light. It's surface crawling with the same dark 'vines' as the walls. The group watched with grim fascination as Despara regarded the controls of the control pillar. Her red eyes were cold, calculating as she scanned the crisp white pillar that controlled the temple. Then hovered her hands over the controls that were mounted at the front on a slightly angled pad. She tapped a sequence of buttons long memorized, by her counterpart, 'Sheana. ' When she was bonded to Mara, a thousand years ago. Activating the diamond shaped screen. That began to scroll First Ones writing. She took a moment to read the screen. Then she tapped crisply on the various triangular buttons that were embedded into a smaller control panel just under the screen. The screen that dominated the front of the pillar, was now flashing with First Ones writing. The symbols scrolled upward at great speed, as Despara read, paying no heed to her surroundings or the others. Who were staring slack jawed and frightened by her presence.

"That's Despara." Bow breathed, leaning into Glimmer for confirmation. He was trying very hard not to tremble. Her

countenance was so powerful, giving off this sense of imminent threat. She moved like a predator, ready to strike. Which made Bow highly nervous.

"I guess…" Glimmer muttered, instinctively holding her staff close to her chest. As she crouched down to try and rouse Catra from her numbed stupor. Gripping the cat girls trembling shoulders and giving them a reassuring squeeze. Whispering affirmations to her 'That they would figure this all out and get Adora back, safe and sound. That they were in this together...a team...the Best Friend Squad never gave up on one another'.

Catra remained staring down at the pale grey floor, blinking back tears as she slowly gathered herself. Her tawny furred hand creeped up over Glimmer's and held tight, accepting her comfort and solidarity. Needing it to ground herself in the here and now. As her troubled thoughts tried to drag her down into a spiral of loathing and regret. At how badly she had failed Adora, this time. Melog had come to stand in front of her, assuming a guarding stance, keeping a wary eye on Despara. They sniffed the air, the dark magic that permeated this transformation hung like a heavy shroud. It was so thick and heady it made Melog slightly light headed. They shook their head vigorously to clear it, trying not to become too intoxicated by the incredible amounts of magic.

Entrapta as always, interpreted the outcome of Adora's dark transformation more scientifically than emotionally. She had witnessed the brutality of Despara's rage when Adora was first corrupted by the disc, back in Dryl. So she was cautious, but not frightened. Slowly approaching the warrior with her voice recorder out.

"Entrapta...what are you doing." Bow hissed in warning.

Glimmer reached for her, but Entrapta was too fast and crossed to the dias in only a few strides of her hair.

"Excuse me...Despara...is it?" Entrapta's voice was modulated and clinical. She had overheard Bow and sought to use her knowledge

of this entity's name to start the conversation.

Despara’s glowing red eyes cut over to her briefly, before her gaze returned to the screen above.

“Why can’t I access the Facilitator. Where is Light Hope? Why does she not respond to my queries” She demanded, her voice was similar to Adora’s but deeper, more raspy.

“Adora destroyed her along with the Sword of Protection to stop the Heart from firing.”

Entrapta answered, simply.

Despara grunted, then tapped a new sequence on the triangle shaped set of buttons below the screen. Swallowing her seething fury at being imprisoned inside that cursed disk, and then cast aside by the First Ones. Since they could not control her as easily as Sheana. She had missed so much in the last thousand years, she was out of touch now and rather unsettled by it.

“The inter-planetary systems have been rerouted...this terminal will not give me administrator access.” She glared down at the controls, furious at being hindered.

“Ahhh….the First Ones systems have been routed to the Sky tree.” Entrapta stated, a gloved hand darted impatiently over Despara’s. Who silently pulled her hands away, allowing Entrapta to take over the ancient keypad.

Despara watched the screen, as Entrapta navigated the control pillar's interface. Displaying the new connections between the First Ones varying installations to what remained of the Velvet Glove, hovering high above the planet.

Despara’s brow furrowed as she realized what had happened in her absence.

“This is reckless…” She snarled, balling her fists tight at her side. “To allow the Horde to commandeer our only line of defense...how

am I supposed to access the Watchtower."

"Etheria has a new Facilitator." Entrapta stated helpfully, a proud grin spreading upon her face as she eagerly typed away at the buttons.

Despara paid her a strange, confused frown. Folding her arms across her chest in a very irritated manner. Suddenly a flash of light was emitted from a hexagonal panel set into the floor beside the terminal. The familiar hologram of the First Ones interface stood before them. Her angular body and expressionless face with the open mouth, flickered to life.

[What is your query?] She inquired.

"Patch me thru to the Watch Tower." Despara demanded.

[Query not recognized.] The interface flickered and then froze. Leaving Despara seething before it. She rounded on Entrapta, her red eyes glowing menacingly.

"Fix it!" She shouted, her voice echoing through the chamber like a thunder clap.

Entrapta instantly cringed at being yelled at so harshly.

"Hey...calm down." Bow interceded, having pushed down his fear when he saw one of his friends being threatened. He walked protectively in front of Entrapta, hands raised in a placating manner. "The tech is ancient...it doesn't work right anymore."

Despara scrubbed her hand, threw her short blonde hair. It was a very Adora like mannerism for when she was really frustrated. Seeking to reclaim some control, since her hair was not contained into her preferred ponytail.

"I need the Watchtower to do a sensor sweep of the Howling Sea's for life signs...now...before it gets away!" Despara growled.

“Before what gets away?” Glimmer asked, leaving Catra’s side to stand near Bow. She hadn’t had time to get a good look around, when she teleported into the bowels of the island. It had been a blur of violent movements at the edge of her sight as several veins tried to grapple them. Desapra had rushed to her side, as Catra screamed for her to blink them away. Now a boiling froth of dread was aching in her stomach at what was down there.

“Omega Prime.” Despara sighed, casting her gaze upward in frustration. “This place was once a military compound, a research facility that manufactured and tested biological weapons. It was officially called ‘Galius’ but nicknamed Beast Island.”

[Planetary Facilitator, Hordak...online] A very deep, familiar voice echoed out behind Despara.

A violent rage took over, at the sound of Hordak's voice. Unsheathing both swords Despara spun on her heel and sliced through the hologram of Hordak. Entrapta squeaked in fright, recoiling from the violence. The hologram shimmered as Despara’s blades past threw the light projection then reformed. Into the body of Hordak, dressed in a digital representation of himself. In the more refined, lighter armor Entrapta had recently made him.

His soft yellow eyes regarded them coolly, his expression flat but the slight twitch of his thin lips showed his irritation at being attacked.

“Hordak! I’ve missed you.” Entrapta exclaimed, rushing for the hologram to wrap her arms and pony tails around him. He instinctively raised his arms to receive her affections. But her arms and hair passed right through, making him shimmer and sway until he could reform unhindered. Blushing and feeling rather foolish, Entrapta giggled and took a step back.

“Right….it’s just a projection…” She sighed, her voice was soft and embarrassed, heavy with disappointment.

Hordak regarded her with a soft smile, his eyes full of warmth, but also disappointment as well. He missed his body, not being able to touch or feel or taste any longer. But he was resolute that he would pay his penance to Etheria in this way. He would aid and protect the people of this planet, until they were capable of protecting themselves.

"You have got to be kidding me." Despara snarled, sheathing her swords angrily at her hips. "A clone is now in control of the Planet's systems." She ranted.

"What is an Omega Prime!" Glimmer demanded, rounding in front of Despara needing her to answer right away. Anything related to Prime, sent her mind spinning into panic. Her thoughts reeling with compounding anxiety at what new calamity awaited Etheria, now.

"The First Ones were experimenting with DNA." Hordak, began. "At first they began to splice Hybrid DNA with Human subjects…"

"Creating the Mutant race." Brojee offered from his position behind them. He stood beside Catra, who was still kneeling on the floor. Arms now folded over her chest, in a protective fashion. Glaring up at Despara with tears in her eyes, barely restraining her fury at the dark goddess that had just stolen her true love's body. She wanted to claw and bite and scream until Despara returned Adora to her. But now was not the time, so she held her rage in check. But as soon as this was all over, she would make Despara give Adora back!

"With that success behind them, they wanted to create the ultimate mutant, one that could survive in any environment. Nearly indestructible and capable of seeding itself into occupied planets. It's Horde DNA would allow it to invade undetected by Primes Surveillance Spires sensors. Then it could covertly seek out and devour Primes clones, planet wide, through its tendrils. Destroying his hive mind one planet at the time." Hordak explained, in a monotone voice.

“So they spliced Horde DNA...with what?” Catra finally engaged in the conversation, rising to her feet. Her eyes burned with barely restrained hatred towards Despara, as she stormed over to Glimmer’s side. So full of fury and contempt, her claws were fully extended. The razor sharp tips glinting in the faint light of the Server Room.

Despara took note of the vague threat, the sight of Catra’s claws provoked. Her glowing red eyes darted downward at the Hybrid hips. where her hands hung low, fingers coiled to strike at a moment's notice.

Despara couldn’t help but grin in anticipation, eager to engage in combat with the vessel’s lover. That battle would be interesting, even somewhat entertaining. She would be able to easily toy with the Hybrids conflicting emotions, while in combat. Coaxing out all kinds of angry expletives and pleading cries as she took her time, dominating her upon the battlefield. Despara’s tongue darted out and licked her bottom lip, aroused by the image. She hadn’t been this eager or excited for battle in a very long time.

“A thousand years ago...the She-Ra had a sacred bond with an Etherian Wyrm. The First Ones used a sample of it's DNA, to create a hybrid clone. Hoping to create the perfect living weapon.” Hordak continued. "But the clone's maturation process was interrupted...I am afraid it is little more than a baby."

“That’s horrible!” Glimmer moaned.

“So this 'baby' was created and then abandoned? Who does that! ” Bow shouted, completely appalled.

“First Ones…” Catra scoffed, rolling her eyes. “They are the real monsters.”

Despara’s eyes were cold as she stared down at Catra. The hurt inflicted upon Adora at her hateful words yet again, hidden behind a mask of icy indifference.

“Hordak...I need you to access the Watchtower and do a planetary sweep for Horde life signs.” Despara turned back to the screen on the pillar, pushing Adora’s painful emotions down. Needing to stay on task and not show the hybrid how much her hatred of First Ones, hurt Adora.

[As you wish] Hordak stated.

Then an image of the continent and surrounding sea appeared on the screen along with many clusters of dots.

Despara’s eyes flew wide in shock at the amount of clone life signs.

“The Galactic Horde invaded...we got a lotta clones now.” Glimmer answered, with a shrug.

“They’re free...cause. She-Ra destroyed Horde Prime so it's all good.” Bow added.

“I know...I was there.” Despara growled back, frustrated at herself, she should have remembered. Her consciousness had been pulled into the vessel, deep in the Heart. At the end of that final battle. Adora had used her abilities to purge Prime from Hordak's body, destroying the aspect of the Nameless One that had been corrupting both of them.

“This is not going to work…” She muttered. “I need you to scan for wyrm, DNA then. There should not be many of its kind left.”

[Scanning] Hordak stated. [Wrym lifesigns detected.]

A blue dot appeared over Bright Moon, another in Plumeria, one blinked in the Kingdom of Snows and another in Salineas. There were no dots over Beast Island or the surrounding sea.

Despara breathed a sigh of relief, nodding with approval as she placed her hands on her hips.

“So you killed it?” Catra approached her, her voice low and accusing. Adora had never wanted to kill it, she had wanted to heal it...save it. Now she understood why and it only made her feel more guilty about her callous actions...her thoughtless argument. She had acted purely on her instincts, her fear of the unknown. Unwilling to compromise or even hear Adora out as she tried to make her understand. That it was an innocent being, that it deserves to know a life without loneliness and pain. The harsh realization that she had betrayed Adora yet again, when she needed her most. Was crushing her heart worse than before. She was a terrible person...selfish and cowardly. Unwilling to take the risks needed to truly heal the deep, penetrating wounds the First Ones had inflicted upon Etheria.

Once again she was confronted by the cold, facts that she was no hero.

Not like Adora...

“I did what needed to be done.” Despara spat, as Adora’s soul shivered in disgust at hearing those words. Which were a vile echo of Shadow’s Weaver’s ideals. Despara glared down at Catra. Who was now toe to toe with her. Her head craned upward, eye’s burning with a righteous fury. Jaws clenched as she seethed, lips pulled back, all four of her sharp canines on display. As a low menacing growl vibrated from deep in her chest. The cat hybrid’s fur was bristled, tail standing straight out like a rod.

“You had no right to execute that creature.” Her words were accented violently by her low growl, as she poked her claw between Despara’s breasts.

Despara merely smirked down at her, an amused gleam in her eyes. Catra was no threat, her tirade coming off as rash and childish. In comparison to the fierce, powerhouse that was looming above her in the form of Despara.

“She-Ra knows she has the power to kill, to destroy but she doesn’t. She’s stronger than that. Adora doesn’t solve problems

the easy way, by merely wiping them out. She's able to see beyond the ugliness of her enemies to their true value. She does not cast judgement upon anyone or anything lightly. She tries to see the good in everyone...even if they're beyond saving...she tries anyway! She wants to forgive, she wants to heal and make this world better...she is the best of us all...she's who I aspire to become….and your….you're just a bloodthirsty killer!" Catra snarled, as Melog burned red beside her. Their mane snapping and crackling with her building fury.

Despara rolled her eyes with a dismissive sigh. Her patience was fraying, she was not going to endure much more of this cat girl's overly emotional scolding. Thankfully, her enhanced hearing picked up the stampeding footfalls of approaching foes. Despara spun away from Catra, pulling out her swords. Dashing across the bridge, her shimmering cape fluttering behind her. Leaving the hybrid even more furious at being cast aside and disregarded as if she meant nothing.

Crita led the charge down the dimly lit corridors heading towards the main control room. A formidable warrior in her own right, with long, wild looking red hair. Dusky, purple skin and striking green eyes, unlike the garish features of most mutants. She was considered quite attractive and she used that to her advantage often. To gain favor and higher standing within the High Council of Denebria. She wore a wide gold headband, across her forehead a token of respect bestowed upon her during her most recent conquest. It kept her hair back so she could see. It also represented her stature as the Warrior Queen of the Gleanon.

Her successful campaign on the Planet Necron, to subdue the Mytes had raised her ranks in the Mutant Empire to that of a Commander. She was now the second in command of the Mutant Fleet. As such she was now sent in to take control of high profile missions when they went off the rails. Which has been happening more and more often, these days. Their empire was losing footing in the Galaxy, as He-Man made it his life long goal to free all the

planets they had enslaved. Pushing their forces back, one planet at a time. It had been a little over three years since this Master of the Universe had appeared and he had proven to be a real pain in the ass.

When Etheria appeared once again a little over a year ago. It had quickly gained the attention of the High Council. Their history began on Etheria, the birthplace of their race. The council wanted her to investigate their origins and reclaim their greatest warrior...Omega Prime. In the hope that they could seed it on Primus and destroy He-man's current strong hold. The death toll would be swift and insurmountable. He-Man would have no idea at first, why the people he was sworn to protect were suddenly dying worldwide. The mystery would keep him planetside, as he raced to save his people. As Omega Primes vines consumed all living things on the surface. All the while the Mutant Fleet would reclaim all the planets they had lost in the last three years.

They had waited in their mothership for months just out of sensor range. When their long range sensor's picked up the Galactic Horde blockade. They would never interfere with Horde Primes' will. But they would not aid the tyrant in his domination either. Their relationship with the Galactic Horde, for the last thousand years. Was one of mutual respect, at least that's what Flogg thought. Crita on the other hand knew better. Horde Prime had no interest in the planets they occupied or their existence. So the Mutant Empire survived by staying out of his way. So when the Horde ships went offline and the Velvet Glove was transformed. Cirta had sent several contingents in smaller recovery crafts to the surface. Landing on Beast Island, which was once known as Galius. A First Ones biological research lab, left to rot for a thousand years. Abandoned by the Eternian's as they fled, when the planet was being sucked into a transdimensional portal. Her strike force had been sent to investigate and recover Omega Prime for the glory of the mutant empire.

They had been harvesting the data crystals and enslaving the Security Beasts for the last few weeks. As they worked out a proper plan to free Omega Prime, without it attacking them. They

had decided to freeze the monster, paralyzing it inside it's protective womb. Then they were going to slowly extract the fleshy prison from deep inside the island and transport it up the Mothership. But that plan went to hell, when three Etherian's meddled with the temperature down in the bowels of the island. Unthawing the beast and allowing it to feed upon her own men. She got a report from one of the soldier's who had survived the attack, reporting that another Master of the Universe had appeared and attacked Omega Prime. Now she had no idea if the creature was still alive? But she had to deal with the threats in the server room first. Then she would send search parties out to check on the monster's prison, for either a grievously wounded beast or for a corpse. Or scour the seas if it had managed to escape, all were plausible outcomes. She refused to return to Emperor Flogg empty handed. Her pride would not allow her to fail. She would do whatever was necessary to succeed in her mission.

Hoove and Karatti had been stationed to guard the entrance to the Control room. But they had been taken off guard when three Etherians teleported inside the room itself. They had reported the breach over the com line but then their transmission had gone silent. As she led her contingent of soldiers and two collared security beasts, up the last few meters of the corridor. She caught a glimpse of a honey blonde Etherian with long hair and flowers woven into the strands. She caught sight of them, and abruptly turned on her heel, dashed out of view, back into the room. No doubt to warn the others. Crita's eyes narrowed in disdain. It didn't matter, this battle was inevitable anyway.

She now stood glowering down at the two mutants, one bound in a net, the other wrapped up in muddy roots. Squirming and moaning defiantly before the heavy open doors to the room.

"Cut them out!" Crita ordered, unlatching her whip from her belt and peering cautiously inside the dark room ahead. The weight of the braided leather hilt was comforting, as Crita unfurled the thin, metal strands of her nine tails. Snapping the many sharp, slender

ropes, violently. The resounding crack of the whip echoed harshly.

“I was decrypting the logs, just like you ordered. But they just appeared...I ran to alert Karattii…” Hoove began to explain, as her men ripped the slippery roots from his face. He was a reptilian faced mutant with thick green skin and sharp teeth. His arms were replaced by bronze mechanical prosthetics. As he climbed out of the vines, he picked up his heavy black helmet with curving horns and adjusted his wide leather belt. His black leather armor was wrinkled and worn, in need of repair. He stomped out of the vines now twisted loosely around his feet. Thick, heavy armored boots in the shape of massive hooves adorned his feet.

“I don’t care!” Crita spat, “We need to regain control of the temple.” She adjusted her grip on her whip, threatening Hoove silently that his failure would have consequences.

“We’re ready for them now.” A low, raspy voice rumbled from behind her. Crita turned to find Karatti rising to his feet. The net that once bound him, sliced to ribbons on the floor.

He stood glowering into the darkness, his pale grey eyes scrutinizing the threats within. He was a green hide mutant, whose bald head was covered in a black hide cap. His armor was light, made of interlocking silver plates. Being a brawler style fighter, his arms were bare. High metal boots rose up his legs to mid thigh, but did not hinder his movements. Two dark metal rapiers were crossed over his back, which he was quick to unsheath.

Crita and her men had no time to react as an ear piercing bellow, thundered from the darkness. Before they could mount a defense, a eight foot warrior clothed in black and silver armor exploded from the gloom. Her red eyes gleaming with the thirst for battle. Her twin swords were raised, sweeping in a downward arc, pushing Crita, Hoove and Karatti backward into the corridor.

Crita jumped back, snapping her whip towards the warrior's chest. Threatening her with lethal retaliation if she continued to charge. Crita was in her battle armor, a dark crimson leather halter top with flared shoulder guards. Her stomach was bare, the tightly packed muscle accentuated by a wide gold belt. Tight matching leather pants, with knee length black boots and matching, long fingerless leather gloves.

She sneered up at the huge warrior now blocking the doorway. "You will not deny us our birthright."

Despara laughed, the snide, taunting cackle ricocheting off the narrow corridor.

"I already killed Omega Prime. There is nothing left for your kind here. I am feeling rather merciful." She shrugged. "I'll let you leave, but make sure your superiors know that if they send any more soldier's to Etheria. I'll stain the soil red with their blood."

Crita lowered her chin, growling in indignation. She had never been spoken to with such pompous disrespect. "I am the Queen of the Gleanon! Second in command of the Mutant Fleet. Your threats do not scare me!" She raised her arm and cut it downward sharply. "Kill them all!" She screamed, snapping her whip towards Despara's left wrist in a vain attempt to disarm her. Forcing Despara to evade the attack and move out of the doorway and into the corridor.

Hoove back stepped to the side, allowing the armed soldier's to rush forward. He wasn't a fighter by nature, even though he could hold his own if he needed to. His leg armor gave him a powerful kick that could kill and he was quite strong. Highly intelligent and resourceful, he would rather strategize and research tactics then engage in battle. He would let the grunts take on the Etherian's while he figured out a way to reclaim the Control Pillar. The contingent of soldiers, flooded, threw the open doors. Their rifles drawn and fired a stream of energy fire blindly into the darkness.

Glimmer blinked away to guard Entrapta. As Bow and Perfuma spread out to lay down cover fire and entangle the contingent of soldier’s now rushing towards them. As Catra and Melog shimmered invisible.

The two Laser Bears roared at the doorway, sending their arsenal of spines across the room. Entrapta screamed and ducked behind the pillar. As a spine struck the holographic platform. Hordak merely huffed in frustration, crossing his arms as his projection wavered and then faded away.

Despara was fully engaged with Crita further down the corridor and paid little heed to the battle now raging inside the Control room. The red haired villain was taunting her, drawing her further and further away. As she cracked her whip, keeping Despara’s strikes at bay. Then darted away, always staying just out of range. Despara’s anger was soon becoming unrestrained, as she figured out Crita was just toying with her. Leading her somewhere in which she would have more of an advantage.

Despara promised the woman was not going to get much further. She charged her at a full sprint, her long strides carrying her down the remainder of the corridor in record speed. Screaming her fury, as she adjusted her grip on the hilts of her swords, raising her blade's high. Intent on slicing the woman’s head from her body. Crita had barely any time to react as Despara closed in behind her. She spun on her heel and then back flipped into an intersection, her eyes wide in sudden fear. As Despara’s blades whistled mere inches away from her neck. Hacking off the good chunk of her long hair, that fluttered to the floor. As a casualty of her narrow escape.

Her crown had flown off, clattering down a side hall. Chest heaving from the exertion required to stay ahead of Despara. Some of her hair was now strewn across her face. She wasn’t laughing anymore, not even smiling. Sensing by how light the back of her head felt, that she was missing at least half of her hair. The wild uneven strands now fanned out over her shoulder. She glanced down at her hair in shock, tracking the scattered piles

upon the floor. Her warrior's instincts, screaming that that last strike could have been a death blow. He-Man never went for the kill, but it seemed this Master of the Universe wasn't burdened by such a heroic credo.

"Who are you?" Crita breathed, her palms were damp and she felt her grip on the curving metal handle of her whip was slipping. Barely holding back her fear, as she gasped for breath. She had been running hard, evading this warrior's strikes at every turn.

Despara merely grinned, her lips pulled back in a sinister snarl. Her red eyes danced with the thrill of battle lust. She was going to enjoy this fight for a little while longer, before returning to finish off this woman's forces. Eagerly relishing the carnage to come.

Perfuma and Bow had worked as a team, from the perimeter of the room. To ensnare Hoove and Karatti once again and a good portion of the soldier's. Now most of them were writhing in nets and roots upon the floor. Glimmer had teleported upon the heads of the two bears, blinding them with sparks. It had slowed them down but did not hinder them from firing their laser's. The bear's main weapon had ripped through the walls, leaving long gashes in the angled panels. Exposing delicate circuitry meshed underneath. Now the queen was standing firm in front of the control pillar, her staff outstretched before her. Glaring with unbridled determination behind a huge magical shield, as the two bears blasted away the walls of the control room. Several energy beams struck Glimmer's magical shield, which was still powerful enough to absorb them. But she cringed, groaning in pain as she forced more and more of her magic into the shield. Needing to constantly refortify the spell, she was in a battle of endurance now. Would the Bears run out of energy first or would she run out of magic? While Entrapta worked behind her, at the terminal. Her fingers flew over the buttons as she worked to deactivate the security system. There were more bears in route and they would be upon them in seconds. She needed to work fast!

Brojee was firing off energy bolts at the last of the soldier's who had scrambled to the back corner of the room. The blasts from the laser bears was more of a threat than anything else.

Catra and Melog were cloaked and making their way around, undetected. They slipped out of the open doorway and dashed down the corridor after Despara.

They needed to reign her in, before she killed people.

Rumble in the Ruins

Crita gasped for breath, pushing her rising panic aside as she darted her gaze to the adjacent corridors. That branched out from the intersection she was trapped in. Wondering if she stood a chance at survival if she merely turned and ran in another direction? But honestly she was done running...she didn't have the stamina to keep going. Her lungs were burning and the muscles in her legs were spasming from being pushed beyond their limits. There was no way to out run, out fight or out maneuver a Master of the Universe. She had fought He-Man enough times to learn that the only way to gain an advantage. Was to out smart them and that was never very difficult in regards to him.

"Who are you!" Crita demanded, taking several steps backward in a weak attempt to put distance between her and this merciless predator. That had relentlessly chased her down to the point of exhaustion. She was heaving for breath, white spots filling her vision. She had never been in such a desperate situation so quickly.

The eight foot warrior stalked into the open intersection. A triumphant gleam in her red eyes, knowing that her prey was trapped and exhausted. Her twin swords held low at her sides. The points of the blades directed towards the ground, glinting in the half light of the intersection. Her iridescent cape billowed up behind her, from the sheer power of her stride. Her expression was smug, an arrogance in her stride as she closed in. Her eyes were narrowed in a seething rage. She was barely holding onto the violent magic that wished to explode from her body.

"I am known as Despara." She growled, barely out of breath. An eager smile pulling upon her lips enjoying their little game of Cat and Mouse. As the echoing footfalls of huge paws vibrated down adjacent corridors. Drawing her attention away from Crita for a moment to engage the approaching threat.

Crita ‘s grin was slow and sly, knowing that finally she may have the upper hand. As two Laser Bears rounded the corner on either side of the intersection. Prowling forward towards them. She felt her salvation had come and she couldn't help laughing. The abrasive, triumphant sound bounced around the intersection. Ringing in Despara’s ears like the high pitched wail of a banshee.

Despara smirked with dark amusement, her eye’s cutting back and forth between the two bears who now blocked the side corridors. Snarling threateningly at both of them. While Crita had no fear, those beasts were collared and under her soldier’s control.

She trusted her men to hide out view, deep inside the corridor’s the bears had come from. They had their control rods directed at the beasts, prepared to command them to attack at any second. They were designated as handlers weeks ago, when her contingent had first begun to explore the temple and set off the security system. They had been collaring every bear created at the temple ever since. Sending some to scout the island, while others were sent back to the mothership. To be used as expendable weapons towards their conquest of the Galaxy.

“The arrogance of your race is truly astounding.” Despara chuckled, “The First Ones instilled in you a false sense of superiority over all others. Dutiful pets, bred for battle...who would charge in ahead of their own soldier’s. Thinking they were the fighting elite, when in reality they were just being used as living shields.”

“You think we were naive to that fact….we rebelled! We achieved our freedom, abandoned the First Ones and allowed them to fall at the feet of Horde Prime. Who showed them no mercy.” Crita spat back, snapping her whip. “We will never bow to anyone ever again. We’ve carved out our own Empire, in the absence of the First Ones. We are mighty now….Denebria will rule over the Tri-Solar System. Emperor Flogg will dominate Primus...then Eternia….then Etheria….the coming war will be glorious.”

“Kinda hard to dominate planets with your secret weapon, dead.” Despara grinned.

Crita laughed harshly. “We both know that Omega Prime is not killed that easily. I had it contained. It was in cryo- stasis until you and your companion’s intervened. Thawed it out! I believe it is still alive, hiding perhaps, burrowing itself deeper into the planet. Healing...soon to be feeding again, upon all of Etheria...now that it is free of its prison. It will slowly devour this planet just as it was programmed too…we merely have to wait.” Crita’s words held a grim honesty that made Despara’s blood run cold. Her theory was very valid. The Watch Tower didn’t pick up on the mutant Wrym’s life signs around Beast Island. Because perhaps it had burrowed itself even deeper into the core of the planet, where the sensor’s were not powerful enough to penetrate. They wouldn’t know if it had survived until it started feeding again...

A cold dread settled inside her as the disastrous implications of her failure slowly set in. Despara’s jaw clenched, grinding her teeth. The vessel had called to her, to help, to fix the current crisis that was beyond her ability to deal with. But she perhaps had made things far worse…

She was so much more powerful when in balance with Sheana...

“Entrapta!” Glimmer shreeked. As two more laser bears lumbered into the control room. Their feral heads hung low, teeth barred as they snarled threateningly. Their third eyes flaring to life as they charged their energy blasts.

Bow and Perfuma were flanking the Bears along the back walls, while Brojee kept to the shadows near the doorway. Moving as silently and as stealthy as he could. Seeking to move around the new threats undetected. He knew that those bears were being controlled by their collars. He wasn’t strong enough to take them on, but he could take out the soldier’s controlling them.

“I’m on it!” Entrapta screamed, back. Her finger’s flying over the controls.

[Perhaps I could help?] Hordak offered, his shimmering holographic form reappearing beside Entrapta.

“That would be wonderful!” Entrapta turned and gave him a grateful beaming smile.

Hordak merely nodded, his expression falling into deep retrospection as he communicated with the data banks of the beacon.

Bow let fly several net arrows at the two bears. As Perfuma raised her arms, calling up a mass of roots from beneath the floor. Which tore the metal floors and walls apart as they sprang from the ground below the First Ones structure. Sending massive chunks of soil and rock into the air. Shooting towards the bears at great speed. The bears reared up, slashing at the roots with their mighty claws. Ripping into them and shredding the first wave easily. But more roots exploded from the ground below and lunged from the massive cracks in the walls to replace them. Moving even faster than before. Wave upon wave of muddy tendrils attacked from all sides, as they sought to ensnare the beasts. Who were quickly overcome by the sheer numbers wrapping around their torso and pulling them to the ground. A thin sheen of sweat was gathering over Perfuma’s skin, trickling down her face from her temples. Her link to her elemental magic was much more powerful. It rushed through her like a raging river. Taking a lot more of her mental focus to control it, taxing both her mind and body far more than before. She grit her teeth and held on to that torrent of magic, wrapping up the bears in a cocoon of roots. Till only dark tufts of fur could be seen poking out between the cracks. The strangled whimpers of frightened animals issued from beneath the living cages. Perfuma panted heavily and bowed over her knees, sucking in deep breaths.

“Wow….your magic is like...super powered now!” Bow breathed in awe, as he slowly made his way back to Perfuma. The remains of

the thick metal walls and stone floors of the server room. Was broken, bent and twisted from her magical onslaught. Circuitry sparked and bloomed into flame amid the destroyed room. Only the pillar remained intact, illustrating how powerful her focus and control was over her powers. That she could manipulate thousands of objects all at once, with such precision.

Perfuma slowly raised her head, giving him a weak smile.

"It takes a lot more out of me now too." She answered softly.

With the threats dealt with. Glimmer released her magic shield, it faded as she swung her staff downward. Turning to Entrapta, with an entreating look, desperate for an update.

"Almost there…" Entrapta answered her questioning stare. Never taking her magenta eyes over the screen, as she monitored Hordak's progress into the Security programming.

[Security override, enabled. Protection protocols deactivated.] Hordak stated, a smug undertone thick in his digital voice.

There was a bright flash, that filtered out beneath cracks of the cocoon of roots. The roots themselves quickly caved in. As the beasts disappeared. Their genetic code, recalled back into the data banks.

As the roots fell onto the floor, with a heavy, wet thump. They saw Brojee standing proudly in the doorway. His energy pistols spinning in his fingers. With two mutant soldier's crumpled into a heap at his feet.

Bow was about to stride over and congratulate him, when Catra's frightened screams shattered the triumphant moment.

Brojee dashed away down the corridor as Glimmer blinked beside Bow and Perfuma.

Entrapta was stunned for a moment, then turned back to the monitor. She was no good in a fight, but she could help here.

Glimmer understood and merely nodded as Bow and Perfuma took her hands. She blinked away in a flash of sparkles to Catra’s location.

Crita knew her words had struck a nerve, a cold hard truth that this overzealous Master of the Universe could not deny. Her actions and those of her companion’s may have caused this planet even more harm. Unleashing a threat far more sinister and devastating. Than anything Horde Prime had wrought upon Etheria during his occupation. So she was easily taking advantage of the warrior's inner struggle. As Despara stood, silently contemplating the dire consequences. Distracted by her own guilt and sense of failure, she made no moves to continue the fight. Glaring at the floor, gripping the hilts of her swords tightly, as if she was strangling them. Crita had regained her advantage in this fight, but she was no fool. So she made a quick retreat. Turning on her heel and dashing off down the corridor behind her. Leaving her men and their beasts to deal with this Despara.

As Crita turned, the two bears charged at Despara. Their sharp maws roared in threat, powerful claws lunging towards the warrior, intent of ripping her apart. Despara snapped her head up, suddenly very aware and engaged with her surroundings again. She growled just as menacingly, adjusted her stance, swords crossed over her chest, as her eyes flared with power. She dodged to the side, avoiding the bear’s deadly swipe. Then ducked low, dashing for it’s chest. Her footwork was smooth and quick. Avoiding its attacks, getting in close. As she slashed across the Beast's neck, with one blade. Her precision with the sword flawless as she cut deep into its neck, severing its main artery. The bear grunted then crumpled to the floor, a pool of blood forming under its great bulk. The second bear howled, as it’s partner was so mercilessly cut down. Bowing its head as it sent a charge of energy straight at Despara. She spun swiftly on her heels, leaping to the side of the blast. The battle lust burning in her piercing glare, as she lunged into a full sprint towards the

beast. As the energy bolt tore threw the floor inches away from her. Metal screamed as it was ripped upward, razor sharp shrapnel exploded from the floor. Raining down upon Despara, who moved through the maelstrom in a flurry of sword strikes. Knocking the debris aside, as it ricocheted off her blades with sharp, clipped ringing sounds. The larger pieces embed themselves into the walls at the mouths of the four corridors. As Despara rushed at the last bear, far too fast for it to defend itself. Cutting it down as easily as the first. By slicing through its thick neck in one fluid strike of a blade.

The soldier's began to fire at her, from further down the corridors. Boxing her in the center of the intersection, as the bolts of energy rebounded around her. She deflected any bolts that got to close, snarling at her new opponents. As she watched helplessly as Crita faded away into the gloom, further down the forward hall. The energy fire dissipated, leaving scorch marks on the floor and walls. The soldier's had stopped firing for now. Their clips were spent or they were retreating, so they could reassess. Find a better strategy and come at her again from another corridor.

"Melog, go get her." Catra commanded, her voice echoing from somewhere nearby.

Despara glanced around, trying to track her voice. As the hybrid shimmered into view right in front of her. As her magical cat, bounded down the forward hall after Crita. The creature was glowing red, it's tail and mane sparking with rage.

"Nice of you to show up." Despara smirked.

"Killed anyone else, yet?" Catra snipped back, raising her hands, claws extended.

Despara ignored the jab, narrowing her eyes, as she briefly scanned the corridors. Scrutinizing the soldier's possible positions and calculating their tactics.

“Only the Security Beasts, in self defense.” Despara sighed with disappointment. “The soldier’s controlling them have retreated.”

“You think they just left?” Catra huffed, her tone doubtful. As she glanced upward at Despara.

“I doubt it, they are either circling around to gain a better shooting advantage or waiting for backup.” Despara answered.

“Then let's get the hell out of here.” Catra nodded, darting for the forward corridor.

“Wait!” Despara shouted in alarm, but it was too late.

Just as Catra cleared the threshold of the corridor an energy blast exploded within. A Laser Bear had just lumbered out of the gloom further down the corridor, blocking the hybrids path. It had let loose the full charge of its stored up energy point blank, right at Catra. Before promptly shimmering away.

Catra screamed in fright as her entire body was bathed in the intense heat of the blast. Her instincts and feline reaction speed, saved her life. She ignited her hands, sending a counter blast of incinerating fire towards the laser beam. The two energy charges collided, resulting in a devastating explosion. The concussive force of the backdraft, sending Catra into the air and propelling her backward. Like she had just been shot out of cannon. Screaming in agony as the inferno washed over her, scotching the fine layer of her fur. The deafening boom of clashing energy and rending metal exploded through her head. Making her ears ring and eyes blurred as she fought to remain conscious. She squeezed her eyes shut, preparing for the pain of sudden impact. When her body would inevitably hit a wall or the floor. What she didn’t expect was the sudden feeling of strong arms, wrapping around her middle. Swinging her bridal style and holding her firmly against the cool armor of Despara’s ample chest.

“Your battle tactics are in serious need of tweeking.” Despara grunted, as she caught Catra mid air. Adjusting her smaller body

to a more manageable position as her boots struck the floor.

Catra gasped, her arms encircling Despara's neck in desperation to ground herself. As she struggled to conceal her blush and maintain a stoic expression. Getting worked up over such an incredible save, felt like she was cheating on Adora. But Despara was Adora...just like She-Ra was Adora...the whole thing was so complicated. It made Catra flustered and angry.

"Put me down!" She shouted, punching Despara in the collar bone for emphasis.

Despara merely grunted in response, promptly dumping her onto the ground.

Catra squeaked and landed hard on her butt.

Just as Bow, Perfuma and Glimmer blinked into existence a few meter's off.

Brojee jogged into the intersection a moment later, panting and out of breath.

"Are you alright?" He gasped, heaving for air as he bowed over his knees.

"Yes." Catra grumbled indignantly as she climbed back to her feet.

Despara paid them no mind, striding off down the forward corridor after her prey.

They all paid each other a meaningful glance before chasing after her.

"The Security system is offline, so it should be clear sailing from here on." Glimmer stated.

"We still have well armed mutant soldier's wandering around here." Catra responded.

“They’ll be easy, like taking down Horde Soldier’s! I could do that in my sleep.” Glimmer bantered back, her hands crackling menacingly with her magic.

“Good times...good times..” Bow responded nervously from behind them. As Catra paid Glimmer a scathing look.

Glimmer merely chuckled, striding confidently ahead of them. Ready to take on whatever threat lay ahead.

Melog had chased after the mutant’s leader. But she was far more cunning and wily than they had anticipated. She knew the buildings lay out and was able to evade them, by using hidden doors or maybe the vents? Either way, Melog had returned to Catra’s side a few minutes later. Growling in frustration and reporting that they had lost her. Catra inquired about Despara, but Melog hadn’t seen her either. Catra was concerned, but quickly dismissed it. Whatever Despara was up to, she didn’t need Catra getting in the way again. She honestly couldn’t handle being around her anyway, her emotions were erratic and jumping all over the place. She needed a little time to calm down and prepared herself to confront that dark goddess rationally. Or she would just end up crying, screaming and demanding things she had no way to enforce. Despara needed to see reason, she had to give Adora back….

The sun had long since set before they finished clearing out the Beacon. Most of the mutants had retreated, when their leader had disappeared. To where, they had no idea. But there was no sign of them or transport craft anywhere in the jungle surrounding the ruins. So Glimmer now led a handful of captured soldiers out onto the rocky beach, their hands bound behind their backs with Perfuma's vines. The greater moons hung heavily in the dark sky above, their smaller satellites scattered amid the blanket of twinkling stars.

The two guards from the Control room, Karatti and Hoove shuffled despondently at the back of the line. Their shoulders slumped in defeat, hands bound tight behind them.

“What are you going to do to us?” Hoove inquired in a small voice.

"You're going to be interrogated about your intentions with Beast Island.” Glimmer shot back. “Then you’ll be held in the Fright Zone prison. Perhaps you can get me into contact with your leader and we can negotiate terms. ”

"You, mean the Scorpania Prison." Bow interjected, with a smile.

"Right, right..." Glimmer rolled her eyes and sighed. It was going to take some time to refer to Scorpia's kingdom that naturally, when she had been calling it the Fright Zone for most of her life.

“Crita will never negotiate.” Karatti mumbled. “We will rot in your prison till we die.”

Bow’s eyes widened in shock, having a difficult time wrapping his head around how cruel and apathetic their leader was. Skeletor had ordered Jitsu to be killed. While it seemed Crita was going to just abandon her soldiers. Neither cared about their people at all, treated them like they were tools. To be discarded when not of any use.

Catra, he noticed. Wasn’t surprised at all by their bleak outlook. Her expression was one of grim acceptance.

“Was that the mentality of the Horde?” Bow turned to regard her. Desperately trying to keep a stoic expression, even though his eyes were tearing up. He felt sorry for these mutants, for Jitsu. They were discarded like they never mattered.

“Yes.” Catra stated back in a clipped tone. “Your worth in the Horde depended upon how useful you were. We were raised to win battles at all costs. In the Horde only the strong survive, the weak are considered a burden and are quickly dealt with.”

Bow was appalled, but it put it into perspective. Adora's obsession about being useful. Her grueling work ethic and need to set such unrealistic goals and succeed at all costs. To the detriment of her health and her happiness.

"How were the weak dealt with?" Bow whispered, suddenly very scared about the answer.

Catra growled and refused to look at him, keeping her eyes forward. As bleak memories of Tama, of her fallen squad mates overwhelmed her.

"Soldier's who failed Hordak were punished brutally and publicly in the Horde. If you no longer had worth you would be sent here, or sent out onto the frontlines to die. If the children were weak they just didn't survive...they died during training."

"Oh…." Bow groaned. A grim clarity about how cruel Adora and Catra's upbringing had been making his blood run cold. He wanted desperately to turn and wrap Catra up in a hug and tell her how much he cared about her. But the dark scowl she sent him made him rethink his affection. He cleared his throat and dropped his arms, nodding to her in understanding. That she was feeling rather emotionally raw right now and unwanted touch was only going to piss her off. A low, frustrated growl rumbled from deep in her chest and she merely veered off. Storming away down the rocky beach with Melog in tow. The alien cat had turned a dark black, with a dull grey mane and tail, which was smoldering like smoke. Glimmer opened her mouth to say something, as Catra walked off. But Bow placed a restraining hand on her shoulder and shook his head. That was a color neither of them had ever seen Melog take. It sent up warning flares in each of them.

"She needs some time." Bow spoke softly.

Glimmer nodded, understanding how messed up today had turned out for all of them.

She would give Catra time to cool down, but if she didn't return to Darla before the next sunrise, she would go find her. She was determined that she would try and comfort her in Adora's absence. Be there for her in the ways she needed, she knew she was no proper replacement for the blonde. But she felt she was better than nothing.

Despara had returned to the bowels of the island, intent on finishing off Omega Prime. If it managed to survive her devastating attack earlier. Finding the flesh sack it had been imprisoned in, shredded and empty. The pit flooded with sea water from it's hasty retreat into the open sea. She scrubbed a hand violently, threw her short blonde hair, this was bad….real bad…

Spinning on her heel with a frustrated bellow of rage, she stormed back down the tunnel. Wherever Omega Prime had escaped to, she was incapable of following. She would need to revise her strategy and speak to that Tech Master...Entrapta. She needed her to build a portable tracker and then she could find the creature and finish it off.

Hours later, Despara slowly made her way out of the Beacon. Entrapta had been set on task and would let her know when the item she requested had been built. With all but one Watch Tower left she had no choice but to wander Etheria until she found a trace of Omega Prime or it started feeding and led her straight to it. A cool breeze rushed past her, as she emerged from the building. Tossing her hair wildly across her face as she craned her head upward to survey the stars. Their positions had shifted since the last time she had seen them, illustrating how much time had past. She had not been summoned solely into a vessel since the First Ones bound her essence into that cursed disc. Hoping to create another portable runestone weapon. As they had with Sheana, with the Sword of Protection. Finding quickly that her magic could not be tamed as easily. Their chosen vessel had been quickly overwhelmed and corrupted by her power. Causing her to

go berserk and kill everyone in the lab. Despara's destructive powers had surged out of control, vaporizing the lab and the vessel along with it. The First Ones were forced to hide her disc deep inside the star seed mines of Dryll. It was by luck and chance that the current princess of Dryll had found her hiding place. Releasing her magic upon the Sword, allowing her for the first time over a thousand years to reconnect with her other half. It had been like touching her between a thin layer of glass, they were together but still very much separated by their bonds to their First Ones relics.

Sheana to the Sword of Protection.

Despara to the Disc of Destruction.

Sheana had quickly absorbed her power and held the majority of her rage in check. Protecting the chosen vessel, so that Adora had only been corrupted, as she held the sword. Thankfully, Sheana's healing had protected her mind and body from being destroyed by Despara's unrestrained power. When the disc had first been destroyed some of her essence was able to escape, but that tech master had mended the disc leaving her magic fractured for months. Until she had been released fully in the Northern Reach, thanks to that Scorpioni.

She was left to wander the universe for years, confused and angry. As her other half, Sheana was still shackled to her relic and could not temper her darkness with her light. So Despara was adrift. Lonely and seething for vengeance. In time she could feel Sheana had escaped her chains as well. Yet, she was not lost to the currents of time and space as Despara was. Having been bound to this Adora for the last two years, her essence was still anchored to the vessel. She was able to lead Adora through her dreams. Guide her somewhat towards summoning She-Ra. So Despara had waited for the vessel to call out to her, to draw her from the void and welcome her power along with Sheana's into her soul. To finally reunite them within the weave of her own magic. The exhilaration and joy she had felt when Adora had drawn her power and Sheana's out of the void. Was beyond

measure, that first desperate transformation in the Crystal Cave had felt like a rebirth. As her emotions of loyalty and rage bonded them together for the first time in a thousand years.

The second time had been driven by fear and intense devotion. Unleashing a wave of universal power Prime could not comprehend, least of all counter with his meager tech. She was getting better at summoning their power, than doubt and guilt clouded her connection. After the last battle with that same Scorpioni, in the place that resurrected so much pain for their vessel. The confusion and loathing the magically tainted Sorceress, created inside Adora, did not help matters, either. The Crystal Castle sought to balance the vessel. By showing Adora the truth she denied, through her vision's of Catra. Forcing her to confront that fact that she loved her, had for a very long time. Shattering her heart all over again, knowing that she could never have what she truly wanted. That she had driven Catra away yet again, by bowing to Shadow Weaver's wishes. Becoming once again the dutiful soldier, who took on the burden of saving the world. Accepted that her life might be sacrificed in the name of the greater good. Then again, the Crystal Castle reached out. Offering Adora guidance and much needed affirmation from Mara. The one person she respected most. Who confessed to her that she did not want to die, the cost was to great. That she had sacrificed herself so that Adora did not have to. That she was allowed to want, that Adora deserved love too. That being She-Ra did not shackle her to same fate. Thankfully in the end, she finally found her way back to balance.

The third time had been the most pure connection they had ever felt to the vessel. Drawn into Adora's soul, with the intensity of her emotions. Of love, hope, and the yearning to survive, to protect and to vanquish the darkness for good. Allowing herself to want, giving into her heart desires for the first time. Confessing her love and solidifying her desire in that fateful kiss. Silently professing to Catra that she needed her, wanted her and could not see her life with out her in it.

Since the repercussions of the Fail Safe. The vessel had been unfocused, her intentions fractured. Her emotions churned in turbulent currents of past hurts, resentments and unresolved rage. Resulting in an imbalanced summoning, calling only the darkness into her soul. Thus Despara had manifested.

Despara wandered out of the jungle and onto the beach, lost in her thoughts. A squat, old crone stood upon the moonlit sand a few yards away. Wearing an old, thread bare pink dress and shawl, gripping the long wooden handle of a broom. Her long, wild grey hair snapped in the stiff breeze howling off the dark ocean beyond. There was a storm brewing out there, it had been threatening on the horizon this morning. But it had never come inland, the dark clouds hovering just beyond the island. Her ancient gaze was averted to the curling waves, rolling in. She never turned to greet Despara, patiently waiting for the dark Goddess to approach her instead.

Despara sighed heavily as she stood beside the ancient Immortal. Shuffling the toes of her boots into the sand, like a freshly chastised child. Who was drowning in the guilt and remorse of her mistakes. Refusing to acknowledge the old woman first. But when Razz never broke her stern gaze from the frothing tide, washing up on the beach. Despara was the first to break.

“Razz.” Despara paid the wizened woman a small nod.

“You were told to be patient.” Razz snapped, refusing to look up at her. Her owlish stare focused on a piece of flotsam, now spinning in the foam.

“Adora summoned me! Old crone!” Despara snarled back, crossing her arms over her chest like an impertinent child. “I could not deny her anymore then you could resist the Flow of Time.”

Razz merely nodded. Her forehead wrinkled heavily with anxiety, as her frown deepened. Slowly coming to some unspoken conclusion.

“She must be taught how to weave the threads properly.” Razz nodded again, scratching an itch upon the tip of her nose.

“Who would teach her?” Despara huffed. “Light Hope was the last...to hold the secrets of She-Ra and she is gone.”

“Perhaps, the Crystal Castle still retains the…” Razz started, but was quickly cut off by Despara’s angry cry.

“We are in this mess, because of the First Ones meddling! This vessel will not be taught by a Horde Clone, turned hologram! He would feed her a corrupted, twisted version of the truth. ” Despara shouted. Her voice booming over the quiet beach.

Razz released a held breath, seeking to remain calm in the presence of such overwhelming feelings of rage and fear.

“We are beginning again….then?” Razz stated pointedly. She passed the tip of her broom stick from one hand to the other, in quiet contemplation.

“As it was in the beginning, so shall it be...again.” Despara responded, her words slow and steady. She was committing to a plan of action so drastic, that if it failed it could bring about the destruction of the known universe.

“Addie, shall train her...with the Woods' permission. Of course.” Despara continued, nodding resolutely. “We shall weaken the veil and allow her passage into the Eternal Realm.”

Razz grunted, her sister whose body was lost in the Cross Roads of Worlds. Had finally found the courage to take on her duty as the Guardian of the Eternal Realm. Currently she has been invading the dreams of both Kaira and Adora for the last few weeks. She wished to help, to heal and show them the truths long denied to them. She had good intentions, but when the veil was weakened there was no doubt. Sheana and Despara would uncover her meddling. If they would approve or not was up to time.

Razz was not going to mention it, that was a knot to be unwoven later.

“Very well then, I shall fight the pull of time for as long as I can, to teach her how to weave the magic. How to balance the weft and the warp, so she can strengthen the knots. Then and only then will you and Sheana be able to bind firmly into her tapestry.” Razz turned and patted Despara’s upper arm. “It will be alright, dearie. Trust in ol’ Razz.” The old woman offered Despara a reassuring smile.

The warrior looked pale, her eyes were dull, unfocused. She was struggling, but too stubborn and proud to show how scared she truly was. Standing stiffly beside the old woman, staring at the distant storm.

“But... is it not dangerous for you to stay inside a mortal body for so long? You could harm her...” Razz mused, tapping her chin, as she slowly trailed her gaze up and down Despara’s well armored frame. Her wild white brows rising up in confusion. Her forehead now is even more deeply wrinkled. Mulling over the knots, she perceived in the threads binding Despara to Adora’s fragile body.

“I know…” Despara sighed, her voice sounded tired.

Then she crumpled to her knees before Razz, giving into this body's exhaustion. The red glow in her eye’s dimmed slightly as she sought to retreat from the vessel. Blocked by Adora’s desperation and held firm by the intensity of her will power. She was unable to unravel her magic from the young woman’s body. Trapped inside the vessel, growing more agitated and frightened, as she felt her magic slowly damaging Adora’s mind. Despara searched the old woman’s face for answers. Her expression was vulnerable, pleading for her aid.

“She will not let go of me….” Despara whispered brokenly. She did not want to kill the vessel. She had grown rather fond of this Adora. A brave, kind hearted soul who had proven time and again.

That she held an iron will and an unwavering determination to rewrite the stars if needed.

Razz's smile was soft and full of sympathy. "Poor dear….she is hurting so much...right now."

Despara nodded solemnly, her stoic facade cracking as a solitary tear rolled down her cheek.
"Just this once, I will defy my oaf." Razz dug her hand deep into the side pocket of her dress, pulling out a handful of sparkling silver dust. Despara bowed her head in supplication, as Razz sprinkled the dust on top of her head.

"Razzle...Dazzle." Razz incanted, as the dust settled on Despara's head a flash of silver light flared. When the light faded, Adora lay sprawled on the sand at Razz's feet. Her skin was pale, a sickly grey pallor. Her chest was rising gently. Her expression was placid, eyes moving rapidly beneath her eyelids, lost to a deep sleep.

Razz merely grunted in approval, turning on her heel as she walked away. The air shimmered and rippled as if disrupted by an unseen force. As Razz merely faded away out of existence.

Catra found herself once more atop the cliff, she had retreated to that morning to sing her aubade. Standing just before the edge, her shoulders were hunched, arms folded tightly around her chest. Mismatched eyes staring forlorn down at the churning ocean slamming against the rocks on the crags below. A cold breeze had picked up as the Greater Moons ascended into the night sky. Tossing her short, dark brunette mane violently every time a gust rose up from the sea. Catra was comforted by the howl of the wind, it suited her dark mood. A storm was hovering on the horizon, blocking the faint light of the lower star's in a blanket of solid darkness. Flashes of light and far off rumbling, echoed inland. Melog chirped beside her, drawing her attention away from the dark ocean. Their body was the deepest black, their mane and tail a thick mist of smoke. Their eyes had turned a

ghostly glowing white. She was unnerved by their change at first. But understood that they were not dangerous, that the ominous state they resembled. Was just a visual representation of the turmoil she was in. She followed their gaze out along the rocky coastline they had been exploring this morning. Finding a familiar, prone body laying out on the sand, a maroon cloak fluttering the wind.

"Adora!" Catra cried in alarm, lunging forward on all fours. Racing down to the beach as quickly as she could. Practically leaping off the side of the cliff in her haste, as she scrambled down the sheer rock face that butted against the beach.

Her hands and feet dug deep into the soft sand, tossing up fine pebbles as she dashed across the beach. Melog remained sitting atop the cliff, ever vigilant to their surroundings. Their body began to lighten into a somber blue hue, their mane and tail becoming an ethereal mist once more. Their warm blue gaze scanned the jungle briefly, then turned to the rising storm forming out upon the ocean and finally their master. Who was now cradling her mate's head in her lap, rocking and crying softly. Feeling secure enough in the solitude, releasing all the fear and guilt she had been holding inside all day.

Addie

Once again, Adora found herself within the dark green embrace of the Northern Forest of Bright Moon. She had no destination in mind, merely journeying through the ancient trees. Basking in the timeless serenity that surrounded her. That seemed more lush and vibrant than before, as if she had changed seasons since the last time she wandered here. The leaves were fresh, unfurling from their branches eagerly towards the bright morning sunshine. The sky was a warm blue with barely a cloud to be seen. The thickets she had passed through, were fresh with blossoming flowers. The buds that blanketed the ground, in pastel hues. The stem's rising prominently out of the grass, petals fully extended and still glistening with dew.

This was the very beginning of the warm season, the days of rebirth when life returned to the forest. The leaves were fresh and shimmering with moisture as if a rain had just ended. The air was damp but softly fragrant with the various flowers in full bloom around her. The light and life that surrounded her, seeped into her very soul. Making her blue eyes shine with wonder and a sense of awe at the delicate beauty of the ancient forest. Adora took a long, deep breath. Relishing in the purity of the renewal she was surrounded in. She had never felt more content or at peace.

She traveled for several days, enjoying the gentle majesty of the northern forests. Camping under the stars at night. Spending those serene hours stargazing and listening to the nocturnal song of the animals hidden just out of sight. She never seemed to tire or grow sleepy. Falling into a quiet contentment…

In time her absent wanderings led her to a large clearing. It resembled a well tended garden more than the wilderness she had walked through previously. The fruit trees and berry bushes were well maintained and sparsely spaced. There was no ornamentation like benches or fountains like in Bright Moon Castle. Tall grasses and wildflowers abound, giving it the feel of a

naturally occurring grove. But the well manicured path of flag stones that led threw the trees. The perfectly chosen colors of the flowers and the lack of dead undergrowth beneath the bushes. Spoke of guiding hands and care taken to ensure the grove remained healthy. Once deep inside the orchard, Adora could feel the air thicken with a timeless magic. Moots of glowing lights floated amid the trees. She had seen these orbs before, just after releasing the magic of Etheria. This place was old, set apart from the rest of the planet just like the center of the Whispering Woods, where Raz lived. Adora glanced off the neatly trimmed path, watching the magic orbs float aimlessly on the breeze. Dancing amid the flowers like bumble bees, before catching the wind and soaring high up into the branches of an apple tree. Disappearing into the warm, blue sky. The tranquility of this place was mystical, this was a place of power. Adora could sense it as clearly as she could smell a freshly prepared meal.

The bright ringing sound of children's laughter floated up from just beyond the trees a little further ahead. Curious, Adora moved off the path. Navigating through the apple orchard for a time. Coming to an open glade, she could see a small group of children gathered around an older woman. Some were human, others' were hybrids. Their assortment of clothes were strange? Some wore clothing styles she recognized. Other's wore clothing she had only seen on ancient recordings from the time of the First Ones. Thaymorian's in their colorful poncho's and knee length pants. Human children in overalls and heavy capes of farmers and shepherds. Tall, Tauran hybrids, with curving horns in dark pants with billowing long sleeve shirts. A few of the girls wore brightly colored dresses with white aprons or clothing similar to the boys. Some Moth Hybrids were in leggings and flowing shirts, buckled with wide leather belts. All of them had wooden swords and were eagerly trying to gain the attention of a lone adult in their midst.

She was a Tauran hybrid. Quite tall, with a toned, heavily muscled body. Her shoulders were broad, with thick arms as powerful as Huntara's. She had a kind, round face. Adora couldn't see the more subtle features of her face clearly, as the group was still too far away. Her fur was a pale tan. The rosy tint upon her cheeks

and sparkle in her soft blue eyes, spoke of a joyful sort of kindness that set Adora at ease. With long silver blonde hair, that shimmered with a very subtle blue tint. Her thick horns twist out from her temple and wove seamlessly into her thick braid. That was plaited high upon the back of her head. The thick tail of her braid hangs low near the base of her back. She wore no armor, but was clothed in heavy grey woolen pants, knee high leather greaves adorned her shins. Her hooved feet bare upon the trimmed grass. With a simple white sleeveless tunic that was accented in gold trim. Her tail swayed behind her playfully, the pale silver tuft fluttering in the wind.

The children were laughing and dueling against each other. As the Tauran woman patiently adjusted the grip of the youngest child's hand upon his practice sword.

"There now you will not get disarmed so easily." She chuckled, her voice was deep and rich.

"Addie...Addie!" The youngest child pulled on the hem of the woman's simple white tunic. Stopping her from moving away to check on the rest of her students.

Addie merely laughed and turned back, crouching before the child with a gentle smile.

Showing them once again how and where to grip the hilt of his wooden sword.

As suddenly as the sweet vision appeared it shimmered away, as if it was merely a trick of the light. Replaced by another lush glade, even deeper in the woods.

A look of wonder spread slowly over Adora's face, as once again she followed the stone path , flanked by the vibrant apple trees. Their branches are so heavy with leaves and fruit, they blocked her sight beyond them on either side. Leading her silently into a hidden meadow of wild flowers. Adora quickly took stock as to where she was, the magic moots of light still float lazily upon the

wind. Which meant she was still within the hidden domain of the forest. A sparkling creek cut through the glade, so she took a moment to rest, sitting on a dusty, granite boulder near the water's edge. Admiring how clear and radiant the water looked, she could see right to the bottom. The river bed was covered in small sparkling stones, with schools of fish hiding within the weeds near the shore. The river was guarded by the same heavy green fir's and oak trees she had seen in her last vision. Further down near the bend, she could make out the thick curtain of green branches of a weeping willow tree. The same kind of tree, she had seen Sheana and Despara leaning against on the other side of the river. In her last dream…

So she must be back in the same area of forest in the far North of Bright Moon. This place held meaning to them.

Adora had never felt really hungry or tired, since coming to this place between worlds. So in time after she tired of admiring the graceful beauty of the creek. She merely stood up and continued her exploration of the meadow. In time she came to descend into a valley, crossing through the fields of wild wheat and rolling hills of thick grass. To the hollow of a hillside that was tucked away out of sight amid a grove of spruce and lilac trees. There nestled in the sheltering curve of the hill, was a cottage. Made from the material of the forest, it blended into the scenery as if it was never truly there. The majority of the cottage was dug into the steepest part of the hill. The back half of the roof was grassy turf from the hill itself. The front of the house jutted out of the hill, domed and clad in clay tiles. The framework of the cottage was built from natural timber from the forest, which meant the beams were not always perfectly straight. The outer walls are a mixture of clay and field stones. Simple box windows adorned either side of the heavy oak door. The windows had thick wooden slate shutters to keep out the elements. The door was ornately carved with ancient runes that twisted and intersected into very intricate knots. A stone chimney rose out from the top of the grassy turf, of

the domed roof. It reminded Adora of Razz's hut, but far more rustic and sturdy.

As Adora approached the cottage a warm, welcoming feeling overcame her. She opened the heavy door and entered into a dimly lit front foyer. This place felt familiar as if she had lived here once a very long time ago. It was a strange surreal kind of deja vu. She instantly felt at ease and at home. There was a set of metal hooks embedded into the wall just before the door with a wooden bench below. An ornate teardrop shaped chandelier hung from the domed roof. Glowing softly, charged by a magic crystal similar to the lamps she knew hung throughout Bright Moon Castle. A rounded archway framed in polished maple wood, stood further into the foyer to the left than another matching archway stood on the right. With another archway ahead which led into a curving hall, proceeding onward out of view.

The walls inside were plastered with smooth clay and painted in warm, earth toned colors. Adora closed the door behind her and proceeded down the foyer to the archways. She glanced into the right archway, finding a simple workbench with carving tools scattered on top. Stacks of drift wood and thick logs were stacked beside the bench. With rustic wooden shelves hovering over the collection of wood. Lined with dented, rusted out buckets and glass jars filled with strange tinted liquids. With a shrug, Adora turned and entered the left archway. Brushing her fingertips along the smooth, polished frame of the arch. Filled with a peaceful nostalgia, she moved into a cozy living space.

That held a large stone fireplace against the back wall. A small pot hung from a hook inside the firebox, which was currently cold. Fresh, dry logs had been set in the iron cradle but not lit. With two simple willow rocking chairs, with plush cushions tied to the seats. Were sitting in front of the fireplace with a small, polished end table. The top was built from a tree stump, with three legs set in a triangle design underneath. That were ornate carved orbs that decreased in size as they ascended to the underside of the table. The simple table sat between the chairs, with an elegantly curved stone pipe sitting on top. With a small tin set beside it.

The large box window sat in the front of the living room with a wide viewing bench built inside. It was covered in a long, pale blue cotton cushion with several more throw pillows of various shapes and sizes scattered on top. The walls held very little in the way of decoration, mostly bare except for the odd shelf here and there. That held tiny sculptures of animals carved out of pieces of driftwood. Modest stacks of books and rolled up maps, tucked away safely in leather rolls. A finely carved wooden desk sat against the wall on the side of the bench, with quill and ink and a scattered assortment of paper atop the working area. With a straight back, wooden chair tucked in.

Laughter echoed from the room just beyond, drawing Adora threw another archway into a modest sized kitchen. There was a row of deep mahogany cupboards set against the side wall, with white marble countertops. A large metal basin was dropped inside the back counter. A modest marble island was set in front of the cupboards. With a pantry nook tucked at the end of the cupboards. The pantry was shielded from the kitchen by a simple pearl beaded curtain. The stone fireplace seemed to be the central pillar of this place. As she could see another side of it against the front, side wall of the kitchen. Iron doors were shuttered, sealing the firebox away. The plaster walls were bare except for a single group portrait hung on the back wall. She didn't recognize anyone in the image, except the silver blonde Tauran. That she had seen teaching the children swordplay. She stood in the center, much younger and full of life. Her cheeks were rosy and a playful gleam was bright in her soft blue eyes. The group of young men and women, all hybrids, surrounded her. Were all smiling brightly as well. All dressed in various types of leather or plate armor, holding weapons of all kinds. They must have just achieved a great victory. Numerous ancient banner's flew just behind them, streaming in the wind.

At the rear of the kitchen, set just in front of the portrait was a solidly built, round oak table with four hard backed wooden chairs. Adora gasped, at the two women currently sitting at the table, staring back at her expectantly. The woman on the right was her past transformation into She-Ra. She wore a version of

her face that was years younger, her glowing blue eyes were breathtaking. No winged crown adorned her forehead, her flowing golden hair curtained her shoulders. Dressed in the full gold armor she had summoned during the Battle of Bright Moon. She had a calm, serene quality to her that was spell binding.

The woman on the left was Despara, her most recent transformation. She also had a version of her face, more mature and hardened from years of war. The expression she wore was bland, her glowing amber eyes predatory, behind the black paint that accented them. Her short, lighter blonde hair looked plain, spartan compared to the vibrant flowing waves of Sheana on the right. Her armor was dark, the silver accents were sharp, violent. Her countenance was heavy, a calculating air of scrutiny and judgement hung in the air. Leaving Adora uneasy and nervous. Each of them had an aura glowing around them, one of gold the other of deep indigo.

'Come...sit. We have much to discuss." Despara waved an arm towards the empty chair that sat at the back in the middle between them. She had a similar voice to Adora's, but deeper and more raspy.

Adora swallowed hard then with a resolute nod, she walked swiftly to the chair and sat down. Glancing awkwardly over to the woman with the long golden hair, that she had been jealous of for years. Finding her smiling serenely at her, her hands clasped upon the table. Adora glanced up over her head finding She-ra's shield, the large white and gold one she summoned at the Heart mounted on the wall behind her. The blue runestone gleamed in the warm light of the kitchen.

With a steadying breath Adora tore her gaze away from the shield to confront Despara.

Who was currently scowling at her, tapping her index finger upon the table in either irritation or impatience. Above her on the wall behind was She-Ra's sword, the slender long sword she conjured

for the first time aboard the Velvet Glove. But the hilt was silver, the stone embedded upon the cross piece was a deep maroon.

"Where am I?" Adora inquired softly, glancing curiously at the archway behind Despara that led into the back hall she had yet to explore.

"This is Addie's cottage." Sheana answered. Her voice was a sweeter, more gentle version of Adora's.

"Who is Addie?" Adora turned to Sheana.

"The first She-Ra." Despara responded. Adora turned to her, shocked and in awe at how similar Despara sounded to her. Her voice was deeper in cadence, but unmistakably her voice.

It was like speaking to two different versions of herself. The mixture of confusion and comfort at this strange conversation was overwhelming.

"She was the first mortal to bond with our magic." Sheana added.

"How…" Adora started, but Sheana paid her a serene, patient smile.

As Despara scoffed, making a disgusted grunt at how utterly asinine that comment was.

"Seriously!" Despara snapped, "The same way you summon us into your body."

Adora laughed nervously, bowing her head in embarrassment. Her understanding of how she managed to summon them was tentative at best. She never truly felt in control, or confident when she called upon that magic. Every time she had managed to transform into She-Ra, it had been because of dire circumstances and a deep, heartfelt wish to fix things.

"That's just it...I've tried to figure out how. I do it. But I really don't understand how it works. All the times I've managed to

summon you properly...Me or the ones I love have been in great peril." She shrugged. "Without the Sword of Protection...I've never actually summoned She-Ra on purpose…"

Sheana sighed and reached out and patted her hand comfortingly.

"Light Hope kept far too many secrets." She concluded sympathetically. Casting Despara a scathing glare for her lack of empathy.

"She just taught me how to fight, how to manipulate the magic in the Sword of Protection. She told me nothing about what or who She-Ra was beyond Mara's tenure as Etheria's hero….not where I came from... or how this magic works...what its purpose is…" Adora began to rattle off her long list of unanswered questions, her voice rising in panic. "I've been stumbling around, trying to figure it all out with barely any information. I am sick of being scared of my magic, I'm tired of not knowing how to use it properly or summon it correctly. I don't want to always be grasping for it desperately when I'm in a tight spot. I want to learn all I can about it, I want to master this magic so I can be useful! I want to be strong, in control and ...and...and...I want to feel safe...again." Her rant ended abruptly, as her voice warbled into silence. Tears flowing down her cheeks, as she angrily brushed them away with *her finger tips.*

Sheana rose from the table and retreated to the cupboards, leaving Despara to awkwardly comfort Adora as she cried softly. The dark goddess sighed and patted the young woman's back, casting Sheana pleading glances to return quickly. As she had no idea how to deal with their vessel in this state of utter misery. Sheana returned a few minutes later, bearing a ceramic mug full of steaming tea. She set it down in front of Adora and settled back down into her chair. Adora wrapped her hands around the mug, humming softly.

"Thank you." Adora closed her eyes and basked in the comforting heat the mug provided.

“Sip slowly, it will calm you…” Despara nodded, finally pulling her hands away from Adora’s shoulder blades. Ceasing her awkward attempts at soothing affection. Staring at her with deep concern and acceptance instead.

“You must have so many questions.” Sheana drew Adora away from her musings, upon the pale green contents of her cup.

“Who are you...I mean...Razz told me some of it...but I’m still confused.” Adora huffed.

“I am Sheana, the light bearer. I am the Beginning, I am the embodiment of order, of creation and the source of all life in the universe.” Sheana answered, her words as cryptic and vague as what Razz told her. But it filled Adora with wonder and awe.

“I am Despara, the harbinger of darkness. I am the embodiment of chaos, of destruction and death. I am the final End to the Universe. “ Despara responded in a clipped, stern tone. That made Adora gasp in fear, it was chilling to hear.

“You fear us?” Sheana observed.

“Why wouldn’t I?” Adora shouted back in exasperation. “From the sounds of it, She-Ra has the ability to create and also destroy…..everything.” She shuddered, “I’m not strong enough to wield magic of this magnitude…I’m nothing….”

Despara growled, interrupting Adora’s self depreciation and forcing her to shut her mouth. “You're right, you were not worth anything. Merely a resource to be used and discarded when no longer useful. Stolen and given to Hordak, to be raised by the Horde. Shadow Weaver molded you to be the perfect soldier. To be the perfect weapon. You were merely a tool, used by Light Hope to fire the Heart of Etheria. To complete some ancient mission of the First Ones.” She spat venomously.

Adora was shocked by her harsh words, staring at her with a desolate, hurt expression. Her eyes watering with unshed tears. She pulled her hands away from her now cold cup of tea and

balled them into fists in her lap. Despara's words cut deep into the very core of her fragile self worth and insecurities. That she had been used her entire life by others who held all the power over her. Molding and manipulating her to be their weapon. Realizing that her sense of independence and autonomy had been a farce. Illuminating her to how weak and worthless she truly was. Verbalizing her failures, her feeling of inadequacy...at never being good enough, smart enough or strong enough. To live up to the grand expectations the universe had thrust upon her.

"But you have shown us your true strengths, your indomitable will to never give up! Never give in and always find hope, no matter how dark and overwhelming things look. At Thaymor, the scales were lifted from your eyes and you came to see first hand the atrocities of what the Horde was doing to Etheria and it's people. It was then you chose to leave the Horde. Months later at Mystacor, you chose to renounced your loyalty to Shadow Weaver. Years later, you rebelled against Light Hope...against the First Ones forced destiny. You refused to become her weapon and had the power within you to destroy the relic." Sheana cut in, drawing Adora away from Despara's penetrating glare. "You freed me. But it was days earlier that you proved to me on Beast Island that you had a pure heart, a fierce bravery and fortitude to wield me. I chose you then to bear the responsibility of my power. " Sheana reached out and placed her hand over Adora's.

"You drew me from the void, in the Crystal Cave." Despara began. "Your stubborn, single minded determination to do what needed to be done. Your unrestrained rage at the injustice of the situation was intoxicating and I could not resist your pull. It was then that I chose you to wield the responsibility of my power, as well."

"The unyielding strength of your conviction to save your friends, to do everything within your power to protect them. " Sheana smiled broadly. "You called to me in that Crystal Cave and I came willing to aid you in any way I could."

Adora sat stiffly, blinking rapidly as she absorbed their confessions. That she may have been manipulated into taking up

the sword. That this magic had no say at the beginning as to who would wield their power. But in time, each of these incredibly powerful magical beings had chosen her. She had earned the right to wield She-Ra.

"You have always seen your training as some sort of race to the finish?" Sheana observed. "Setting goals and achieving advancement in those new skills, at a steady, unrelenting pace. Working non-stop to perfect those skills...not because you enjoy the training...but because it is expected of you."

Adora moaned and nodded in agreement to that assessment.

"Shadow Weaver expected a-lot from me, growing up. So did my Staff Sergeant...I'm a soldier...that was how I was raised." She answered. "I always strive for excellence, to obey orders. Not to think for myself, but to follow procedures. I was made to believe that I needed to fight until the battle was won or I was dead. I was trained to conquer at all costs, to never back down from a challenge. I am expected to be the best, I am responsible for the soldiers under my command. If I fail….then we lose….if we lose...then we are all dead and it would be all my fault. " She heaved a great sigh, at finally verbalizing the burden she bore. Her voice thick with bitterness and venom, at how easily she had been conditioned. To see value in herself only by how useful she could be for others. To be nothing more than a tool...a weapon to be used and discarded if and when she had become of no more use.

Despara understood her, she was the dark aspect of her soul. That was governed by that violent rage, the need for exact revenge and retribution on all those who had broken her spirit as a child and rebuilt her into this perfect soldier. Who knew only how to fight a war, unable to relax and truly live in a world of peace. The force of justice she wished to direct upon all the people who had wronged her and protect those she loved. Despara regarded Sheana with a knowing smirk, they had been arguing of late. As to how to best support their new vessel. Who was struggling to find balance. Adora's grim statement only

proved her point. She was shifting more towards the negative then positive aspects of herself. Thus Despara had been summoned and not She-Ra.

"Your thinking is flawed, child." A cool, gentle voice invaded the room. "That is what is hindering you from truly grasping your magic."

Adora snapped her eyes open and looked up. Finding the female Tauran from the forest now entering the kitchen.

"You have put all this pressure on yourself to succeed, the weight of the world is not yours to bear alone. So stop letting it crush you. You must see yourself as a part of the whole. You are not some lone savior tasked to protect this planet at all cost. As others have made you believe. " Addie...the first She-ra was breathtakingly beautiful. Her facial features were gentle, yet elegant. With pale blue eyes, that sparkled with a kind playfulness. She had a warrior's build, that was feminine in that same tall, robust way as Spinnerella. With broad, well muscled shoulders. Her short fur was pale, her rounded cheeks rosy but weathered from years living in the wilderness. She moved about the kitchen, preparing herself some tea and a light snack. Her movements were precise, as she cut up an apple with her belt knife. On the heavy wooden chopping block, embedded into the counter by the basin.

"My name is Addie." She leaned casually against the island, biting into a slice of apple with a contented moan. Her blue eyes that looked almost silver, bored into Adora. Holding an easy confidence and not a trace of arrogance.

"I was the first to wield Etheria's Heart, I shall be your teacher...in time."

Adora gapped at her, as shock, hope and relief flooded through her.

"How...When...now…" She blurted out eagerly.

"No, child...First you must understand the weaving and Razz has offered to teach you. When Etheria feels you have woven enough of your own tapestry, with both the warps and the wefts being strong enough to wield She-Ra's full might. Then the Whispering Woods will call you and lead you here. To my cottage, so I can complete your training." Addie announced with a gentle smile, finishing her last apple slice and turning to retrieve her tea from the back counter.

"Thank you…" Adora breathed, nodding to each of them in turn.

"Until then." Sheana turned towards the shield upon the wall behind her, raising her hand to call the weapon into her hand. It shimmered away into nothingness and reappeared upon Adora's right wrist as a golden bracer with a blue runestone.

"I shall aid you...in a more 'restrained' fashion as your shield." She smiled fondly at Adora, patting her wrist affectionately.

"I shall aid you as well." Despara nodded, turning to the sword behind her and calling the weapon off the wall. It appeared upon Adora's left wrist as a silver bracer with a red runestone. "You may wield my sword, in time of need to dispatch any foes foolish enough to fight you." She smiled smugly, tapping the bracer with her index finger.

"Neither of us will weave into your soul again until you are ready, practice calling upon us through these weapons instead." Despara finished, retracting her hand slowly. A nervous hesitation in her retreat, that Adora never noticed.

Adora blinked down at her two new accessories in wonder.

"Thank you…" She breathed.

As both Sheana and Despara shared a grim smile of acceptance, understanding that they were now willingly going to shackle themselves into objects yet again. They would be apart again, as their vessel grew stronger, more confident in her magical abilities.

They were willing to sacrifice their freedom for a time. In the hopes that this vessel would free the universe of the ever looming shadow of the Nameless One in the future.

"Go now... learn, train. But I want you to see it as a journey of exploration and discovery, for yourself. That will benefit others in time." Addie offered, "That is the first step, child."

Catra knelt upon the sand, with Adora's head cradled in her lap. Brushing her claws tenderly threw the loose blonde strands, tucking them back behind her ear. Hours had passed, as Catra anxiously watched her sleep. When the twin bracer's appeared on her wrists, she was alarmed at first. Noticing the two rune stones and nodding in understanding. When she called upon her own magic, a tiara formed upon her forehead that held the Sun Stone. Melog had explained, during one of their long talks back at the farm house. That it was a physical manifestation of the Fire Rune, her magic. That the stones were a conduit to help channel and store magic. Catra figured Adora was tapping into the power of She-Ra in a new way. Knowing that She-Ra's magic would be stored in those bracer's now instead of Adora, eased her anxiety a lot.

It also helped that the red veins of corruption never appeared over Adora's skin. Catra began to dwell upon the mental and physical consequences that were in store for her. Summoning that magic was exhausting and strained her muscles, leaving her stiff and tired for days. But what would the outcome be for wielding Despara? She had heard from Scorpia that after she was separated from the tainted sword, Adora had become quite a handful. Would the outcome be the same? Would she become a silly, inebriated mess? Catra was suddenly very uncertain if she could handle Adora, acting so free and out of control. The sharp, blinding glow of the sun, cresting the horizon of the ocean drew her gaze upward. She squinted as the light refracting off the water was piercing. Then sighed heavily, it was dawn and she would need to sing her aubade. She found the morning greeting

and evening farewell to the sun, cathartic. A piece of her heritage, given to her from her mother. The only link she had to her, as a way to feel closer to the woman she barely remembered.

Catra took a deep breath, trying to place herself in a calm state of mind. Settling her turbulent emotions as she began to sing. Not wanting them to interfere with her communion with her source of magic.

“But I wonder, if....

I wonder if...

life, could ever be that simple?

Again?

I Wish...

I could prove,

That I love you,

I need you...

I can't bear to see you....

walk away, again...

She sang softly, welcoming the sun as her lyrics of love and loss echoed out over the ocean. Her voice grew stronger, as the sun blazed upon the water.

‘In the night...

I watch you sleep.

I have never felt...

so happy....

so warm...

so peaceful.”

My sanctuary, my sanctuary.

The sun rose fully from the horizon and set the sky on fire. Its brilliance bathes the lower sky in a breathtaking glow. There was something so soothing about singing to Adarion. As the sun rose into the sky, she could feel the heat penetrate deep into her soul. It offered her comfort and affirmation that everything was going to be alright. Catra took one more deep breath before finishing the last few lyrics of her love song. It was still very much a rough draft, but she had time to rework it. The most important thing was that she allowed Adarion to bear witness to who she truly was, inviting that ancient power willingly into her heart and soul.

“All my fears fall away.

My Heart...

I know, you will keep it safe.

I need you....

to hold me,

I need you...

to show me,

That whatever comes,

beyond this morning.

our future will not scare me.

That it will never be like it was before...

I will never,

walk away...

This time....

you will hear me say.

I love you...

I need you...

Stay with me...

I won’t let you go...

My sanctuary, my sanctuary…”

Catra slowly opened her eyes to find Adora staring up at her, with a dazed love drunk expression.

“That was beautiful…” Adora crooned, tears glistening in her eyes, and a goofy, lopsided smile gracing her lips. Adora paused for a moment, enraptured by Catra. Who leaned over her, protectively. Her mismatched eyes wide and full of concern.

“No….” Adora suddenly changed her mind. “...your beautiful.” Adora swooned, reaching up with both hands to cup Catra’s cheeks pulling her downward. Catra yelped, at the sudden manhandling, expecting a kiss. She was quickly disappointed as Adora merely smooshed her cheeks then released her with a giggle.

“NO!” Adora yelled, in sudden excitement.

“Your fuzzy!” She quickly lifted up Catra’s training shirt and pressed her face into her soft belly fur, humming with delight.

Catra shivered at the sudden, rather abrasive affection. The vibrations of Adora’s lips humming against her skin were strangely tantalizing and she soon found herself becoming slightly aroused. Her face bloomed with a warm blush as she quickly regained her composure. Her hand fluttered around the sides of Adora’s face, desperately needing to regain control.

“Are you alright?” Catra asked, her heart leaping into the throat. As she lightly pinched Adora’s chin and gently turned her face away from her stomach. Forcing her to confront her worried eyes.

“YES!” Adora screamed, thrusting both arms over her head. Unsettling herself and tumbling to the sand, laughing merrily. She finished her tumble by rolling onto her stomach. Bracing her chin in cupped hands and kicking her legs behind herself playfully.

“Wanna makeout?.” She offered with an excited grin, quickly moving into a kneeling position. Her movements clumsy and very uncoordinated as she crawled forward, reaching for Catra. Puckering her lips and closing her eyes expectantly.

Catra was alarmed, but not surprised it had been a possibility. That Adora would start acting drunk off her ass...after summoning Despara. But this was way worse than tired Adora. That, she knew how to handle, that was easy. Just keep her comfortable and then enjoy hours of snuggles. This Adora was unpredictable and loud! How the hell was she supposed to deal with this? Scorpia's tale of woe about dealing with a crazy, loopy Adora in the Northern Reach. Was nothing compared to this hot mess...she is dealing with now.

"We should head back to Darla." Catra countered, crab crawling out of reach. Before Adora managed to cage her in, by crawling over top of her. Adora huffed at her retreat. Adjusting herself to a kneeling position, shoulders slouched dejectedly. As she swirled her index finger in the sand, her lower lip jutting out in a very obvious pout. Catra quickly stood up and offered Adora a hand. She was not going to be able to handle this alone, she needed back up!

"You're no fun." Adora pouted, refusing to move from her kneeling position. Forcing Catra to hook her hands under her arms and haul her up to her feet. Adora leaned almost all her weight against Catra, as they stumbled down the beach.

"Seriously, Adora you can't walk?" Catra whined.

"Nope. " Adora responded, twirling on her toes and flopping over Catra's arms. Catra attempted to catch her but it was futile. She yelped in surprise as Adora threw herself and all her weight onto her. Catra instantly crumpled down to her knees in the sand, with Adora giggling with glee in her arms. The blonde had wrapped her arms around Catra's neck in a very undignified damsel in distress pose. Her blue eyes were wide and mournfully pleading. Her bottom lip quivered pathetically.

"I can not go on….carry me." Adora whimpered, giving Catra a quick peck on the tip of her nose. Gazing up at her with a smug, self satisfied grin.

(What is wrong with your mate?) Melog inquired, sniffing Adora's hip curiously. They could smell a sour sweat upon her skin, as if she was suffering a fever.

"Side Effects of summoning Despara…" Catra groaned, as she hauled herself and then Adora back up onto her feet. Adjusting her hold on Adora's wrist, as her arm was slipping from around her shoulder. Tightening her grip around Adora's waist, as the blonde could barely walk. Her steps were shaky and she kept swaying against Catra as if her balance was off.

"Hi…" Adora breathed, acknowledging Melog with a curt wave of her free arm. Nearly slapping the Krytian on the nose, with her wild swinging arm.

Melog pulled back a bit then promptly sneezed.

Making Adora roar with laughter. "That was so cute!..." She screamed, then drew serious. Staring intently down at Melog. "Do it again!" She ordered, her eyes sparkling with mischief. Catra groaned and rolled her eyes, this was going to be a very long, very annoying walk back to Darla.

She gave up halfway there, with a long drawn out groan. Dropping Adora to the sand and then crumpled to the sand and flopped backward herself. After the long, strenuous day she had yesterday. Leaping through the trees to get to the beacon then dealing with all the battles inside...too stressed out to sleep last night. She just didn't have it in her to drag Adora several more miles back to the ship.

When Catra released her arm. Adora dropped boneless to the sand, face first at the sudden lack of support. Rolling onto her back, muttering curses and spitting out sand. She turned and gave Catra a sad, disgruntled pout.

"Why'd you drop me…" She whined.

“Cause I’m tired.” Catra never turned to face her, staring upward at the dawning sky. Blinking lazily, barely able to keep her eyes open.

“Ok, you sleep then.” Adora leaned up on an elbow, nodding with an easy smile. Giving Catra’s belly a couple friendly pats, before scrambling to her feet and darting off towards the jungle as if something shiny caught her eye.

“What...no...Adora…urgh!” Catra scrambled to her own feet, exasperated and exhausted.

(She’s quite a handful.) Melog observed, trotting after Catra into the underbrush at the edge of the beach.

“Adora, Where are you!” Catra called as the deep shade of the canopy enveloped her.

She could hear Adora giggling, but she couldn’t see her. So she tentatively sniffed the air, intent on tracking her that way. The jungle was dark, way darker than the last parts she had navigated through. Her ears folded back and she tucked her tail low between her legs. The vines that twisted up and around the clusters of trees, held a new and horrifying meaning. Making the jungle seem far more menacing and predatory. Her ears twitched at every creepy sound.

Melog mewled nervously, as her fear and anxiety crept through their link.

“Adora!” Catra screamed again, unable to keep her growing fear in check. That something may have happened to her? She needed to find her, keep her safe...now more than ever.

“Adora!” She called again, her voice cracking with fear.

There was a rustling, then a body swung down from a low hanging branch right in front of her. Catra screamed, recoiling

from the limp body. All the gory, horrifying images she had ever imagined about Beast Island, flooded her rational mind. Her body felt electrified by sudden fright. The fur on her body was standing up and her tail was puffed up to twice its size. All the terrifying stories of the monsters and how brutally they killed a person. That Shadow Weaver had ever told her was now running rampant in her head. Reminding her how deadly this place could be.

Adora's squeals and snorts of laughter broke through her fear. Catra growled and opened her eyes, finding that the body was Adora. Hanging from a branch by her legs. Her head was flushed a bright red from being upside down for far too long. Her arms dangling down and swaying limply near the ground. She giggled and swung her arm forward, booping Catra on the nose.

"Boop." She giggled, sweetly as her finger connected with the cute peak of Catra's nose.

Catra wanted to strangle her...not in a friendly way either. She had been having a hell of a couple days, she was on the edge and did not need Adora pushing her off that proverbial cliff! With her stupid, drunken antics.

"Adora…that's not funny." Catra whined instead, helping Adora down. Which of course was a struggle, the blonde was so uncoordinated she basically dropped out of the tree like a dead weight.

Crashing on top of Catra and pinning to the ground, once more. Catra grunted as Adora's body was sprawled out on top of her.

(Are you alright?) Melog offered, nudging her cheek with their cold nose.

"No...this sucks." Catra grumped. As Adora had fallen asleep and was now snoring fitfully on top of her, using her body like a bed.

(We shouldn't stay here, it's not safe.) Melog observed.

“I don’t care….I’m too tired to move.” Catra mumbled, nuzzling her face into Adora’s loose blonde hair just under the blondes chin. That was pulled partially free from her ponytail, falling like a wild waterfall across Adora's forehead. Curtaining either side of Catra's face. Catra was done dealing. She wallowed in the security of Adora, sniffing her comforting scent and allowing it to lull her to sleep.

“Catra…” Melog chidded, impatiently.

“No...let them eat us...I’m not moving.” She argued petulantly, wrapping her arms around Adora’s waist and holding her tight, as if she was a teddy bear.

Melog merely sighed and then settled down next to her, as Catra started to cry softly.

She was just so worn out...she just needed a break...just for a little while.

Loves Requiem

Several minutes later, the eerie calls from the jungle constantly surrounding them. Had Catra so on edge, her instincts were screaming. She was so hyper aware of every sound, every smell, every slight movement lurking around them. She couldn't relax and thus couldn't sleep so she gave up. Making tired, grumpy snarls, she lightly shoved Adora off. Who slid boneless to the ground. The disgruntled blonde merely huffed, snorted and rolled over onto her side and fell back to sleep. Catra sat up and glared at Adora ruefully. Then looked beseechingly up at her alien companion.

"Can you carry us?" She inquired, her expression sullen. Melog had been right, this place was way too dangerous to catch a nap. Her stubborn, obstinate ass just wasted a whole bunch of time. That they could have used getting someplace safe, so they could actually get some sleep.

Melog nodded and increased their size. With a groan Catra climbed to her feet and awkwardly hauled an unconscious Adora to her own feet. Cursing and grumbling, she dragged her heavy, boneless, unhelpful blonde bulk over to Melog. Lifting and leaning Adora against their back. It was one small strategic maneuver after another to get Adora balanced on Melog's back. At first she slumped the blonde over their back like a sack, her arms flopping over their side like limp noodles. Then lifted one of Adora's thick, toned legs up and hooking her ankle over Melog's hip. Then rushing around to the other side of Melog to adjust her long, muscular arms. Almost instantly Adora was sliding off one side. Forcing Catra to scramble frantically around Melog to catch her. Push her upward and adjust her arms and legs once again, to regain balance. Once she got Adora settled, draping her on her stomach over Melog's neck. Catra climbed on behind her. Melog set off, striding out of the shade of the jungle and back into the warmth of the morning sun. Travelling down the rocky beach to the soft sand near the ocean. Adora had grumbled and moaned in discomfort the entire time. Squirming and twitching as she

attempted to get comfortable on Melogs constantly shifting shoulders. Forcing Catra to hold onto her waist, to keep her on Melog's back. It had taken about five more minutes before the loopy blonde had decided to adjust her position completely. Causing chaos and calamity as she twisted out of Catra's steadying grasp. Unconcerned and completely oblivious to the danger. She attempted to stand straight up on Melog's back. As soon as Melog felt her rough soles of her boots against their shoulder blades, they stopped. As her weight shifted when she started to stand up. They stood as still as possible. As soon as she was standing, Adora promptly lost her balance. With a yelp and her arms flapping frantically, she spun on her tiptoes like a ballerina, then fell backward against the giant cat's neck. Giggling proudly, that she hadn't fallen off. She lay sprawled on her back now, over Melog's neck. Staring up at Catra with a proud, goofy grin, giving her two thumbs up.

"Seriously...you idiot." Catra smiled tolerantly back. Infinitely thankful for Adora's good luck, she could have easily tumbled off Melog and hurt herself.

Once Catra got her settled again, Melog started padding forward again. Adora remained smiling lazily up at her, her eyes glazed and unfocused. Not picking up on how irritated Catra was becoming, as her tail lashed aggressively behind her. Adora merely laughed with amusement at her tails sharp movements and leaned up and around Catra's waist. Snatching her flicking tail and pulling it around. So she could flop back down on her back and play with it. Lounging against Melog's neck and brushing the fluffy tip of it under her nose and across her cheeks. Giggling happily as it tickled.

Catra released a long, drawn out sigh and rolled her eyes. If Adora was content to play with her tail she was ok with that. She would hopefully stay occupied enough, not to try and do anything more risky. The journey down the beach in the dawning light was soon filled with a tense silence. As Adora's euphoric haze faded into a sad melancholy, that worried Catra. Catra kept a close eye on Adora, who seemed to be avoiding eye contact. Staring out at

the shimmering morning sea, her eyes distant. Her eyebrows were scrunched together as she brooded over something. She had released Catra's tail a while ago, but Catra had not pulled it away. Letting her tail curl lightly on top of Adora’s upper thigh. Adora kept her hands busy, carding and re-carding her fingers on her stomach. Then steepling her fingers, tapping them together. This anxious fidgeting was a sure sign she was upset and working through and organizing her thoughts. Catra watched her cautiously, as one of Adora’s hands slunk down her thigh, gripping Catra's tail again. Pulling it towards her chest seeking comfort once more. Holding her tail securely enough that Catra couldn’t pull it away but not so tight that it hurt. Adora absently petted the fur at the very tip. Swirling her fingertips in small, terse circles. Creating a concentric pattern to the fluffy, velvety fur and making Catra shiver, at the sensually soft touch. Adora’s feather light caress was oddly soothing and then turned suddenly abrasive, When she began to swirl the fur in the other direction. Her fingers went against the natural growth of her fur, making it stand on end like a pom, pom. Catra clenched her jaw and forced herself to stay calm and not yank her tail away at the suddenly unsettling petting. Adora had never touched her like this before...it was tender but also unnerving with how agitated she was spinning her fingers through the fur.

“Your still mad at me.” Adora pouted, brushing Catra’s, puffed up tail tip in small circles on her cheek.

“I was never mad...just frustrated with you. You're reckless and impulsive and that scares me.” Catra responded earnestly, leaning forward to grip Adora’s knees, to keep her steady as she seemed to be slipping sideways again.

Adora made a discontented sound, as her fingers stopped swirling her tail tip, refusing to look at her. Catra had not responded the way she had wanted and she was frustrated. Catra tensed up, Adora was upset with her. After everything that had happened yesterday, this confession was long in coming. Catra swallowed and wondered if she was strong enough to hear what Adora had been keeping from her.

“Talk to me…” Catra was worried, Adora had been holding back her true feelings for a while now. She had tried to get Adora to open up about their troubled past back in Erelandia, during their time alone together in the inn. But she had dismissed her attempt to start a conversation about it. Spouting how all the bad stuff they did to each other was in the past...and that was where she wanted to leave it. But the bad stuff just didn’t fade away, it festered silently… poisoning them. Catra knew that better than most. Adora had let slip a couple times in the heat of an argument. How Catra’s cruelty, her callous disregard for Adora’s emotional and physical well being during the war. Had hurt her, how it still stung deep down and how she was having a hard time letting that pain go. Adora would immediately regret bringing up the past and apologize, but it didn’t make her words any less true. Perhaps this was the time to get her to open up, completely. Her guard was down and she was being open and honest for once. She could easily take advantage of this. Catra was desperate to know exactly how much she had hurt her. She had a lot of time on Primes Ship to reflect about her past sins and agonize over the pain she caused. She knew she had hurt Adora far deeper than she would ever show her. But she needed to hear it, craved Adora’s confirmation of how much of a monster she had been. It was a sadistic yearning for the verbal lashing she deserved from Adora. The selfish hope that after all those festering wounds had been lanced. That healing and possibly an absolution would follow. So she braced herself for the emotional assault that awaited her. Squeezing her eyes shut briefly as she found her courage. Then like everything else she had ever feared, she tackled it head on.

“You're the one mad at me...have been for a very long time...you just won’t admit it.” Catra poked Adora upon the forehead with an antagonizing claw. The shine in her mismatched eyes held no amusement, shimmering with unshed tears that reflected only shame. As she stared down at Adora firmly. Her eyes burning with silent accusation, that she had been lied to yet again.

“I can’t trust you to be there...when I need you...” Adora breathed, the words rushing out. As her gripping hand tightened

briefly upon Catra's tail. Catra cringed at the sudden pinch but stayed resolute not to pull her tail away.

“I was always there when you needed me..” Adora continued, then clamped her mouth shut at Catra’s scoffing smirk. The feline merely crossed her arms over her chest in silent rebuttal. They both knew Adora had thought she was protecting her all those years back in the Fright Zone. But honestly she had just been bossy and condescending towards her. Always trying to control her so she wouldn’t get in trouble. Never really standing up to Shadow Weaver in any way that mattered. Never wanting to disrupt the status quo, or jeopardize her rank, as their Squad Leader by pissing off the old crone. One of the first lessons in survival growing up in a cruel, unforgiving environment like the Fright Zone. Always look out for yourself first. Gauge the risks of looking out for others before committing to anything selfless.

“ I...sucked at it...but I tried to be there...at least...in the ways I could. ” Adora finished in a shameful mumble. Slowly drawing Catra’s tail down to lay it on her chest. Where it curled tenderly over the Fail Safe scar, the tip flicking nervously just under her chin. Adora knew she had tried and failed numerous times over the years to protect Catra, to save her. Her attempts growing up, to keep Catra out of trouble, to protect her from Shadow Weaver’s wrath had been a tragic failure. She had never been able to keep Catra in line. Far too immature, naive and emotionally stunted to offer her the love and support that might have changed the downward trajectory of their friendship. She had never been able to give Catra what she truly needed. In the portal reality, when she tried to get through to her, was one of her worst failures.

Catra was confused, frowning down at her and then nodding in agreement. It was true, she had promised when they were children. To be there for Adora, to look out for her and she would do the same for her. But her jealousy and resentments had gotten in the way and she had unconsciously pulled away...seeking to protect her fragile heart. So easily hurt and wounded. Every time her victories were stolen, her accomplishments overshadowed, the praise and acclaim she deserved always remaining out of reach.

While Adora was favored by the other cadets, by Shadow Weaver, by their Staff Sergeant. Receiving all the acceptance and laurels Catra yearned for.

“I was there eventually...” Catra whimpered, bowing her head low as she gazed shamefully at her hands in her lap.

Adora sighed heavily and nodded…”Took you long enough…to show up!” She sniped back angrily.

Catra moaned, blinking back tears. Adora’s honesty was far more destructive than she had anticipated. It was ripping her heart out once again. But what did she expect? She deserved this, this is what she had wanted...a full disclosure...so she needed to be strong and endure it.

“You LEFT ME!” Adora shouted…her hand tightened once again around her tail. Making Catra flinch and jerk slightly at the sudden pinch. Yet she refused to pull her tail back, she endured the discomfort of Adora’s small assaults and the rising anxiety that followed. That Adora might hurt her tail severely next time. Melog growled, their ears swiveling to listen to their heated argument. As their mane flickered with a yellow tint, just under the surface of the somber blue.

”You give me crap for leaving...but you left first.” Adora muttered bitterly.

“Ok...maybe..at Thaymor...” Catra nodded, now flustered and still confused.

Adora releases a low brittle chuckle, shaking her head and rolling her eyes mockingly.

Catra tried again, “In the Woods before the Heart. I did leave then...but I couldn’t bear to watch you die! You didn’t have to take on the Fail Safe! Shadow Weaver could have taken it! But you love to be the Hero!... “ Catra snarled, still holding onto a certain amount of rage at how reckless Adora had been. How she

never valued her own life, not taking into account how devastating her death would be upon her friends...on Catra.

“That wasn’t the first time! I’ve pleaded for you to stay...that I needed you...and you left anyway. I have always needed you, Catra. But you always punish me. When you think I’ve taken Shadow Weaver’s side...over yours...I didn’t have a choice Catra!” Adora wailed. “I never have a choice.” She finished, muttering bitterly, casting her eyes away in shame and betrayal. Her hand loosened upon Catra's tail for the first time since this painful heart to heart had started.

“I came back!” Catra defended, her voice rising in desperation. All that Adora had said was true. She had been petty and had retaliated against her many times. Never really taking into account the emotional tug of war Adora dealt with every day. In regards to meeting Shadow Weaver expectations and her loyalty to Catra. Always the magicat would retaliate after some perceived slight. In that confusing, passive aggressive way. Always so desperate for Adora to just once, just once. Stand up to Shadow Weaver and stop being her perfect little soldier. When they were kids she would run off and hide, sulk and brood. Because Adora would always choose Shadow Weaver over her. Showing her that she didn’t matter...then Adora would find her. Spending all her free time looking for her all over the Fright Zone. She would apologize, or offer small gifts and they would make up. Adora's efforts to find every one of her hiding spots. Soothed the hurt of Adora’s continued betrayals. Unfortunately Catra kept nurturing those resentments towards Adora, deep inside her heart. But having Adora's undivided attention at least for a little while, eased the sting. It made her feel like she mattered....at least for a little while.

“No!” Adora spat back. “You left me long before that, you broke our promise again and again! At Thaymor...At the First Ones Ruin.. down in that pit! Countless other times growing up...I tell you how much I need you...but I can’t count on you to always be there. I have to carry all the responsibility...the consequences...all alone...! ” She finished her voice fading into trembling sobs.

Catra didn’t know how to counter, it was petty and she wanted to spit right back. That it was Adora who told her to stay at the barracks, before leaving her to run off to find that stupid sword. That she had asked Adora to come back home with her at Thaymor and was rejected. That in the pit Adora had been asking for something impossible..something, Catra had no idea how to give. Treating her like an object instead of a person, that could just instantly help her summon She-Ra. But she bit her tongue, refusing to ever spit such petty vitriol at her ever again. She had hurt Adora. So many times with her mean retaliatory words over the years. She needed to dig deeper. She needed Adora to release all the emotional poison that had been hurting her for so very long. Catra was strong, resilient. She had endured far more brutal verbal lashings by Shadow Weaver growing up. Adora’s words would sting but she could take it….maybe.

“You're not being fair.” Catra mumbled, finally yanking her tail away from Adora’s loose grip. Needing to reclaim some personal power, by relinquishing her consent to touch her tail. Curling it up protectively around her hips and holding herself tightly. She knew this was going to be hard, but she felt so brutally attacked. She felt the need to curl up and defend herself.

Adora snickered. “You never fought fair, Catra...”

“True…” Catra admitted, unable to look at Adora any longer. Casting her eyes out to the rolling waves the same as Adora. Silence reigned between them for a long time as Catra cried softly.

“You broke my heart too…” Adora mumbled, then sniffled. “Did you really want to get rid of me...kill me?” Adora moaned, piteously. “When you cut that web I was hanging onto on the cliff inside the Crystal Castle? “

Catra snapped her startled gaze back to Adora. She swallowed hard, unsure how to answer. She had been so angry in the First Ones ruin, she could barely see straight let alone think rationally. When she had gotten back to the fortress. She had retreated to

her room, lying to Scorpia and Entrapta that she was going to bed. Instead she had the most painful, agonizing crying jag ever. Drowning in guilt, terrified that she had really killed Adora in a blind rage. Not able to settle down until she was able to think it all through rationally. Figuring the ruin would never really hurt Adora and was thankful she was alright. When they ran into each other at the Battle of Brightmoon. Yet her pride would not let her apologize, her ambition to prove her worth still driving her. Fueled by resentments and years of pent up anger. She had doubled down on her chosen path. Needing to win, to make Adora hurt...

"I'm sorry..." Catra moaned back, unwilling to delve too deeply into those brutal memories.

Adora merely grunted and turned quiet.

"I could have killed you…." Adora hissed a few moments later. Her troubled thoughts leaping forward to her own moment of holding Catra's life in her own hands.

Catra gasped in sudden dread.

"Now that I've transformed into Despara... I remember everything. You infected me with her disc in the Northern Reach. You wanted to control me...make me your weapon..to attack the rebellion with...you would have made me fight my friends...kill them....but it backfired." Adora laughed harshly, the sound was cold and brittle. Her eyes burned with disdain towards Catra.

The pain of betrayal in her laughter was heartbreaking. Catra's ears folded back, as she cowered even more before Adora. Holding herself tighter, her claws digging sharply into the small of her back.

"That was wrong… I understand that now. I..I... regret what I did. I'm sorry...I am really, really sorry..." Catra began to ramble an apology. She cared so much for Glimmer and Bow it hurt her heart to think how horribly things could have gone if her plan had

worked out. Her future would have been so bleak, lonely and loveless.

"In my nightmare….Despara made...me see it...feel it...what it would have been like to run you through with my sword...take your life…" Adora whispered brokenly.

Catra gasped and clutched her hands over her mouth to quell the painful anguished sounds from escaping.

"I can't get the image of you...dead at my feet out of my head. Watching the life leave your eyes...you were looking up at me with so much fear and surprise...that I would do it...could do it…It shattered me...Catra..." Adora gasped and bit down hard on her lower lip to stop it from trembling, to hold in the sorrow that wanted to escape. She was quiet for a long time, listening to Catra softly crying.

"I was terrified of you for a very long time…" Catra darted her eyes up briefly, unable to deal with the anguished visage of Adora crying silently. She returned her mournful gaze back out to the ocean. Melog's fur had turned a dull grey, their mane fluttered weakly, lacking any color. It looked almost translucent, as if it was made of air.

"You were so cruel...ruthless...selfish….and heartless...I couldn't get through to you. No matter how hard I tried….I lost you…for so very long...Catra.." Adora kept going, her eyes distant and consumed by the memories of the worst years of her life.

"I became the worst version of myself…" Catra whispered, brokenly.

"I couldn't give up on you...but I was close...after the portal...I nearly did...I thought there wasn't a shred of goodness left in you. I tried to let you go…" Adora confessed in a harsh, gravelly whisper. Her voice was already so sore and tired from bearing her heart.

“I was ashamed of what I had done, I couldn’t face you...I thought you hated me.” Catra added, softly.

“I regretted so much of what happened between us. I wanted to make it right. When I found out the Fright Zone had been destroyed. I had just broke the sword and was on the border of the Fright Zone. Bow had gone to the fortress to find Glimmer, he found me later that night. He let me know that the Fright Zone had fallen, that he had been too late to save Glimmer. That Horde Prime had taken her. I searched for you….for a long time. Scorpia thought you might still be on the Salineas coast. But I couldn’t find any trace of you. Then the Galactic Horde invaded and I had no more time to look. I was so scared that I had lost you for good and I would never get the chance to make things right between us. I thought about you every day. Then you saved Glimmer, I was confused...but after so many long years of watching you spiral out of control...I had hope...that my Catra...was still in there. I could never let you go! I promised myself years ago that I would never leave you behind again!” She spat vehemently, still glaring out at the rolling waves crashing against the shore.

“I’m so very sorry….I’m sorry….for everything...I truly am…” Catra gasped out, barely controlling her voice over her heart wrenching sobs. “I am so glad you came back for me…” She finished with a weak, watery smile towards Adora who still refused to look at her.

Adora was silent for a long time, Catra timidly reached out to hold her hand. But Adora pulled it away sharply. Folding her hands together over her chest instead to deter Catra from reaching for her again. Catra whimpered at the harsh rejection, holding her tail to her chest as she curled up tighter into herself. Her throat was tight and it ached from holding back the painful sobs she needed to release.

“You don’t love me anymore.” Adora’s whimpered, tears moistening her eyes as she glared furiously out to sea.

Catra had no idea how to respond to that statement, she just blinked in complete disbelief. As Adora verbally leaped off track, her accusation came out of nowhere.

“I don’t understand…?” Catra croaked out.

“It’s because I’m a First One….” Adora muttered, her eyes darkening with shame. “My people are vile, evil….tyrants! How many worlds have we harvested...for our own gain? How many have we left to die at Prime’s feet, in the name of saving just our own people. We enslaved Etheria’s magic….weaponized it. We killed and enslaved your people...I’m an Eternian... therefore I am capable of the same evil too...right?” Her voice was weak, seeking confirmation that she was right.

“Adora...I...have never seen you as an Eternian...we’ve gone over this.” Catra pleaded, hating how hurt and broken she looked.

“BUT I AM AN ETERNIAN….I’M THEIR LOST PRINCESS! For star’s sake!” Adora shouted, tears now streaming unchecked down her cheeks. “I can’t just stop being ashamed and feeling guilty. I need to atone for the sins….of my ancestors.” Her words faltered, as she took a shuddering breath, before sobbing brokenly.

Once again Catra was at a loss for words. Adora barely opened up about anything, without a lot of coaxing. Even then it was like pulling thorns, she only offered a little about what was hurting her, leaving a portion of the thorn under her skin. To continue to fester and burrow deeper. Now she seemed completely open and unguarded about what had been bothering her for so long. A part of Catra wanted to use this opportunity to have Adora disclose everything that she had been brooding on. While another part of her was now scared and wished Adora would just shut up. She didn’t know if she could handle any more.

“Come here, come here!.” Catra leaned down and sought to pull Adora up and into her embrace. Desperate for comfort and needing to be consoled and console Adora in turn. Adora didn’t resist, at least not at first.

"I love you...I will always love you. I'm sorry for hurting you, I never meant for you to take the blame for what your ancestors did to mine." Catra whispered against the shell of Adora's ear. Adora folded herself into Catra's arms. Clutching desperately at her shoulder blades as she burrowed deeper into her embrace.

"I can't do this...alone.." Adora whined against Catra's neck.

"You're not alone…" Catra professed.

"I'm scared that I'm not strong enough…not smart enough...to protect...Etheria." She moaned.

Catra held her more tightly, pressing desperate kisses to her temple.

"I need you…" Adora whimpered, nuzzling closer into the shelter beneath Catra's chin.

"I'm here...you can count on me..." Catra promised.

Adora pushed away suddenly at that statement, giving Catra a distrusting glare as she flopped back down on Melog's slender neck. Catra had said those very same words countless times growing up and Adora had come to distrust them. Catra had never been very dependable and Adora had long since lost faith in her.

"It's going to be ok…" Catra cringed, knowing she had said those very same words in the pit. Just before Adora transformed into the dark version of She-ra.

"I feel terrible that I couldn't help you become She-Ra...but you are not alone. You're right I wasn't there for you for a long time, but I'm here now and I am not going anywhere. We will figure this all out together. " Catra promised, offering her a watery, ghost of a smile.

"You promise?" Adora whispered, her voice weak and vulnerable. Pleading for her to reassure her that she could be trusted. That

her heart was safe this time and Catra wouldn't crush it like she did before.

"I promise!" Catra assured her, reaching out and clasping her hands tightly. Adora never pulled them away, allowing Catra to reassure her. Catra made a silent promise to herself as well, to watch her words and temper her anger in regards to the First Ones. An ironic kind of clarity was striking her hard, Melog's cruel words in regards to the clones yesterday. Had hurt her in a very similar manner. She understood the clones in a way no one else would. To be enslaved by Prime and have no free will...to be nothing more than an obedient pet. Melogs words had hurt, in the same way her words had hurt Adora.

Adora was quick to roll her hands out of Catra's grasp, then. Unwilling to let her comfort her any longer. Slumping back against Melog's neck, lost to her brooding once more. She needed space to unpack all the resentment and bitterness she held towards Catra. By finally confessing how much Catra had hurt her, she had given those tortured emotions life. She had tried so hard to keep the hurt and heartbreak hidden, to not reflect too deeply on the pain. Hoping that those unwanted feelings would just fade. If she refused to acknowledge them. Now they were throbbing inside her chest, ripping and tearing at her heart and shredding her as thoroughly as they did in years past.

Bow had always been a morning person, rising with the day moons as a child and now with the sun. He strode purposefully down Darla's exit ramp with a steaming cup of coffee clutched comfortingly in his hands. Finding Brojee, pacing around the crumpled remains of the rounded front cockpit of his star ship.

"How are the repairs going?" Bow asked sympathetically, as he took note of Brojee's frustrated grimace. He stared down at the busted panels, now ripped off and laying on the sand. Revealing a mess of wires and components, Bow couldn't even name.

Brojee laughed bitterly and then made a hand gesture of a gun and pretended to shoot the open panel.

“My ship’s dead, my friend.” He huffed. “Drizzi showed me a crack in our Thulite drive so wide, it might as well have been broken in two.”

“Oh…” Bow responded.

“So unless you got a spare Thulite drive from a Primus Freighter...Nebula class or smaller, mind you...anything else is only going to blow us up like an interstellar firework.” Brojee commented bitterly.

“No...all our tech is either First Ones from over a thousand years ago...or Horde.” Bow shrugged.

“Modern Horde drives are far too complex for this simple mechanic to hook up, and First Ones are way too volatile” Brojee sighed, placing his hands on his hips. “I do not mess with trans-dimensional drives. Traveling through the CrossRoads of Worlds is way too risky. I am fine with light speeds, it’s basic and way slower but it gets me and my crew where we want to go eventually.” He nodded, his eyes resolute with his decisions about how his ship runs.

Bow swallowed and turned to stare at Darla with new found confusion and a hint of fear.

He remembered in Mara’s last transmission she had used up the last of Darla’s power to transport the entire planet to Despondo’s. It was incredible to think that kind of power lay hidden inside Darla’s engine core. He knew next to nothing about how that ship worked, even after all those months traveling aboard her.

“Brojee...can you teach me about starships?” Bow inquired softly.

“Sure, looks like we are going to be here for a while.” Brojee nodded, then scratched the back of his neck morosely. “Guess I

better break the news to Litha." He groaned, heading around the side to his ship and up the entry ramp.

Bow watched him go, taking a long sip of his coffee. It was comforting to finally have someone who really understood all this tech. Entrapta was a genius but she was still just as clueless as he was. Having to experiment and research the ancient databases to understand all the tech discarded around Etheria. This was a great opportunity for him to tinker and develop new tech under Brojee's tutelage. He already had so many ideas he couldn't wait to start building.

Bow had just started heading back towards Darla, when he noticed Melog padding over a dune a few yards away. Melog hung their head low. Their body and mane were the same lavender and blue but the hue was dull. A grim melancholy aura was imbued in those muted tones. Bow had grown accustomed to gauging Catra's moods, based of Melog's countenance. The feline's emotional state tends to shift far more severely than any of his other friends. So he used those tells, as way of risk management when wanting to engage with Catra. Melog looked docile and kinda depressed, so he changed course and headed towards the giant cat. Concern was etched over his face, as he sought to find out how last night went. Adora or Despara had never shown up and he was beyond worried at this point. He released a sigh of relief when he noticed Adora, flopped backward over Melog's neck. Staring despondently at the sand, with Catra sitting up stiffly, riding just behind her. The magicat's facial expression was placid, as if all her energy had been drained out of her. They both looked haggard and utterly exhausted.

"How'd your night go?" He inquired innocently as he came into stride next to Melog.

Adora never looked at him, merely swung her head in the other direction to actively avoid Bow's question.

He was shocked at first, Adora hadn't been this upset and dismissive of him since her fight with Glimmer. He glanced up, his

eyes going wide in both surprise and worry.

Catra's eyes were red rimmed from crying and she had heavy bags under her eyes from not sleeping. She looked physically worn out and emotionally spent.

"We're going to bed." Was all she said, patting Melog's shoulder to coax them to go faster. Melog picked up the pace, leaving Bow standing in worried confusion. Quickly coming to his own conclusions about last night. They must have gotten into a one hell of a fight. Bow took another long sip of his coffee. Relationships were hard work, he had faith they would figure it all out. Catra and Adora were meant to be together. Just like he was meant to be with Glimmer. Things would work out and if either of them needed any advice or someone to talk to, he would be available.

Adora never said a word, when Melog stopped in front of the door to her room. She merely slid off their back. Her footing was still uncertain and she wobbled off balance as her boots struck the floor. She squared her shoulders, raising her chin up stubbornly before stumbling through the slowly opening door. Catra was quick to hop down and follow Adora into her room. It wasn't as spartan as Catra's little chamber down near the engine room. Adora had a cot similar to Catra's. A simple metal desk, full of scattered papers with a hard back, metal, utilitarian chair sitting in front. A large cork board hung on the wall above the desk, full of drawings and star charts from their first journey through space. A simple, locked, metal chest sat in the corner. It held spare clothes and the shattered remains of the Sword of Protection. Adora had never taken it out to show her, but had told her what was inside.

Adora practically ripped the wing pin from her cloak, as it fluttered to the floor. She shuffled cautiously towards the bed, her expression was hard. Determined to make it there on her own. Catra was quick to catch her when she lost her footing. Steadying her with one arm around her shoulders the other around her

stomach. Adora grunted and rolled her shoulder's hard, tossing Catra's arm off and spun awkwardly out of her grasp. Grumbling and cursing under her breath, Adora widened her stance and stood still for a moment. The sudden movement to get away from Catra, making the room spin more than before. She took several deep breaths, swallowing hard as if forcing down vomit and then stumbled the last few yards to the cot.

Catra stood nibbling on her lower lip nervously, wondering if she should follow Adora into bed? Watching crestfallen as Adora angrily crawled into bed, tucking herself under the blanket. Then flung the blanket over her head and curled up facing the wall. Effectively shunning and dismissing Catra with one very angry, hurt action.

Catra stood staring with a dumbstruck, uncertain expression for a minute or two.

"Hey, Adora…" Catra called, her voice weak and trembling.

As Adora remained silent, refusing to acknowledge her, resolutely facing the wall. Balled up tight in her cotton cocoon. Her breaths were heavy and labored, from holding back her own sorrow or rage.

Catra didn't know if she was wanted and that made everything even worse. She didn't know how to deal with this sudden, more vehement kind of rejection. She had done this very same thing, just after Adora had saved her from Prime. Shunning and dismissing Adora's attempts to care for her. By hiding under her blanket in her room. Or sniping some sharp tongued barb about how stupid Adora was to come back for her. She had been so ashamed, so upset and scared, she couldn't face Adora or anyone else for a long time. Retreating back into her angst refusing to look weak or vulnerable.

In the past she would have gotten mad right back at Adora, made her feel guilty and remorseful for getting upset with her. Deflect or dismiss her feelings and reverse her accusations right back at her.

Until she was the one apologizing. But Catra had grown and understood that was not how you treated someone you loved. Her entire world was falling apart, all her worst fears were now coming true. Adora didn't trust her, didn't want her, hated her, wanted her gone.

Catra sniffled, refusing to break down here in front of Adora. She could not show any more weakness. Or how much Adora's silent disappointment and seething anger was destroying her. Adora may not love her anymore...but she still had her pride.

She spun on her heel and quickly exited the room before she lost all control. Storming past Melog, her hands balled into tight fists as her sides. Her claws drawing blood from her palms, that now trickled down her knuckles and dripped upon the floor. As her hurried stride then turned into a panicked run. As a shuddering sob escaped her tight lips. Dashing blindly down the hallways, as a new more powerful wave of tears made her vision swim. Gasping for air and struggling to keep it together she rushed down to her own room. Once in the secure, dark solitude of her chamber, the door hissing closed. She finally allowed herself to fall apart. Crumpling to her knees, holding herself tight as she keened mournfully. Then began wailing painfully with grief. Sobbing brokenly, a new tears steamed down her cheeks. Overwhelmed by her guilt once again. Allowing the full weight of her past sins to crush her. As she rocked back and forth, slowly drowning in her misery.

It was never meant to be….Their love was doomed from the start. She had known it would not last, that there was no way to overcome all the horrible things she had done, the pain she had caused. This had just been a dream...but it was over now and she had to face the truth. Shadow Weaver was right all along. She was just like her, mean and toxic and a monster...She was destined to be alone forever…and after everything she had done...she deserved it!

The rush of sudden panic and crushing anguish was suffocating, as complete devastation set in. At that cruel and lonely realization

of how her future would be. Catra screamed and lashed out, digging her claws deep into the floor. Rending the metal, as it tore with a sharp, reverberating wail. Catra was desperate to feel anything but the debilitating heartache she felt now. Knowing that her heart had now officially been cut out and that she had been the one wielding the knife! It broke her in ways she would never recover from.

Catra had quickly out paced Melog in her rapid retreat back to her room. Leaving the alien cat, trotting several yards behind. The rage and despair slamming inside of them, in unrelenting waves. Melog growled, hanging their head low and shaking their entire body violently. In a desperate attempt to shed a portion of the negative emotions now overwhelming them. Their body darkened with rage, their mane vibrating in bursts of red and yellow. When they got to Catra's room, the front door was locked refusing to open. With a huff Melog sat before the door, bunting the metal with their forehead.

(*Catra…)* They called gently, listening to the agonizing screams and then the harsh crash of her cot being thrown violently against the wall. Followed by more rage fueled howls and the screech of rending metal echoing from inside. Fear and trepidation clawed at Melog's calm and they reared up and pushed against the door forcefully with their powerful front paws.

(*Let me in, Master….you need to calm down…)* They pleaded, pushing their weight against the door in a frantic attempt to break in.

"Leave me alone!" Catra screamed back, the fury and loathing towards herself scalding Melog threw their link. They cringed in pain, moaning and slinking away from the door as if it had burned them. Their body lightened into a sickly grey as their mane and tail turned translucent.

(*I will never willingly leave your side...our magic is bonded, our link is forever intertwined. Your pain...is my pain…)* Melog ground out between clenched teeth. At that point the door hummed to life, sliding aside. Melog padded lightly into the darkness beyond the doors. Finding the room trashed, the bed upturned against the wall. The mattress was shredded, laying discarded in the far corner. Deep gouges marred the floor and walls, as if a wild animal had gone ballistic within the small confines. Catra was seething and pacing at the very back of the dark room. Her eyes glowing with power, a dark blood red halo of fire covered her body. The flames flickered and snapped with her agitation. She resembled a menacing spectre, prowling the dark recesses of her room. The disconcerting aura of malice and loathing hung like a toxic fog in the air. It made Melog shiver with dread as they cautiously approached her.

"I was so stupid...stupid...to think things would work out this time." Catra mumbled, then snapped her fierce glare towards Melog. "Why did I let myself hope! There was no way, Adora could just let go of what I did. I treated her so cruelly…. For so long...she didn't deserve it! Why am I like this! Why do I destroy everything….that I care about!" She screamed, tears trailing down her cheeks as she wrapped her arms around herself tightly. "We never had a chance…." She flung her head back and laughed maniacally. "Shadow Weaver was right…." Her sour smile was paper thin and laced with an acidic bitterness. At the irony of how she had sabotaged any hope of ever being happy. Just because she couldn't control her anger. The mocking voice that always nagged at her, telling her she was worthless, that her life didn't matter. That she was a cruel, heartless monster undeserving of love and kindness. Was echoing maliciously inside her head. The writhing hatred for herself, stretched over their link like a darkening shadow.

Melog growled as their body shifted into a dark indigo shadow. Their mane was tainted with a thick grey smoke that billowed around their neck. They resembled some kind of vengeful phantom when they lunged, pinning Catra to the floor.

“She hates me! She wants nothing more to do with me….she would be better off without me anyway!” She cried, ducking her face into Melog’s chest. Her hand flew up to clutch desperately at Melog's biceps, her fingers curling into their short fur. As their alien feline body flared to life with soothing white flame, engulfing both of them. Catra’s painful sobs of rejection and grief were soon drowned out by Melog’s loud, calming purr.

(*You need to calm down...you are self-destructing...let me tell you a story.)* Melog waited, pressing their weight down upon Catra. As she slowly stopped writhing beneath them and began to lay still, accepting the restraining weight and allowing it to calm her. Her breathing continued to come in short shallow bursts, heating the fur against their chest.

(*My last master was an outcast. He had been shunned and persecuted by his own people. Because they believed he was cursed. His own parents had cast him out to the streets as a young child. Worried his curse would harm their other children. Because of ignorance and superstition, he was run out of the village at a very young age. To survive or die in the forest beyond. He lived a life of solitude deep in the wilds of Krytis. Even though his own people refused to accept him, he held no ill will towards them. Choosing to forge his own path, with only me as his companion. He was a very wise man, a scholar and a healer. He held immense power in the wild magic. Able to tame the ethereal currents that coursed through Krytis and bind them to his will. He was no good with people and when he had to interact with them, he did so reluctantly. Whenever he had to make his way through villages or cities to meet with other's within the Krytis Resistance. He would rely on my ability for invisibility to avoid the crowds along the streets. He taught me about acceptance, that was the only way I could survive for so long on my own after the planet died. I will tell you what he said to me...Life is beautiful and infinite in its possibilities. But it cannot be tamed, it is wild and unpredictable. Not always gentle, or kind. Often it will seek to harm you, leaving wounds not easily healed. Most times our past will leave scars, ugly and long. But we need to accept them. By worrying about them. Or wailing about how unjust and unfair the*

circumstances of those scars are, we give them power over us. Wondering how long or if they will ever heal or disappear is a waste of time. By doing so, you only reopen the wound and increase and prolong the pain. Pain…is a given...but suffering is optional. Come with me, we will go get some air and talk this all out.)

Catra grew quiet, as she contemplated their words. Reviewing what Melog said, then mulling over Perfuma's words back at the lake about her being trapped in a cycle of rage and reaction. Needing instead to think things through with a peaceful mind. So she could see the ripples her decisions would make.

"You're right, I need to go for a walk.." She mumbled, despondently. Melog nodded and rose off of her. Allowing her to get up. She slunk out of the room with her head hung low, shoulders slumped in defeat. Melog reverted to their normal colors, as they followed resolutely behind Catra. Needing to keep her safe and grounded, as she dealt with the grief of her tortured past with Adora.

Truth and Consequences

“No! Scorpia, you can't imprison royalty!” Glimmer shouted into Darla’s holo graphic communication sphere.

Perfuma blew an irritated puff of air upward into her bangs. She was leaning against a side console on the command deck next to Glimmer. Glancing over, to pay the Queen of Brightmoon an exasperated look, folding her arms over her chest stubbornly.

“I see Scorpia’s point.” Perfuma offered, “Princess Sweet Bee aided and abetted Peekablue and some mysterious magicat, who stole an artifact from Mystcor. She should be held. Until she confesses about Peekablues intentions, with that little thief.”

“It’s against the kingdom accords.” Glimmer spat back, casting Perfuma a perplexed, disappointed frown.

“Those accords don’t pertain to my kingdom since it didn’t exist when those documents were being drawn up.” Scorpia’s voice echoed out from the orb, firm and matter of fact.

“What you are doing could be seen as an act of war!” Glimmer shot back, pinching the bridge of her nose in frustration.

“I'm not planning on going to war with anyone!” Scorpia cried suddenly in alarm. She was just following proper Horde protocols concerning prisoners.

“We are not done talking about this. Anyway, I got a ship full of alien trespasser’s for your cells, Scorpia. Darla will be enroute to Scorpania later today. We should arrive before sundown.” Glimmer rolled her eyes to the roof with a groan. Turning to confront Perfuma, with a disgruntled glare.

“You of all people should be on my side...Scorpia doesn’t know how to run a kingdom yet, or our diplomatic policies between other kingdom’s. She needs to be taught proper royal decorum or we are going to end up fighting another war?” Glimmer whispered

harshly. Seeking to get her point across by bracing her hands indignantly on her hips.

Perfuma huffed, "Meadowlands remained neutral during the war against Hordak and when Horde Prime invaded, they hid away in their subterranean hives. They have contributed nothing to Etheria for close to a thousand years. We owe them nothing. Sweet Bee is not an ally. She has her own agenda and I do not think she should be treated any differently. Just because she's of royal blood." Perfuma responded, her eyes cool and full of resolve.

Glimmer's mouth fell open in surprise. The sweet, peaceful Perfuma, was completely disregarding Sweet Bee's rights as a Princess. Firmly agreeing with Scorpia's uncompromising approach. To incarcerate Sweet Bee and her crew until they submitted to Scorpia's demands. Glimmer had never seen this tough, commanding side of her. Her time as the leader of the rebellion had changed her in ways, Glimmer never thought possible. It left her feeling rather unsettled in regards to how well she thought she knew the Princess of Plumeria.

"This is not how we treat fellow princesses….even if we may feel they deserve it." Glimmer grumbled defensively. As the first of her friends to take on the role as Queen. She saw the long lasting impact this could cause to all their kingdoms. It might drive Meadowlands to become even more reclusive from the rest of Etheria. Leading to further distrust among the nobility and perhaps war would once again be in their future. She had to maintain the peace, if that meant swallowing her pride she would. Pander to Sweet Bee's better nature not to retaliate, apologize for Scorpia's mistreatment and seek a peaceful resolution.

"Scorpia, I want you to release Sweet Bee. I'll talk to her, I'm sure if we treat her with respect and kindness she will tell us everything we want to know." Glimmer commanded, cutting the communication abruptly. Expecting Scorpia to obey her orders.

Perfuma paid her a tolerant look. Adjusting her folded arms over her chest as she calmed her rising ire.

"Scorpia is not some underling for you to command. She's your friend and the ruler of her own kingdom, you need to treat her with more respect. You might not agree with what she did. But she was also a Force Captain, a commander same as you and she knows what she's doing. I hope the olive branch you are about to offer Sweet Bee doesn't rot on the vine."

Glimmer sighed heavily, as Perfuma strode purposefully from the command deck. Once again Glimmer felt like she had overstepped her authority. Taking command just came naturally to her. When she felt things were going to go wrong. She just wanted to avoid confrontations…future complications…why can't Perfuma see that? This taking a step back…trusting in others, allowing them to chart their own course so to speak…it was hard…

Adora bolted awake with a sudden cry of alarm. As she remembered her brutal honesty with Catra the night before. She had just laid it all out, a full disclosure of how deeply Catra had hurt her. Three years of pain and heartache, unfiltered and unrestrained. The regret and anxiety of what she had done. Washed over her like a bucket of ice cold water.

"NO...no.no,no.no." She stumbled out of her cot. "What have I done…" she cringed, devastated by her actions. Then her eyes flared wide in sudden realization of the consequences. That Catra might have already left for good. Catra did not handle her anger and rejection well the last time. Adora's eyes shimmered with rising anguish, as she darted out of her room. Desperate to find Catra and repair the damage she had done. She was sweating and out of breath by the time she made it down to Catra's room.

"Catra!" She shouted, pounding on the door. Her heart was slamming against her chest in panic. All her worst fears screamed

in her head, that she had destroyed everything. That Catra was gone and would never come back.

The door slowly eased open with a painful groan. Adora blinked in disbelief, releasing a slow morose sigh. Catra's room was completely trashed, the floor had been gouged in long jagged claws marks. The walls were scarred with tons of criss-crossed scratches, the mattress was shredded. The metal frame of the cot tossed against the back corner.

"Stupid..stupid...stupid…" Adora muttered vehemently under her breath. She had tried so hard to leave all that hurt and distrust behind. The after effects of transforming into Despara had ruined everything. She had been out of her mind, laying her heart bare like that. Now she had a bigger mess to fix. She spun on her heel and dashed back down the hallway, her mind spinning with where Catra may have gone.

Adora rushed down the exit ramp, darting her gaze up and down the beachfront. It was late afternoon, the sun had already dipped behind the canopy of the jungle. The clusters of trees casting long shadows over the sand. Her eyes glistened with unshed tears as she searched frantically for any sign of Catra. Finding nothing but barren sand and sharp monoliths of corrupted tech down the rugged coastline.

"Adora?" Bow's inquiring voice snapped her back and she spun to face him.

"Have you seen Catra?" She nearly shouted, grasping his shoulders and shaking him lightly.

"No...I've been in Brojee's ship for most of the day." Bow answered, his brows furrowing in concern. It had been a long time since he had seen Adora looking so stricken and fearful.

Adora moaned, returning to scanning the barren beach front. Wandering away from Bow, chewing on a fingernail nervously.

“I’m sure she hasn’t gone far. Did you guys have a fight?” He enquired gently, placing a concerned hand on her shoulder. Seeking to calm her down.

“Yeah...I said some stuff I shouldn’t and….I need to find her!” Adora shot back, shrugging off his arm and jogging away.

“We all say things we don’t mean when we're mad. I’m sure she'll forgive you.” Bow offered.

“That’s the bad part...Bow. I did mean what I said, but if Despara hadn’t compromised my better judgement...then I would have never said any of it.” She groaned, pinching her nose in frustration at herself.

Bow’s face scrunched up in confusion. “That’s not healthy...Adora.” He reprimanded. “You can’t have a good, solid relationship with other people by keeping what’s bothering you a secret. You're just hurting yourself...you need to be open and honest with the people you love. Trust that they will accept and validate how you feel and be willing to work through the issues harming your relationship with them.” He advised.

Adora heaved a great sigh, giving Bow an unimpressed frown. “Healthy communication was not something they taught in the Horde.” She jogged away on a hunch. Heading towards the cliffside, Catra had retreated to yesterday morning.

“We were raised to be soldier’s, Bow! There was no touchy, feely bullshit in the barracks!” She shouted back, hoping her hunch was correct...she was desperate to repair the damage her inebriated honesty had caused. A few moments later, she was stunned to find Bow was jogging along with her. He offered her a reassuring smile.

“We’ll find her together.” He promised.

Adora grinned in both amusement and admiration, she was so thankful to have Bow in her corner. He had always been a stalwart

ally, always there to support and reassure her no matter how dark things looked.

Adora stood atop the cliff, scanning the rocky shoreline slowly. Catra was not where she had hoped she was. But she had been here recently, Adora took note of the flattened grass by the boulder they had sat beside yesterday. Catra's empathic magic filled this place. Adora could feel the hot pulsing anger still hovering in the air. Layered with regret and a deep sorrow, that was beyond measure. The suffering had shed off Catra like a negative aura, before she abandoned this place. Adora cringed and ducked her head, as if being reprimanded severely. As her heart dropped low into her belly with bitter disappointment. But she wasn't giving up either. She quickly raised her head and began to scan the beach. From this higher vantage point she could see a lot farther. At the top of the beach, where the sand met the tall grass just before the jungle. She caught sight of movement, a small shape hunched against the melted mass of a corrupted bulkhead, covered in black vines. Adora ground her teeth, as she remembered that Omega Prime was still out there. That the tortured beast had escaped into the sea. She quickly shook her head to clear away the roiling anxiety. That was for future Adora to deal with. Right now she had to fix things with Catra. Bow spun around just as he reached the summit, panting for breath. As Adora dashed past him back down the sharp incline of rocky ground heading towards the beach. Bow groaned then nodded with determination, following Adora back down.

Bow slowed his gait as Adora approached the tall grass at the tree line, with a certain amount of caution. Bow found her sudden wariness confusing, he would have never been on edge to approach Glimmer after a fight? But Catra could be so much more volatile. So he strangely understood his friend's wary approach. Adora took a deep, settling breath before striding purposefully into the tall grass. Resolute to accept her punishment for hurting Catra

last night. She stopped instantly, finding Melog hovering over Catra. Who was tucked under their chin in a tight ball. Having curled herself up against their belly, sitting hunched over a patch of smooth sand. Idly scratching into the sand with the claw of her index finger. As the alien cat glared threateningly up at Adora. Melog's demeanor was ferociously protective, but thankfully not red in warning. Their chin was draped over the top of Catra's bowed head like a living cowl. A pulsing blue fire was flaring out from Melog's body, their mane crackling a brilliant white. A tamer version of the ball of blue flame they had become back in the cavern under Horror Hall. When Catra was confronting the bones of her parents, expressing an overwhelming amount of grief and sorrow over their deaths.

Adora swallowed hard before quietly calling out to Catra.

"Catra…" She slowly knelt down. Pulling Bow down with her. Not wanting to make any sudden movements and set off Catra's fight or flight instincts.

Catra's tail flicked away from where it was wrapped around her ankle, thumping against the ground aggressively. Illustrating that she had heard her. Yet, she refused to look up, concentrating on the patch of sand she had scribbled on instead.

Then softly she began to sing.

"We have both been there before,

Feeling lost and alone,

Searching for that place to call home,

Struggling to find hope.

We both have battle scars.

Demons and broken hearts.

Trying our best to cope.

Please don’t worry,

You can trust in me,

You will never be alone.

Leave the pain behind,

I’ll be by your side.

I’ll be by your side.

When the light is fading, don’t be sad.

I'll be there.

When you’re lost in the dark, don’t be scared.

I'll be there.

It’s so hard to start over,

when you have battle scars.

Demons and broken hearts.

Please don’t cry,

You can trust in me.

You will never be alone.

We all need someone to rely on,

A hand to reach out for,

When we're hanging by a thread.

Leave the pain behind,

I'll be by your side.

I'll be by your side.

When you stumble and fall,

I'll be there, to pull you up.

When you feel broken inside,

I'll be there, to hold the pieces.

I will always be by your side..."

"Nothing bad can happen…As long as we stay together…" She finished in a breathy, vulnerable sob. Slowly raising her face from the ground, revealing tired, red rimmed eyes and wet tear tracks down her cheeks. Fresh tears now trickling down, dripping off her chin.

Catra barely had the last word spoken before Adora lunged. Not waiting to be given permission this time. So overcome by the serenade of grief and hope in Catra's voice. Adora was spurned to act. Wrapping her arms desperately around Catra's neck. Melog backed off in an instant, as Adora's weight and momentum carried Catra to the ground. She pressed her lips against Catra's mouth in a fierce, pleading kiss. Seeking her forgiveness. Catra sobbed and kissed her back just as fiercely. Adora's crushing weight was a welcomed relief from the worry and heartache she had been enduring all night.

Bow had been brought to tears with her song. With a sniffle, he merely nodded and stood up. Their touchy feely bullshit was developing just fine. Perhaps he needed to give them space to have that heart to heart on their own. Brushing dirt off his pants with a sigh. "Well, ,my work here is done." He commented with a mild chuckle and headed off back to Darla. Giving the lovers some much needed alone time. He would be there for advice or just to listen, but they honestly didn't need him butting into their personal business. They were handling things just fine.

"I'm sorry…" Adora moaned, pulling away and rubbing the tears away from her cheeks angrily with the cuff of her long sleeve shirt.

"Stop, apologizing!" Catra snapped, the relieved smile falling into a scowl of reprimand.

"I am so sick of you saying sorry, every time you're honest with me about how you feel. You have every right to be angry with me, to be disappointed and hurt about how I treated you in the past…." Catra eyes flicked away in shame, her chin falling as she meekly rolled away from beneath Adora. "But I'm not that petty, cold hearted, resentful person anymore." She finished, "I'm not going to run away, or lash out at you...or seek revenge...like I did before." She heaved a shaky breath. "I want you to feel safe...and secure sharing with me...I want to know how you feel...no matter

how brutal or harsh...or how much it might hurt me. I want to know...ok." Catra glanced up, smiling softly. "I've never held back in regards to you...not with how angry I was, or how hurt I was, or my rather harsh opinions... or even the intensity of my love. I've been open and honest with all of it...I want you to do the same...ok." She finished her rant, with one last heaving gasp of air. Rubbing the heels of her hands into her eyes to quell the tears streaming down her face.

"Ok…" Adora answered weakly. Moving to sit before Catra. Crossing her legs and folding her hands in her lap. 'I love you….I never wanted to hurt you...I've just been so scared and angry...and hurt for so long…" Adora began, staring remorsefully down at her hands in her lap. "The last three years have been….brutal." She moaned and rolled her eyes.

Catra laughed and nodded, affirming silently that she agreed with that statement.

"We have so much to work out...don't we?" Adora heaved a shaky breath, casting her head back and staring up at the clear blue sky. That seemed to taunt her foul mood, with its bright, unfretted countenance. She stuck her tongue out at the sky, as she glared up at it in contempt.

Catra giggled in confusion at her childish antics, making Adora look down at her with a grateful smile.

"You can be the biggest dork on the planet, sometimes." Catra commented lightly.

"But I'm your dork." Adora added, flopping down on the sand and crossing her arms behind her head.

Catra laid down beside her on her stomach, resting her chin on her crossed arms.

"Want to talk about, some of that stuff?" Adora offered.

“Not really.” Catra moaned with dread, tenderly brushing away a strand of blonde hair that had fallen over Adora’s nose, back behind her ear. “I think you shared enough last night and I need a breather.”

“Ok…” Adora nodded. “But can I talk about She-Ra? I had another strange dream and I think finally I am going to find out everything about my magic and how to use it.”

“Really?” Catra’s interest peaked. “So no more freaking out and trying to use me like the Sword of Protection.” She tapped Adora between the eyes with a claw, smirking teasingly. As Adora groaned and squeezed her eyes shut in humiliation.

“I am so sorry...that was so out of line.” Adora winced with regret.

“I get it, you were scared and desperate. I wasn’t any help...either...I was freaked out about you transforming and overwhelmed by the expectation that I could just poof She-Ra into existence with a kiss.” Catra crawled back into a sitting position, far too nervous and uncomfortable with the conversation.

“Putting all that pressure on you was so unfair of me...I’ll never do it again. I promise.” Adora sat up and turned to face Catra. Crossing her legs again and staring down sheepishly at her fingers in her lap.

“Despara is….intense...the magic...is dark but not evil...it’s fueled by a righteous fury and this thirst for retribution...that is so violent and demanding. I’ve never experienced that kind of magic since the disc…infected the Sword.” Adora swallowed hard, instinctively reaching for Catra’s hand and clutching onto her firmly. Catra's touch was grounding and gave her courage to keep speaking.

“When that magic left...I felt so happy and free….I had no sense of consequences. I just did what I wanted, said what I wanted. It got worse because then I got really sad and I said things I would have never said...If I was thinking straight.” Adora admitted, with

a nervous laugh. “I will from now on...I’ll be open and honest with you...no matter what.” She cringed and ducked her head, feeling the heated glare of discontent flaring from Catra. As she released Catra's hand and then adjusted their hands, carding her fingers with hers. “Transforming into She-Ra...Is even more intense because it’s both sides of the magic...But I guess before with the Sword of Protection...I was only harnessing one side of the magic...Sheana...the light bearer…” She rambled...trying valiantly to put into words what she had experienced and what she had found out just recently in her latest dream.

She glanced up to find Catra staring in confusion at her.

"They gave me these bracer's to channel their magic, so that I would not have to summon the magic through my own body...they want me to learn from Raz, to train and get stronger first. Before they will let me transform into She-Ra again." Adora glanced briefly at each bracer with a bitter sweet smile.

"Good." Catra nodded and pulled a hand free to cup Adora's cheek, tenderly. Understanding that Adora would see this as a failure on her part, not being able to be She-Ra. Adora met her searching gaze with a small, sad smile.

“We have all the time in the world. For you to train and get stronger, to figure it all out and I will be there for all of it this time, I promise. ” Catra smiled softly, soothingly rubbing her thumb along Adora’s wet cheek bone. Seeking to wipe her tears away. “I love you too...dummy.” She finished playfully.

Adora gave her a watery smile, “Yeah…” she agreed, her eyes shining with hope and joy that she hadn’t ruined them. “Your song was beautiful…” She complimented Catra, as the feline crawled into her lap, curling up under her chin with a contented purr. Banishing all of Adora's worry, showing her that everything was ok between them by seeking cuddles. Needing to be in the security of her arms, feel the warmth of her skin and hear the soothing beat of her heart.

“Thank you...I spent all night thinking things out and writing down my feelings.” Catra offered, nuzzling into her neck. “Perfuma would be so proud...I calmed my mind and thought things through. I was able to create the ripples I wanted to make instead of just reacting to the pain and making things worse.”

Adora had no idea what all that meant, but she was happy with how things turned out so she was just going to enjoy it. She held Catra securely in her lap, petting a hand down her head and scratching her behind the ears, just how she loved. Listening to her purr grow louder, as she dosed. Her happy, secure feelings echoed from Melog. Their more common color's of deep lavender and electric blue had become more vivid, their mane fluttering vibrantly as they purred nearby.

It was a couple hours later, before Adora and Catra returned to the ship. Glimmer was standing in the shade under Darla’s forward bulkhead talking into her communication pad. While Bow was talking animatedly with Brojee at the end of the cargo ramp to Darla. Caz was just entering Darla at the top of the ramp, pushing something ahead of him. Bow’s arms were flying as he described something he was passionate about, while Brojee merely nodded in assent. Litha and Drissi, dashed down the ramp of their own busted up ship. Pushing a flat metal skid, with two small engines attached to the sides that made it hover between them. It was packed with an enormous amount of packs, sacks, boxes and larger crates.

“What’s going on? Adora inquired as they approached.

“Brojee’s ship may be unsalvageable.” Bow sighed, rubbing the back of his neck ruefully.

“My crew is unloading our cargo. We have salvaged tech and materials from other planets to offer your Scorpania Kingdom in trade for whatever old Horde components we may find in these

ruins you call the Fright Zone.” Brojee added, then turned to direct Litha and Drizzi as they entered the hold.

Catra chuckled, it looked like all the junk that was once cluttering the hold inside the kid’s ship was now going to be cluttering Darla’s hold. She gave Adora’s hand a quick squeeze before moving off to talk to Glimmer. As she glanced back a few steps later, she found Adora now hauling an arm full of random crates up Darla’s ramp. She was grunting under the weight, her blue eyes determined to give this task her all.

Catra sighed fondly, her girl was always eager to help, to prove how useful she could be.

As Catra approached, she slowed her gait. Glimmer had a hard, do not mess with me scowl shadowing her face. As she glared down at her communication pad, sucking in calming breaths as her nostrils flared. Catra hadn't seen her this angry, since their stand off in the compound in the Whispering Woods. Glimmer had nearly killed her that day, if it wasn't for Double Trouble coming to her rescue. Catra was honestly kinda scared to approach her.

“Scorpia...please..listen to me. You have to handle Sweet Bee carefully. She is already a bit of a xenophobe. Locking her up is only going to make her more scared to interact with the rest of the kingdoms.” Glimmer pleaded.

“She aided and abetted... a criminal. She was offered a chance to confess who the magicat was, where she was transporting them. She chose not to...so I locked her up just as I promised I would if she didn’t comply. We can’t take the chance she is working for Eternia? Meadowlands had no affiliation with the Horde or the Rebellion...she’s a loose cannon? Why can’t you see that?” Scorpia commented back, her voice was modulated as if barely hanging onto her own temper.

“I know you are only trying to protect Etheria...but we don’t need to go to war again with another kingdom…” Glimmer pleaded.

“I know what I’m doing Glimmer, I took a very extensive class in interrogation techniques. It’s all a part of Force Captain training. “ Scorpia responded, trying valiantly to ease Glimmer’s anxiety.

“Yeah, like waterboarding, electro shock, sleep deprivation…” Catra added with a playful smirk as she came into view. Giving Scorpia’s disgruntled countenance on Glimmer’s screen, a cocky two finger salute. Glimmer paled and stared at both of them nervously.

“Not helping, Wildcat.” Scorpia scolded.

“Relax Sparkles, Scorpia will keep the Meadowland Princess nice and comfortable till you arrive. Then she can deal with the new prisoners for the cell blocks. While you have a nice little tea party with Sweet Bee or whatever you princess do. ” Catra added, rolling her fingers in the air in a mockingly hoity- toity fashion. Then turned to regard Scorpia. “Ran into some more interlopers here on Beast Island..things got...dicey...but as always the Best Friend Squad and Flower Girl prevailed.” Catra raised a triumphant fist in the air, then pulled Glimmer into a sudden, firm side hug. By wrapping her arm around the shorter girl's shoulder.

“Ok...ok…here.” Glimmer handed the pad over to Catra. “I have a massive headache right now and I am not dealing with you guys shenanigans anymore.” She grumbled and shuffled away in defeat.

Catra laughed good naturedly, staring at Glimmer’s retreating back with concern.

“What did you do to Sparkles?” she asked, as she returned her attention back to the screen.

“We are having a disagreement of sorts.” Scorpia shrugged, “She does not agree with how Horde trained officer’s deal with suspected traitors.”

Catra's eyebrows raise in surprise, Scorpia's response was rather cold and blunt. This was the first time she had ever witnessed her acting like a true Force Captain. It was rather startling.

"Hear her out, Scorp'. These Princesses do things way different than us, but their way isn't wrong either...maybe try and compromise a bit." Catra offered.

"Sure, Wildcat, as long as it doesn't put further lives at risk." Scorpia agreed, then killed the communication as a small squad of guards entered the room behind her.

Catra had no idea what was going on back in the Fright Zone, but seeing a group of heavily armored soldiers suddenly enter a room was never a great sign.

Catra sighed and then routed a communication line to Entrapta's pad. It toned for a good long while, giving her time to settle into a cross legged position on the cooling sand as evening set in. Melog curled up at her side, allowing her to idly pet down their back. Preparing for this conversation to be rather awkward and uncomfortable. But Entratpa needed to know about the dead clones before she left the island.

Adora found her about an hour later, sitting further down the beach. Staring despondently out at the shimmering, evening sea. The sun was hovering just above the horizon, sunset was a good couple hours away. Illuminating the low lying clouds in a fiery glow, of deep orange, azure and indigo highlights.

Glimmer's communication pad was lying, face down beside her. Her index claw lightly tapped on the back, lost to her thoughts.

"We're all finished loading up Darla." Adora called, chucking a thumb back at the gleaming silver ship behind her.

"How did your talk with Entrapta go?" She added, when Catra didn't turn to face her.

“It went....She’s pretty focused on her First Ones research and other projects. Which are all important, I get that. But I just don’t understand her sometimes.” Catra sighed heavily.

“What do you mean?” Adora settled down next to her, wrapping a supportive arm around her waist. Joining her in watching the sea, roll lazily onto the beach.

“I found some dead clones in the jungle and I thought she would want to know, that she would want to bury them or something?” Catra leaned forward, scratching a claw into the sand. “She didn’t seem to care at all….stating that it was up to Wrong Hordak and his brethren what they wanted to do about the bodies. A group of clones are headed here on a transport in the next few days to deliver tools and supplies from Dryl. She is adamant she wants to set up a permanent base of operations here.” Catra leaned her head against Adora’s shoulder.

“Well, she’s got Holo-Hordak now...what more does she need?” Adora commented dryly.

Catra laughed softly and smiled at the nickname, leaning back to rest her head against Adora's shoulder.

“I hate the idea of them just rotting out there, to be picked apart by beast island predator’s.” Catra groused.

“Maybe the clones will take them back up to the Skytree?” Adora offered, cupping her cheek with a hand fondly.

“Maybe...but I doubt it. Clones are not sentimental...they see themselves as tools, merely parts of the machine that Prime built.” Catra groaned, having an unsavory understanding of the Hive Mind since she had been a part of it.

“Have a little faith in Wrong Hordak, he’s more sentimental than most of us.” Adora observed, her voice soft and forthright.

“You're right, I once caught him getting all teary over burnt dumplings on the way home. He will take care of his brothers.”

Catra nodded, then glanced at Adora. More than ready to leave Beast Island and it's troubles behind her. Adora stood up and reached out for her, Catra smirked and grabbed Glimmer's pad. Raising an arm to take Adora's hand, who pulled her up and they proceeded to Darla hand in hand.

Reunion

Chapter Notes

> This is an extra long chapter for you to enjoy! Since I will be going on hiatus for a couple weeks. Thank you all for the kudos and comments. I shall return in the New Year.

Fourth year of Junior Cadet Training…

Catra combed her claws roughly through her thick, wild mane. Brushing errant strands out of her face with irritation. Her long hair had become a nuisance, always falling over her eyes and getting in the way. For the last few months, Adora had been attempting to tame it with one of her elastic bands before training scenarios. By pulling it back into a ponytail similar to her own hairstyle. But Catra's hair was so thick it just snapped the band eventually. Always at the worst times, like now! In the middle of a very important combat test! She was so sick of being so close to ranking number one and having it taken away, for one stupid reason or another. She did not need her hair getting in her way! An odd, angry, irrational thought burst into her mind. Suddenly wondering if Adora was giving her already weakened elastics, that she had already used, just to sabotage her? So she would have less competition and be able to maintain her place as Shadow Weaver's favorite. Catra quickly squashed those ideas, she didn't ever want to think that way towards her Best Friend. She would never do that! With a growl, Catra stopped combing her hair out of her face. She was giving up on ponytails...permanently.

She was hidden beneath a huge oak tree, nestled in a sunken patch of mossy ground, under the crook of several crawling roots. Dressed in her favorite red sleeveless tunic, with the white over her chest. It was still in good condition but her grey shorts were starting to fray along the hem. Catra figured Shadow Weaver would wait until that garment was nearly shredded before giving

her a new pair. Or hopefully, Adora would out grow her current pants and she would get those.

Catra growled, adjusting the straps on her sensor vest. The bulky piece of equipment did not fit her slender frame and was always sliding off her scrawny shoulders. The smaller sensor's on either side of her waist were less of a nuisance since they were attached to a belt she could adjust properly. Her dark ear's twitched, as she heard rustling sounds coming from further ahead. The VR goggles she had to wear because of her large ears was a nuisance and an distraction. The elastic strap loosened every time her ear's moved. With a growl she adjusted them back into place to see the holo-landscape clearly. Her strike team was in the middle of the Whispering Woods playing out a survival scenario in the simulator. It was like hide and seek and tag...but way more violent and the stakes as always were pretty high. Since their times, stealth abilities and hand to hand combat were being assessed and their ranking was on the line. Their performance was also going to be reported back to Hordak. Cadet assessments were a seasonal occurrence now that they were older. Every cadet in every squad was ranked from first to last. Currently, Catra was second and she did not want to lose her standing. She had her goals set on gaining first place in her squad before the yearly trials. So that she could take over as squad leader and command the Red Squad to victory. Shadow Weaver would finally see that she was worth something. Adora had been ranked first and became their squad leader years ago. While she had been ranked second for the last few years. But this year, she felt she had a chance to finally beat Adora. To prove to Shadow Weaver and Lazlo and even Hordak that she was the best, the strongest, a cadet worthy of receiving praise and accolades.

Just like Adora!

Catra darted her eyes down to her quarterstaff, laying on the leaf litter at her feet. The day moons were high overhead, but the lush canopy was so thick that it blocked most of the light. The countless shards of light was fractured and danced over the underbrush like tiny flickering motes. It was rather hypnotic if you

stared at it too long, so Catra huffed and shut her eyes for a moment gathering her resolve to break cover. Her keen hearing, sense of smell and natural agility had given her an advantage so far. With the ability to move silently high up in the branches, she didn't give away her position as easily. As the others who had to move along the ground. But the elastic band that had kept her hair in check had just snapped. With her sight suddenly obscured while she was high up in the canopy. She had misjudged her last leap and fell short of her intended branch. Landing off balance on a branch far below were she had intended to land and promptly lost her footing. Tumbling to the ground, hitting every damn branch on the way down, making one hell of a noise. Wounded and in pain. She had quickly hidden herself beneath the roots, checking over her scraped up elbows and knees bitterly.

But someone had heard her and was drawing close to her position. She could hear the soft rustling of footsteps, creeping closer.

Catra gripped her quarterstaff tight to her chest, her eyes darting along the underbrush in front of her hiding spot as the footsteps got louder then stopped.

She had two options, stay and fight or try to run. Her ears twitched again as a new sound echoed from a different location. The sharp snapping of branches, announcing that it was more than one squad mate hunting for her.

Running might not be an option now, gritting her teeth. Catra eased herself out of the maze of roots as quietly as she could, but the dried leaves still crunched softly under her bare feet.

A strange bird call sounded from the left, she held her staff outward to parry any kind of threat. When nothing came, she chose a direction at random and ran for it.

Using her staff to bat the low hanging branches away, as she sought to put distance from her squad mates. The bird call echoed from the left, so Catra darted right. Then a few meters

away another bird call straight ahead. So she veered left, ducking under some low branches of a prickly pine. Darting into the tall grass and overgrown bramble at the edge of a small glade. She was quick to ascertain the bird calls were from Ami and Arron. They were working in tandem to herd her somewhere or freak her out enough to break cover. Staff Sergeant Lazlo explained that this was a test of survival, cunning and single combat. So it was against the rules to work as a team. But the twins never played by the rules. Absolutely incapable of doing anything without the other. They had formed an alliance to take her out and wreck her ranking!

Catra was not going to lose to them, or Adora. Snarling in frustration, Catra minimized her staff and sheathed it on her hip, lunging for the nearest tree that had branches strong enough to hold her weight. Swinging onto the lowest branch of an ancient oak, whose limbs were as thick and sturdy as the metal beams that reinforced the roof of the Barracks. That she ran across, to move unseen when she was making an escape to avoid punishment or just to get into position to pounce on Adora before lights out. When she came back from some special tutoring, that she constantly got from Shadow Weaver. Catra continued to leap up into the higher branches with ease. Needing to survey the forest and get a bead on those cheating Twins.

As she crouched within the upper canopy, scanning the rolling hills of endless trees. She couldn't help but see the beauty of the Whispering Woods. The scenario was set in the cool season. The forest was a patchwork of colors. The oaks still stoically wore their dark green leaves. While the maple and beech leaves were already tinged a coppery red, proudly showing off their dying mantle. A light breeze tossed the branches, wafting the sour scent of sweat and anticipation under her sensitive nose. Catra grinned and purred softly, her keen eyes quickly catching sight of movement in the heavy underbrush just below her tree. Catra watched with a smug grin as the holographic bushes, heavy with berries. Flickered and parted in two diverging paths. Just as she had assumed. It was Ami and Arron. They stumbled out of the bramble a few yards away from her tree. Each wearing white t-

shirts with red sleeves and grey training pants. Sporting the sensor vest over their chests and sensor belt around their waists. They were not prepared for battle. As their quarterstaffs were still latched to their utility belts, still to focused on tracking her down. Their eyes were cast downward, scanning the forest floor for something. Perhaps looking for her footprints? Which would have suddenly disappeared several miles back when she had taken to the trees.

"Gotcha now." Catra hummed smugly, crawling down, deeper into the sheltering concealment of the canopy. Only making it down her branch a few feet, before a small stone whistled past her head. Striking the bow of the branches she was on with a dull thump. Catra yelped and ducked, swinging low to the next set of branches as several more stones flew past her. The sharp whistle of the projectiles, making her sensitive ears fold back against her head. The lower she climbed the less foliage she had for cover, as the tree was already molting for the cold season. So she was suddenly an easy target, unable to navigate down the twisting branches fast enough to avoid the constant barrage of stones. That was now hitting the branches on all sides, caging her in near the trunk. She was struck, hard in the shoulder. Curled up in the narrow elbow of two twisting branches, close to the trunk. Forced to shield her face with crossed arms, as she snarled and yelped in pain under the barrage of stones striking her body.

"No fair!" Catra cried, as stones pelted her arms and legs.

A loud, abrasive bird call was her answer. Then an excited, answering bird call several seconds later. The twins had her pinned down, with nowhere to run and no way to defend herself.

Catra needed to get out of this...but how. She lifted her arms a little, making a crack she could see out of. Finding both twins standing at the foot of the tree, picking up stones and hurling them at her.

Ami's long dark hair was tied back in a thick braid that snapped like a whip every time she bent down to retrieve a stone. Her

sweet, doll-like features were flushed from the hours of exertion trekking through the forest all afternoon. Her demeanor was calm and calculating, moving only slightly as she found more stones. Taking aim and striking Catra with precision on the arms and legs, trying to make her fall. While her brother, Arron was a hyper, spastic mess. Dancing on his toes and snapping up stones in sharp frantic movements all around the base of the tree. Then hurling them all at her in a constant barrage for a few moments, that struck her haphazardly all over her body. The barrage would stop as quickly as it started as he sought to retrieve more ammo. He was a male replica of his sister, with short dark hair neatly trimmed over his ears. The same pale skin, flushed with excitement and dark blue eyes that looked almost black. Shining with glee at their triumph. Soon this game would be over and he and his sister would be the victor's!

Catra was trapped, hissing and snarling at them. Her tail lashed and puffed up in fear and frustration. But if she was going to win this, she couldn't lose her cool. She needed to endure this assault and find a way to flee or fight back. With a low growl, she unfurled herself from her tight ball. Intent on crawling around the trunk, to the back, so it could shield her better. But as soon as she uncrossed her arms in front of her face, she got a good sized rock square between eyes. White spots clouded her vision as she grunted and slipped sideways off the branch. Landing in the leaf litter, dazed and unfocused. Barely able to think straight, the throbbing pain now building inside her head was overwhelming. She grimaced as Ami stood over her, tapping the end of her extended quarterstaff onto her chest sensor.

"You got her!" Arron exclaimed, dashing to his sister's side, who smugly looked up and tapped the end of her staff against his chest sensor. As he charged towards her.

Arron stood in blank surprise, gazing down at the red x now flashing on his sensor. His mouth hung open in disbelief that his sister would do that.

(Ami is our winner!) Lazlo's voice echoed out over the simulation as it flickered and faded away. Leaving the now four cadets in an empty room. Adora sat dejectedly, a few feet away, her chest sensor already glowing with a red x. As the treacherous twins had got her first.

"Are you alright?" Adora's worried voice penetrated the thick fog clouding Catra's brain. As the blonde rushed to Catra's side, as she lay sprawled and seething on the floor. The panicked blonde quickly knelt beside her, hands hovering nervously over her stomach, unsure how to help.

Catra winced, ripping the now cracked lenses of her VR goggles off her head and tossing them aside. Adora sounded far away or underwater. Lying prone on the floor, the overhead spot lights were glaring into her eyes making her even more dizzy. She rolled her head to the side, giving Adora a furiously disgruntled look.

"They cheated…" She slurred, desperately trying to stay conscious. As the spots in her vision began to grow, making thinking and speaking difficult.

"I know…" Adora agreed, wrapping an arm around her shoulders and hauling her up to her feet.

The metal doors to the simulator hissed open as Lazlo strode in. It was the cold season and he had allowed his dark hair to grow out and hang over his ears. A full beard peppered with grey covered his face. Making his brown eyes even more stern and piercing.

"Fall in Cadets!" He shouted. Their strike team had started out as five, with Tama. Now it was just the four of them.

Ami and Arron dashed to him, standing stiffly at attention. While Adora guided a barely lucid Catra towards their Staff Sergeant.

"Very good, use of strategy and cunning. Ami. I shall report this win to Hordak."

Ami grinned broadly, puffing out her chest with pride. It was rare to get the upper hand on Adora, even Catra. They were the best soldiers in the Red Squad.

"Ami cheated…it's not fair…." Catra slurred, drunkenly. A huge discolored bump was forming on her forehead, making her squint. Her eyes tearing up from pain, not from disappointment.

"She did not cheat, Catra. This was an exercise of survival, if you are ever trapped behind enemy lines you must use everything and everyone at your disposal to get out alive."

Lazlo instructed.

"But…" Adora started to protest, but Catra interrupted her as she made a low, gurgling sound. Adora was bracing her against her side, having hung Catra's arm over her shoulder and holding onto her hand to keep her upright. The sick sound turned into a loud, wet, heave. As Catra's body curled forward and then she deposited the contents of her stomach all over the floor.

"Ewww…" Ami moaned, as Arron looked on in both horror and regret at hurting Catra so badly. It had been his sister's idea to team up and throw rocks at her to get her out of the tree. The exercise had been everyone for themselves, he regretted teaming up. He had paid the price for trusting her, too. Next time he promised, he would think for himself.

"I got to take her to the medic…" Adora moaned, guiding Catra out of the doors. The hybrid's feet shuffled, as the world spun in sickening circles.

Catra ended up with a concussion and a few days of bed rest in the infirmary. It was the most boring time of her life. She had tons of little bruises on her arms, legs, torso and a big ugly one across her forehead. But Adora came and visited her often. They would laugh and plan out their coming prank of retaliation against the twins. Ami and Arron would not get away with what they did

without due punishment. It was late in the evening when Catra was finally released from the infirmary. The day moons had set behind the slender towers of the refinery complex, casting the Fright Zone in long, dark shadows as night loomed. The halls inside the barrack compound hummed to life, as the artificial lights came on. The small round bulbs embedded into the curving tin roof of the hall flickering as they charged up. Creating an eerie strobing for a few moments as their footsteps echoed in the empty corridor. The inner, winding corridors of the Fright Zone were gloomy and kinda scary at twilight. The halls were void of all life, all the patrols were already stationed on the outer battlements and most of the other soldiers were in the mess hall having supper. The strange industrial sounds of the base serenaded them as they walked. Pipes groaned as water and waste was moved, vents howled and boomed with hot air as the heat from the forge was channeled throughout the base.

Adora held Catra's hand, as they walked through the pale green metal corridors. Needing physical contact, to reassure her that Catra was alright and they were going home...together.

Adora started to chatter aimlessly about anything that came to mind, as Catra was distant and brooding. Glaring down at her bare feet, as Adora led her back to the barracks. She had a lot of time to think and had come to the conclusion that there was nothing fair in waging war. If she wanted to win, then she would have to be more cut-throat and cunning than her opponents. She had to be willing to do whatever was necessary to win. If Ami and Arron could get the better of Adora, then she could too. She just needed to adjust her tactics. Become more cunning, bend the rules of engagement to her advantage. Then she would win more often and gain Shadow Weaver's approval. Then the sorceress would no longer see her as a failure...she would have worth and would no longer have to worry about being disposed of. If Adora ever stopped liking her.

It was the first time she ever allowed herself to view Adora as her rival. Her eyes cut meekly over to Adora, who was aimlessly chatting away. About her days of training and classes that she had

missed. Happy and oblivious, her voice was bright and eager to get Catra to the mess hall before supper was over. At first Catra was conflicted and stared at Adora in shame. Her stomach roiled and a bitter taste had invaded her mouth. Would she have the resolve to start fighting dirty...just to win more often? Would Adora still want to be her friend? She was really mad at Ami for winning that way. Was it worth losing Adora, to have Shadow Weaver's approval? All of these thoughts burned inside of her, scalding her heart and making her eyes tear up.

Would winning be worth it in the end?

Catra never saw the twin's till lights out, when she was getting undressed for bed. She was pulling off her dark red and white t-shirt. When she felt a light tap on her bare shoulder. Whipping the shirt the rest of the way, over her head in alarm. She swiftly spun around to confront whomever it was. Now dressed in nothing but her grey undershirt and frayed shorts. Her lean body coiled to deal with yet another aggressive confrontation. Things in the bunk room had been tense between her and other's for several seasons. As they had gotten older the cadets were constantly pushing the boundaries with each other. Always in competition, always seeking to be the best at something. To earn praise and recognition from their superiors. So a pecking order had started amongst the cadets. The bunk room had become as hostile of an environment as the training yard. In which the stronger, asserted their dominance over the weaker. Not in a violent way, since Adora who was their leader and would never put up with that. But in more subtle ways, through intimidation both verbal and physical. Making sure the cadets beneath them in rankings knew their place. Catra was by no means one of the weaker kids, so she always had to stay on her guard. Always prepared to defend herself. Adora never had to worry about constant threats, since she was Shadow Weaver's favorite. The rest of the squad left her alone, they were all scared of the Sorceress and did not want to get punished by the Black Garnet, like Catra did.

“Come to gloat?” Catra sneered, flexing her fingers at her sides unsheathing her claws as a subtle threat for Ami to back off.

“Glad you’re back.” Ami folded her arms over her chest instead. She never flinched or even took a step back. Standing her ground and glaring down at Catra, with false bravado. Her win had bolstered her confidence and she refused to show weakness. Needing to prove that she was no longer intimidated by Catra’s claws. Not realizing that Catra could smell the stress sweat collecting under her armpits. Her keen heterochromatic eyes capable of noticing how Ami shivered under the her feral gaze. How the hair on her arms stood up and the gooseflesh spread across her skin.

Ami was also ready for bed, in a red undershirt and black shorts. Her twin hovering just behind her, dressed in the same manner. He was cowering behind her, his hands gripping his sisters shoulders, an index finger tapping anxiously on her collarbone. Wanting her to back off. Antagonizing Catra never turned out well for any of them. All of the squad wore scratches to prove it. As she had tagged all of them at one point or another over the last few years. Lonnie and Adora were the latest casualties to Catra’s anger. Sporting a set of long scratches across her nose and Lonnie under her jaw. They had long since healed, leaving only the scars behind.

“Enjoy it, cause I am never going to let you win ever again!” Catra snarled, leaning into Ami’s personal space. Enjoying the shiver of fear that coursed through the taller girl. Catra was the shortest in the squad with Ami only an inch taller. So her attempt at intimidation wasn’t as comical as it had been a week ago when she tried it on Atila. They had gotten into an argument about something out on the outer training yard before morning laps. He had merely chuckled and glowered down at the feline, who was hovering at chest level. Growling and hissing up at him. He then swatted her away like a bug. Catra had yelped and hit the chain link fence crumbling to her knees. As Atila did not always hold back his obscene strength and knocked her down hard. Catra had

been embarrassed and had run off for the rest of the day. Earning her a week of latrine duty, for skipping training and classes.

But as the cold season passed. Catra had kept that promise, beating both Ami and Arron in every training exercise, every test, every combat scenario. She didn't have the courage to fight dirty against Adora... yet. So she was never able to beat her, but she was working on it. With the warm season setting in. Staff Sergeant Lazlo came with order's for every cadet but Adora. To be escorted to the Infirmary for a blood test, he was also ordered to participate. The whole of the Horde Army had to have blood drawn. Then over the next few weeks. Specially chosen soldier's, Force Captains, even cadets from every squad were taken away to participate in a critical mission. Ami and Arron were so proud to be selected. Ami rubbed it in Catra's face every chance she got. Stating how special she and her brother were to be chosen, while Catra was just average because she wasn't chosen by Hordak. Catra was seething with jealousy. It never occurred to her that this mission might be deadly, since Shadow Weaver had made sure Adora was not involved. Until Ami and Arron never came back and Lazlo, who had also been chosen for the mission as well. Came back to the barracks, changed into some kind of beast. He was no longer human. His body was covered in a thin layer of blue fur, his hair replaced by spikes and his eyes had turned a brilliant yellow.

Suddenly Catra was relieved to have not been chosen. Adora had asked when Ami and Arron would be getting back. But Lazlo just said that they would not be returning and left it at that. Adora at this point knew not to push, but to accept and move on. Stuff just happened in the Fright Zone and you didn't question it.

The strike teams had to be reassembled. Levi, Max, Sara, Atila. Otis and Bryson were one team, While Adora and Catra, got Lonnie, Kyle,, Rogelio and Louis.

Twilight was falling, by the time Darla flew over the sprawling metal tower's of the Fright Zone. Catra had finished her evening serenade down in the hold just as they had passed over the deep canyons of the Dark Edge. With the hold so cluttered with crates and various chunks of alien wreckage the acoustics were gone. Her voice no longer echoed, but hung heavy in the air. Her song had sounded, hollow and rather bland. Her communion with Adarion had suffered because of it. Her connection to her element felt weak and the whole ritual was rather unfulfilling. Melog had accompanied her to the hold and promptly, curled up amid the cargo for a much need nap before touch down. So Catra left them there and returned to the command deck and took her regular place. Lounging on the wide side panels of Darla's control deck. Staring out of the huge side window watching the darkening sky. Adora sat in the command chair, once again immersed in a set of recordings, Entrapta had decoded from Arxia's server's. The tiny holo sphere, floated just above the arm controls of the chair. The slightly garbled voice of a long dead First One, droned on with a daily report about supplies from a Planet called Primus. They knew the planet by name only now but Adora's curiosity peaked. She wanted to learn more, learn everything she could about the tyrants who had first occupied Etheria. She began tapping impatiently on the arm control pad, searching for any recordings that had any mention of Primus or Eternia. Then filed them away in a list to listen to later. Noticing that Darla had just cleared the heavily fortified outer ramparts of the Fright Zones northern perimeter. She returned her focus back to the command deck, finding Bow speaking softly to Brojee and Caz in the corner. No doubt, strategizing where and what kind of tech they were going search for. While Glimmer and Perfuma were standing at the front of the deck. They were not speaking to each other, pretending to be more interested in the blinking controls in front of them. The tension was heavy and Adora was concerned. She had been given a short summary about what was happening back in the Fright Zone…Scorpania…and it wasn't good.

She had not taken sides and hoped she never had too. But things needed to stay peaceful. They had enough to worry about with

the whole Universe now knowing Etheria was back and wanting to pay them a visit. Each faction that had landed so far, seemed to have their own agenda. They did not need more trouble rising from a neighboring kingdom as well.

[Transmission coming in from an Allied frequency] Darla spoke abruptly.

Catra raised an eyebrow in mild surprise, as Adora cast her a disconcerting frown.

"Drissi, updated your communication system and tagged this ships com channel to the rest of our allied com-streams. He also added this Scorpania's com channel too, when we talked to them earlier to get permission to scrap in their kingdom." Brojee offered.

Adora merely nodded, "Patch them through."

[Welcome to Scorpania air space, Darla. We got you a landing permit for the northern Milita yard, just land anywhere. A strike team will meet you there to take custody of your prisoners.] A young man's voice echoed out of the sphere, polite and all business.

"Alright." Adora shrugged and rubbed the back of her neck nervously. Feeling a bit of emotional whiplash about how quickly. Formal relations with Scorpania as a real kingdom had come on. Scorpia rebuilding her kingdom had been just a hypothetical dream for so many weeks now, finally seeing it coming into fruition. It was a bit startling but not unwelcome. But the military build up that was now spreading out on the cement of the huge tarmac. Of the southern Militia storage yard was unwelcome. As they flew over the expansive tarmac, finding long lines of lamp posts once again fully lit. Glowing down upon numerous repair crews hard at work, repairing all manner of equipment. From tanks, Scorpion Cruiser's to Cargo hauler's and wheeled artillery cannons.

“What the hell happened in the last few days?” Catra asked quietly, not expecting an answer as everyone was wearing similar expressions of worry and concern. Leaping down from her perch and falling in with the rest of her anxious friends. The sudden turmoil of her emotions roused Melog and they quickly hunted her down. Just as they made their way down to retrieve their prisoner’s from the makeshift brig, they had set up in an old bunk room. Melog padded along side Catra near the back of the line, bunting her thigh softly in silent demand to know what was going on. Catra gave them a gentle stroke and with a tired sigh, gave them a quick overview of what they saw upon flying over the tarmac.

A contingent of fully armed and heavily armored soldiers. Met them as soon as they touched down on the tarmac of the militia yard. They wore the same grey and black colors of the Horde, but the symbol on their chest plate had been replaced with a red Scorpion stinger, curled to strike. They escorted the small group of mutant’s into a couple runner’s. No pleasantries were exchanged, the group of soldier’s were once again acting as if war was on the horizon. They had been quick and efficient in performing their duties. It was scary how easily the ex-Etherian Horde had reverted back into a military regime. Both Adora and Catra were left with sick feelings rolling in their gut. Glimmer was adamant about accompanying the prisoner’s directly to the prison. She climbed into a runner, never asking for permission. She needed to confirm that Scorpia had followed her order’s. Also smooth things over with Sweet Bee. Perfuma, Adora, Catra and Melog tagged along, jumping into another runner before it took off. Leaving Bow, Brojee and his crew. To scour the tarmac of broken war machines for viable parts.

The security in the cell blocks within the Scorpania prison, were now tripled and it required several levels of clearance just to enter the hallways outside the facility itself. Glimmer and the rest were not allowed to follow the guards inside the prison like last time.

Left to wait outside in the corridor, until they obtained clearance to enter the prison's holding area.

“What the hell?” Glimmer grumbled, arms crossed over her chest as she fumed.

“Something happened.” Catra advised, “After you left a bunch of soldier’s interrupted Scorpia’s call and she cut communication abruptly.”

Perfuma’s eyes flared wide in sudden fear, then she merely turned on her heel and dashed off.

“What is going on!” Glimmer ranted, as she watched Perfuma rush away. Her further tirade was interrupted by the heavy security doors suddenly sliding aside. Revealing Grizzlor, standing just behind. He was once again in full leather armor, with the Scorpania emblem on his chest instead of the Horde. His powerful furry arms were bare, the armor shredded accordingly just over his thick shoulders. He glowered down at each of them in turn. His feral, yellow eyes taking stock of each of them in turn.

“As the Queen of Brightmoon I demand to know if Sweet Bee had been released. As per my order this morning?” Glimmer was not intimidated by him in the least. Shrouding herself in the commanding aura of her royal title.

“She is under Scorpiana jurisdiction, as are the other prisoners you released into our custody. You have no authority here, Queeny.” Grizzlor snarled, folding his arms over his large chest.

Glimmer sputtered in astonishment, never expecting to be denied so flippantly.

“Grizzlor, this is important. If you will not let us in, then at least tell us what we want to know. We don’t want to start another war.” Adora moved forward, trying to be diplomatic.

As Catra darted her eyes downward at the sharp crackling of sparks, that were now dancing around Glimmer’s tight fists. Melog

grunted, acknowledging the rising tension by adjusting their position to stand in front of Catra. Catra snapped her gaze up to Grizzlor, hearing the faint rustle of his leather armor creaking as he adjusted his stance to defend himself if Glimmer attacked.

Things were going to escalate and get out of hand really quickly!

"We don't want a fight." Adora got in between Glimmer and Grizzlor, raising her arms up on either side of herself in a warding fashion.

Glimmer glared up at Grizzlor, her lavender's eyes burning with righteous fury. She would not stand to be treated this way. Scorpia had no right to deny her an audience with Sweet Bee.

"Is Sweet Bee still locked up?" Catra demanded. Her threatening scowl, as intimidating as it was when she was Second in Command of the Horde. Melog growled, their mane crackled an electric red in warning.

Grizzlor instinctively took a defensive step backward. "Yes…but I am only following orders."

"Where's Scorpia?" Glimmer demanded.

"I don't know…she left to think…" Grizzlor began to answer. But Catra jumped in and interrupted him.

"I was talking to Scorpia several hours ago, a bunch of soldier's barged into her quarters. What happened around here?" Catra snapped, lunging under Grizzlor's chin. With a threatening growl, tapping a claw against his collar bone.

Grizzlor blinked his tiny eyes rapidly, as sudden fear rushed through him.

"There was a breach in the southwestern quadrant of the fortress…whatever got inside. It's small, because it came in through a narrow waste-water pipe. That drains out of the munition factory complex out there ." Grizzlor rushed to answer.

“Alright, We’ll go check it out.” Adora nodded, glancing at both Glimmer and Catra to see if they were going to come along.

“NO!” Grizzlor shouted. “We have sent out several strike teams to search the area. We got surveillance bots prowling all the pipes coming out of those factories. Recommissioned bots are patrolling topside. Whatever or Whoever was stupid enough to try and infiltrate Scorpania. We will have it destroyed or in custody within the next twenty-four hours. We don’t want or need your ‘assistance’” Grizzlor declined their help in an indignant, yet polite manner.

Glimmer was absolutely fuming at this point. In less than a day, Scorpia had gone rouge. She was no longer treating her like a trusted ally. Perhaps their friendship was not as solid as she had thought.

“Fine!” She snarked, storming away.

Catra took a deep breath, pressing her index finger’s into her temples. Rubbing in vigorous circles as she felt a headache coming on. Melog whimpered and shook their head, trying to clear the dysphoria washing over them.

“Go back to your ship and wait for an audience with our Queen.” Grizzlor instructed, his deep rumbling voice was stern and broached no further argument.

Adora shook a threatening finger at Grizzlor, her mind spinning at the sudden turn around. “We’re not done here…” She sputtered, grasping Catra’s hand and hauling her away. Sensing the cat was seconds away from tearing into Grizzlor and storming the prison herself. Melog snarled and huffed as they retreated after them. Their body had ignited into orange flame, their mane flickering aggressively, as their tail lashed in fury.

They spent a restless night in Darla. On the tarmac within the Fright Zones old militia compound. Surrounded by rows of

obsolete and nearly destroyed military equipment. Along with recommissioned, siege machines that were now currently under repair. Ranging from tanks, skiffs, runners, cargo haulers, to wheeled artillery cannons. Scorpia had pulled many of the mechanics from their regular duties helping with the rebuilding effort. To resurrect what was left of the Horde's war machines back into operational service. It was disconcerting and filled everyone with dread. Perfuma never came back that night, which could be taken as neither a good or bad thing.

Glimmer had spent the next morning outside the prison's gate, trying to convince the guards to let her in, or let Sweet Bee out. Since she could not find Scorpia anywhere? It had been an effort in frustration only, they would not listen to her. The fact that she was the Queen of Bright Moon meant absolutely nothing to them. They only took orders from their senior officer, who they would not tell who it was. Or the whereabouts of their own Queen… Scorpia, who was currently MIA along with Perfuma.

Adora and Catra had a very important trip to get back to. So Glimmer was not going to derail them from it any longer. So she had bustled into Adora's room back on Darla just before lunch. Finding the two had gone out and tracked down their packs. Currently repacking them to make sure nothing had been stolen while they were unattended. Catra slung her pack over her shoulder, expelling a long drawn out breath of disdain. Before resolutely walking up to Glimmer.

"Scorpia likes to hide out up in Horror Hall when she's upset and needs to think. I bet she's up there." Catra offered, giving Glimmer a small, sympathetic smile.

"I got this…you two need to just relax and enjoy your time with your…fam…fri…Uhh.." Glimmer verbally stumbled hard. Not know how to categorize their relationship with Lonnie and the other's.

"Bunk mates…that's what we always called each other." Adora offered with a kind look. Taking Glimmer's hand, as she adjusted her pack on her shoulder with her other hand.

"Ok, let get this over with." Catra clasped Glimmer's other hand and squeezed her eyes shut. Just as the Queen blinked, sending Catra's stomach somewhere down near her knees and the world spun away in a sickening leap.

It was long after midday when Glimmer deposited them and their backpacks somewhere far south of the Fright Zone. They stood on the edge of a steep bluff, a wide, lush valley stretched out below them. The steep grades and inclines of rolling hills spread out towards the horizon, lit by the sun in a golden hue. Thick groves of magically grown trees were clustered deep in the center of the valley. Stretching out on all sides towards the furthest edge on the horizon. Proud stands of oak and beech trees shaded the heart of the forest. With supple maples and thin pale spruce in outlying groves. Their leaves had started to turn, rippling in the breeze in hues of pale yellow and rusty red. Wild ferns and berry bushes cowered among the trees, protecting and hiding the small animals that skittered and chirped out of sight. The soft sounds of small animals that had now migrated out of the Whispering Woods into new territory. Was a welcomed sound, drawing a proud smile upon Adora's face. The magic She-ra had channeled from the Heart back into the planet. Had brought this once barren wasteland back to life. The natural world was healing...and in time she had hope that the kingdoms could heal as well. She couldn't allow herself to wallow in her anger or her fears and doubts. It did no one any good, least of all her. She had let her sorrow and resentments fester like a ticking bomb inside her until she exploded. Nearly destroying her relationship with Catra. She was going to work harder to share her burden and communicate her desires. At least with Catra...

Glimmer never bid them goodbye or anything. Just teleported away in a cascade of angry sparkles to deal with an elusive Scorpia and a very irritated Bee Hybrid. That was infuriatingly, still incarcerated in a prison cell.

Adora glanced around the field of thick grass and wildflowers that stretched out below them. Scanning the flowing hills receding into the forest in the distance. Not seeing any sign of people passing through. Catra scanned the valley slowly, sniffed the air, along with Melog hoping to catch the scent of Lonnie or any of their other bunkmates. All she could pick up was the heavy smell of old wood smoke coming from closer to the river, that cut through this valley. That was now hidden amid the trees.

"This way." Catra vaguely pointed towards the hills, heading down a steep slope with Melog at her side. Slinging her pack over one shoulder. Her bare feet were nimble upon the soft ground, her toe claws digging into the steep grade of the earth, to keep her steady in the near vertical descent.

"What would I do without you?" Adora called, happily.

"Probably still be lost, in the Whispering Woods with that dumb sword." Catra called back sardonically. Her tone was light and playful, no longer holding that harmful edge it once had during their teasing banter during the war.

Adora chuckled, nodding. Stealing that skiff and getting tossed over the side had been a fateful adventure. But it had been Catra who had guided them out of the woods and drove them back to the Fright Zone. Worried she had brain damage from the fall. After babbling about some magic sword she found in the woods. So many of her adventures as a kid, began and ended with Catra. Just like her last adventure...to become She-Ra and save the universe. From now on, Catra would always be the constant, guiding star that she followed. Adora hefted her own pack and jogged after her.

"Hey! Wait up!" She shouted, stumbling down the slope as she dashed to keep up.

Adora was soon gawking at her beautiful surroundings. Remembering this valley more as a dried up canyon. Nothing grew within the Fright Zones borders back then. As the many industrial

factories inside the fortress had poisoned the soil decades earlier. Their small troop had been walking at a steady pace through a lifeless wasteland for days before reaching this valley. Running low on rations and more frighteningly low on water. Morale had been low, they had been tired, frustrated at losing the sophomore trials. The seething rage burning inside each of them at Louis's pointless death hadn't helped. They all wanted to just defect into the Crimson Waste that lay beyond the Scorpion Hills. They had argued and debated the risks. Being raised in an orderly, high security and predictable environment. Did not breed kids, prone to whimsy or running off into deadly deserts. That most Horde soldiers were sent to die in. It was not a risk they were willing to take. Also the rest of their squad was waiting for them to return. Already enduring punishments on their behalf. So leaving the Horde was never an option at the time.

So Adora had to keep their spirits up and focused on their mission. They were going to erect a monument with an epitaph and pay their final respects to all the squad members they had lost over the years. Then return to the Fright Zone, resolute to their own awaited punishment. So lost in her memories, Adora was soon lagging behind, making Catra slow her gait accordingly. They climbed to the top of a large hill, just before the summit. Catra stopped and took a tentative sniff of the air. Wanting to make sure she was tracking the smoke correctly. In case it had been picked up by the wind and carried from a different direction. In any case, from this higher vantage point she could scan the whole of the valley and maybe see the remains of their squad campfire from earlier.

As soon as they crested the hill, Adora's breath was taken at the majestic beauty this once dried up valley had become. The whole of the valley lay before them, a glorious tapestry of green fields, filled with the rainbow blankets of wild flowers. Thick groves of young trees and bushes, glistening with fat berries, were scattered over the hills. Far below near the very middle of the valley, was the bulk of the trees. All crowding around a huge willow tree in the center. It's branches bending in supplication towards a sparkling river, that ran like an ethereal ribbon of blue

threw the fields below. That tranquil river had been there years before and had been a very welcomed sight to the parched and travel worn teens. They had camped there for a couple days reluctant to leave and take their chances in the desolate landscape beyond. In the end they just followed the stream and it slowly led them to the sea. They had built their modest little monument there, amid the Scorpion Hills on a cliff overlooking a rugged portion of the Serpentine Straits. It was there they bid their childhood farewell. Remembering those they had lost along the way, by sharing sad, yet fond stories. Laughing and crying with each other, safe from the scrutiny of the other soldier's back in the barracks. Here in the wilderness, they were allowed to grieve and be weak with each other.

"They're all down there." Catra pointed towards the grassy bank of the river far below, deep inside the forest. A small tendril of smoke floating up into the clear blue sky above the canopy of the trees. The campsite was tucked away, on a natural embankment created by the tree roots of the giant Willow tree. That stood like a regal queen before the river, it's lush pink curtain of leaves an elegant crown flowing over the edge of the riverbank. Standing tall among the younger saplings that surrounded it. Holding back the full power of the fast moving river and protecting the young forest from being washed away.

Adora moved briskly down the shallow slope, finding Catra had not moved to follow. Standing stalled and uncertain at the top of the hill, staring out towards the river. Her expression was distant and forlorn.

"Catra, com'on Lonnie and the others have been waiting days for us to catch up." Adora called.

"I don't know about this…Lonnie, Kylie and Rogelio may have given us a pass. But the other members of our old squad may not." Catra moaned, her ears falling despondently as her tail wrapped around her waist. A clear sign of her discomfort and worry about the coming confrontation. Melog bunted her hip with their nose, with a small inquisitive meow.

“The sooner we can get things smoothed over the faster we can all become friends again.” Adora added, holding out her hand for Catra. Catra groaned rolling her eyes, she may be trying harder to keep her heart open. But she was still a realist, this was not going to turn out well. Adora's positive attitude and eagerness to resolve things was inspiring but ultimately it may blow up in her face. Their squad had been in combat for years against the rebellion. She doubted either of them would be welcomed warmly. As the Commander who repeatedly put them on the frontlines to die and the defector who chose to fight against them. Catra knew without a doubt the only thing that awaited them down in that campsite was disdain, hatred and rejection.

“Ok let’s get this over with.” Catra huffed, trotting down the hill with Melog on her heels. Dreading the moments to come.

They were soon enveloped by the forest as they headed towards the river. The air grew moist, as the thick canopy of interlocking branches hovered above them. The heavy mantle of the trees blocked the sky above. Shading them in a dim almost dusk like atmosphere. Adora was nearly blind in the heavy shade, instinctively reaching out for Catra’s hand. The feline was more than eager to hold her hand and take the lead. Walking confidently forward, her eyes glowing in the half light. Adora focused upon the large trees. Their base was covered in a layer of purple moss. As if they had been growing here in this lush valley for decades.

A lazy stream flowed a few meters away, beside them. The water trickled softly down the slow slope of the forest. The water was clear, sparkling in the faint light. The stones beneath the water shimmered. The surface disturbed from time to time by insects and small frogs. The overgrowth of bushes and boggy patches that ran beside the stream, hid even more small frogs. Their beady eyes blinked from the shadows. Curious at the new visitors to their secret home.

“This place is beautiful.” Adora gawked openly at the forest surrounding them. Trusting in Catra to lead them. As she skirted around the fat trunk of an oak tree, moving them cautiously threw it’s maze of roots.
“The magic from the Heart...is changing Etheria everyday.” Catra added, glancing briefly up at the canopy. “Returning the planet to its natural state, I figure.” she mused in a low whisper. “But Scorpania a thousand years ago was not this green and it definitely did not have forests...so it’s not like it’s returning the planet to how it once was.” Catra oddly wondered if that was because of the First Ones tampering?

Adora merely nodded. “In a way, it’s like She-Ra just hit a reset button.” She chuckled, giving Catra’s hand a small affirming squeeze.

Catra stopped and glanced over her shoulder, paying Adora a curious look. Her comment had more meaning than just an idle observation.

“Did you ever wish we could reset the past?” Catra asked, softly. She wanted to know if Adora ever wished to change how things had gone wrong between them or had she just accepted it and tried to move on.

“Yes...and No.” Adora shrugged. “Sometimes...I would imagine She-Ra could give me the power to go back and change some of my stupid decisions. In the hope that things would turn out better.” Adora remarked, her mind bringing up several outcomes she would love to change. Thaymor...The Crystal Castle...Princess Prom...The Portal….the list goes on and on.

Catra chuckled and released a long drawn out breath, shaking her head ruefully.

“I try not to think like that anymore...but I had wished to change our past too. After the Portal…I stopped fantasizing about it.” Catra took a deep breath, one of her upper fangs hooking on her lower lip to stop it from trembling.

Adora noticed how upset she suddenly got.

“That Portal reality…it wasn’t real, Catra.” Adora offered, not understanding that that fractured reality had been Catra's deepest wish made real. She had Adora back, they were both still in the Horde and they were going to rule Etheria together.

“Everything went wrong anyways…always does.” Catra heaved a great breath, “ It’s not productive to dwell on what ifs and could have been's. We can’t fix what went wrong in the past, but we have hopefully learned from it. So we can make better decisions now.” She finished casting Adora a bitter sweet smile over her shoulder.

“Wow...” Adora moved astride her, bumping her shoulder playfully. “How insightful.” She mocked, playfully.

Catra cast her a less than amused frown. She knew her revelation was rather obvious for most people, but it had taken her a long time to come to terms with it. She had no choice but to live with her mistakes and try to move forward with a better purpose.

“Watch it!” Catra warned, wobbling slightly on loose stones near the stream as Adora’s brute strength unbalanced her. “You’re going to dump us both in the creek.”
“Right..” Adora cast the shallow water a conspiratorial glance.

“No...nope...not going to happen!” Catra released her hand and darted forward out of her reach. Already anticipating her subtle scheme to yank on her arm and toss her into the water. The creek would barely reach her ankles and she would mostly just get splashed over her knees. A rather minor inconvenience, but she wanted Adora to work for it. She also wasn’t ready to deal with the consequences of her actions, concerning their old bunk mates and hoped to have a little fun and to stall a while longer.

Laughing playfully, Catra tore away from Adora, her tail raised high and waving merrily. Leaping over roots and quickly disappearing into the woods with Melog on her heels.

Adora was quick to engage, laughing and eagerly giving chase. Darting around a fat oak following Catra’s taunting calls and happy laughter. She caught a shimmer just to the right, near the edge of the creek.

“Hey! No turning invisible, that's cheating!” Adora yelled, as she turned and watched Catra’s footsteps splash lightly across the water to the mossy bank on other side. Her footprints indenting in the soft muddy embankment, briefly before disappearing all together into the heavy foliage of ferns and maple trees.

Catra's response was a quickly fading laughter of merriment. That only spurned Adora’s competitive nature. With a growl she charged across the creek, ducking under some low branches. Intending on capturing her wily girlfriend through pure gile and stubborn determination. The game of chase continued through the underbrush, as Adora darted her eyes about. Catching sight of Catra shimmering into view, casting her a teasing smirk. As she ducked out from behind the slender trunk of an elm tree. Giggling with ever rising amusement at how lost and frantic Adora’s attempts to find her had become. As soon as Adora would catch a glimpse of her and rush in her direction. She would shimmer away and run off laughing gleefully. The game continued late into the afternoon. As Catra wove them in a lazy arc towards the campsite. The sun was setting behind the hills on the far side of the valley. When Adora, out of breath and exhausted. Was ready to call it quits and just sit down anywhere and admit defeat. Finally figuring out Catra had been stalling, not wanting to face Lonnie and their other bunk mates.

Then she caught sight of Catra’s tell-tale shimmer just to the left, beside a large beech tree. Feinting that she hadn’t noticed, Adora pretended to bumble onward slightly to the right of the tree. Only to lunge left at the last second and grapple at her girlfriend blindly. Catra squealed in both alarm and exhilaration as she shimmered into view. Melog’s rumbling laugh could be heard from nearby. Adora’s hands had unintentionally cupped both of Catra’s breasts and she had pushed the feline up against the rough bark of the beech tree. That was rooted just behind her, standing tall

like a stalwart sentry. The branches were thick and twisted into natural cradles. If they were needing to sleep off the ground to avoid predators or enemy patrols. Adora knew this was the kind of tree she would climb, to sleep safely in.

The softer hues of twilight were filtering down through the branches. Casting Catra in a gentle, somber light. That softened her striking beauty into something truly breathtaking. Catra was panting, her gorgeous lips were parted slightly, inviting Adora to kiss her. The felines cheeks were flushed from their game and perhaps arousal. Her mismatched eyes glowing in the semi-darkness as she stared wide eyed up at Adora. Catra was quick to cover up how submissive she felt, pinned so aggressively to the tree. By Adora roughly grabbing her breasts. The excitement of the chase fading, replaced by simmering lust for more. Having the blondes face so close to her's, Adora's hot breath puffing against her cheek. Her glorious scent overwhelming Catra instantly. Back was that mischievous twinkle in her eyes, that unwavering smugness that she could regain the upper hand. If she wanted too.

“You caught me.” Catra purred, yielding with a sassy smile. “Now what are you going to do with me?”

Adora huffed, out of breath, suddenly very flustered. Her cheeks already flushed from exertion became even more red. She had been one step behind Catra for hours. Scrambling and bumbling around the forest like a lost idiot trying to find her. As the more agile feline toyed with her, leading her around and around. This was her opportunity for some pay back and she was not going to pass it up. Adora quickly regained her composure, a cocky smirk pulling on her lips. She could feel the hard nubs of Catra's nipples. Pushing against the cotton material of Catra’s white training shirt. Unable to resist, Adora deftly swiped her thumbs across them. Catra gasped, her pupils dilating as she stared up at Adora in both awe and wonder at how bold she was being. The shy, awkward phase of their relationship was behind them. Adora had confidence now and a plan. She slowly slid her hands away from Catra’s breasts, trailing her fingers seductively up Catra’s slender

neck with a soft, knowing smile. As the feline's breath hitched in expectation. Adora leaned her arms against the tree on either side of Catra's head, caging her in. As she pressed herself firmly against Catra's more slender body. Rubbing their breasts together briefly, showing Catra how turned on she was as well.

"Your stalling." Adora whispered accusingly against the velvet tip of Catra's ear.

Catra whimpered, squeezing her eyes shut as she clamped down on the rising heat, pulsing between her legs. Swallowing a couple times to clear the needy whine from her throat. She snaked her hands up and cupped the sides of Adora's face. Drawing her down into a passionate kiss. Her lips moved in wanton, needy movements against Adora's. Then just as abruptly as she began to kiss her. She pulled away, to whisper seductively inches away from Adora's lips.

"Maybe I just wanted to play?" Catra responded, biting Adora's lower lip and tugging on it, with an impish grin before letting go.

Adora suddenly felt a jolt of arousal deep in her core, that rippled alluringly throughout her body. She groaned, slamming her lips forcefully against Catra's. Sweeping her tongue inside and dueling with her unable to contain the roaring passion the hybrid had ignited. It would be alright..if they were a little later. They could take a small break for a while. After their last intense emotional breakthrough, they both needed to reclaim that physical connection. That confirmed that they loved each other, needed each other and would never let go ever again. Lonnie and the other's wouldn't mind, they were days late already. What was a few more hours.

Catra arched her back, as Adora slid her tongue into her mouth. Her hand flew up to grip the blonde's shoulders, as she teased Adora right back with her own tongue. Lapping and licking in sharp, alluring motions that had Adora moaning loudly with need. As soon as the passionate kiss ended, Catra ducked her face into the arch of Adora's neck. Inhaling on instinct, bathing in the rich,

warm scent that engulfed her. Her sharp teeth grazed the soft flesh against her pulse point. Adora whimpered as Catra's lips began to kiss the tender spot behind her ear. The heat of Catra's breath tickled her skin, making her shiver. Gripping the back of Adora's shirt tighter she pressed herself closer. One of Adora's knees slid up between her legs and settled just below Catra's sex. The whisper light friction, sending sparks of pleasure to shoot through the smaller cat girl.

"Ah," Catra cried out with pleasure, pulling away from Adora's neck. Arching away and throwing her head back as she basked in the euphoria now rushing through her. As Adora moved her leg with just a hint of force. Rubbing her knee against the heat between Catra's legs. Catra's body trembled in response, as the friction caused the sensitive nub hidden in the folds there to throb and pulse at the stimulation. Then Adora buried her head in the curve of Catra's neck and shoulder. Breathing heavy, her strong arm moved down and slipped around Catra's waist bracing her securely. So Catra could shift her weight upon her knee, rubbing herself lightly in the ways she needed most. Her arms locked around Adora's neck for added support. As she rocked wantonly upon her thigh. Closing her eyes and tucking her face into the crook of Adora's neck, as she focused on pleasuring herself. Panting and needy, she keened softly as she chased that explosion of pure bliss. She had only experienced once before on Mystacor.

They were so immersed in one another that neither heard the whisper of leaves or the crack of twigs of an intruder. Movement just on the periphery of her vision, snapped Adora out of her fog of pleasure.

She moved like lightning, pulling away from Catra. Her maroon cloak snapped like a war banner. Spinning to confront the threat and unsheathing her quarterstaff from her back in one fluid movement.

"Calm, down girl!" Lonnie's easy voice and amused laughter floated from just out of view deeper in the trees. "I saw

movement up here from our campsite and came to investigate. Never imagined I'd get to watch you two having sex against a tree."

Adora instantly turned red and ducked her face in humiliation. Rubbing the back of her head with one hand nervously. As Lonnie emerged from the underbrush, her hazel eyes dancing with mirth, a huge grin gracing her full lips. Melog slunk off, head low in humiliation. Their whole body glowing a pale pink as they disappeared into the concealment of the forest.

"Lonnie…" Catra's warning tone echoed out from behind Adora. Who had unconsciously shielded the smaller woman on instinct. Which only made Lonnie's smile widen slyly. "Don't stop on my account, the show was just getting good." She teased.

"Anyone up there!" Kyle shouted.

Lonnie smirked, then she turned, cupping her hands to the sides of her mouth. " I caught Force Captain Catra fraternizing with a Rebel. I think we should court-martial her for treason."

Catra was off the tree and darting for Lonnie in seconds. Lonnie giggled and sprang to the side, weaving through the trees in the same taunting manner Catra had used against Adora.

"Her tongue was so far down Adora's throat. I thought our old Squad Leader was going to choke!" Lonnie shouted, ducking and weaving behind more slender elm trees, further down the rugged decline of the path.

"Shut up!" Catra screamed, valiantly trying to tag Lonnie with her claws as she swiped blindly around the trunks.

"Catra...calm down." Adora pleaded, trotting down the narrow, worn foot path after the two would be combatants. Lonnie always knew how to push Catra's buttons and Catra had so little restraint to teasing. This was only going to escalate into a real fight. That would leave Lonnie nursing some bad scratches and Catra feeling horrible about losing her temper.

Catra chased Lonnie down the overgrown path of roots and loose stones by the stream. Screaming promises of imminent pain and bodily harm. The stream that had lazily wound its way through the forest earlier. Was now moving faster, becoming more rocky, more violent. Catra was chasing after Lonnie with a single minded focus, not paying attention to how the water was changing. Water roared beside her, slamming against large rocks along the bank. Before it tumbled off even larger rocks ahead, frothing a little further on as it then dropped out of sight abruptly. Catra watch in horror, as suddenly Lonnie jumped to the side of the footpath. Catra was going too fast, her heels slipping on the loose dirt. When the path suddenly ended into a vertical drop. The water beside her turned into a roaring waterfall, disappearing into a cloud of mist that hovered in the air. As the water crashed down into a clear pool of a larger river below.

Catra was in free fall, her arms pin wheeling and legs kicking. As she fell over the edge of the cliff, disappearing into the mist below.

"I hate you Lonnie!" She screamed in terror as the spray drifted up and dampened the fur on her face. She spun in mid air, pulling her pack off her shoulders and heaving it at Lonnie with all her strength. The smug dark skinned woman was standing a little further down the foot path that hugged the side of the steep cliff next to the waterfall. Lonnie's highly amused laughter was cut short with a grunt, as the heavy backpack hit her full in the face. Lonnie stumbled backward off the path near the edge of the cliff, tripping on a root and landing on her ass in the bramble.

"Catra!" Adora shouted in dismay as she skidded to a halt at the edge of the cliff. Staring forlorn into the rolling cloud of mists, searching the frothing pool far below for her girlfriend.

When suddenly the back of her neck was clutched in an iron grip and she was hoisted up off her feet.

"What the hell!" She hollered in fright, twisting her body to try and free herself. As her hands clawed at the thick green scaly

fingers holding her up by the back of her neck and now dangling her over the side of the cliff.

Rogelio growled softly near her ear, making her moan in dread.

She nodded in acceptance that this was to be her punishment along with Catra for being late. As he merely slipped her backpack off her shoulder so it wouldn't get wet, then dropped her. She fell screaming into the pool below.

Her voice silenced as she hit the frigid water feet first. She was under the surface in seconds, mouth clenched tight as the water surrounded her. The fading light made the water dark and murky. When she went under all she could see was blackness. A jolt of panic shot through her for a moment before she kicked up towards the surface. Sputtering and gasping for air, she blinked away the droplets clinging to her eyelashes. Catching sight of Catra's sleek form already swimming towards the rocky shore.

She followed the tell-tale splash of Catra's arms and legs as they cut through the dark water. Once she was crawling onto the spongy shore, of mud and moss. Catra leaned down and helped her up. They trudged through the damp earth, towards the roaring campfire, flickering further up the embankment.

"About time you love birds showed up." A sarcastic deep voiced drawl called from inside a tent just beyond the fire.

Catra and Adora slumped onto a large flat stone set before the fire. Their waterlogged clothes quickly dampened the warm rock beneath them. Adora bent down and pulled off her long, leather travelling boots, dumping the water out with a grimace.

"Shut it, Levi!" Catra snapped back, pulling off her leather jacket and flinging it angrily at another stone nearby. She was beyond furious! She hated getting wet, hated being teased and most of all hated looking like a complete fool in front of people who hated her.

"Aye, aye. Force Captain!" Levi shouted back mockingly.

Catra groaned and slowly rubbed a hand down her face, scrubbing a layer of water out of her fur. She sighed and focused her eyes on the tents huddled against the trees. Finding her teasing squad mate, crawling out and crouching in front of the open tent flap. Continuing to rummage for something in a leather pack laying just inside.

Catra hadn't seen Levi in years, not since she had taken over Shadow Weaver's position as Hordak's second in command. The stocky young woman had cut her dark hair yet again. It had been short before, now it was buzzed tight to her scalp on one side. The other flopped over the left side of her face and hung low against her sharp jawline. She was filled out more, her arms were as muscular as Adora's. She still wore some of the regulation armor, such as Horde issue combat boots. Her thick legs were in heavy black pants, her stout torso sheathed in a smoky grey, artillery vest. The various pockets were already bulging with items she had stored within. With a white and red training shirt underneath.

Catra caught sight of Adora waving nervously at another bunkmate. Who was standing in the twisting roots of the massive willow tree to their left. She turned to find Max, leaning against the trunk of that huge tree. His hair was still long, the same bleached green-blonde color. Hanging low over his eyes and trailing down the nape of his neck. He was fiddling with a fishing rod. A woven basket at his feet, already full with the shimmering bodies of small fish. He looked like a bandit from the Crimson Waste. With his pale grey woolen, wrap around cloak and tan leather pants. He still wore the same combat boots as Levi, the only piece of his Horde past he still hung onto.

"Take off your wet clothes, or you're going to get sick." A deep baritone rumbled from the other side of the fire. Then a huge shadow loomed into sight, as a bulky black furred Tauran lumbered into the firelight. Carrying two large wool blankets, draped over his huge, bulging forearm. He was dressed in loose amber pantaloons, with a wide utility belt around his waist. A matching sleeveless amber vest that hung open, showing off his

huge, well muscled chest and large washboard abs. Heavy, black, knee length leather greaves adorned his calves. His hoove tips were sheathed in metal, blunting the sharp ends. A red headband wrapped over his forehead. Tucked and tied under his large curving horns. That pointed outward from his temples like twin battering rams, the tips also blunted by metal caps. He looked every bit the handsome, swashbuckling pirate from the Salineas coast. Atila was built like a tank and could hit just as hard. His hot temper and stubborn attitude had been tamed over the years. Now his huge, threatening frame held a gentle, kind hearted spirit. Yet, his soulful brown eyes were cold as he approached them. Offering each a blanket solemnly before sitting down on the ground nearby. Atila had a strong jaw and a round face. His long black mane was tied back into a ponytail with leather ties. The strands knotted into numerous slender braids that were beaded with tiny opals and pearls. His mane hung down the length of his broad back, the thick tuft at the end brushing against his butt.

"Atila." Adora sniffled, smiling up at him in appreciation. Taking the blanket and setting it down beside her. As she quickly unbuckled her leather sheath with her quarter staff and set it aside. Then unpinned her wet cloak, tossing it over the rock behind her. Tucking the golden wing pin securely into the pocket of her pants. Before pulling off her shirt and pants next. When she was in nothing but her grey bra and shorts, she quickly wrapped herself up in the dry blanket.

Catra merely gave Atilla a curt nod of thanks, following Adora's lead to undress. Wrapping the blanket around herself, once she was in nothing but her breasts wrap and panties. The Tauran's kindness was conflicting with the steel in his gaze. Leaving Catra uncertain as to his true intentions. She kept a wary eye on Atila, she didn't know him as he was now. Only the angry, quick to violence bully she had known in her youth. So she didn't trust him sitting so close. She tried to mask her unease by taking stock of how the campsite was set up and the other member's of their squad milling about. They were not threatening, but hovering close by. As Catra unconsciously began to strategize their escape route if things went south.

Adora seemed to just accept the kind act at face value, hunched on her rock in her blanket. Shivering and staring at the fire with a subdued, contemplative expression as Max had not returned her wave.

"Did you find my skinning knife?" Max inquired, leaning casually against the Willow Tree. As Levi strode purposefully through camp, towards him shaking her head.

As Adora and Catra watched the last hybrid on their squad crawl out of the tent after Levi. Otis was a squid hybrid, similar to Octavia in appearance. He had the same four tentacles growing out of his back. But his scales were a warm blue.

Both Adora and Catra gasped in shock, to find all four of Otis's tentacles had been amputated at different lengths. Each one was now capped by silver, metal bulbs.

He wore similar amber pantaloons and a long sleeveless vest, that was closed with large black wooden toggle buttons and leather hooks. Catra figured that he must be a part of the same sailing crew as Atila. He had a white silk sash, wrapped several times around his more modest hips. His feet still adorned in black combat boots.

Otis had stern, sharp features with hawkish yellow eyes that never missed the smallest of details. His head was crowned in wild, white hair that he kept rather short. Looking more like a sea urchin had attached to his head than hair.

"Got it." Otis replied, never looking at either of the women who just joined them.

As Levi pulled out her own boot knife and began gutting and descaling the fish. On the other side of the willow tree on a large flat rock.

"Where's Sara?" Adora inquired innocently.

Atila lowered his gaze with a long forlorn sigh. "We lost her."

Catra took a deep breath, her eyes darkening with sorrow and regret. Resigned to ask the fateful question. Ready to accept the grim answer.

“Where did she fall?” Catra prodded in a clipped tone.

“Otis lost his tentacles during a battle up the northern coast of Salineas. Their princess turned out to be a rather ruthless combatant. She used her magic to sink several gun ships, drowning more Horde Soldier’s than I could count. “ Atila responded.

Adora’s eyes flared in shock, then hardened in understanding. It had been war, casualties on both sides had been inevitable. The rebellion had no warning, no way to prepare for the fall of Salineas. They were on the defensive, frantically trying to stay ahead of the Horde’s advancing troops. Evacuating the coast and retreating back into the shelter of the Whispering Woods and Bright Moon with the survivors. Mermista had been consumed with sorrow and shame at first. At not being in her kingdom to protect it. Needing to save what was left of her people, she had become a harbinger of death and destruction. Retaliating against the Horde with all her power. It was hard to accept that Mermista could kill so easily. Yet, she had been driven by rage and a thirst for vengeance. Bloodshed on both sides had been inevitable during those battles.

“Otis was holding a bulkhead open for us, so we could swim out of the engine room. When the metal succumbed to the pressure of the depths, as our gunship and several others were being sunk inside a massive whirlpool. The razor sharp metal twisted and collapsed just as he was swimming free, severing every one of his tentacles.” Atila hedged, telling the first of their grueling tales instead. Unwilling to delve into Sara’s death just yet.

“He was a hero.” Adora nodded, her smile was unsteady, eyes filled with tears of regret and a deep sadness. For the strife and horrors of war her childhood friends had to endure.

Catra merely grunted, she had curled up against her knees, staring down at her nervously tapping feet. As her finger claws anxiously scratched into the stone on either side of her butt. She had commanded those sea battles for a time, until Hordak sent her back to the Fright Zone. A cold lump formed in her chest, as she wallowed in her guilt.

"I saw many 'hero's' during my time fighting the rebellion. Some lived...most died." Atila scoffed, using the word hero more like a curse than a compliment.

"Is that how Sara died...was she being a hero?" Catra asked quietly, trying and failing to keep the bitterness out of her tone. She was nervous about asking, knowing he blamed her for Sara's death. But morbidly she needed to know.

Atila's eyes narrowed, as he sought to figure out her intentions. Having a difficult time, comprehending how the Hordes. Once ruthless and calculating Commander, who had been hell bent on winning the war at all costs. Could be sitting before him, now so meek and mild. Inquiring about Sara, as if she really cared, what had happened to his dearest friend... his lover. Unable to come to terms with how much Catra had changed. He merely snorted, rising to his feet.

"You should already know how she died! My Force Captain, cataloged her death in his final reports, Commander." He grunted, climbing to his feet and stomping away.

Catra groaned, casting her face up to the darkening sky. Atila was giving off a very aggressive aura. She had been preparing for a fight. Her muscles now ached with built up tension. Her body humming with the need to release it. Her throat felt raw and her chest ached with pent up emotions. Without another word she rose up on her own feet.

"I gotta go sing my farewell." She tossed Adora a dismissive wave then strode out of camp in just her underwear with the blanket wrapped tight around her shoulders. Heading along the grassy

bank of the river and quickly out of sight before Adora could say anything. Melog shimmered back into view in the tall grass and growled. It was a low disgruntled sound as they followed after Catra further up the embankment into the forest beyond.

Adora watched her go, hating how miserable she looked. But she was feeling just as upset and heartbroken. She had expected things to be tense, she never expected that half of her old squad would pretty much be shunning her. Atila had been kind, but he treated taking care of them like it was a duty and nothing more. While Otis and Max ignored her and Catra outright. Catra had put up with Levi's mockingly snide greeting. Then she had endured the broken hearted Atila's anger with a stoic acceptance.

Adora got the message loud and clear. They were not liked and definitely not welcome anymore. Adora huddled more tightly under her blanket. Picking at her wet clothes spread out behind her nervously. She wanted them to dry faster so she could get dressed and feel less vulnerable. Her stomach was roiling with anxious feelings and she wondered if forgiveness was even an option for either of them.

The twilight was darkening into the deepest blues, when Catra's voice echoed from the forest. She sang softly at first, slowly increasing in power and cadence as she bid farewell to the sun.

"I watched you... walk away,

You would never... hear me say,

That, ..I need you,

That, ...I love you.

I don't want... to let you go.

What's left of me,...

What's left of me,

Now your gone,”

Her voice trembled with limitless regret and sorrow as the stars began to shine overhead. The squad grew quiet, as her melancholy voice floated into camp. Adora sighed, hugging her knees. As once again all the emotions Catra held in her song washed over them.

“I’m fighting..my rage.

I'm falling...into sin...after sin...

I'm drowning...in my lies.

My heart is breaking...

All these regrets have.. left me broken inside.”

“I’ve become...so numb…

I’ve become..so afraid…

That I’ve lost myself... to this darkness…

That there is…

no, turning back,

no, forgiveness..

no, hope for me now…”

Her struggling voice slowly fell silent as she couldn’t finish without breaking down into sobs. Leaving the power held in each verse to ebb away on the wind.

Catra took a deep breath of the evening air, settling down upon the grass of a small overlook with Melog. She could see the fire burning on the marshy bank below and her bunk mates moving around the blaze, setting the filleted fish on long pikes to cook around the fire. She wrapped herself up tighter in the blanket, as silent tears fell down her cheeks. She was still too weak, too emotionally vulnerable to return to camp and face her childhood friends who now hated her. Melog had left camp with her, now they settled on the ground at her hip. Purring quietly, as she began to stargaze. Yearning for a more innocent time, when every day had been bright and full of hope and she had yet to learn the sting of heartache and the vile bite of betrayal.

Remembrance

First year of Sophmore Training…

Catra sat atop her bunk, legs pulled tight to her chest. Dressed in a red and white v-neck short sleeve shirt and a pair of grey pants with shredded, worn out cuffs. Her feet were wrapped in white cloth, needing a bit more protection now that she was older. Her foot pads had hardened and could take a bit of abuse, but she could still easily cut the arch of her bare feet and had on occasion while training against harder, sharper things. Such as bots or climbing to the higher reaches of the Fright Zone. So she reluctantly began to bind the softest part of her feet to protect them. Her tail was tucked around her ankles, the tip flicking nervously. She felt safe hidden in the shadow's on her top bunk, tucking out of view in the corner of her mattress. Able to survey the empty bunkroom from her hiding place. She had been psyching herself up for the coming one on one combat test against her strike team all morning. She was anxious and excited all at the same time. She had been striving for many season's to become more cunning, more devious in her feints when in battle. So that she could out strategize or out maneuver Adora. As always she was only a few points below Adora and a couple wins would put her ahead. She was eager to take her rightful place as the Red Squad Leader. Tired of losing the yearly trials...tired of being second best, of living in Adora's shadow. Not receiving the praise or laurels she deserved. She worked just as hard, studied just as hard. Yet Shadow Weaver refused to see her as nothing but a nuisance, a distraction to her beloved Adora! Her squad mates knew she was strong, smart and a very capable cadet. Yet they didn't treat her the same as Adora. They were friendly, welcoming and eager to be around the blonde. She had respect and the adoration of others. She got to bask in an easy atmosphere of belonging, when they were playing games and bantering with her during their down time. They were less enthusiastic about including Catra. Even with Adora's assurances

that she was going to play nice. When Adora wasn't around, they still took verbal jabs at her, attacking her insecurities about her appearance….her fluffy fur, wild mane, her big ears, her tail that she had yet to learn to control…always giving away how she was truly feeling. Broadcasting her vulnerabilities such as fear or shame. They tried to intimidate her with their larger bodies, or physical strength. All things she might never have? Stuck in her short, scrawny, pre-pubescent body. Catra had grown resentful and bitter towards her squad mates inability to accept her as willingly as Adora. She had honestly stopped trying to be their friend season's ago, Adora was the only person she wanted to be around anyway. If Adora wasn't around, she would just take off and find things to occupy herself away from the barracks. She didn't need anyone! She was just fine playing on her own.

Her ears twitched in irritation as an ear splitting squawking sound shattered the quiet of the bunk room. She narrowed her eyes in painful fury, as Bryson sauntered into the bunkroom. Dressed in a Sophomore cadet issue uniform. That was a red t-shirt with a white stripe up the middle and grey pants. Wearing a pair of red and white combat boots to match. He was taller now, but still stout and soft around his middle. His once spikey blonde hair was now buzzed close to his scalp. His sky blue eyes gleaming with joy as he played with his favorite toy. His round cheeks flushed from blowing into that dented piece of rectangular metal pressed to his lips. It was some kind of instrument, Bryson had found discarded on one of the tables in the Mess hall a couple season's back. It had never strayed too far from him. Catra had been enduring the sharp pain that little torture device did to her hearing ever since. She grit her teeth, folding her ears tight to her head as she glared down at Bryson from the shadows of her bunk. The clueless lout never even noticed her, huddling in the top corner of her bunk. Hiding just out of sight behind the curving pillar of metal that attached the bunkbed to the tin roof. Blowing hard one last time, the ear splitting squeal echoed off the metal roof like a gunshot. Then he tucked it away in his grey pants. Catra squeezed her eyes shut tight, taking several deep breaths as her ear's rang miserably.

"Red Strike Team A, report to Combat room 23 for testing. Louis is exempt from the test, due to injury. Red Strike Team B, report to Combat room 22 for testing." Lazlo's deep voice boomed from the loud speaker, tucked in the far corner of the roof. Bryson turned on his heel and dashed back out of the bunk room. Catra heaved a huge calming breath, then leaped down from her bunk, following after him. Balling her hands into fists at her sides as she marched resolutely towards the testing room. Determined and completely focused on her goals.

An hour later…

Catra gripped the sides of the sink in the locker room, her claws scratching into the white ceramic. Grinding her teeth as she seethed. Choking back heart broken sobs, as tears beaded at the corners of her eyes.

She was so angry...and frustrated...and overwhelmed by her disappointment at the outcome. She hated Lonnie for interfering, she had been so close….she could have won! But Lonnie caught on that she was playing dirty and she liked Adora, so she jumped in to protect her! Lonnie wouldn't do that for her...it's not fair! Now Adora and the rest of her squad were celebrating Adora's win...while she brooded in the locker room. That should have been her win! Adora got everything...she wanted!

Catra had to bite and claw for everything and still it was taken from her. She never stood a chance...she was never going to win, never going to receive the praise and accolades that she deserved. Shadow Weaver was never going to care about her in the ways she craved so desperately. Never going to be liked by her squad-mates….the way they liked Adora...so why was she still trying so hard! Losing to Adora…again and again...it was killing her...like a slow poison. She sniffled, gritting her teeth as she held

in the sob swelling in her throat. She was alone in the locker room, it would be alright to cry just a little bit…right?

A squawking sound vibrated through the room. Catra stilled for a moment willing her tears to dry, as she spun upon the abrasive sound. Finding Bryson, hovering just behind the row of lockers with that cursed object hanging from his lips. He had not known she was there at first, the sink was hidden behind the row of lockers. So he just headed to his locker to hang up his sensors. Out of habit he had taken his harmonica out of his pocket and pressed it to his lips. Then tragically he had finally noticed Catra and how upset she was. Bryson cursed his bad luck, immediately holding his breath! Catra had a volatile temper and catching her in such a vulnerable state would not end well for him. He did not want her to notice him, trying to be silent and sneak away. Desperate to avoid a confrontation with the feline hybrid. Since Catra could become very violent when pissed off. But he couldn't hold his breath any longer and was forced to push to air through the holes in the harmonica. It made a weak, warbling sound.

Catra was furious and embarrassed at being caught crying! The hurt and anger currently eating away at her, fueling her actions. She bolted across the room and lunged for that stupid harmonica. Ripping it out of Bryson's mouth. Bryson jumped back against the locker's with a resounding clang. Catra pinned him there, by invading his personal space. Hovering her snarling face inches away from his, the raw fury and violence in her aura made him cower before her.
"I hate this thing! I hate you! I hate this place!" She shouted in his face, pupils thinned to narrow vengeful slits. Her canines inches from his nose, claws coiled to strike on either side of his ears. Piercing the metal of the locker door he was pinned against.

Bryson swallowed hard, his heart lurching in terror in his chest. Standing prone and pale with fear as Catra screamed inches from his face and then ran off with his Harmonica. This wasn't the first time a stronger, more aggressive cadet had intimidated him. Made him feel weak, inadequate, foolish...less than...Bryson whimpered

in further humiliation as he felt the hot trickle of liquid running down his leg. He and many of the other cadets in Red Squad had already come to fear Catra...more than even Atila. The Tauran was a brute and a bully, but he never had the eyes of a predator. One day, if pushed too far, pushed too hard...Catra could kill and she would do it without guilt or remorse. He was certain of that. She was a perfect Horde Soldier...something he would never be.

Catra had climbed as high as she could go, to the very top of the Fright Zone. Perched upon a railing at the edge of a long platform. That overlooked the sprawling, behemoth of buildings and smoke stacks that was known as the Forge. The day moons were glowing red as they sank out of view, into the chemical haze that hovered over the Refinery complex beyond the Forge, far in the distance. A hot, putrid wind blew over her. Tossing her long dark hair over her shoulder, no longer having the curtain of her mane obscuring her face. The shimmering tear tracks down her cheeks were clearly visible in the dying light. She snarled, glaring vengefully down at the harmonica in her hand. Then threw the offending object as far as she could. Relishing it's departure over the irregular shaped towers in the distance with a smile.

"Good Riddance." She huffed, as the metal glinted out of sight on the horizon of the industrial landscape.

Catra heaved a long, shaky breath, adjusting her crouched position on the railing. Lower her butt to sit upon the railing and curling her tail more tightly around her ankles. Crossing her arms over her calves as she now had her legs pressed up firmly against her chest. Her gaze was lost, brooding upon her resentments and loathing her cursed life.

"Catra….I know you're up there!" Adora's voice echoed out from far below.

"Go Away!" Catra shouted back, towards the ground. Growling and shifting away from the edge of the platform. Unconsciously

shielding her tears from Adora far below, even though logically she knew the human girl's eyesight was not that good. She would never see her tears from so far away anyway. Catra had found this place a few season's back and had kept it a secret for a long time. This had been her greatest find, a place no one but her could reach. She finally felt she had found a refuge to retreat to, which was completely secluded and secure. Able to disappear completely whenever she needed to.

She had finally broken down and shown it to Adora, last season. She had gotten into some serious trouble with Shadow Weaver, as accusations of stealing items from the supply shed had been reported. They were not false. But she wasn't ready to deal the repercussions of getting caught and had disappeared for a couple days. When she finally found the courage to return and face her punishment. She instead found her best friend in the bunk room in a state of terrified panic. Her eyes were puffy and red rimmed from crying and she looked on the verge of even more tears. When Adora had found out what had happened, she instantly went into crisis mode. Wandering all over the Fright Zone for days searching for her. She hadn't slept, had barely ate. Sneaking off during their breaks, from class and training. She had even snuck out of the bunk room late at night with a flashlight, searching until dawn. Checking all of Catra's usual haunts and hiding places. When she couldn't be found. Adora had begun to spiral. Contemplating that perhaps Catra had been taken away….like Tama...like Ami and Arron… Shadow Weaver had threatened to dispose of Catra...perhaps this time she had followed through? Adora as always blamed herself. She was just now trying to find the courage to confront Shadow Weaver and get to the bottom of what happened to her best friend! Catra had felt terrible, she never disappeared for so long before. She had always showed Adora her new hiding places when they were little kids.

But as she got older her thoughts and feelings became more complicated in regards to Adora. The silent rivalry for acceptance and praise from Shadow Weaver, a persistent knife carving a divide between them. Sometimes her anger and resentment became harder to keep hidden. A tragic understanding coming to

light, that she both loved and hated her best friend. It was confusing and heartbreaking, driving her to seek solitude more and more often. So she needed a private place just to think and lick her wounds when life got too hard to deal with. She couldn't open up to Adora in the same way she did as a kid. Keeping more and more secrets as the seasons pass. Because some days she felt she couldn't live without her...other days she wanted her to just disappear. Some days she wished she was the one who would disappear….

"No!" Adora yelled back. Her tone was firm and slightly annoyed. "It's supper time and you skipped breakfast...cause you wouldn't leave your bunk...this morning. " Adora's voice was breathless, with long pauses. As she began to climb the narrow rungs of the access ladder that led up to the multi levelled roof, of a storage building that abutted against the massive tower that held the platform.

Catra watched her climb, her expressions shifting from mild curiosity to concern. She had shown Adora this platform but this was the first time the headstrong human had attempted to climb it. Her keen eyes keep track of her best friend's progress with both awe and disbelief. As the blonde just kept stubbornly climbing higher. Moving from the roof of the storage building to begin to free climb up the tower. Using the utility pipes or narrow makeshift ledges of slightly crumpled metal of the outer shell of the tower. Or even sometimes the tiny metal conduit boxes, just to keep ascending. Stopping and reassessing her position, her face contorted with exertion and unwavering determination. Finally she ran out of hand holds as the tower became completely smooth. She had her back pressed against the side, at least twenty feet below Catra's perch. Yet already so high over the Fright Zone the human could see for miles. Adora slowly scanned the landscape of varying rooftops, that sprawled below her into the far off horizon. The looming shadow's of the Forge and then the Refinery behind accenting the edge of her vison. Sucking one deep breath after another, her eyes wide in both wonder and fear.

Dressed in her grey pants, a heavy utility belt clipped to her waist, her red boots and red and white training shirt. The wind buffeted her as she pressed herself up tight against the tower. Her pony tail snapping like a banner behind her. The metal above her head was covered in scratches and gouges from Catra's claws. Then with a resolute nod, Adora turned from the expanse of the Fright Zone to confront the last league of her journey upward. Her pink tongue was peeking out of the corner of her mouth, as she unlatched a grappling hook from her utility belt.

Catra threw her head back and laughed with pride and amusement. Adora was always prepared! She must have caught sight of her earlier than ran back to the barracks to prepare for the climb. In minutes, the hook struck and latched itself to the railing near the back of the platform with a resounding clang. Then Adora hauled herself up the rope, climbing over the railing with a smug, self satisfied grin. She sat down on the floor of the platform, puffing and out of breath.

"Well...that was fun!" She heaved, flopped backwards to lay on the cool metal. Struggling to catch her breath and grinning broadly in triumph.

"Show off!" Catra teased, her tone was playful but it still held a little bite to it. As she leaped off the edge of the far side railing near the open platform. Landing gracefully on her toes before pacing inward to sit down beside Adora

Adora took her sarcasm in stride, used to being on the receiving end of Catra's sour attitude. She rolled her head towards her best friend pulling out two ration bars from her pocket. Thrusting them both at her.

"Eat!" Adora commanded.

Catra growled, but smiled softly at her, taking both bars. She quickly had them unwrapped and devoured. As they watched the moonset together.

It was long after dark by the time they returned to the bunkroom. The tension in the room was thick, emotions running high. Something had happened?

Atila was pacing, glowering down at his hooves as he stomped back and forth down the aisle, between the rows of their bunk beds. Dressed in a dark red training shirt with the sleeves torn off and black shorts that hugged his thick thighs. Sara was perched on the thin mattress of her top bunk near the back of the bunkroom. Her dark brown hair was still moist from the shower. With her gaze focused unwaveringly upon her hands, curled tightly in her lap. Her long bangs hung over her eyes, shrouding her fear. As her long ponytail, shivered upon her back as she fought to conceal her bodies quaking. Her legs were swinging anxiously as she darted her stricken eyes upward from time to time to watch Atila pace past her. She was dressed in a white shirt with red accents on the short sleeves, grey pants and red sneakers. Lonnie and Rogelio were comforting Kyle. The three were huddled together on Rogelio's lower bunk at the front of the room. Louis and Otis were standing apart from the other's speaking softly. At the back of the bunkroom near the heavy iron, back door to the outer training yard. Otis as a hybrid had a white tunic with the sleeves rolled up on his biceps. The back was cut out to allow his four tentacles to be free and grey pants and black combat boots. Louis had gotten hurt during their morning drills, yesterday. So his right wrist was now wrapped in a bandage. Wearing a similar red and white training shirt like Lonnie, black pants and white sneakers. Max, Levi and Bryson were absent. It wasn't strange since those three were close and spent their free time together.

Then Lazlo's voice exploded from outside in the yard.

"The Ore Plant! What the hell were you three thinking!" He was yelling at someone. Giving whomever in their squad one hell of a dressing down. Sara jumped in fright at the sudden explosion of

rage. Her large, doe shaped eyes staring wide and terrified at the back doors.

Catra hovered near the doorway, nervous and uncertain. Adora was motionless for only a second, while she steeled herself. Her eyes cooled into that stern, emotionless focus. She wrapped around herself like armor, when she had to take charge and tend to her duties. Adora was quick to take action. She strode down the length of the bunks, slipping easily past Atila and out the back door. She was their squad leader and needed to know what was happening. They were all under her command and if they were in trouble. Then she was at fault and had to take on the consequences as well.

Catra watched morbidly, as Adora slipped out of the back doors, to be greeted by Lazlo's next furious explosion directed her way.

"Red Leader! Fine time for you to show! Where the hell have you been!"

Catra growled and then dashed for the back door, refusing to let Adora face their Staff Sergeants wrath alone. She slipped silently to Adora's side and took her hand. Thrusting her chin up defiantly, refusing to blink as Lazlo was screaming right in their faces. Standing stiffly but resolutely at Adora's side.

Then Lazlo took a deep breath, seeking to calm his rage. "Stand to attention and oversee your squad's punishment! They are to keep running laps until I get back! " He finished, his voice hoarse from screaming for the last few minutes.

Catra watched Levi and Max running laps in the twilight. Dressed in the white t-shirts with red sleeves and grey pants. Their matching red combat boots striking the pavement in an endless crescendo of grief and misery. Red faced, exhausted and bawling loudly. Tears streamed down their faces, as they were completely inconsolable.

Catra glanced nervously at Adora, finding her best friend standing tall. Staring mournfully at their squad mates, her lower lip trembling. Struggling to keep her composure, as Lazlo stormed back to the back door. Throwing it open with a resounding clang then disappearing inside. As soon as Lazlo was out of sight, Adora threw off Catra's hand and sprinted to catch up to Levi and Max.

"Adora!" Catra shouted, dashing off after her. They would be in even more trouble for disobeying orders! Soon all four of them were running laps, then the rest of the squad trickled out of the bunkroom and joined them. None but Levi and Max knew why they were running laps. But the squad, in an act of solidarity, took on the punishment as a unit. All they knew right now was that Bryson was missing and Max and Levi were hurting. Absolutely devastated by whatever had happened.

Lazlo eventually returned, standing at the back door with his arms crossed. Watching the whole squad running together. The barest hint of pride gleaming in his yellow eyes, that was quickly cooled into a steel hard glower. He recalled the squad back into the bunkroom to give them all the tragic news.

After supper, Max, Levi and Bryson had gone beyond the northern ramparts to the Quarry that bordered upon the Dark Edge Canyons. Where the Horde were mining for Iron ore and other minerals for their armor and weapon's manufacturing. They were playing down in the pellet piles around the Ore processing plant. A couple older cadets from Indigo Squad had shown up and started bullying and daring them to to do stupid stunts. One stunt was to run over the silt piles beneath a set of hoppers that was currently dumping finely ground iron. Max and Levi had been fast enough to get up and over the pile before the hopper opened up...Bryson hadn't been. He was crushed instantly when the ore dumped on top of him. A recovery team had been sent to the Ore Plant to dig out the body. Then Bryson would be disposed of.

Upon hearing the news, Shadow Weaver had come by and taken Adora away. For what purpose Catra didn't know, only that the cold, unfeeling woman had ignored her outright. Even though she had been sitting right beside Adora on her bunk already consoling her. Adora had left her, dutifully beckoned to Shadow Weaver's side. The cold, calculating woman then u shered a stunned, silently grief stricken Adora out of the bunk room. With a guiding, subtly controlling hand on the back of her shoulder. Catra was instantly fully alert and aware in Shadow Weaver's presence. She heard the Sorceress's voice, cool and calm as she inquired how Adora was handling everything and what were her plans going forward were to control her Squad better.

Catra's regret at screaming at Bryson earlier and stealing his most treasured item was suffocating. She had crawled up to her top bunk and once again, curled herself against the wall at the head of the bed. Balling herself up tight, under her grey blanket as the only comfort allotted to her. Folding her ears back, trying to ignore the sniffles and whimpers of her bunk mates as they all dealt with the sudden death.

Adora returned late into the night, long past lights out. Climbing into her bunk and under her blanket and with a soft whimper. Catra still wasn't asleep, unable to settle down until Adora was safe back in the bunkroom. But with the security of Adora and the others now fast asleep. She crawled down from her bunk and climbed onto the foot of Adora's mattress. Burrowing herself under Adora's blue blanket, needing to smell her to calm herself down enough to perhaps sleep just a little bit.

Adora said nothing a few hours later, when she woke up. Feeling something warm and furry pressed up against her bare feet. Pulling back the covers to discover Catra in her bed, under her blanket, curled up tight in a ball near her feet. She merely leaned over, slipping her hands under Catra's armpits. Pulling the feline's willing body up against her own. Holding her best friend close, as she nuzzled her wet, tear stained face into Catra's thick dark mane. Taking several deep breaths, absorbing all the comfort Catra's presence offered. This was the first night they would hold

each other so boldly in the bunkroom. Before they had only comforted each other like this in the security of one of Catra's hiding places.

"What a stupid way to die…" Catra muttered bitterly, finally allowing the tears the fall. Rolling over to hide her face against Adora's chest, holding her best friend even tighter as she sobbed quietly.

Catra would spend many season's searching the Fright Zone for Bryson's harmonica, but she never would find it.

Catra sat upon the grassy bluff that overlooked the campsite. Admiring the first two greater moons as they ascended over the edge of the valley. Absently petting Melog, her ears turning towards the campsite at every sound of laughter and soft conversation. Brooding over how terrible her reunion with her old squad had been.

Feeling insecure and angry around them was nothing new, she always felt like an outcast. Growing up in the barracks. Adora had always been the one to protect her from bullies from other squads. Or share in her punishments. When she got caught seeking pay back on those other cadets. Or smooth over any misunderstandings or offer excuses for her temper, after she lashed out at her own squad mates. Over some small slight or failure during their daily training. In Adora's absence, she had basked in the power she had over them as a Force Captain. For the first time in her life, she held command. There had been no one to reign her in and she had become the worst version of herself.

She watched her old bunkmates relaxing around the fire, sharing the now cooked fish, Max had caught. Her stomach growled, yet she refused to join them. Guilt and her pride kept her rooted in

seclusion beyond camp. They didn't want her around and she would not force them to endure her presence. She was a bit irritated that Adora had stayed and not followed her out of camp. But that was typical, Adora usually let her have some time to cool off. She would come find her eventually. She figured Adora was valiantly trying to mend ties. Swallowing the hatred and apathy she received from Atila and the obvious disregard from the rest. Slapping on that warm, unwavering smile she would reach out to them again and again. Attempt to find a common ground to rebuild that broken friendship. If her attempt was rejected, she would give them space. But she wouldn't give up, she would just try again. Patient and resilient, Adora would slowly earn herself back into their good graces.

Catra on the other hand….felt incapable of ever repairing her relationship with them.

Catra had always been hot-tempered and sharp tongued. She had never been really close to any of them. Honestly, she had never really tried to connect with anyone else beside Adora. Tama's death... watching her little body burn away to ash. It had left an ugly scar on her heart she couldn't heal. She was unwilling to open her heart and befriend anyone else, never wanting to go through that pain again. So she kept everyone else at a distance. Maybe she was slightly closer to Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio since they were on the same strike team. But she had only really wanted to be close to Adora from then on. But they all still grew up together. She had once had a family-like bond to them and it hurt to have them reject her outright. But she had burned that bond as if it meant nothing...as she rose to power. After she had lost everything...came to realize how her ambition and thirst for power had been utterly meaningless. Feeling lost and alone, trapped on Primes ship. She was forced to finally reflect upon herself, wallow in her tortured thoughts, confront all her demons. Coming to understand how much Adora, Scorpia…her squad mates all meant to her. She sought to atone, by sacrificing her life for Glimmer. Accepting that there was nothing left for her. No one left to care about her. But as always, Adora would not allow her to go out in a blaze of glory. Not listening to her warning, too

stubborn and too pure hearted to let her go. A small, fond smile pulled upon Catra's lips as she remembered all the fights they would have on Darla over Adora’s hero complex. With a long drawn out sigh, Catra turned her wistful gaze upward once more to the stars. She wanted forgiveness...a second chance to show them she wasn’t that tyrannical Commander anymore. Quickly lost in the endless round of her frustration and hopelessness. Since she couldn’t come up with a plan to mend her relationship with them. Her thoughts sank into the common grief that haunted all of them.

“We never got the chance to say goodbye…” She muttered absently. Her heart ached as her breathing became more shallow. Unconsciously beseeching the universe with her deep, heartfelt wish to see Tama and the others one last time.

She never noticed the quiet blue flame that began to glow over her body. Melog chirped in inquiry as her magic flared across their bond, igniting inside their own body like a flare. Melog had been enveloped in that melancholy flame many times. They huffed and shifted their weight, sitting up and keeping a close watch over the moonlight forest and outlying hills. As their body glowed softly with that somber hue, slowly fading away.

Catra never noticed, her focus drawn inward on her pain as she picked absently at the grass at her hip. She sighed heavily, pulling her knees up to her chest and crossing her arms over them. Resting her chin upon her arms as her gaze was lost. Falling back into her bittersweet memories of her childhood. She had expected Adora to show up by now and she was starting to feel rather lonely.

A soft rustling whispered from the tall grass that dominated the hilltop that overlooked the campsite. Catra’s ears twitched at the subtle disturbance, suddenly alert. She tossed the blanket off her shoulders and to the ground. Standing in only her black breast wrap and panties. Feeling rather vulnerable and underdressed for

a fight. She glanced around frantically for Melog. But it seemed they had left, perhaps they had gone back to camp to find Adora and bring her back? She adjusted her stance preparing to defend herself if necessary. The hilltop was bathed in the gentle silver light from the five greater moons now hovering high above. She could see the tall grass shifting as the creature moved closer. Catra raised her clawed hands preparing to confront the intruder that was creeping up on her position.

She noticed the rusty, red, fluffy ears first. As they were bouncing amid the waving grass as a cool breeze disturbed the trees below. The low, mournful creaking of the Willow trees' long branches broke the silence of the night. Her tail went straight and puffed up in fright at the eerie sound. This whole scary situation was way too familiar. Her nerves were still shot from Beast Island. She was not mentally ready to deal with little monsters creeping in the woods.

“Who goes there!” Catra warned. “Show yourself!”

A bright, joyful giggle answered her. Catra’s ears folded back in shock, her heart leaped into her throat. Never expecting to ever hear her infectious laughter, let alone see her again.

“Tama!” Catra called, demanding that the little fox come out of hiding.

“Cat…” Tama called back, leaping from the concealment of the grass and wrapping her small, pudgy arms around Catra’s neck. She was solid and felt so alive! Her weight, causing Catra to stumble and swing the little fox hybrid in a circle before tumbling to the ground. Tama was dressed in the same cadet uniform she had been wearing upon her death. Of Catra’s old red and white shirt, with the shredded collar and grey ankle length pants. She never wore shoes, being a predator type hybrid like Catra.

Catra lay stunned on the ground, with Tama straddling her bare stomach. A huge proud grin spread over her cute, round face. Her warm green eyes sparkling with joy.

“I missed you!” Tama exclaimed, lunging forward and hugging her again.

Catra was overcome with far too many emotions. A wail of both anguish and gratitude escaped her as she wrapped her arms tight around the little fox and cried with joy.

“I missed you too!” Catra admitted, never wanting to let go. Tama’s death and her body's cruel disposal had scarred and traumatized her so deeply. She had felt like she had failed Tama. That moment of helplessness as she had watched Tama’s blanket vaporize into ash in the furnace. Gave birth to the rage that would fuel her thirst for revenge against Octavia, Shadow Weaver, Hordak… The need to prove that she was stronger than the cruel, unjust world she was trapped in. Driven to rise up in the ranks of the Horde, to claim power for herself so that she could change her world and finally feel safe.

“Forgive me...I was too slow...too weak..to save you.” Catra blubbered in gasping sobs against the little girl's small shoulder.

Tama merely laughed with amusement, pulling out of Catra’s grasp to squish her cheeks with her small hands.
“Silly...there is nothing to forgive. I was already gone...” She stated, smooshing Catra’s cheeks a couple more times. Amused by how the Magicats lips looked like a gasping fish.

“Are you alive?” Catra was dumb founded, shocked and desperate for answers. She poked Tama’s stomach and gripped her tiny arms. The little girl just giggled and squirmed. Catra was shocked as she pressed her ear up against Tama’s small chest. The hope and wishful thinking that perhaps Tama was alive shattered in an instant. When she could hear no heartbeat, or feel her chest rise and fall with breath. She was nothing but an animated doll.

“How are you here?” Catra grunted out, as she gently extracted herself from Tama’s grip. Sitting up and adjusting the little girl on her lap. She was freaking out! Trembling with disappointment and sorrow and trying hard not to show it.

Tama merely shrugged, “I don’t know...I heard you calling my name… I think. Anyway, I sensed that you were really sad and I felt you really needed me. So I came to check on you.” She turned in Catra’s lap, leaning her back against her stomach. “You sure have gotten big!” She exclaimed.

“I’m all grown up now, Tama.” Catra explained, combing her claws through Tama’s curly, red hair. Trying to soothe herself with the comforting gesture. She decided she was just going to roll with it for now. This version of Tama, smelled right, it just wasn’t alive.

“Are you and Adora still together?” She asked innocently.

“Yep, things were bad for a while between us. But we’re closer than ever now.” Catra sighed in defeat. She unfortunately was getting used to the strange, wondrous yet scary world that magic brought into her life.

“How’s your lif….” Catra quickly stopped herself from saying life. She had no idea what happened after you died, if this Tama was real or just a manifestation given flesh. Of her deepest wish to see her again. She might have even just fallen asleep and been dreaming all this. That was typically how these encounters went.

“Oh...I’m happy. “ Tama turned and grinned over her shoulder.

“Thats good…” Catra started, her eyes searching the distance for a bit as she summoned the courage to ask more questions.

“Have you seen the others?” She finally burst out.

“Yes….Sara joined us recently...she’s all grown up like you.” Tama nodded, slowly rising to her feet.

“Us?” Catra swallowed.

“Yes, Ami and Arron came, then Bryson, then Louis...now Sara.” Tama glanced meekly to her side, her ears twitched, as if someone was calling to her.

“So, Ami and Arron died...they were not reassigned to another unit.” Catra huffed, at finally getting that confirmed. The cadet barracks were a huge sprawling complex that spanned the southwest corner of the Fright Zone. So it wasn’t unheard of for kids to be reassigned to another squad and never be seen again. When she took over for Shadow Weaver, she had found the documentation of Hordaks experiments into cloning which had failed. Hordak’s body had been slowly dying over the last few decades and he was desperate to extend his life. He tried bonding Horde DNA into live subjects. Resulting in strange, sometimes deadly mutations. In the hopes that they would be able to survive having a control port installed in their necks. Wanting to be able to use living vessels to transmit his consciousness into.

When they were in their fourth year as junior cadets, the whole army had been ordered to take a blood test. Adora was the only one not required to go to the infirmary to have it done. Weeks later, the twins. Ami and Arron were taken away and they never saw them again. Lazlo returned...changed. He had been proud of being useful to Hordak and gaining a more powerful body. He had told them that Ami and Arron were still of use to Hordak and would not return to their barracks. Catra had no doubts that their blood had been a match for what Hordak wanted for his experiments. It was clear now that they had not survived the surgical procedure for that control port. Adora had asked Shadow Weaver when Ami and Arron would be coming back from their special training. Once again, she had told her that they had been taken care of. Allowing Adora to believe what she wanted from such a vague explanation and a rumor began that the Twins had just been reassigned to another unit.

Adora has always accepted Shadow Weaver’s words at face value. Catra always questioned what she was told, never trusting any of the adults who looked after them. But she had no power at the time to try and find out where Ami and Arron were or what happened to them. So she just latched onto Adora even more strongly, promising that she would protect her and keep her safe from the evil that surrounded them.

“I kinda sneaked away...I better go back before I get into trouble.” Tama skipped away, turning and smiling sweetly up at Catra. Reluctant to leave her side.

“Tama!” Sara’s velvet soft yet husky voice called from the distance. The thin fabric of reality warped as if it was water disturbed by a stone. As a young woman strode into view. She was much taller than Catra, perhaps even taller than Adora. Wearing a Horde issued infantry troopers armor and no helmet. She had a quiet beauty, with long chestnut brown hair tied back into a ponytail. Long bangs hung low over her eyes, falling on either side of her gently rounded cheeks. Her hazel eyes were fierce, but tempered into a smoldering warmth.

“Hi, Catra, it's been a while.” She tossed her a small wave, before crouching down before Tama.

Catra sat stiffly on the grass, dumbfounded yet exhilarated at the same time.

“Angella is going to freak out, that you crossed the veil. We need to get you back asap.” Sara grabbed Tama’s hand, just as three more kids and a teen darted out of the same ripple in the air. Catra scrambled to her feet as she was now confronted by the small group of long lost bunk mates.

Ami, Arron, Bryson and Louis. All wearing the same training clothes they had been wearing at the time of their deaths.

“Wow,....wow...wow…” Catra breathed in awe, back stepping in sudden fright. How was this happening….

“Ok...seriously guys?” Sara turned and confronted the small army of kids with a disgruntled frown.

“What...Tama’s the one who cut the hole in the veil.” Ami whined, pointing to the fox hybrid. She had long black hair and pale skin. Her eyes were a deep dark blue that looked almost black. Her face was sweet and innocent, her body was so slender and dainty.

She resembled a living doll more then a simple girl. Wearing the red and white t-shirt and grey pants and red boots.

"I did not! " Tama countered with an indignant stomp of her clawed foot. "The veil was weak...don't blame me, just cause I was keen enough to notice it and let myself fall through it. "

"We saw you jump through the breach! There was no accidental falling involved." Ami accused, sticking out her tongue.

"Well, we jumped through the breach too. We wanted to cross over and explore for a little while…" Arron explained. He looked just as doll-like as his sister, with short black hair that was neat and orderly with dark, soulful blue eyes. That seemed to stare far too intimately for Catra's liking. Wearing an identical uniform as his twin sister.

The twins had always been kinda creepy...

"Com'on Sara don't you want to see Atila?" Bryson coaxed knowingly. He was a sturdy looking boy close to his teens, with dusty blonde hair shaved tight to his scalp. With strong features and a square jaw. Wearing a red shirt with a white stripe up the middle, gray pants and red boots. His clothes still dusted with fine ore powder from the moment of his death. They had lost him in a freak accident down in the Quarry during their first year as Sophomore Cadets. He had been fooling around with Max and Levi on the ore piles. They were playing king of the hills. When some older Cadets had caught sight of them. They had wanted to play too, but they were years older and the game would have been unfair. They had just wanted an excuse to beat on younger cadets for fun. In the end they started daring each other to do dangerous stunts. He was buried alive in seconds, when a hopper filled with crushed ore opened up over his head.

The Staff Sergeant was furious and punished Max and Levi for weeks for being reckless and playing in a dangerous area of the Fright Zone. But honestly there wasn't a safe place to play in the Fright Zone...period.

Her and Adora took those same kind of risks, when they went and played beyond the barracks. Swinging from pipes and cables as they explored the service ducts and vents. Racing to the Forge, or the Refinery or anywhere else amid the congested thoroughfares of moving military equipment. Dodging tanks, Runners full of soldier's and cargo hauler's, as they darted and weaved through the traffic. Or climbing to the highest reaches of the fortress to their secret platform.

“If Angella catches us...we’re going to be in trouble….” Louis moaned, crossing in front of the rest. Seeking to herd them back towards the tear in space. He was an older teen, tall and sinewy like Kyle. With dark brown hair shaved close to the scalp, except for long strands of hair on top. That fell like a waterfall down the back of his head. He had gentle features and a pointed chin, with stormy grey blue eyes. He was wearing the light weight training armor with sensor pads, similar to what they used in the simulators. The exact same outfit he had been wearing that fateful day, he was killed during their combat trial as Senior Cadets.

“How…?” Catra sputtered, as her fright and discomfort increased. Her tail now wrapped tightly around her waist.

None of her old bunkmates heard her, as they were now squabbling as to what to do.

Tama huffed and quietly let go of Sara’s hand moving back towards Catra. As if sensing how upset and freaked out she was becoming. Catra turned to regard Tama with confusion and bewilderment.

“You're magical now, dummy. “ Ami finally answered, her tone as impatient and condescending towards Catra as it had been when they were children.

Tama rose up on her toes and grasped Catra’s hands, drawing her threatening scowl away from Ami. For the first time Catra noticed the thin blue aura of flame surrounding Tama and crawling up her

own tawny brown arms. She snapped her gaze up, taking in the rest of them and how they also glowed. Concluding that her whole body must be covered in the same ethereal light as them.

“I did this?” Catra questioned, in breathless awe. At the magnitude of her power.

“Yes, child. But not intentionally.” Angella’s voice echoed out, as regal and gentle as before. As the soft white glow of her presence glided through the ripple in the air, to stand before them. She was translucent and luminous, not having a solid form like the rest.

“Queen Angella…” Sara stood at attention out of instinct. When confronted by a superior.

Louis followed suit, but the children were not as indoctrinated into military life so did not have the unconscious response. Ami, Arron and Bryson darted behind Sara and Louis as if they were shields.

While Tama held Catra’s hand more tightly. As if scared, Angella was going to rip her away.

“Magic is more than just runes and glyphs. It is fueled by emotion and driven by intention. You were feeling very lonely and extremely sad. You desperately wanted to see your old friends again, to heal the damage their sudden deaths had caused. Your intention was so pure, so intense. That your magic responded, igniting the blue fire...casting an ancient spell known as the Soul Pyre.” Angella nodded towards Catra’s hands.

“I did this before...I made blue flame. In the cavern with my parents' bones...then days later. Shadow Weaver came in my dreams...and you took her away. Then my mother...and she crossed back to the Eternal Realm?” Catra was once again verbally working out the puzzle of her magic, her ears folding down in dismay. “But they all came to me in my dreams?”

“Yes, I was able to travel through your dreams. When I felt your misery in the Whispering Woods, knowing how desperately you needed solace. I was then able to show you your true self, the life

you had lost and the heritage long forgotten to time. I could guide those whom you had lost, to your side as you got stronger. Along that ethereal thread of endless possibilities. All of that was possible, because your magic was already woven with the magic of Dream." Angella nodded.

Catra was silent for a while, she had not seen the Rune Bearer of Dream back at the Basilica…within the Elemental vestibule. But Ouroboros had told her it wasn't one of the Greater magic's…not Elemental…it was one of the Lesser magic's…but who held that power now? That she would already have formed a bond with?

"But how are they here….Tama said I called her…I was the one who weakened the veil?" Catra was beside herself, trembling and overwhelmed by the sheer magnitude of her magic.

"You have also now woven your magic with the threads of Life and Death...I don't know when or how. But the link was made and you are strong enough now to wield the Soul Pyre." Angella nodded.

Catra swallowed…"What is its purpose?"

"That is up to the wielder...magic is not like a simple tool that serves only one purpose. It is fluid...infinite in its possibilities. This is a part of your magic...it is up to you how to use it." Angella smiled serenely, turning back towards the ripple. "Come now, we should all return before your souls become lost between realms."

"Is that possible?" Sara lightly clutched onto the tip of Angella's longer flight feathers. Staring wide eyes and fearful up at the Immortal Queen, beseeching her for the true risks of staying.

"The longer you remain here the more frayed your tether to the Eternal Realm becomes." Angella glanced over her shoulder at Sara. Answering her solemnly.

"How was Tama able to cross?" Catra demanded.

“She found a frayed thread in the weft of realities. That your powerful yearning had unraveled. I am rather impressed she was capable of seeing the weave. Even more impressed she figured out how to tether her soul to yours. Then she merely pulled herself across the veil tearing a hole between realms” Angella turned to regard Tama. Her eyes burned with warning, about how dangerous that was.

Catra chuckled and shook her head. “When did you become so adventurous and reckless?” She chided Tama.

“I learned from the best.” Tama quipped smugly, before offering Angella a timid glance.

Catra laughed harder, in life Tama would just watch and follow her and Adora. As they competed in everything from who could climb highest to who could run the fastest all over the Fright Zone. Getting into mischief from one end of the fortress to the other, heedless of the dangers that surrounded them. This was the first time Tama had ever been so bold. She had done it all for her...because she sensed Catra was hurting and wanted to make her happy again. Catra’s smile was glowing with gratitude as she laughed. The crazy act of selfless kindness and compassion was just so Tama, it made Catra want to hug her tight again.

“So did the rest of you do the same thing?” Catra asked when she got her laughter under control.

“I tethered myself to Tama, when I saw her soul leap beyond the veil. “ Sara crossed her arms and gave Tama a scolding look. To which the fox hybrid avidly ignored.

“We tethered to Sara.” Arron shrugged, chucking his thumbs at Ami and Bryson who were standing on either side of him.

“I tethered myself to them, knowing I would have to bring them all back.” Louis admitted, his tone firm and commanding. Running a hand threw his long hair, a nervous tick he seemed to have held onto even after death.

Angella paid them all a soft smile. “Your loyalty and concern for each other is admirable but staying too long in the realm of the living is dangerous for spirits.”

“So it's like you are all holding hands across a chasm...with my magic as a metaphysical link…between realms” Catra mused, tapping her chin. “So as long as I can maintain the link then you can stay here...at least for a little while?” She looked up to Angella for confirmation.

“This is your magic, child. What do you propose?” Angella sighed, already used to compromising, thanks to dealing with her stubborn, hot headed daughter.

“The other’s miss you...It would help them all move on I think. If they got to see you too. At least for a little while to say goodbye. We never got the chance last time.” Catra offered, her voice breaking slightly at admitting the pain of losing her squad mates.

They all turned to ask silent permission from Angella. Who rolled her eyes and laughed in gentle resignation.

“Fine, I will wait here. As soon as you begin to feel your tether’s fray you must return to me. My magic can ferry you across safely to the other side.”

“Yeah!” Ami and Arron exclaimed, pumping their fists in the air.

“Com’on lets go!” Tama released Catra’s hand and bolted down the hillside at top speed. “I’m gonna freak ‘Dora out so bad!” She giggled.

Bryson ambled after Tama and the twins. “Max and Levi are going to be so confused. I am going to enjoy this.”

“Bryson...wait!” Catra lunged for the young man, grasping his shoulder before he could jog off.

Bryson turned, blinking up at her in confusion. His whole body had gone rigid, muscles tensed for a confrontation.

Catra cringed and pulled her hand back. Bowing her head in shame, she had bullied Bryson so bad back then.

“I’m….sorry for how I treated you...I’m...sorry I stole your harmonica and threw it away.”

Catra moaned, apologizing never got easier.

Bryson heaved a great sigh and offered her a smile of understanding.

“It’s ok...we were all just dumb kids then.” He advised, turning away from her.

“They blame themselves...for your death!” Catra called out to him.

Bryson stopped and turned back to her, his expression was pained then he simply nodded and jogged off.

Louis looked to Angella briefly, for consent that it was alright to go with them.

“Otis has missed you...Catra is right. Use this time to help him heal…” Angella smiled gently, silently giving Louis permission.

Louis nodded back then jogged off.

Sara sighed heavily, staring down at the campsite with a sad, desolate expression.

“Atila and I...we had finally given in to our feelings...Just before I left…” She choked out. “I want to give him closure...but I wonder if seeing me would only hurt him more?”

Catra’s ears folded at her admission, now questioning if bringing them back to camp was a good idea or if her good intentions would only create more harm?

“I’m sorry...for putting you on the frontlines. For pushing the army forward so relentlessly at the end. I was a power hungry tyrant and I understand how irresponsible and callous my order’s were back then. I put so many lives at risk...I can never make amends for that.” Carta began, her apology cut short when Sara turned and confronted her with a hard scowl.

“We were at war...you were in command...it was us or them? One side had to win and I wanted it to be our side.” Sara gripped Catra’s shoulders and gave her a small shake.

“You didn’t have to die….it’s my fault!” Catra shouted, refusing to be reassured that it wasn’t. She pushed Sara’s hands off her shoulders and crossed her arms stubbornly over her chest.

“I was fighting because I believed in the doctrine of the Horde. That we would bring order and prosperity to Etheria under Hordak’s rule.” Sara admitted.

“It was a lie...Hordak just wanted to conquer Etheria so he could hand it over to Horde Prime when he showed up.” Catra snarled, clamping her mouth shut and glancing nervously towards Sara regretting her heated words. Worried that her bitter admission to how pointless the war had been, would shame her, make her feel her death was meaningless.

“That does not concern me, my time here was over before Horde Prime showed up.” Sara turned a soft, patient expression on Catra. “What I am trying to explain. Is that I died fighting for what I believed in. I have no regrets beyond the pain and heartbreak my death caused Atila. I want to right that wrong tonight.” Sara nodded, then headed down the hill.

Catra heaved a long, drawn out breath then jogged after them. This had been her impulsive plan, helpful or not she would see it through. She would also make sure each one of those souls made it back into the afterlife.

Reconciliation

First year of Senior Training…

The beginning of the hot season was upon them. The heat and humidity, creating an uncomfortably clammy atmosphere within the Fright Zone. The air was stifling, thick with the rotting stench of the factory's chemical smog. The evening sky burned, glowing a brilliant orange and blood red. As the day moon's fell beyond the distant tower's of the Foundry that bordered the chain link fences of the cadet barracks. The sky high above was already darkening into the deeper, blue hues of the coming night.

Catra welcomed nightfall this time of year. The cooler temperatures was the only respite she got from the wet heat of the day. Otis and Rogelio never minded the moist heat, their scales and slick skin seemed to absorb it. Making them oddly kinda shiny this time of year. But she knew Atila who had the same layer of fine fur over his body understood her discomfort. The moisture clung to her like a slimy layer, she always felt unclean and long showers to wash it all off was not an option either. Her thick dark mane hung in wild waves down her back, falling over her eyes slightly. As she pulled off her bronze mask, tracing the contours absently with a clawed hand. Attempting to dry some of the sweat out of her bangs, by releasing her hair from the heavy mask. She set the mask down beside her, then pulled up her mane and shook it. Seeking to cool off the back of her neck. Then started to comb her finger's threw her mane, if was futile effort. She couldn't cool off at all. She had pulled off her orange tunic and dark knee length leather leggings. Leaving her in only her grey undershirt and ripped maroon shorts.

Catra lounged casually, against the chain link fence, with her legs stretched out, feigning indifference. As Red Squad had retreated to the outer training yard, as soon as Adora got back from her Trial debriefing with the other Squad Leaders. T he rusty metal

links clinking and creaking as she shifted her weight against it to get more comfortable. She pretended to be examining her bronze mask, idly thumbing the smooth points as she half listened to the tactical plan's her squad was discussing nearby. Rolling her head to the side, with a disinterested frown refusing to engage with the others. Even though her ear's swiveled to hone in on the hushed tones, whispering from the small huddle of her squad mates. Adora had pulled off her jacket and tossed it on her bunk, along with her white cadet t-shirt as soon as she got back to the bunk room. Desperate to cool off, she was now only in her undershirt and grey pants. The white sleeveless tank top had her muscular arms on full display, her toned stomach peeking out when ever she stretched beyond her reach. As she knelt high on her knees, with a stick in her hand, scratching at the dirt. Pointing at certain parts of the map she had scratched out earlier, her voice rising slightly with her enthusiasm. As she worked out their tactical assault, then she would nod as she acknowledged the other's opinions. The rest of the Squad were similarly dressed in mostly red or white t-shirts. Atila and Rogelio had their shirts off, their large well muscled chests were shiny with oily sweat. Atila had a red head scarf wrapped around his head to keep the sweat out of his eyes. HIs heavy black mane braided down his back. Rogelio only had a tuft of green hair atop his head so that wasn't much of a problem for him. Lizard-kin were built for the heat!

They were at the end of the testing week of their yearly trials. They would be engaged in a mock assault against Green Squad. Who were charged to defend a bunker along the southern Salineas coast. The simulator was being prepped for the first thing in the morning. To project a portion of beach head none of them had ever seen before. As was common for yearly assault trails, the scenario would be completely new. Adora had been given tactical details and a sparse map of the location and nothing else. This was a test of their teamwork skills and tactical capabilities.

Catra had long since given up on becoming Squad Leader. Her jealousy over Adora's red jacket now just a distant loathing she barely acknowledged. The only trophy she could lay claim too

from all her years of hard work was this mask. Shadow Weaver had given it to her several season's back, near the end of Sophmore training. A backhanded kindness, stating that since she was incapable of restraining her wild mane. That she needed this hair piece to keep her hair out of her face. So that she would stop being a hindrance to Adora during combat training. It was the only gift Shadow Weaver had ever given her. That would aid her to excel in her training. She both resented and took pride in the mask. Because it did help, a-lot actually. She had become far more confident and deadly with her attacks during combat scenarios against bots Coming to the rescue far more often than Adora, when their strike team got into trouble. Even her wins in hand to hand had improved. They were now one of the top ranking squads thanks to her, not that Shadow Weaver would ever give her credit for it. Adora took all the glory for their achievements...always.

"Alright, we got about a mile of beach to cross before we even reach the cliffs. That the bunker is hidden in." Adora sounded exhausted.

"These multi-phased plans have never worked out...Adora." Lonnie whined, crossing her arms over her chest.

"They always fall apart…" Sara sighed, staring down at the scratched out map in the dirt in dismay.

"We've gotten really good at improvising though." Levi added, elbowing Max who was sitting beside her in the huddle. Max and Levi had become a deadly duo over the years. Able to read each other's combat movements flawlessly, adapting their tactics on the fly when thing went sideways.

"Your battle tactics would be impressive...if they weren't always so terrifying." Kyle muttered, Rogelio growled in agreement.

"Look...the plan is sound...it just requires teamwork and precision timing…totally doable." Adora tapped her chin, her eyes darted over to Catra for back-up. But the magicat was ignoring her.

Fiddling with the points upon her mask, acting all aloof and uncaring about this very important planning session. Adora took a deep breath, it had been a long time since she could count on Catra to be responsible. Over the last few seasons. She had become more insolent and bad tempered. She had stopped taking their training seriously and seemed like she was just putting in time till graduation.

Adora had honestly lost a lot of faith in her. She would do as she pleased, consequences be damned. Adora needed to focus on her own goals, she had a squad to lead and a victory to plan.

"Did you take into account the heavy artillery, Green Squad will have mounted inside that bunker?" Catra quipped.

"Yes…" Adora, snipped back. "There is combat debris littered along the shore from previous battles. We are going to use that for cover, pushing forward every two minutes. While the B team covers us. A team will sneak up the ridge around the back and take out the bunker...easy!"

Catra sighed and crawled to her feet, striding over to the dirt scribbled map. She stood over Adora's shoulder, hands on her hips slowly scrutinizing their overly complicated strategy.

"Won't work." Catra huffed, "and I am tired of losing the trials, so I'll help."

"Hey!" Adora yelled with an indignant grunt, crossing her arms over her chest when Catra snatched her stick out of her hands.

The squad watched in silent irritation as Catra scribbled out Adora's strategy and redrew one of her own. She reassigned Kyle and Louis to B team. Stating that a smaller group would be able to move faster. The two strike teams would split up. B Team would be on the beach front. Fanning out just out of range of the cannons at first and fire on the bunker. Moving forward at staggered intervals to keep green squads attention on the beach. While the smaller A team would infiltrate the bunker from the

forest behind, never setting foot on the beach. Hopefully taking out the bunker before the Green squad picked off all of B team.

“So you want to use us as a distraction?” Sara huffed.

“Yes...obviously.” Catra shrugged.

“If this was a real battle….you would be throwing our lives away for a stupid bunker?” Louis pouted.

“Your soldiers, that's your purpose!” Catra was confused, “The Horde see’s your value by how useful you are. Our Force Captain is not going to take our lives into account when they send us out there to fight the Princesses. We have to win the War at all cost! Putting our lives on the line is what we were trained to do. If you die, then it’s your own damn fault.”

“No one is going to die.” Adora interceded, grabbing the stick away from Catra with a disgruntled frown.

"It's never gonna happen. Cause Adora's gonna be our Force Captain...anyway." Louis muttered petulantly, bowing his head and frowning down at his knees.

Catra huffed and slipped away to sulk against the fence. As Adora scratched out her plan and replaced it once again.

It didn’t take longer than five minutes for Adora’s plan to go to hell! The cover on the beach front was sparse. The map’s location of the debris had been inaccurate by several yards. So their timing was off, as they pushed forward to new cover up the beach. Making their timed assaults out of sync so cover fire was not always there. Forcing the groups that actually made it to the beach to scramble for new cover as they lurched forward. They were all dressed in full Horde Infantry Armor, as if this was a real battle. With the simulator sensors strapped to their chests, back, wrists and hips. With stun batons clipped to their utility belts and energy rifles mounted on their backs. That would shoot non-lethal

rounds of energy bolts. Enough of a charge to stun you and alert the sensor's if you got hit, not enough to kill. They were not wearing helmets, but the tactical-visor's that were required equipment during simulations. Since it tracked their combat stat's and downloaded the data right into their cadet files.

Max and Levi were pinned down, behind a flimsy barrier of barbed wire and sandbags to the south. Lying on their stomachs on the sand, as the energy cannon mounted inside the bunker laid waste on the beach in front of them. The blasts kicked up sand, creating a wall of fine dust that blinded them and had them choking for clean air. Unable to fire back, as they had to duck their faces into their armpits to find clean air to breath.

Atila and Sara got separated from their strike team close to the beginning of their maneuvers and were nowhere in sight. Otis and Louis were pinned down a few feet ahead, behind a blasted out tank canopy. The tank hatch was half buried in the sand, the turret sticking up towards the sky at a useless angle. The treads were curled and still smoking several yards away. They were huddled inside the twisted remains of the turret basket. They kept looking back over the metal railings, towards the fragment of dented metal sheeting. Adora and her group was hiding behind. Desperate for instruction as to where to go next. Since there was no cover, just bare sand for the next few yards ahead of the burnt out tank to the ridge.

The grassy slope of the ridge lay beyond the sand. It looked undisturbed, the bunker was high above them, completely hidden. If it wasn't for the glint of the metal mussel of the cannon and explosion of fire erupting from the gunner's hole. They would have never been able to pick out where Green Squad was hiding.

Lonnie and Rogelio were crouched behind Adora and Catra, as they all huddled behind a large broken piece of metal sheeting from the body of another smoldering tank. Kyle had been shot by the cannon just as they broke cover from the forest for the first time onto the beach. He lay sprawled and unconscious at the tree-line.

"This sucks...this sucks...this sucks!" Catra growled, ripping her visor off her face and tossing it to the sand. They had lost, so there was no need for that stupid piece of tech anymore. Her toe claws were curling into the sand in frustration. The muscles in her legs were twitching with the need to run. She was the fastest, she could take out that bunker on her own!

"The plan can still work, we just need to regroup." Adora advised with a small hopeful smile. Just as the cannon blew apart the sandbags, tossing Max and Levi into the air. Screaming in fright, their voices were abruptly silenced as they hit the sand hard. Several meter's back down the beach. Their chest sensor's blinked as they lay unconscious and sprawled on the sand.

"Adora what do we do?" Lonnie shouted, over the whine of the cannon recharging. Knowing that their cover was about to be destroyed.

Adora peeked her head around the side of the metal wall. Blue eyes narrowing in scrutiny at the bunker that lay just a few meters ahead. It was barely more than a hole in the cliff, with a large energy cannon poking out. It completely blended into the landscape, with grass and dirt covering the top and a curtain of vines obscuring the front.

"Screw this stupid plan!" Catra snarled, breaking cover on the other side of the metal sheeting and sprinting for the bunker.

"Catra!" Adora screamed in terror.

As a strike team from green squad flooded down the side of the rocky incline, lured out by Catra's kamikaze dash for the ridge. They converged upon Louis and Otis in seconds. Catra ignored their plight, focused on getting back into cover. As a couple members of that strike team hung back on the top of the ridge, to fire their rifles at her, thinking she was an easy target. She zigged and zagged through the meager debris, of scattered sand bags and barbed wire, as the energy bolts struck the sand around her. Her speed and agility along with her highly tactical mind, kept her

one step ahead of the sniper fire. Leaping amid the rocks and boulders that covered the far side of the cliff. She was going to take out what was left of Green squad hiding in that bunker and win this trial all on her own!

Adora growled in frustration as she watched Catra disappear behind the rocks of the cliffside. Resigned that Catra was going to do as she pleased....as always!

"We gotta go help them!" Adora commanded, racing out of cover with Lonnie and Rogelio. They pulled their rifles off their backs, laying retaliatory fire at the approaching soldier's converging on Otis and Louis. Sprinting full speed towards the burnt out tank. As their outnumbered comrades engaged in hand to hand combat.

Catra was inside the bunker, taking out the soldier's within. She had slipped into the back hatch that had been left open by the Strike Team that had flooded out earlier. Slinking in silent and unnoticed. Knocking out the two guards that had been positioned by the side of the hatch with her stun baton. It was dark inside the small, cramped hole which gave her the advantage. The only light source was the sudden sparks of her stun baton connecting with sensors and the alarmed shouts of the soldier's. She was knocking out the last of them, when Adora's frantic scream broke through Catra's battle haze.

"Medic!" Adora screamed, again and again.

Catra was in motion instantly, her heart leaping in her chest with fear. That Adora had gotten seriously hurt. She ran out the back of the bunker on all fours, leaving her stun baton behind. Leaping to the grass covered roof of the bunker, she quickly surveyed the aftermath of the battle on the beach below. Finding Adora kneeling behind the burnt out tank hood with Lonnie and Rogelio. Otis was hovering over the body of Louis, who was lying curled up into a ball. The squid hybrid had begun to triage his best friend. Pulling off the young man's tactical visor and tossing it aside,

beginning to unlatch his chest armor to see the damage. Louis's chest armor was scorched and caved in, the sensor melted. As if he had taken a real cannon blast, point blank. The damage was far beyond what their training weapons were capable of. At least not during a combat trial...

"We didn't mean it…" A green squad member muttered, his eyes wide in fright.

"We just wanted to take you guys out in one hit…So we would have the fastest time. So we hacked the security settings for our stun batons..." Another green squad member tried to explain.

Catra's ear's flattened as she heard those fateful words. She leaped from the bunker, free falling off the cliff and landing in a puff of sand on all fours on the breach. Landing several feet below and rolling into a forward somersault to absorb the concussion of the impact. Regaining her footing she ran on all fours towards the tank once again. Rage and grief ignited inside of her as she cleared the distance. Suddenly overwhelmed with bloodlust and the need to exact revenge once more. She leaped up on the tank turret, crouching over the rival strike team that stood below. Snarling down at them a ball of pain and fury. Claws fully extended, pupils thinned to predatory pin pricks. Her canines on display as she roared down at them, they sucked in a terrified breath. Their faces growing pale and slowly backing up. The slowest soldier to react became her prey. She pounced on his chest, slamming him into the ground. Crouched on his chest, claws raised and ready to tear him apart. She couldn't hear his screams over the pounding of the blood rushing in her ears.

Rogelio was fueled with a righteous need for revenge as well. He growled and engaged in the fight. Heedless of the consequences, he grabbed the nearest enemy soldier by the throat and tossed them away. Punching and howling at the next soldier, as he sought to pound what was left of the green squad into the dirt.

Catra had torn apart the armor of several soldier's who were now scrambling to get away in the tattered shreds of their cadet

uniforms. Racing up the beachfront, pale and terrified. One soldier had not been fast enough to evade Catra's deadly strikes. She had sliced through the chest armor, her claws digging deep into the flesh beneath. He was now curled up against the loosened, twisted treads of the tank a few yards away. Blood seeping through his fingers, his tactical visor cast aside. As he stared down at his fatal wound in fright.

Rogelio had pinned his prey beneath him, straddling the enemy soldier's chest. The soldier's chest armor was dented beyond recognition by the lizard-kin's powerful fists. His visor was ripped viciously off his head and tossed aside. As Rogelio had gone completely feral, his hybrid instincts to kill took over. His large powerful fists, swinging again and again at the young man's head. Smashing the boy's nose and pounding his face into a bloody pulp.

"Catra!...Rogelio!" Lonnie screamed, trying to regain control. As the two Hybrids hovered threateningly over their prey. Catra had left the soldier she had gored in the chest to bleed out, uncaring how long it took for him to die. Turning and leaping on the back of another soldier trying to run away. She was currently crouched on their shoulder' blades pinning them face first into the sand. Rogelio had left his first prey and hunted down two more trying to flee. He had smashed the two soldier's heads together and now they lay slumped against each other on the sand at Rogelio's feet.

Otis was standing over Louis's body, in stunned confusion. His four tentacles shivering in fear. Adora knelt over Louis's body. Her face was pale, wild, terrified eyes shimmering with tears. Unwilling to try and reign in her squad. A part of her wanted them to seek revenge, wanted to help them hunt down the rest of Green Squad. Instead she held Louis's hand, as the warmth ebbed away. His face was frozen in a surprised expression as death took him. As he stared up at her from the sand. His eyes became dull, unseeing.

When Catra reentered camp, she was confronted by a strange, comforting kinda chaos.

Bryson had Max and Levi cornered near their tent. Chatting happily and uncaring or not noticing how freaked out they were. The two adults were standing dumbstruck and confused, staring down at their childhood friend. They had lost over a decade earlier. Atila was not as shell shocked by Sara's sudden appearance. Having wrapped her up in a bear hug and was currently swinging her in small circles near the willow tree, laughing with relief and joy. Otis sat with Louis near the river bank, speaking in hushed tones. Reconnecting with the teen, in that same quiet, rather stoic nature of his. Louis had always been the louder, more outgoing side to that pair. Lonnie and Rogelio stood stunned near the fire. As Ami and Arron were laughing and dancing around Kyle who was standing by the fire, tidying up the skewer's that once cooked the fish. His sky blue eyes kept track of them, as he offered them a wary, yet happy smile. He had magic now, so he was more open with encountering unbelievable events. Nervous and a little jittery about suddenly seeing his dead bunkmates. He attempted to back out of Ami and Arron's dancing circle. Only to trip over his own feet and land on his back on the ground. As soon as Kyle's body hit the ground, which was covered in dried leaf litter and sticks. His skin morphed into black soil, dried leaves and sticks, instantly concealing him in the thick shadows beyond the firelight.

Ami and Arron cried in alarm and began to search the ground. Their frantic pawing hands quickly find Kyle. Who started giggling and squirming as they unintentionally tickled him. His transformed body is a writhing pile of leaves and sticks, making Ami and Arron laugh in turn. Catra smiled fondly at their antics for a moment. Before she started scanning the campsite for Adora. Tama was missing too? Which had Catra jogging right through camp, grabbing her clothes from the rock as she went. She left the leather jacket, knowing its thick hide would take longer to dry. Her

ear's were flickering at every tiny sound. As her stomach dropped in anxiety. Plagued by doubts that perhaps in her absence. Adora had been pushed out of camp as well, needing to get away from the tense unwelcome atmosphere. But where would she have gone?

She sniffed the air, moving cautiously back into the woods. Slipping into her black leggings and training shirt. Slowly walking upward along the overgrown path of roots and boulders. That descended down from the side of the rocky cliff that held the waterfall. Making her way back into the thicker forest just beyond.

A gentle wind rushed through the trees, carrying Adora's scent. The smell was warm, sweet and always intoxicating to Catra. She stood for a moment, breathing in the welcoming smell. That had always meant safety, love, and happiness to her. Letting it cleanse the painful memories of the past few days, that still lingered like a shadow in the recesses of her thoughts. It would take time and many more painful conversations before all their...battle scars have been acknowledged and could begin healing.

Catra was not eager for those difficult and highly emotional talks. But she was also resigned to having them. As much as was needed to resolve the anger and heartache that still remained between them. She had made a promise to herself. That night in the Whispering Woods before going back to the compound for Adora. That if she was going to go back to Adora's side and help her reach the Heart. Then no matter what happened she was never going to leave her side again!

The Greater Moons and their satellites were high overhead, when she moved into the thick greenwood above the campsite. Her feline eyes glowed, as her pupils grew. Taking in what light they could from the moons to penetrate the darkness of the forest. The once verdant leaves of daylight, now hovered around her in a muted blue-grey hue. The thick underbrush cast in deep shadow, the night time creatures rustling and chittering about their intruder. Catra felt a catch in her throat, as she moved into the

dense tickets of towering oaks and sprawling beech trees. This place was as mysterious and magical as the Whispering Woods….and it lay within this valley. Deep inside what was once the barren wasteland of the Fright Zone. The symbolism was not lost on Catra, to walk amid this beauty...that was now flourishing where once was such a desolate, harsh landscape only a year ago.

Magic….it was amazing and so undeniably powerful.

It gave her hope. In the strength and resiliency of her long time friendship with Adora. That had bloomed into love just recently. That they could survive their harsh past and flourish as they moved forward together. She would hold onto that hope and never give up on them ever again. No matter what life throws at them from now on, they will overcome it...together.

“Cat!” Tama’s bright, childish voice echoed from the tree’s ahead.

Followed by Adora’s playful laughter, that rang through the branches. Cascading upon her like the gloriously beautiful song that it was.

Catra wandered forward, keeping a close eye on the forest floor, not wanting to be hampered by a stray root or bramble. As she sniffed the air, her feet practically danced over the narrow dirt path. Leaping over roots and darting through the underbrush as she tracked them. Moving deeper into the forest amid the twisting roots of giant oak and sprawling beech trees.

Tama’s laughter became more excited the closer she got to their location.

“Dora and I are hiding...come find us!” She called in a childish sing-song. So pleased with being a part of this game. Playing with her long lost friends once again.

“Tama...Adora…” Catra called up into the trees, turning in a small circle just before the huge beech tree Adora had pinned her to earlier.

Her ears folded back in both awe and alarm, to find a large rain tarp. That would be draped over the top of a tent. Now strung up in the branches high above as a large hammock.

Finding both Adora and Tama peeking over the edge, grinning down at her with beaming, eager smiles.

“Com’on Catra...get up here!” Adora called her.

“I’ll time ya...how fast can you climb, Cat!” Tama taunted.

Catra offered them a knowing smirk, leaping up to the nearest branch. She clutched onto the bark with her claws digging in to keep her purchase, hanging for a moment before swinging herself up. To perch on all fours on the branch, then she ran down the length to the trunk. Digging her claws into the bark, as she climbed to the next branch that grew just out of reach.

Swinging, climbing and leaping from branch to branch in a zig zag pattern up into the vast canopy above. She was soon crouching in the crutch of two branches just above the homemade hammock. Panting and grinning triumphantly down at them. Her mismatched eyes glowing with mirth.

Tama was rolling on the tarp, clapping and giggling with glee.

As Adora settled down on her back, arms crossed behind her head. Once again dressed in her white long sleeve shirt and grey pants, her feet still bare. Gazing up at her with such a proud, affectionate expression. Catra’s heart instantly melted, then she scanned the hammock with a wary eye.

“Who’s idea was this?” Catra asked, nervously. Tama usually was the one to come up with such a 'creative' endeavour as this. While Adora and sometimes Catra would be the muscle to get it done.

“Mine.” Tama shouted proudly, rocking on her butt and holding her toes.

“Figures.” Catra muttered.

“Don’t trust my handiwork?” Adora prompted.

“No, I trust that you can tie a knot. I worry about how this flimsy, threadbare tarp you used is going to tear with my added weight and claws.?” Catra commented, curling her fingers and flashing her claws.

“Valid.” Adora nodded, casting Tama a knowing look.

“I never thought you were a scaredy Cat….Cat.” Tama commented with a mischievous smile.

“I’m not scared...I’m being cautious there’s a difference!” Catra shot back, suddenly feeling like she had just reverted to childhood. Tama was pushing her buttons, just like she knew how.

“Aww, ok...if you don’t trust me then.” Adora pouted, pretending to be hurt and affronted by Catra’s refusal to join them.

“Adora…” Catra whined. “I’m just...looking out for you. I don’t want us to go crashing to the ground if this thing doesn’t hold. I got claw’s and I’m agile. I’ll be able to save myself. I’ll be perfectly fine, Tama’s…” Catra frowned and grew quiet as she sought to articulate her opinions nicely.

“A clutz!” Tama offered, with a beaming grin.

“Yeah...so you might just bounce all the way down like an idiot. While Adora on the other hand will go crashing down like a lead weight breaking all her bones on the way.” Catra finished a smirk, realizing that she didn't need to soften her snark around her best friends. As Adora huffed and stuck out her tongue in mocking indignation.

Tama heaved a long suffering sigh and stood up. She began to bounce upon the tarp as if it was a trampoline. Adora squealed in fright, rolling onto her stomach. Stretching out her arms and legs into a starfish pose so as to not get thrown off.

“Scaredy Cat! Scaredy Cat stuck in a tree! Scaredy Cat, Scaredy Cat she can’t catch me!” Tama stuck out her tongue and cackled with childish glee.

That was the final button push Catra needed. To throw caution aside and reclaim the reckless abandon of her youth. She hopped down, making the tarp ripple and jump, like waves upon the sea. Adora shouted in fright as the tarp snapped aggressively beneath her. Catra was now crouched on the rippling tarp. Knees bent, tail out straight and arms out to her sides to maintain her balance. Glancing nervously at all corners of the tarp, scrutinizing the ropes wrapped and tied into sailor’s knots around other branches. As Tama’s little body bounced towards Adora, as the tarp moved violently to compensate for Catra’s weight. The fox giggled at the simple joy of the ride, clutching onto Adora's waist as she landed next to the blonde. As the tarp sought to fling them all off the side.

Slowly the tarp settled down and so did they.

“That was fun…” Tama breathed wistfully, casting Catra a hopeful look that she might climb up the tree and jump onto the tarp again.

Catra merely settled down near Adora on her side, as Tama lay between them. Her wide innocent green eyes turned to stare up at the endless starlight with wonder. The branches above had twisted as they grew away from the trunk, to leave a large open space in the canopy like a natural skylight. They could see the endless blanket of star’s spread over the night sky for miles.

“Let me guess, you're hiding up here cause you were not welcome either?” Catra commented dryly a couple minutes later.

“Things could have gone better.” Adora admitted. ”But I’m not giving up. We can fix this Catra.” She turned and regarded her girlfriend sternly.

“Sorry, I bailed on you.” Catra sighed, shrugging sadly.

“I understood, the sun was setting.” Adora, leaned over Tama and cupped Catra’s cheek. Her eyes are tender, her expression is easy and accepting.

“I wish you would have come back after you sang, though.” Adora added, pulling her hand away.

“I assumed you would just follow me...or at least come find me.” Catra turned her gaze away, staring ruefully up at the stars.

“I figured you needed some space...and I had to try and repair our friendship with the others.” Adora released a long drawn out breath.

“How bad was it?” Catra inquired.

Adora made an explosion sound, her hands mimicking the ever expanding cloud of smoke and debris.

“Just as I predicted.” Catra huffed, shaking her head.

“I really need to just stop and think things through..” Adora winced. “I might have made things slightly worse.” She pinched her fingers together in a measuring gesture.

“How!” Catra spun her head back and snapped in alarm. Adora could be rather bold and earnest when she went after something. She made it a mission to succeed at all costs...during training, missions and now friendship repair. She was now anxious to know what kind of damage. Adora had done. To their already very rocky acceptance amongst their old peers.

Adora opened her mouth to explain. When Tama jumped up and knelt between them.

The little fox had been turning her head back and forth between them as their anxious conversation volleyed back and forth. But had now lost all patience with them, wasting their precious time on trivial worries. With a groan she had rolled up onto her knees,

smashing her hands over either of the women’s mouths. Scowling down at them in irritation.

“Stop...this is life stuff...you two can deal with tomorrow.” She whined. “I only got tonight...so it’s Tama Time!” she declared. Flopping back down between them with a sulking huff.

Both women stared down at her in surprise, blinking lamely. Then nodded in agreement. “You're taking Tama’s appearance rather well.” Catra quipped.

“Oh, I was surprised at first.” Adora admitted with a sigh. Giving Tama’s red hair a fond ruffle. “But I’ve learned to just roll with strange magic events.”

“Yeah, Being a Princess brings the weird.” Catra acknowledged.

“Really,” Adora cocked an eyebrow. “So this weird thing is you're doing, then. Princess?” she verbally poked with a teasing smile. Her blue eyes shone with a smug amusement, as Catra groaned and rolled her eyes. She knew damn well, Adora could see the blue glow that surrounded her body and that damned tiara that always appeared upon her forehead when she called her powers.

“Shut up!” Catra huffed.

“She cast Soul Pyre.” Tama answered absently, pointing up at the stars to the southwest. Both women followed her pointing finger as she seemed to connect the stars into a pattern. “It’s so cool, you brought the star’s back. Dora.” She breathed in awe.

“Been telling her stories?” Catra arched an inquisitive eyebrow.

“We got a lot of catching up to do.” Adora shrugged.

“Yeah, Dora told me all about the war and your big fight. That you were a bad kitty, but now you're a good kitty.” Tama turned with a teasing grin, poking Catra between the eyes with a claw.

“Adorrrraaaa.” Catra whined. “What all did you tell her!”

“I told her the truth and nothing less.” Adora responded ardently, nodding her head towards the stars.

“You two had so many amazing adventures.” Tama spread her arms wide over their heads. “It kinda sucks that I missed it all.” She pouted.

“What is it like over there...in the Eternal Realm?” Adora asked, her voice a breathy whisper as if it was taboo too ask.

“Can’t tell ya.” Tama shrugged. “It’s like a secret club though, once you cross over to that side you get to know. But I’m happy there.”

They were quiet for a long time. Both Adora and Catra gazed at Tama with soft, loving eyes. As the little fox continued to scan the star’s above, using her tiny fingers to draw above their heads.

“Can you see the animals in the sky, too?” Tama asked in a hushed whisper.

“We can if you show us.” Adora moved in closer to Tama, leaning the side of her face against Tama’s temple. Catra followed on the other side of the little fox, a low purr rumbling out of her chest. As she felt the soft fur of Tama's cheek against her face, the child’s gentle nostalgic scent filled her nose.
Tama smiled and closed her eyes with a contented hum. “I missed you guys…” She sniffled.

“We missed you too.” Both Adora and Catra responded in unison.

Soon they were all giggling and stargazing, sharing stories of their childhood. Basking in the easy rekindling of their friendship, simply enjoying their time together. A sad, but calm acceptance falling over them, knowing that their time would not be for long.

It was a few hours before sunrise, when Tama began to feel the light, feathery tingle across her body of the Eternal Realm calling to her. It was time to go. She slowly and carefully, began to shift herself out of the all encompassing cuddle she was trapped in between Adora and Catra's arms.

"Is it time?" Catra mumbled, her arms instinctively pulled Tama close, refusing to let her go.

"Yeah...I gotta get back.." Tama responded in a soft whisper.

"Ok...can we walk you back to the rift then?" Adora countered, unwilling to just let her leave on her own.

"Sure." Tama's fluffy, auburn ears flared wide and flickered with happiness.

It took a few minutes to crawl across the hammock and climb down as both Adora and Catra were still sluggish and bleary from not getting any sleep.

Once on the ground, they headed down the overgrown path. The dried leaf litter crunching under their feet. Adora led them, head down in solemn acceptance. Holding onto Tama's chubby hand who walked behind her. Catra walked quietly in the back, holding Tama's other hand tightly. Tama merely swung her smiling face back and forth between them. Content and happy with the gift she had been given, she would cherish these new memories for eternity.

"I'm sure happy...that you guys are still friends." She grinned broadly, showing off her fangs.

"More than friends now, actually." Adora added with a giggle, casting Catra a fond, affectionate look. Who instantly blushed and smiled bashfully, as she bowed her head.

Tama's eyebrows raised as she giggled. "You two fell in love...didn't you?" Her grin widened even bigger with joy.

“It was a hard road getting there..but we figured it all out eventually.” Catra swung theirs hands playfully.

“Yeah, well...neither of you were ever really that self aware.” Tama huffed, sounding far wiser than her age. She sounded more like an adult? Which made Catra wonder how the Eternal Realm worked?

“Hey!” Both Adora and Catra cried out in friendly rebuttal.

“It seriously took you fifteen years to figure out what I already knew as a little kid.” Tama huffed.

“I doubt you knew…you were just a dumb kid just like the rest of us.” Catra grumped.

“Ok, you want proof? You slept with Adora almost every night.” Tama began.

“Cause Adora had nightmares.” Catra stated.

“More like you had nightmares!” Tama shot back.

“You climbed into Adora’s bed plenty too.” Catra countered.

Tama nodded, sagely.

“I did...I had lots of nightmares then too…” She added, her voice fading into a melancholy refrain as she kept the reason for those nightmares a secret.

While Adora began to chuckle. “Why are you two even debating this?”

“You held hands like all the time, you played together like all the time, you always chose each other when we partnered up during training… like all the time. You ate together like all the time. You were inseparable...no one would want to be around another person that much unless they loved them.” Tama answered.

“Yeah, well you did all that stuff with us too.” Catra jerked her little arm tenderly, with a fond smirk.

Tama giggled, acknowledging how close they had been. ”I knew what love was...before I was taken by the Horde Soldier’s. So I knew you loved one another...and I knew you loved me.” She finished her voice fading into a breathless tremble as she fought not to cry.

Adora moaned and turned abruptly, wrapping her arms around Tama. As she bit down on her lower lip valiantly trying not to sob too loudly.

Tama mumbled in alarm into Adora’s stomach, her little hands clenching tight to the white fabric at her back. As she cried softly.

“Adora ease up, your going to smother her?” Catra exclaimed, her voice tender as her eyes filled with tears.

“She's already dead...Catra..I can hug her as tight as I want.” Adora responded indignantly.

“True…” Catra nodded, striding forward and embracing Tama from behind just as tightly.

The little fox let out a squeak of both glee and dismay as her best friends pressed her between their bodies like a vise. Laughing and crying as they squeezed her relentlessly.

The campsite was empty, as they passed through. The rest of their bunkmates had already left and headed up to the overlook. That the rift between realms was hovering upon. Their pace unconsciously began to slow as they got closer to the crest of the hill. They could see the dark silhouettes of the others, already standing around the glowing shimmer in the air.

“Wait!” Tama shouted, pulling on Adora and Catra’s hands forcing them to stop.

Adora and Catra crouched down on either side of her, eyes wet and brimming with tears.

“I need to tell you guys something in private.” She leaned in, her voice a low conspiratorial whisper.

Adora eyes widened in apprehension while Catra’s ears flickered nervously.

“It’s a secret ok...Queen Angella would be really mad at me if she found out I was sharing stuff you only get to know after you're dead.” Tama’s expression turned stern, as she held her pinky finger. “It’s gotta be a pinky promise...unbreakable and forever.”

Catra and Adora nodded, holding out their pinky’s. This ritual had been common between the three of them. Tama linked her pinky with theirs and nodded solemnly. As the two women leaned in to hear the whispered secret.

Tama glanced briefly at each woman, a slow sly smile spreading over her lips.

She slowly guided them down to the grass, sitting happily as they settled down.

“This will be my last story...so listen good.”

Adora nodded, her expression serious, as Catra rolled her eyes with a smirk . Tama was always so dramatic, but she loved her stories so she sat attentively.

Tama cleared her throat. “ Once there were two fox cubs, who wandered too far from their village. To caught up in their game of chase, they soon got lost deep in the forest. One got her leg caught in a hunters trap. The other cub got scared and ran, leaving her to her fate. She cried for hours for someone to come save her. Twisting and pulling on her leg, until all the sweat and

blood allowed her to pull it free. She began to limp back to her village but she soon grew tired...but she kept walking. Focusing on her steps forward. Time passed and she came upon a stream. She decided to stop for a drink, noticing how several crows had started to circle above. One crow swooped down and perched upon a branch over her head. They were waiting for her to die. She grimaced and looked down at her mangled leg, it was bleeding really bad and she felt so tired. She could just lay down here by the stream, it was pretty and peaceful. She was mortally wounded and would not last the night, anyway. Better to stay here and get it over with then keep struggling to get home. More loud caws shattered the night sky above, as the crows began to descend. Perching around her, in the lower branches, waiting for her end. She was mad at first that her friend had left her to die, but she still loved her. Wanted to see her again. Thinking that perhaps her friend had been scared and had gone to find help? She decided to believe her friend had not left her to die and that she needed to see her again. She would not die here in this beautiful place but push on, no matter what, just to see her again. So she stood up and began to walk. The crows circled and jeered, belittled and threatened the injured fox. She began to weaken and fall into despair, knowing that the village was still far, far away. But she kept walking, her body ached and the pain in her leg was like fire slowly consuming her. But she kept focused on seeing her friend again. Time passed, it came to a point in which she could not go on. She fell to the ground amid the flowers of a lush and beautiful glen. Staring up at the warm blue sky above, she slowly closed her eyes. Knowing that she would see her friend again. She just had to be patient and never give up hope. Warmth and peace overwhelmed her, as the pain faded away and she slept. Time passed, then an echo filled the glade that was someone calling her name. She opened her eyes. There was her friend fully grown but still as sweet and kind as she remembered her. She scrambled up onto her feet, fully healed and eager to embrace her friend. Who looked so happy and relieved to have finally found her again.”

Both Adora and Catra stared down at Tama awestruck and slightly confused. As Tama grinned proudly up at them.

“That’s kinda a sad story to be telling, us?” Catra groused, realizing Tama had merely used the ruse of telling them secrets about life after death as a lure to get them interested. She had just wanted to tell them one final story.

Tama cocked her head, in confusion. “It had a happy ending?”

Adora’s brow was furrowed as she contemplated the bitter sweet tale.

“I will wait for you in the glade, until you come and join me.” Tama leaned forward and patted Catra’s hand softly. Before rising to her feet and jogging away to the hilltop.

Catra and Adora scrambled after her, the weight of impending loss once again crushing them both.

Adora stood awestruck. As she saw Angella standing before the rift. She was glorious, an ethereal regality to her form. Glowing a warm, soft white. Her elegant wings spread wide, hands clasped serenely before her. It had been years since she had sacrificed herself. The guilt and worthlessness that had once consumed Adora after the portal, washed over her anew. If she had been stronger, smarter...more in control of the magic, perhaps she could have saved her.

Angella turned towards her, her warm iridescent white glow flaring as she regarded Adora with a soft, loving smile.

“Come here, child.” She beckoned, slowly raising her arms.

Adora swallowed hard, darting into Angella’s arms as silent tears fell down her cheeks.

“I’m sorry...I’m so sorry…you had to die.” she whimpered as she sought to embrace the queen.

She had been expecting to hold onto something solid, when her arms passed through Angella. Enveloped in a warm, glowing vapor instead. Adora took a quick step backward, staring up at the queen with a stunned, slightly dumbstruck expression.

“I am an Immortal. I can not die, child. I only had to give up my physical form to escape that unstable dimension, before it imploded. My body is now trapped in the currents of the Cross Roads of Worlds, but my essence has always been pure magic.” She explained, “So I was able to traverse the dimensions to an extent. I exist now in the plane of existence the lies beyond life. Having taken on my true responsibilities. That I was given at the beginning of time but refused. I was a coward and ran away from my destiny. Far to young then, immature and selfish. Hiding in the mortal realm, reveling in the carefree, joys of youth. As the eons came and went. I watched over the universe as it expanded from the Source. Becoming more lively, more complicated and I watched many civilizations rise and fall. I grew older, wiser…. I fell in love with Etheria…sought to protect it…fell in love again with a mortal man and unbelievably became a mother. Leaving was hard and I regret the pain I caused to you and Glimmer…to Micah. But it's merely my time to finally be brave and take my place within the eternal weave. ” Angella instructed with a warm, regretful smile at the sorrow she had put Adora through.

“Can we get your body back… bring you back to Etheria?” Catra interrupted, knowing that time was limited.

“I was never a mortal creature? That form was just a construct… my magic willed it into physical form when I retreated into the Mortal Realm. Life...death...those terms have no meaning for me.” Angella smiled patiently.

“You are like Oroborous?” Catra nodded.

“In a way, yes.” Angella chuckled.

“Sheana and Despara….they are beings of pure magic too.” Adora added.

“No, they are more than magic. They are the threads that bind the universe together. I exist within their threads as we all do.” Angella instructed again, glancing impatiently over to the other’s. Who were still saying their goodbyes.

She glanced at Catra, finding the blue glow that was once so robust and strong, had faded. Flickering softly along the hybrid’s body like a dying flame.

“The conduit grows tired, we need to go now, children.” She commanded gently.

Adora filed away all that Angella had said. She had a lot of research and training to do when she got back to the Crystal Castle. She looked down at her two gauntlets, their presence solid proof that she could learn to wield She-Ra again. This time she was certain that she would get all the answers she needed to master her powers. No more stumbling around, pleading to the universe to give her what she needed to save everyone. This time she would be strong enough, knowledgeable enough to wield the full might of She-Ra without fear.

Tama clutched onto their hands again, drawing them away from Angella.

Catra and Adora willingly allowed themselves to be pulled away. Their attention quickly drawn into the tearful farewells around them. As Tama quietly slipped away into the rift, smiling fondly at them as she faded away.

Ami and Arron bid Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio goodbye with a sad smile and wave. As they turned and walked through the shimmer in the air. Their bodies turned translucent, as they faded away. The air rippled as they crossed over.

Otis clapped Louis on the shoulder, his expression was stoic but his yellow eyes were wet.

“I’ll see you soon.” Louis promised. Then turned to regard Catra.

“Thank you.” Louis nodded towards her. Catra sniffled and nodded back, as he walked into the rift, shimmering away. Another flash, vibrated just in front of the rift.

Bryson was a sniffling, crying, mess. As he hugged Levi and Max, goodbye.

“Bye.” He blurted out, then turned and ran through the rift. Levi and Max watched him go, holding each other and crying softly. The boy faded and a more solid flash of electric blue light flared just before the tear in reality.

Catra’s eyes narrowed, as the flash of light briefly made a feline outline before fading away.

“I don’t want to let you go.” Atila pleaded in a low rumble, his face was tucked tight against Sara’s neck. She was crying softly, petting her hands down Atila’s long black hair.

“I know...but we will be together one day. I need you to live for me, Atila. Promise me, you will strive to have a good and fulfilling life?” Sara demanded, pulling away from him. Staring up at him earnestly, as he slowly nodded.

“I will love only you…” He whispered, leaning down and kissing her tenderly.

“Thank you...but I hope not.” Sara chuckled. Giving his large hand a final squeeze before pulling away and dashing through the tear in reality. Feeling she needed to leave swiftly and without further delay, so Atila could start to move on and heal.

As her body shimmered away a final flash illuminated the grey, pre dawn. As the blinding blue flash faded away. Melog’s dark lavender body and pulsing mane of blue fire remained. As they crumpled to the ground, exhausted and drained of magic.

Catra was awash with new clarity as the blue flame that once covered her body snuffed out as well. She dashed to Melog’s side, wrapping her arms around their neck.

“Thank you…” She muttered irreverently against the cool mist of their mane.

(I gave them my body, so that their souls could have a physical form...so that you may say farewell properly.) Melog moaned in utter exhaustion, their mental voice barely a whisper.

“Take my magic...take what you need…” Catra whispered, holding them close as the edges of the valley began to glow with the coming dawn. The soft cries and sniffles of her bunkmates' mourning accented the peaceful dawn.

Adora kept a close eye on Angella, as she turned and merely walked away. Her ethereal presence fading into the warm, morning light.

Rebirth

As the sun began to warm the horizon, setting the low lying clouds aflame. Catra's voice echoed out over the warming valley.

"*We have both been there before,*

Feeling lost and alone,

Searching for that place to call home,

Struggling to find hope. "

Trembling with a long held sorrow, a wash in the memories of an innocence lost too quickly. Her childhood, ground up in the unrelenting cog of the Horde's War Machine.

"We both have battle scars.

Demons and broken hearts.

Trying our best to cope."

Her tone brightened, rising in volume and power. As the sun ascended above the far away hills. With the light no longer hindered by the valley's rim. It illuminated the valley, warming everything into a beautiful golden hue.

"Please don't worry,

You can trust in me,

You will never be alone.”

Catra slowly pulled away from Melog’s neck, where she had been huddling as dawn approached. She kept her head bowed, eyes closed as she focused upon the magic within her melody. Her song was no longer held by the normal bonds of mere voice and tone. Her magic began to thread her emotions within the lyrics. Soon the air was thick with love, hope and her heartfelt wish to find absolution from the darkness that haunted her...haunted all of them as child soldiers.

“Leave the pain behind,

I’ll be by your side.

I’ll be by your side.”

Catra ears swiveled as she heard Adora’s quiet sobs, beside her. With her eyes still closed, she curled her tail around Adora’s arm. Sensing her sitting just beside her on the grass, offering her subtle comfort. Melog purred softly on her other side, soothed by her voice and her magic as they rested. Absorbing her magic into themselves to strengthen and replenish the stores they had lost last night.

“When the light is fading, don’t be sad.

I”ll be there.

When you’re lost in the dark, don’t be scared.

I”ll be there.”

Catra slowly opened her eyes, finding her remaining squad members had settled on the grass around her. Listening to her song, each in a trance-like state of somber reflection.

“It’s so hard to start over,

when you have battle scars.

Demons and broken hearts.”

She sought to reach out to each of them, seeking to connect and offer them peace with their tortured pasts. Locking eyes with Lonnie first. Who was held in a three-way embrace with both Kyle and Rogelio, crying silently. Her soft hazel eyes mirrored the sorrow and regret she held in her own heart.

“Please don’t cry,

You can trust in me.

You will never be alone.”

Catra slowly blinked at Lonnie, who was stunned at first but gave her a small smile in return. Then Catra pulled her gaze away towards Levi and Max. Who sat holding hands with their heads bowed. They were lost to bittersweet memories, struggling to find closure for the guilt they carried for Bryson’s death. Catra understood that kind of crushing guilt, she carried the same for Glimmer’s mother.

“We all need someone to rely on,

A hand to reach out for,

When we’re hanging by a thread.”

She found Otis sitting on his knees, gently rubbing the metal bulb of one of his amputated tentacles. His yellow eyes shined but not a single tear fell. He was at peace over not protecting Louis. Whatever they had talked about last night. He was now able to move on.

“Leave the pain behind,

I’ll be by your side.

I’ll be by your side.”

Atila was staring right back at Catra, his dark eyes cool and void of emotion...his face frozen...expressionless. His burly frame was trembling as she sang, large hands balled into tight fists against the grass, as he knelt on all fours. Looking very much like a bull about to charge.

“When you stumble and fall,

I’ll be there, to pull you up.

When you feel broken inside,

I’ll be there, to hold the pieces.

I will always be by your side…”

The mournful aura was too much for her and as her song ended in a painful whisper. Catra succumbed to her own grief and began to allow the tears to fall. Her body began to shake and quickly the warmth and security of Adora’s arms surrounded her. She tucked her head into Adora’s neck. Holding on tight as the heartbroken sobs tore from her throat. Adora cried softly. Allowing for the first time all the sorrow and guilt to rise to the surface. For Tama and all the other cadets she had failed to protect. Finally releasing those toxic emotions she had held onto, purging them from her heart.

As the sun ascended over the horizon, none of them were willing to move. Exhausted and lethargic from grief. They all settled down in the grass falling asleep. Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio were curled up together. While Max and Levi snuggled in each other’s arms. Otis and Atila lay near each other. While Adora hugged Catra close, her slightly taller body, curling around her smaller frame. As Melog’s low, rumbling purr echoed into the coming dawn.

It was the heat of mid-morning that finally roused them all from sleep.

Sticky with sweat and groggy. Adora sluggishly opened her eyes, finding Catra sitting nearby with Melog curled around her crossed legs. Their head resting in her lap, as she absently stroked their ethereal mane. That past threw her fingertips like ghostly liquid. As she held a soft, whispered conversation with her alien companion.

Adora slowly sat up, feeling the soft touch of a hand on her shoulder. She turned to find Lonnie smiling softly down at her.

“We’re going to head down and pack up camp.” She nodded towards the grassy outlook.

“Ok.” Adora acknowledged despondently, as the rest of her old bunkmates filed past her without even looking at her. She watched sadly as a few stopped to talk to Catra for a bit before departing. They seemed more inclined to repair their relationship with Catra than her.

It stung….to feel so unwanted...

Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio were trying to reconnect with her. But it was strained. Lonnie had been trying to put the past behind her. Rekindle her friendship with Adora as it once was. But they had both changed so much over the last three years, their conversations so far had been rather stilted. While the boys were wary and didn’t know how to act around her. Rogelio was aloof while Kyle was simply nervous and awkward.

The rest of her old squad were ignoring her outright.

Adora was at a loss as to how to proceed, last night’s attempt to mend her broken ties had been an absolute disaster. She had made a polite, if annoying nuisance of herself as she tried again and again to reconnect with them.

“Hey, Adora?” Catra offered her a tender smile full of empathy and understanding. As she crouched down in front of her. After finding Adora, staring forlorn down at the ground. Absently pulling up grass as she mulled over her options concerning their bunkmates.

“They all hate me.” Adora whimpered, sighing deeply as she raised her face upward, casting her gaze skyward. Releasing a low, sad groan. She couldn’t blame them, she had left, joined the rebellion. She had become everything they had been raised to hate.

Catra settled down on the grass before her, reaching out and clasping both of her hands. She understood the maelstrom of emotions Adora was navigating. She was full of regret, guilt and shame at hurting them. She had felt the exact same way just after being rescued from Prime. But she had been far less cordial than

Adora. She had retreated into her anger and bitterness, refusing to leave her room for days. Worried and uncertain as to how to move forward with people she felt hated her.

“Look, Adora. You just need to relax and be patient with them. They are not that friendly with me either.”

“They at least talk to you.” Adora grumped, flopping down onto the grass on her back.

“True.” Catra flopped down on the grass beside her, folding her hands neatly on her stomach.

“Levi called me a traitor last night.” Adora admitted reluctantly.

Catra groaned, reaching out for her hand. Offering her support and silent reassurance that she was on her side.

“The Horde was evil…I knew it, yet I stayed. I chose what I believed to be the lesser of two evils Because I was too scared to leave...believing in the dogma they taught us about how dangerous magic was and how evil the Princess’s were. I believed you had been corrupted by them. She-Ra was...frightening and I blamed that magic for you leaving. It took years, but I realized what you managed to understand in one day. That magic was not something to fear and fight against. That the Princess’s were fully capable of controlling their powers and only wanted peace. That the war was all Hordak's doing. That he sought to subjugate the people and offer the planet to Horde Prime. As a means to prove that he wasn’t a defect, reclaim his position as Prime’s General.” Catra turned her head, offering Adora a small, regretful smile. “I was a fool, blinded by my anger, my hatred and fueled by my selfish ambitions. The others will come to their own conclusions regarding what you did, the role you played in the war. But you have to be patient and let them come to you on their own terms. Maybe some of them will forgive you, maybe some won’t. But what you did was not wrong...you fought for what you believed in. Just as they did…” The personal truth’s of Sara’s words still

resonated within Catra as she sought to explain what the other's might be thinking.

"Now I understand how scared you were after I rescued you from Primes's ship. To be surrounded by people you knew hated you. Struggling to find the courage to confront them and try and fix your mistakes. " Adora squeezed her hand.

Catra chuckled and nodded. "You are handling things much better than I did."

"No...I'm not." Adora moaned. "I made a complete nuisance of myself last night. Trying to earn their forgiveness, instead of being patient and giving them space. Now they hate me even more."

"I hid in my room for days, snapping at you every time you tried to be kind and showed honest interest in my well being. Which was quite often..." Catra chuckled, cutting her fond gaze towards her with a knowing smirk.

"I was worried...ok. I had finally got you back and I was having a hard time leaving you alone…" Adora slowly worked through how she handled Catra's return into her life and how she was handling having her bunkmates back. Shaking her head and laughing lightly. "I guess that's just how I am...I never seem to give up, huh. I just keep trying and trying until I manage to fix things."

"That's why I love you." Catra gave Adora a swift peck on the tip of her nose. "Don't stop trying to salvage your friendships with them. But from my experience. From trying to repair the damage, I did. In regards to you and the princess's. Be patient and never lose hope that you can fix your mistakes."

"Leaving the Horde wasn't a mistake." Adora advised, her blue eyes stern and unyielding as she looked up at her. Catra nodded her agreement at first, then grew somber.

"No, but the way you left was." Catra snapped back, folding her arms over her chest stubbornly.

Adora took a deep breath, mulling over Catra's angry response.

"You abandoned me...in a matter of hours for complete strangers." Catra tried to explain. "The rest of our squad...they didn't even get to watch you leave. You just disappeared, and joined the enemy...as if they didn't matter."

"Catra…" Adora moaned, tears welling in the corner of her eyes. She had honestly never dwelled too much on the personal consequences of her actions, back then. The callous disregard she had shown them. To hear it stated so bluntly. It was like a sharp knife, jabbing into her chest.

She clamped her mouth shut tight, her brows furrowing as she sought to hold her twisting guilt in check. Struggling to hide her inner turmoil as she hardened her eyes, refusing to cry. Seeking to wipe her face clean of any expression.

"Hey…We promised not to hold back any longer." Catra rolled onto her side, propping herself up on an elbow. So she could cup Adora's cheek, leaning over and pressing her forehead lovingly to Adora's.

"I know…" Adora whimpered. But it was so hard, hiding when she felt vulnerable. It was second nature and a tough habit to break.

"We were raised to hate and fear magic...When you became She-Ra...at Thaymor. You became everything we were taught to fight against. They were a part of the strike team at Thaymor, too. I'm sure some of them saw you transform. You even fought against a few of them. I was terrified of you. I believed...my Adora was dead...corrupted by magic. You betrayed us and joined the enemy..." Catra admitted.

"But the Horde was evil!" Adora huffed, as Catra rolled onto her back and crossed her arms behind her head. Staring up at the warming sky with a sad, bitter sweet smile.

"I've come to realize that evil is in the eyes of the beholder." Catra sighed heavily, as Adora's brows furrowed in worry. Catra's

morality had always been suspect for many years. Ever since they were cadets, her sense of right and wrong had been slightly skewed. Adora had thought her mindset had changed after Prime? Her words invoked doubt and worry in her heart once more.

"You have always seen the world in black and white...Right and wrong, good and bad. While I've seen mostly gray…what's good and bad has always been up for interpretation. " Catra hesitantly began to explain. As she glanced over seeing Adora's worried expression and grimaced.

"What are you talking about?' Adora leaned up on an elbow, leaning over Catra as she stared down at her in confusion.

Catra's eyes darted nervously away, avoiding Adora's beseeching gaze. She focused on Melog curled up at her side as she sought courage. She had been trying very hard to leave the darkness of her past behind, to be a better person. But the core beliefs of a more greyscale ideal of right and wrong remained.

"I've come to understand that Shadow Weaver was not evil…." She muttered, after so many years hating her. Hearing herself offer that vile woman forgiveness was startling. A weight that she had been carrying deep inside her heart was finally lifted and she felt more free, more at peace.

"She wasn't a good person, Catra...she was manipulative and cruel." Adora snapped back, sitting up fully. "Especially to you!" She nearly shouted, the sheer intensity of her righteous fury overflowing her ability to contain it.

"So was I…" Catra responded, her voice a shameful whisper. Then Catra followed her, sitting up and taking her hands. Seeking to calm Adora down, as her blue eyes darkened into a stormy gray. Illustrating the intensity of her anger, as the silver bracer on her wrist began to hum. The red jewel flared, summoned to life by her boiling rage. Catra held onto her hands tight, snapping her eyes down to Despara's bracer in alarm. Worried Adora might take off like she did last time, she brought up their "mother figure."

“I wasn’t a good person either…. I was cruel and manipulative just like her, for a long, long time…I hurt everyone who ever tried to care for me.” Catra heaved a shaky breath, valiantly keeping her tears at bay.

Adora ducked her head and worried her lower lip with her teeth, silently agreeing.

“I came to realize that Shadow Weaver was just scared, Adora… she did the best she could, considering...” Catra began, keeping her eyes cast downward. “I don’t know what she was like before…when she was Light Spinner. But the spell of Obtainment corrupted her, with the darkness of the Nameless One. Her body...her eyes...they were so much like those of the Husks...like a reanimated corpse? That parasitic magic was slowly devouring her. I think she was siphoning the magic of the Black Garnet to stay alive. She told me that she fought against that darkness everyday. That she wasn’t always strong enough to resist its corruption. She hurt us...I won’t deny that. But she was not evil...She did what she had to do, what she felt was the right way to raise us to be strong... She was trying to train us to fight against this Nameless One. Her intentions were good...deep, deep, deep down…” Catra chuckled morbidly. “ In her heart of hearts, she always wanted to protect Etheria.” Catra pushed through, her heart hammering in her chest as she sought to confess her greatest regret.

“How can you...defend her?” Adora spat, twisting her hands in Catra’s grip. Seeking to pull her hands free. But Catra held firm.

“Because...I’m weak in the same ways as Shadow Weaver…” Catra began, reeling at admitting it. Unwilling to delve any deeper into that twisted train wreck of thoughts, she continued to confess instead. “In the Portal Reality...I was so full of rage and despair. I gave up and allowed that dark magic...this Nameless One... to devour me too…I died in that portal and was reborn into darkness just like Shadow Weaver. ” Catra gasped, as silent tears fell down her cheeks. Spilling from the corner of her eyes as she took a shaky, frightened breath.

Adora's face paled, as she stared down at her in horror.

"You never thought...I was evil...did you?" Catra beseeched her. Her brows furrowed and her expression crumpled into despair.

"Never…" Adora shook her head, tears falling unchecked down her face. "I felt you were making bad decisions again and again...and I only wanted to get through to you...bring you back with me to the rebellion...but every time I tried to convince you to come with me...I just ended up pushing you further away instead." Adora admitted, her expression full of pain and disappointment.

Catra wanted to pull her in, hold her close and comfort her. But she swallowed hard instead needing to confess everything while she had the chance, while her courage lasted.

"That dark magic...it corrupted my soul...just like it did to Shadow Weaver and I became a monster…consumed by the worst parts of myself. I spewed all the hate and resentments I felt towards you, all while trying to rip you apart…" Catra shuddered, finally pulling her hands away to hug herself, as she slowly curled into herself. The guilt and shame, bowing her before Adora.

"I'm scared a fragment of that dark power still hides in the deepest parts of me...that I will never fully purge it from my soul. That I will have to fight against that darkness for the rest of my life...the same as Shadow Weaver." Catra was quiet for a long time. Staring forlorn at the ground, before finally having the courage to voice what lay festering in her heart.

"If you can't forgive Shadow Weaver….then how can you forgive me? " Catra heaved a great breath, suddenly feeling dizzy and light headed. Her heart was pounding in her chest overwhelmed by the stress of finally confessing to Adora one of her deepest fears.

Adora reached out then, pulling Catra in. Holding her against her chest, brushing a comforting hand down her short hair as she gathered her own thoughts.

“Despara’s magic...is...similar...it is born from the negative aspects of the universe. ” Adora nodded, seeking to find a common understanding. That they were both touched by darkness in a similar way. They both wept brokenly, clutching onto each other.

Adora’s mind swam with the ardent vow she had spat at Shadow Weaver during their last confrontation before the Heart.

(**I will never forgive you! You ruin people! You destroy any chance they might have to be happy!)**

She had shouted up at the old woman, with such vitriol, such disdain and hatred. The sorceress had recoiled from her in shock. Then Adora had stormed past her, retreating into the rebel compound. They never spoke again, Adora avoided her and Shadow Weaver gave her space. Even though the ill will between them was gnawing at the sorceress. The old woman’s pride refused to allow her to show weakness. So she merely hovered nearby as they planned their final assault against Prime. Sitting upon the crates near the door, acting aloof and uncaring. Sipping absently at her cup, the only item she had cared about since abandoning Bright Moon. Adora didn’t know what the old woman was drinking at the time and didn’t really care. Then she sacrificed herself for them…leaving them once again confused and reeling from her dramatic exit from their lives. It had been barely a month since her death. But the heat of Adora's anger towards Shadow Weaver had never cooled. Now Catra was asking her to forgive that terrible old woman? Catra needed that certainty. That if Adora could forgive a woman as despicable as Shadow Weaver. Then she could trust in the forgiveness Adora had offered her. Adora didn’t know if she could do it…but for Catra she would try.

“I will try and forgive her….I will try…” Adora mumbled between gasping breaths into Catra’s neck. Who only held her tighter, her claws pulling at the fabric of her white shirt along her shoulder blades.

It was well past mid-day, when the squad of ex-horde soldier's finally left the valley behind them. Walking in a loose line, through a wide field of golden grass and wildflowers. Unlike the last time they trekked through this flat, barren land. Adora was not confidently leading them forward. She now lagged behind the group, meek and crestfallen. She hung her head low, gripping the heavy cloth straps of her pack in a death grip. Once more in her maroon cloak, with the hood pulled tight over her head. She looked small, hiding away from the other's as much as possible. Catra walked beside her, keeping a close eye on their once childhood friends. Her leather jacket was still slightly damp, but she ignored the unpleasant feeling. Clutching the straps of her own pack, as it hung off one shoulder. She kept a close eye on Lonnie, who was now in the lead. A proud smirk pulling on her lips. Things certainly have changed. The dark skinned woman had far more confidence. Then she ever did back when they were Cadets. She had become a leader. Whatever had happened in the last year, Lonnie had been forged anew. The brash, hotheaded soldier she had been was gone.

Kyle and Rogelio as always, were following close behind her. While Max and Levi flanked them to the left, Atila and Otis flanked to the right. It was instinct for all them to naturally move in formation. The military training they grew up with would never truly leave them. The sun was high overhead, beating down on them mercilessly. As they followed the river ever southward towards the Scorpion Hills. They were all perspiring. Weary from getting no sleep the night before and hungry, since they had to skip breakfast so they could finish the day's hike before nightfall. No one complained, their faces set in grim frowns of concentration. They were soldiers, duty and discipline was second nature. So long days of walking with heavy packs was taken stoically. Their survival training during their senior cadet seasons had been far more grueling.

"Oh, Soldier!" Lonnie's voice shouted from the head of the line.

“Combat Soldier!” Kyle shouted back, along with Rogelio growling in tune.

“Pick up your weapon and follow me!” Lonnie responded.

“We are Horde Infantry!” Max, Levi, Atila and Otis shouted in unison.

“Hey, there, Soldier!” Catra took up the marching cadence, nudging Adora in the arm with her elbow.

Adora looked up, “Out of bed, Soldier! ” She called out, her voice loud but uncertain. Worried that the march song would stop, now that she was participating.

“Get your gear and follow me!” Catra continued.

“We are Horde Infantry!” The rest shouted back, not missing a beat.

“Oh, Soldier!” Lonnie continued.

“Combat Soldier!” Kyle took up the next line, with Rogelio letting loose with a mournful howl.

“Pick up your pack and follow me!” Max adjusted the straps on his pack for emphasis.

“We are Horde Infantry!” Levi punched him in the shoulder.

“Hey, there Soldier!” Catra cackled, poking Adora between the eyes as she skipped in front of her.

“Armor up, Soldier!” Adora smiled, as she called out to Catra. As the feline marched ahead of her.

“Strap on your boots and follow me!” Catra called back.

“We are Horde Infantry!” They all shouted with reckless abandon.

“Oh, Soldier!” Lonnie screamed, smiling over her shoulder as she turned to march backwards for a bit to survey her Squad.

“Combat Soldier!” Kyle laughed.

“Pick up your pace and follow me!” Levi smirked at Max as she jogged past him.

“Hey, there Soldier!” Atila’s voice boomed out.

“Keep up with me, Soldier!” Otis burst into a sprint, passing Levi in a few strides. As all four of them quickly over took Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio in the front.

“Forged in the Fright Zone!” Max shouted in the distance.

“Fighting on the Front Line!” Otis exclaimed.

“We are Horde Infantry!” Levi responded, her voice echoing as they dashed away into the distance. Each one vying for first place, in this sudden race towards some invisible finish line.

They didn’t stop marching until dusk, having followed the river out of the valley, and into the fields beyond. They were now once more camped by it’s tranquil banks in a wide open prairie of wild grass. The last of the sun’s ray’s glowed like the ember’s of a dying fire upon the flat horizon. The clear sky had darkened, as an eternity of stars blanketed the heaven’s above. Catra’s voice echoed in the distance as she sang her farewell to the sun. Her

voice this evening carried a nostalgic warmth and hope that it never held yesterday.

Adora sat before the campfire, sitting on the edge of her bedroll. Poking the fire with a long stick. Lonnie and the other's were busy setting up their tents nearby.

"Her voice is beautiful." Levi commented, as she squatted on the other side of the fire. Her short dark hair hung over one eye, as she stared down at the fire. Refusing to even look up at Adora. Levi held two ration bars in her hands, but Adora never got her hope up that the spare was for her. More likely she was just waiting for Max to show up so she could give it to him.

"Yeah...I love listening to her sing." Adora sighed wistfully, smiling fondly out into the darkening landscape beyond the fire. Catra was out on the wide field somewhere singing, she couldn't see her. But she knew she was there, her voice calling out softly as she finished her song.

"I bet...you've loved a-lot more than that." Levi chuckled, wiggling her eyebrows meaningfully.

Adora blushed and ducked her head. Wanting to make a witty retort but not thinking of anything.

"Jealous?" Catra snipped, tossing a rock at Levi. As Melog curled up beside Adora.

Levi merely laughed, raising an arm to deflect the stone. As children they threw rocks at each other all the time. It was a form of silent communication they had used often when stuck outside in the training yard during drills. Sometimes it was in jest, like now. Or because they needed to get the other's attention before said cadet got them into trouble with the Staff Sergeant. Or because they were angry and using the rock as a weapon. The intention of the hit depended on how hard the rock was tossed and what location on the body had been targeted. Max settled on the ground beside Levi. Giving her and Catra questioning looks.

“As violent as ever.” He commented dryly, brushing a hand through his greenish blonde fringe of hair. Moving the errant strands that were in his eyes off to the side of his forehead.

Catra huffed and sat down beside Adora with her arms folded stubbornly. She couldn’t deny that, she had been rather feral growing up. Lashing out with her claws and teeth frequently at her squad-mates. Adora wasn’t the only one bearing scars on their bodies due to her temper. Max and Levi had a few too.

“Why are you singing so much now?” Levi asked, handing her extra ration bar to Max

Catra never said a word but summoned her magic, fire quickly engulfed her body, her elegant tiara flaring to life upon her forehead. As the flames within the circle of stones flared to twice their size in response.

Levi and Max cried out in fright, scrambling to get further away from the wild blaze their campfire had become.

“I’m a Princess now.” Catra smirked smugly, tossing a ball of flame from one open palm to the other. Her elegant tiara glowing like burnished gold across her forehead.

“Silly, me…” Levi muttered. “Didn’t think you could get any scarier.” She finished in a hushed, intimidated mumble.

Catra groaned and instantly snuffed out her flames.

“I never meant to scare you.” She sighed, in all honesty she had been trying to show off. “I found out about my past recently. My mom was the Rune Bearer of Fire...a thousand years ago. So I am too... I have to commune with the sun a couple times a day to recharge my magic.” Her voice was soft and sullen.

Levi looked perplexed. While Max merely scowled neither of them really understood the complexity of her statement. They were taught how to fight Princesses, not how their magic worked. Catra

wasn’t offering the full story so they quickly let it pass. Resigned to the troubles of the present.

“What happened to you?” Max was confused. “The old Catra would have been thrilled at how freaked out you just made me and Levi?”

“Thankfully, that mean, power hungry version of me is dead and gone. “ Catra focused her gaze on the fire, taming it back into a gentle flame. “I am sorry for how I treated you when I was a Force Captain.”

Levi and Max looked even more confused now.

“You were in charge and trying to win a war...you did nothing wrong.” Max responded between chewing.

Levi released a disgruntled sigh and shoved her empty wrapper into the pocket of her pants.

“What are you sorry for, you barely had anything to do with us? You were our Force Captain for like a month..” She remarked, coldly.

Catra narrowed her eyes, as Melog flared an angry red. Levi's statement had been harsh, but not wrong. She had risen up the ranks in the Horde very quickly, leaving her squad-mates behind. As she took over as Hordak’s second in command. She was pretty much running the Horde by the end of her first year. The only missions she paid any attention to, where the ones she lead. She had no idea what had happened to her Squad-mates or what battalion's they had been reassigned to once she left.

“I’m sorry too…” Adora’s voice was small, as she sought to continue her apology but Levi shut her up with an irritated growl.

“Ugh...stop...apologizing. That’s all you did last night! You don’t even understand why I’m mad at you.” Levi snarled, storming away.

Max sighed, refusing to look at Adora. Knowing how upset and frustrated Adora was. Last night's attempts to make peace with everyone had been a sad and embarrassing display on her part and things were not improving tonight either.

"The last three years have been...rough. Give her time, Adora." Max shoved his own empty wrapper into his pants before retreating from the fire.

Adora merely nodded, barely keeping her tears at bay as she pulled up her hood once more. Catra quickly reached over and took her hand.

Atila had retreated into his tent as soon as he had it up, sealing the front so no one could come in. Seeing Sara again, had given him closure. But he was still grieving the loss and needed time alone. Unwilling to show anyone his sorrow...his weakness, he locked himself away.

Otis joined them at the fire with a packet of salted dried fish. He silently shared his meal with Catra but did not engage in conversation. He had tried to offer some to Adora, but she was too busy brooding and barely acknowledged his presence by the fire.

As soon as the rations were gone, Otis simply got up and retreated into his own tent. Catra watched him go with a small, sympathetic smile. Understanding that this was a thank you, for what she did last night.

The first two greater Moons had ascended into the starlit sky, by the time Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio settled down around the fire.

"You guys had anything to eat?" Lonnie inquired,

Adora heaved a loud suffering sigh and flopped backward onto her sleeping mat.

Catra nodded, as Lonnie tossed two ration bars at her anyway.

Catra caught them in each hand, her hand eye coordination had always been phenomenal. She lightly tapped Adora's stomach with the edge of a ration bar, silently inviting her to take it.

Adora groaned and snatched the bar. "Thanks." She grumbled, slowly unwrapping it. Concealing her disappointment that it was a brown one, with a short grunt. Taking a big, angry bite of the bar.

"We should reach the memorial by midday tomorrow." Lonnie advised, chewing lightly on her brown ration bar.

"So what happened to you guys back at the base? Lonnie said you just disappeared?" Kyle inquired innocently. Unwrapping his own bar and choking it down in three bites. It was the brown kind and they all had the same trick. Eat as quickly as possible so you don't have to taste it.

Catra began to tell them about everything that happened on Beast Island, while Adora sulked, refusing to be a part of the conversation.

Kyle was enthralled by the story, while Lonnie became more wary and concerned.

"More Eternian's?" She groaned then asked about Brojee and his crew. Who were now back at the tarmac scavenging for parts.

"No, they're from another planet but have been living in space for the last few years." Adora finally spoke up, rising up on her elbows to regard their friends. "Between Skeletor and now these Mutants, who are from yet another planet. It seems the wider universe is still fighting for it's freedom. The war's not over yet...not by a long shot. There is a larger rebellion, another magical warrior like me...called He-Man." Adora's voice grew more adamant and eager as she sat up.

Catra turned to her and quickly clutched her hand, metaphorically holding her in place. Adora was so excited and eager to get out there among the stars and help those other planets still struggling. Catra swallowed hard, as the cold dread of coming abandonment swelled in her stomach. She suddenly felt queasy, as anxiety flooded over her. Melog was lounging nearby in the shadow's just beyond the fire and huffed loudly as Catra's anxiety washed over them.

"My magic...She-Ra….I'm known as a Master of the Universe and there are more out there like me." Adora squeezed her hand back, reassuring her that she would not go off into the stars without a plan. That she would be patient, learn about her powers, master them before heading off to save the universe.

"So what's the plan then...going forward." Lonnie asked, her voice wavering with fear. At the overwhelming understanding that alien's, some peaceful, some not...were still arriving on Etheria. That the unknown powers lurking up in those stars would never stop invading.

"Entrapta is still on Beast Island, working on a more powerful detection system. She wants to hotwire the First Ones Watch Tower's communication array with Primes Spires around Etheria." Catra advised. "Boost the signals so they go farther…or something like that."

This was the first Adora had heard of it, but Catra had been the last person to talk to Entrapta.

"And….this Omega Prime...monster? Is it dead?" Lonnie was hesitant to ask.

"I went to check for a body but...it's escaped...for now...hopefully Entrapta will be able to pick up it's life signs, once those spires are online." Adora shrugged, glancing meekly at Catra. Worried that she was going to be angry, she hadn't shared this information earlier. As this was the first she had spoken about what happened to the Monster since Beast Island.

“Yeah, she's working on tracking Omega Prime, too.” Catra nodded, giving Adora’s hand a squeeze. Silently, trying to calm her down. That Entrapta had told her all about it and she wasn’t upset.

“Entrapta has a lot on her plate right now. She is going to be busy setting up Etheria’s tech for a long time. But she has got Holo-Hordak, so she’s happy again. At least.” Catra shrugged.

“The last few months have been….” Adora struggled to explain.

“Crazy...intense...but in a good way.” Catra finished with a teasing smirk.

“I would have said overwhelming and scary...but ok. ” Adora chuckled dryly.

“We still got a long, long way to go. To get Etheria back on track. I say we take it one day at a time and try not to overwhelm ourselves with too much ‘what if’s?’ Lonnie shot Adora a knowing glare. The sternness of the look was tempered by the warmth in her eyes. She knew the blonde had a tendency to dwell and spiral when she didn’t feel in control. Adora bowed her head and nodded, a soft smile warming her lips. Friends always made the tough times less scary.

They talked well into the night, laughing and sharing stories both from their childhood and recent events. It felt like old times, when they had been a squad out on survival training just beyond the walls of the Fortress. Or goofing around before lights out back in the bunkroom. Adora’s heart felt lighter and Catra was finally relaxing. Laughing and joking with Lonnie and teasing Kyle. Who as always took it all in stride, laughing along with them at his own expense.

As the Greater moons climbed higher into the night’s sky, their smaller companions surrounding them. Everyone began to grow drowsy. Kyle had leaned his head against Rogelio’s shoulder, discretely holding onto the lizard's hand as he fell asleep.

Adora had climbed into her sleeping bag, with Catra. Snuggling together near the fire, as Lonnie watched them fondly.

"It's nice to have my family back…" Lonnie muttered, flopping backward onto the grass to gaze softly up at the starlit sky.

Reckoning

The Crimson Waste was an inhospitable place of relentless sun. A barren, arid desert that stretches on forever, with no respite. Until you reach the deep sandstone canyons at the southern edge of the Waste. Known as the Valley of the Lost.

To find the lower continent transformed into a savannah of golden grass and cluster’s of lone balboa trees. Was shocking to say the least.

Peekablue knew that when She-Ra had released the magic of the Heart, Etheria had been reborn in many ways. The true extent of the magic’s power was still startling to behold. Finn on the other hand was taking it all in stride, completely unfazed by the change. Their dark ears would twitch as the flies buzzed around them. The low hum of the many tiny insects that usually occupied the Waste, had now multiplied thanks to the more lush environment. Finn’s fluffy blonde tail swished happily as they walked through the tall golden grass of the Savannah. They were right at home here, scanning the rolling grassland with a lazy smile of nostalgic comfort.

This was their home…

Peekablue came to understand, as they began to open up and talk about their kingdom. That during their life, in their timeline. This place was not known as the Crimson Waste. But as Serenia, the Crystal Kingdom. This was where their mother’s ruled and where Skeletor had them imprisoned. Until DT rescued them. They would speak in short bursts, as the days of travel drew on. Reminiscing about their childhood. Running the long, iridescent halls of the Crystal Palace. Getting underfoot an distracting the Sentry's along the crystalline ramparts or pulling pranks on the castle guards inside. Spending days tending the horses with the squires in the stables, or just exploring the many gardens and orchards that surrounded the Castle. Getting lost in the open expanse of the

Savannah more than once. Having Swift Wind come to their rescue and fly them back.

The sprawling Palace, that crowned the twin peaks of the Sunna Stones. Was made of pure, clear crystal that reflected the sun, moons and stars. The Jewel of Etheria, that was so grand and majestic one could see it glowing from space.

Finn spoke of harassing the Castle Knights as a little kid. Demanding to be taken on as a squire, to be taught how to fight, so that they could become a hero and defend the kingdom. So enthralled by the heroic murals that were carved into the crystal walls, in the Hall of Hero's. The grand, colorful tapestries that hung in the conference room that depicted their mother's many adventures before their birth. The heroic bedtime stories his mom Adora told them of the Great Rebellion, the Princess Alliance and the Rise of the Galactic Guardians who now protected Etheria from threats beyond the stars. They were so obsessed and stubborn, they had become a regular nuisance down at the Castle barracks.

So their mother’s had to intervene and reluctantly began to train them. They had wanted them to live a life of peace and never to know the hardships of war. But Finn admired their mothers so much and the royal children often gossiped about who’s parent was the strongest warrior on Etheria. So they now had something to prove, they wanted to be strong, they wanted to protect their kingdom, defend Etheria. They craved adventure and the unknown. So very bored with the dull, predictable, peaceful days. That began and ended the same. They regret that wish now. They would give anything to have those bland, lackluster days back. To have their mother’s alive and caring for them as they did when they were young.

They spoke of spending lazy afternoons playing with their friends in the streets of Solaris. The crown city that sprawled out from the feet of Mount Sunna’s, two halves. Devluging only a little about Etheria’s alternate future, before quickly closing themselves off. Wrapping their arms around their chest, ears falling sullenly and

tail dropping as they worried. Peekablue sought to keep their spirits up, stating that they could share whatever they wanted, that it would not affect this timeline. Finn would open up a bit more about some things, but in regards to the death and disappearances of their mothers. They kept stoically silent. As if speaking about it was taboo.

Peekablue was keen enough to figure out that Adora and the rest of the Queens had been lost to the Sanctuary spell. Because Catra had been killed before or during the casting and Finn blamed themself.

It was long into the dark hours, the light of their campfire blazed between them. Peekablue was hunched over his diary, scribbling as best he could by the poor light of the fire. He had started this ritual years ago, of writing down his visions. No matter how trivial they might be. Everyone of them had a purpose, even if it was just for the benefit of some random farmer and their crops in the next warm season. Finn as always was sprawled out on the grass just beyond the firelight, staring up at the stars. As if the cosmos above. Held all the answers to quell the maelstrom of thoughts that always plagued them in the quiet hours.

“Can’t sleep?” Peekablue offered, tapping the tip of their black feather quill. Into a tiny ink well set beside their crossed legs.

“Do you know the names of the moons?” Finn asked quietly. Watching the waxing and waning moon’s hanging in the night sky. Ducking in and out of the clouds racing past on the wind.

“Some of them, yes.” Peekablue offered, finishing up his writing and putting his open book aside. Setting small flat stones on the edge of either side to keep the pages open for the ink to dry.

“Elidor...is the largest of the Greater Moon’s. The Jewel of the sky and the source of light magic.” Finn pointed to the large, silver half moon now hovering high above a cluster of trees out in the

field of grass.
“Then it’s companion’s, Kiona, Fiore, Heliwir and Vesi.” Peekablue pointed out the four remaining modestly big moons and one slightly smaller one that all hovered near Elidor. Each one of a different shade of pink, yellow, blue or green

Finn turned and smiled with wonder at Peekablue. “They are the sources of the Greater Elemental magic of our planet. Known as the Coral Moon, Hunter's Moon, Snow moon and Flower moon.”

“Why the trivia about the Moons, kid?” Peekablue interjected with a kind chuckle.

Finn merely shrugged, “The queens communed with their sources in the ancient ways...they had such incredible magic….but it wasn’t enough to protect them in the end…”

Peekablue kept quiet, silently urging the child to continue. Wanting Finn to purge the guilt and fear that was festering deep inside their heart. The young magicat, would only toss him crumbs about what had happened that fateful day when Etheria fell to Skeletor. Giving him just enough information to puzzle out the rest. He hoped one day Finn would trust him enough to tell him all of it.

Finn was staring up at the blanket of stars high above, their expression was rather forlorn. Lost to their thoughts once again, they drew quiet and contemplative. Yet, Peekablue could sense someone staring at him. It was odd and unnerving. He glanced out towards the dark field of tall grass, finding it empty. The wind picked up, flattening the grass. Still the savannah was void of any intruder’s. Peekablue sighed, doubting his senses. Perhaps he was just tired and paranoid from being on the run for so long. Glancing absently down at his book, he found a tiny, silver-white lizard with rainbow wings staring up at him. It had huge beady blue eyes and a shimmering golden horn in the middle of its slimy head. It puffed out it’s cheeks, aggressively. As it released a low croak, that rumbled in their throat and then flicked out its black forked tongue.

“Eeeek!” Peekablue screamed. His alarmed screech was rather high pitched and piercing. Tossing the book and the lizard into the air. The lizard spread its wings and floated lazily toward Finn.

“Eek!” Finn exclaimed in delight, sitting up and holding out their hands so the tiny lizard had someplace to land.

“You know that disgusting thing!” Peekablue shivered, he could deal with a lot of creepy, crawling things but he drew the line at Lizards and Snakes. Which was rather unfortunate since they were now wandering around what was once the Crimson Waste...a region of Etheria known for its lizards and snakes! Giant three headed snakes that could eat you up in one bite and an array of lizards both small and hybrid, that all posed some kind of threat. That he would have to be vigilant for.

“Yes...he’s my friend. We share a sacred bond!” Finn explained, proudly. As the lizard crawled up onto their shoulders and draped themselves around their neck like some awful, scaley scarf. Finn adjusted the red bandana they wore, so that it draped over the lizard's back like a blanket.

Peekablue shuttered in revulsion, stomping over to his book. Picking it up in a huff, as he slammed his book shut.

“I am going to sleep...don't stay up too late. We got another long...long...long walk ahead of us tomorrow.” Peekablue grumbled bitterly, as he settled himself down in his bedroll near the fire. Rolling away from Finn. So he would not have to see the lizard, currently cuddling with the child like a prized pet.

A few minutes later, Finn began to sing. Their voice was a soft, gentle hum accenting the quiet night. Peekablue was instantly enthralled with the lovely melody the child had begun to sing.

“Hush now, little one.

My kitten, my darling, my precious one. ”

Rest your head, let my love soothe you.

Hush now, my baby, for the day is done.

Listen to my purr,

Feel the warmth of my fur.

Seek the serenity that lives within you.

The lyrics were simple, full of joy and hope. But the emotion's underlying the harmony echoed to him. A yearning for this child to know only peace, to always feel loved and cherished. Everything their mother had not been allowed to have.

"Child of my heart, sleep softly.

Night has fallen, the moon's sing your lullaby.

I'm by your side, forever watching over you.

Hush, now my baby. Sleep now, my baby."

Peekablue's thoughts were pulled away upon the next stanza. As his magic of foresight bloomed with vision's of an older, more regal and indomitable image. Of Catra. Standing in defiance upon a raised crystal dais, before an unseen foe. Elegant twin thrones sat behind her, carved from the same ethereal crystal that surrounded her. They floated several inches above the dais. The wide backs resembled broad shields, with wide flaring sides. The curved seats were covered in regal red and gold velvet. The throne room was a massive octagon structure with vaulted ceilings rising high overhead. The sun refracted from the skylight above, casting a prism of light upon the carved crystal floor. Tall

archways, carved with runes flanked the dais. The outer walls themselves were massive windows that overlooked the magnificent sprawling city of Solaris. The room held a mighty aura of power, that practically hummed in the air.

Catra's long dark mane was pulled back into a ponytail, high atop her head. Her silver tufts were delicately braided and hung low along her neck. Beaded with orange sunstone shards. That glinted like sparks from a smoldering campfire amid the ash gray strands. A silver, magicat mask adorned her forehead. It was more elegant, finely crafted then her previous mask. The points flaring majestically upward in the same manner as She-Ra's crown. Etched with runic knots down the sides, that hooked into sharp points along her striking cheekbones. With a brilliant orange sunstone gem, that glowed with magic power in the center of the mask. She was dressed in dark black leather pants, with a gold stripe up the sides. Long knee high black hide boots with wide gold buckles were on her once bare feet. She wore a dark red leather armored vest over her chest, with a gold winged pin above her right breast. Her arms were bare except for the matching leather bracers on her wrists. Black fingerless gloves adorned her hands While a long white cape with gold accents hung off her left shoulder. The vision sped up, flashes of Ten kingdoms. Bright Moon, Salineas, Plumeria, Snows, Scorpania and the Crystal Kingdom, the HighLands of Bright Moon, Medow Lands and Dryl. All were rebuilt, more prosperous and far more advanced than they were now. Illustrating how Etheria had become a part of the wider Universe, benefiting from trade and other worldly technologies. Then the voices of thousands upon thousands crying out in fear and agony then suddenly silenced. As an eternal darkness swallowed the universe, as instantly as a blink of an eye.

"The star-shine calls you, so close your eyes.

Let the dreams carry you away.

To play amid the weave and dance within the magic.

Here I shall join you, in the realms between.

Never to be apart, Never to be lonely.

Always and forever, the child of my heart.”

As Finn’s sweet voice faded away, so did the pull of Peekablue’s magic. Leaving the great sage, heaving for breath. As he was released from the ethereal current of Farsight. The last fragments of his vision, still haunting him. For it spoke of a future not yet woven into the threads of this time. But yet the inevitably of it froze him to the very core. He could not shake the horror of the universe's last moments and the infinite silence of nothingness that followed.

“The Nameless One….” Peekablue shivered, holding himself tight.

Adora raised her hand to shield her eyes from the glare of the sun. The day had been hot, almost scorching. As they moved into the rolling fields of tall grass that was the very beginning of the Scorpion Hills. An area of slowly increasing hills, that progressed into barren heaths and cliffs looming high over canyons and crags. That led to the rocky shores of the southernmost bend of the Serpentine Straits. The cliffs overlooked the rough waters, scattered with tall protruding rock formations and hidden sandbars. That guarded the last few leagues of water to the more tranquil mouth to the Howling Sea. Out beyond this twisting stretch of water, was the small continent of Meadow Lands. Home of the reclusive insect hybrids, known as Andreenids and Sweet Bee’s kingdom. On a clear day, one could see just the dark silhouette of the island's coastline. Which had been left to grow wild as it was devoid of any kind of civilization. Pirates and smugglers would hideout in the lagoons and small bays, having no

fear that the coast was being guarded. While the other side of the strait had been under Horde control for decades.

The wind gusted from time to time, flattening the grass as it howled by. Creating a strange motion as if the field was a rolling ocean. As the grass shifted and settled at each gust. The squad was silent. Moving in formation as always, with Catra and Adora in the rear. Each one lost to their own grim contemplations the closer they got to the site of the Memorial. The air held a melancholy that fell thick and heavy upon each of them. It resonated deep in their very souls. That ethereal sense of loss, forever intertwined with resignation. That one day, they would all be reunited with those they had lost, when they too crossed over to the Eternal Realm. But they had a long life ahead to them that they were expected to live. That they each had to move on, make peace with the past and find meaning to the days ahead.

By noon, the field of grass had ascended into the rolling landscape of Scorpion Hills. A region of steep hills and cliffs that bordered the edge of the Fright Zone and the Crimson Waste. Overlooking a rocky and dangerous portion of the Serpentine Straits. That divided the mainland from their neighboring landmass of Meadowlands. This area of the Straits was subject to strong tidal currents from the Howling Sea. That could reverse direction at a moment's notice, sending smaller ships incapable of sailing against it. Into the rocks and shallow waters that hid sandbars. That littered this part of the strait. So there were a lot of shipwrecks left to rot along the coastline. Horde Patrols, sent out from their nearby naval base. Had ‘rescued’ many sailors and refugee’s from along this part of the strait. Bolstering their ranks every warm season.

“Did you guys want to break for lunch or keep going?” Lonnie asked, calling from the head of the formation. Her hand was already slipping under her pack's shoulder strap to pull it off.

“Otis and I have a boat to catch, so let's just get this over with!” Atila snarled back, pushing ahead of them all with Otis on his heels.

Lonnie rolled her eyes, but kept silent. The closest working port was many days' journey further south in the Crimson Waste. The Horde’s naval base, which was only a few miles north, had long been abandoned. Not having much use, after the Salineas Sea Gate had been destroyed and the Archipelago it protected had been conquered. So there was no way they were catching a boat there. Atila was just being grumpy and short tempered, which was a normal state of being for the Tauran.

Catra had noticed Max had been casting Adora, strange, mournful looks over his shoulder. Every time he thought Levi wasn’t watching. Silently seeking for Adora to try again and find the courage to talk to Levi. But Adora was avidly avoiding everyone. She had barely spoken to Lonnie this morning at breakfast and had not said a word to anyone else. Catra would try to start a conversation and Adora would respond in quiet single word answers, not trying to keep the conversation going at all. She was stuck in her head, wallowing in her thoughts. Keeping her head down watching the grass, as if mesmerized by it. Or looking mournfully out towards the ocean. As they climbed the ever increasing hills towards the more barren, rocky cliffs. That were covered in short scrub grass and dried out clay beds. Adora would kick the loose grass from time to time, sending clumps of clay into the air with a satisfied grunt.

Catra took note of how deeply Adora was brooding. Worried that she had given up on making peace with their squad. Or perhaps she had taken her words to heart and she was just giving them space. Giving Levi time to come to her instead. But Max seemed to think, Adora should keep trying? Why? Levi had made her feelings very clear the night before.

The closer they drew to the Memorial the more anxious Adora became. The air had turned slightly salty, as they neared the ocean. By the time they were mounting the last bend along the

trail to the very top of the cliffs. Adora had the hood of her cloak pulled low over the head, so that it hung over her forehead. Her arms were curled tight around her middle, staring somberly down at her slowly trudging feet. Making long scuff marks on the dusty clay ground. Unwilling to meet even Catra's concerned gaze.

It took Lonnie's startled gasp and Atila's howl of rage to finally draw Adora's eyes up. Finding the cliffside barren, where a simple chunk of dried out driftwood should have been.

"Where is it?" Max moaned, darting forward to where the epitaph should have been. They had dug a hole and mounted the heavy log in a small, secluded outcropping at the edge of this cliff. Circled the log with stones, before each one of them had etched a name into the wood with their boot knives. Then Adora had carved a final farewell. 'Fallen but never Forgotten' into the base of the log.

Levi merely shook her head in bitter disbelief.

"Did someone take it?" Kyle offered, glancing around the rugged outcropping of cracked clay soil and patches of yellowed grass. Where only the circle of stones remained.

Rogelio merely grunted, walking dejectedly towards a nearby boulder with his shoulders slumped. Dropping his pack to the ground and hunching over his knees, pressing his snout into his hands as he wept softly.

"It's gotta be here….it's just has too?" Otis snarled, dropping his own pack and moving with purpose towards Kyle. Dropping to his knees, he proceeded to crawl around. Pushing the tall clumps of grass aside as if the huge chunk of wood had just fallen over and was hidden amid the stalks.

"Figures…" Catra heaved a despondent sigh, scrubbing her hands through her short dark mane. "It was just a hunk of wood we carved up, it wasn't like it was anything special." She muttered, jadedly.

“It was special to us.” Adora turned to her, her eyes wet, expression pained by Catra's flippant disregard.

“Yeah...you might not have cared about it. But we did!” Levi snapped heatedly.

“So then we are going to find it!” Adora commanded confidently, thrusting a fist into the air. The rest of the squad hollered their agreement. Leaving Catra on the sidelines once again.

Catra watched them scour the cliff. Looking behind boulder’s and crawling through the grass. Each one of her bunkmates had a similar, hard look in their eyes of determination and resolve. Adora was in the thick of the search with them. Never giving up, always offering them supportive, positive words of encouragement. Sliding easily back into her role as their Squad Leader.

While Catra remained aloof from the rest, hands on her hips smirking knowingly at them all. Her ‘family’ was finally acting like normal. With Adora in the lead and the rest eager and determined to succeed. With Catra hovering on the periphery, helping covertly as she scanned the cliff with her keen eyes. Acting aloof and embittered, as she seemed to wander aimlessly about the cliffside, engaging in the hunt in her own ways with Melog in tow.

For a long moment, the only sound was the howl of the wind. Gusting up from the rocky beach below the cliff. Then within seconds, all hell had broken loose. A whistle from the beach, two shadow’s shooting up into the sky. As the howl changed into a squealing whine of energy fire. A bolt of red lightening tore through the ground inches away from Catra. Who was standing near the edge of the cliff. Sending chunks of clay and pebbles in the air, creating a dust cloud of sharp shrapnel to rain down upon them. Catra screamed in fright, jumping backward to avoid the shrapnel. As Melog flared red with rage, their mane snapping, as they hovered protectively in front of Catra. Their glowing eyes scanning the sky above, for any trace of the attackers.

“What the hell!” Lonnie yelled, crossing her arms over her head as she ducked behind a boulder for cover. Kyle squealed and followed her into hiding. Max and Levi stood their ground near the circle of stones, amid the scrub grass on the outlook. With their stun batons crackling in their hands. Otis and Atila had been on the far side of the bluff, which was protected by an overhang from the steeper cliffs rising behind it. Allowing the grass and wild wheat to grow thick and tall, as the area was unhindered by the wind. So they were now crouched low, able to hide easily. Rogelio had quickly ducked behind the boulder he had been investigating and was out of view.

Adora refused to move, standing her ground a few meters away from Catra near the cliff’s edge. Hand hovering over her golden bracer scanning the sky above. She had taken up a sturdy battle stance. A warrior’s calm settled over her, as she became highly alert to every sound, every flash of movement amid the clear blue sky. Then a low hum, echoed from the underside of a rugged ledge of another bluff. That was ascending just above and to the right of her position. She snapped her eyes up in that direction, just as an obsidian orb floated up out of its hiding spot. From a shallow crack within the sheer clay wall and fired.

Adora’s fighting instincts were primed and she summoned both Sheana’s shield and Despara’s sword instantly. No longer hindered by fear or doubt. The bracer’s dissolved in a flash of gold and crimson light. Reappearing in both her hands as a large white shield with a clear blue gem stone in the center of the golden eight sided star. Along with a slender long sword, with an elegant yet aggressively shaped, silver cross guard. With a dark crimson gem stone set in the quillon block of the guard.

Adora swung the shield up, blocking the energy fire. The red energy bolt pulsed as it struck the shield and then dissipated along the unmarred surface. Adora was quick to strike with her sword, sending a crescent arc of indigo magic right back at the orb. But before her attack could hit, a white orb flew in front of the black one and absorbed her attack.

“What the hell…” Adora exclaimed. As the black orb shot away, sending down a barrage of cover fire. That had Adora skipping and dancing on her toes to avoid getting hit. She was right out in the open with no cover.

“Adora!” Catra wailed, sprinting towards her. Her whole body was aflame and she moved with far more speed and agility than before. Rushing past Adora, she swung low with a flaming set of claws. Raking them across the white orb that had used the black orbs fire as a distraction to get close to Adora.

The orb squealed in pain, as four slash marks appeared across it’s smooth metal skin. The slashes quickly bloomed a electric blue with what could be it's blood? As it spun away, the black orb shot in to protect it, sending another barrage or energy fire. That had both Adora and Catra running for cover, behind a large boulder. Finding both Lonnie and Kyle crouching behind it as well.

“What the hell is that thing?” Lonnie snarled, her fingers gripping the hilt of her stun baton tighter.

“How should I know?” Catra spat back.

“It seems magical...or very high tech?” Adora added, peeking around the large stone to try and keep track of the two orbs.

“It screamed when I hurt the white one, so alive?” Catra mused.

“But it shoots energy bolts...so tech?” Adora added.

“Or just magic?” Kylie offered.

“The Lazer bears were both tech and living creatures?” Catra responded.

Adora nodded, “But it could be alien...organic tech…”

“Or…just magic.” Kylie offered again, putting more force into his voice.

“Why does this matter?” Lonnie interjected with tried irritation. “They are attacking us…”

“Crita…. Or Tri-clops?” Adora muttered, trying to figure out who sent these creatures to kill them.

“Tri-clops…” Catra snarled, pointing high up to the very peak of a cliff several miles off. In which a small glint of metal reflected just beyond a rocky outcropping. “ A Death Seeker Drone has been spying on us.” She finished, glowering up at the drone in contempt.

Adora followed her line of sight, nodding when she too saw the glint of metal far in the distance.

Lonnie groaned, gripped her baton tighter.

While Kyle rolled his eyes and moaned piteously. Then squared his shoulders. As his blue eyes became focused and determined. He had tangled with a Death Seeker before and his magic gave him the edge to destroy it. He could do it again.

Melog had been crouched beside Catra, they growled and then faded away. Slinking off after their prey, determined to hunt down Tri-Clops and finish things before their master got hurt or killed.

They would never allow any Eternian threat to get to close to their master ever again!

“Is that the guy who’s been trying to kill Jitsu?” Lonnie asked, her voice rising in fear.

“Yep.” Catra answered, popping the last syllable angrily.

“Looks like we’re on the guys hit list now too.” Kyle grumbled.

“I figured that guy was a one trick pony…only capable of sending Death Seeker drones to do his dirty work. Nice to know his arsenal is varied.” Lonnie crossed her arms, with a disgruntled

frown. As the panicked screams of Max and Levi rang out. The sound of blaster fire and exploding stone followed.

Adora was quick to leap up on the boulder and send a couple arc's of energy towards the black orb, currently bombarding Max and Levi's hiding spot. Giving them enough cover to dart away into the sheltered health of tall grass further down the outcropping. Where they would regroup with Otis and Atila.

"Where did Melog go?" Catra cried in panic, finally noticing that her magical companion had taken off. Her expression was both angry and stricken, as she ducked out of hiding for a moment. To quickly scan the blasted out remains of the bluff their memorial had once been on.

"Alright let's do this!" Kyle growled, touching the boulder and summoning forth his own magic. Turning his body to stone, then with a battle cry he leaped out of cover and charged for the black orb.

"Dammit Kyle!" Lonnie and Catra shouted in unison. As Adora stood stunned atop the boulder, watching Kyle's brave act of stupidity. Get him blasted into the air and sent flying back towards their hiding spot.

He hit the ground with a grunt, going limp and unconscious instantly. His stone transformation reverted back to his normal body, of flesh and bone. As both Catra and Lonnie hovered over him. Their expressions flowing from fear and concern to irritation and resignation. Kyle would always be Kyle. Brave, kind hearted and foolhardy.

"Keep him safe." Adora commanded, leaping from the boulder and charging the black orb. That was about to shoot off into the sky again.

"I will." Lonnie promised.

Catra gave Lonnie a firm nod, then dashed off after Adora.

“It's my job to keep you safe, Princess!” She yelled at Adora.

Lonnie’s smile quickly crumpled into an anguished frown, as silent tears fell down her cheeks.
“You are a damn fool...you know that.” She ranted down at Kyle, giving his shoulders a quick shake. Attempting to rouse him.

The orbs were hovering just at the edge of the grass on the far side of the cliff. Scanning for life signs or nervous about entering the small field of wild wheat and grass. It was then Atila charged out of concealment within the grass, boot knife glinting in his hand as he rushed at the white orb. As it shielded it’s partner once again from Adora’s energy attacks. That were coming at them from behind. The black orb hissed, spinning around the white orb and firing on Atila. He was struck point blank in the chest. The blast set his cloth vest on fire and burned the thick hide on his chest. He howled in pain, ripping the flaming garment off and stomping on it with his hooves. As both orbs shot away into the sky to attack again from another angle.

It quickly became a deadly game of cat and mouse. The black orb would streak in, firing at them. Blasting apart one hiding spot after another, never allowing them time to regroup or strategize an attack. Keeping them panicked and scattered over the now battle scarred cliff. They never connected an attack on the black orb, as the white orb always protected it. Absorbing Adora’s energy arcs or Catra’s flames as she struck with her claws. Never tagging it as deeply as her first attack. Their stun batons had been adjusted to full pulse. Levi and Max had managed to shock the White Orb. But still the orb was able to absorb the deadly current effortlessly.

Soon the whole area was blasted into fine debris of smaller stones and gouged with scorched divots into the ground. The squad was exhausted and no longer had anywhere to seek cover. Now

standing in a small circle amid the rubble, out in the open upon the bluff that overlooked the beach below. Each one desperately scanning the perimeter of the cliff and the sky for any sign of their stealthy, speedy attackers.

“This sucks, this sucks, this sucks!” Levi ranted, her stun baton crackling menacingly in her hand as her brown eyes darted about nervously.

“What's the plan, Squad Leader.” Max glanced over to Adora. His greenish-blonde hair fluttered over his face in a gust of hot wind. That rushed up from the sea below, slightly masking the challenging stare he was now giving Levi.

Levi narrowed her eyes at Max, looking affronted. While Adora’s jaw dropped.

“Naw, uh.” Atila grunted. “What’s the plan, Force Captain!” He pointedly looked at Catra, who was standing shoulder to shoulder with Adora.

The feline moaned and rolled her eyes in disdain.

“Now is not the time for this!” Catra snarled. Never wanting their squad to be divided like this.

“Two teams, then. One with Adora and other with Catra and we attack from different fronts.” Lonnie was rolling with it, taking charge. With the same positive leadership she used back in Scorpiana with her troops. Accustomed to this fly by the seat of your pants planning. That she had used while leading the Rebellion in the Crimson Waste. As her rag tag bunch of fighters went up against the Clones and Chipped people during the war.

“Fine.” Catra nodded crisply. “Atila, Otis, Levi, you're with me.” Then she dashed off towards what was left of the tall grass within the sheltered heath. Ducking into cover with her team in seconds. Leaving Adora, Max, Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio to take off in another direction. Towards the rocky debris that littered the edge of the cliff.

Retaliation

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Huntara was cresting the peak of a steep bluff, intent on heading across a windswept field of grass. That was sheltered on one side by a ring of rock formations. The ledges and crags that loomed high above were barren and weathered from the constant assault of the salt laden wind. Blowing up from the shoreline far below. Scorpion Hills was the southern most portion of the deep canyons. Which formed the mysterious region of Etheria, known as the Dark Edge. A rugged, wind blown landscape of rolling hills, steep cliffs and wide heaths that overlooked the rocky shoreline of the Serpentine Straits.

She had just managed to ascend to the summit of a wide heath, when she first saw them. Two strange orbs, streaking across the sky far out over the water. Coming in from the dark silhouette of the Meadowlands coast far off on the horizon. She lost sight of the small objects for a moment as they ducked behind thin wisps of clouds. The wind was howling up off the strait, drowning out the low whistling they made as they flew. But the clouds were moving fast, sweeping across the sky like glossy ribbons.

She stopped and squinted up into the sun, tracking the orbs within the thin layer of clouds. Then catching sight of them again when they emerged, following their trajectory as they rocketed out of view down the coastline.

"Odd…" Huntara muttered, tapping the ear piece to activate it. Listening avidly to the com chatter of the Eternian Forces scattered throughout Etheria. She had been eavesdropping on the com channels for days, as she travel south. Heading back to the Crimson Waste. It was the last place she ever wanted to return too, but she needed to gather some more tracker's and perhaps enlist the aid of a few Bounty Hunter's. The infestation of

Eternian's was far larger in scope then she had first thought. This Skeletor fella, seemed to be a rather subtle and cunning type of conqueror. These Eternian's were set up in small infiltration teams. Stationed all over, hiding in plain view amid the Etheria population. Gathering tactical information on every Kingdom. This invasion was much more subtle and sinister than what Prime had done. They had set up a central base of operations, somewhere on the main continent. But Huntara had yet to figure out where, hence the need for reinforcements.

[Target acquired…] A gruff, deep voice rumbled from the earpiece.

[Aerial Assault Golem's inbound] A young male voice answered.

[The subject does not seem to have a portable rune stone, but was still able to transform into a Master of the Universe. Which is unheard of...Currently I have not managed to get a visual of her transforming. Since the last contact at the Horde Fortress, known as 'The Fright Zone'. So I want those Golem's in the red line, full, aggression. I need her to feel threatened enough to transform. So I can take proper readings of her magical power…what I got last time was inconceivable and I need it confirmed.] The gruff voice responded.

[Tri-clops...Lord Skeletor is becoming impatient with this little pet project of yours. If you waste those golems without gathering anything valuable.] A sultry, deep female voice echoed out in an exasperated tone.

[Lynn…If the data I got last time is verified. Then this 'She-Ra' could be far more of a threat to the Lord's future plans. Then He-man ever was.] Tri-clops stated heavily, his voice close to a growl as he ground his teeth.

[I am merely offering you a heads up...that your failure to kill Jitsu has strained Skeletor's patience. He has sent out a more trustworthy assassin to finish the task, before our plans are compromised. Our Lord wants you to concentrate on finding the

Shard of Kaydak that Jitsu lost. That relic is what truly matters in this back water world. If you keep ignoring his orders, for your passion projects. There will be repercussions] She offered, in a bland, bored tone.

[Noted.] Tri-clops snapped back, cutting the feed with a sharp crackle.

Huntara grunted, tapping the ear piece to cut her own feed.

"Well isn't that interesting.." She mused with a smug grin. "My prey must be nearby…" She squatted low, concealing herself into the tall grass that dominated this outcropping. Pulling a pair of Horde issued combat binoculars from her belt. Scanning the sheer cliffs and steep hillsides below for this illusive Eternian...Tri-clops.

Catra lay flat to the ground, concealed with her team within a green embrace of the thick grass. That was wild and overgrown within the shadow's of the steep, arid bluff that lined this part of the coast. Her team lay behind her, anxious for combat. Yet their outward demeanor was unbelievably calm. All were war hardened soldiers. Able to push down any unwanted emotions, to deal with later if they survived. Focused on what was required of them. Engage the enemy without any useless distractions such as fear or doubt or regret. Destroy, kill, be victorious.

Failure equals death.

That was what the Horde taught them. So they were primed to attack swiftly and effectively when commanded.

Levi was adjusting the setting on her stun baton. While Otis and Atila gripped their boot knives tight. Catra kept glancing upward to the looming sandstone cliffs and shallow clay ledges above them. Searching desperately for Melog. They had been taking off far too often these days. Going out on patrol before they slept was one thing, but she suspected they had taken off to find Tri-Clops on their own. Just like at Mystcor…

Her whole body was humming with anxiety and adrenaline. Her muscles twitched to go into action. To finish this battle quickly and go after Melog, make sure they didn't get hurt or captured like last time.

The high pitched whine, alerted her that the balls of destruction were hovering nearby. Her ears swiveled trying to catch the soft sound again. While her tail was lashing low to the ground. Her tail tip, unintentionally smacking Atila against the cheek, repeatedly. The Tauran huffed, batting her tail away in irritation. She ignored the frustrated smack to the tip of her tail. Laser focused on scanning the open sky above and the edge of the cliffs. Her mismatched eyes wide, pupils dilating as she searched for her prey.

"Force Captain…" Levi's nervous voice filtered through Catra's concentration.

"We are going to lay low...do not attack until I give the signal." Catra growled, also ignoring reprimanding Levi. Over the military title that she now hated being called. Expecting them to obey her orders. With no further questions.

She could feel the tension mounting from her team member's as the whine got louder, yet the orbs could still not be seen.

"Where are they…." Atila snarled, the dull thump of his tail tuft hitting the ground in agitation.

"Stay hidden…wait for my signal." Catra hissed, crawling forward a few meter's if any of them was going to become a target then she was.

"Catra…" Otis whispered, roughly in warning. As the Magicat slunk out of sight ahead of them in the grass.

Adora pressed herself up tight to the blast damaged boulder. Keeping a close eye on the Death Seeker drone hovering high

near the crags of a nearby cliff. It had never sought cover, uncaring that it was wide open for attack. Observing and recording the battle below. Tri-clops had to be up there somewhere, controlling that drone and also perhaps the other two? Adora was torn, should she lead her team up the cliff, take out Tri-clops or continue to fight the two drones down here. Would Catra and her team be able to handle them? The battle had not gone that well so far and they were nine strong.

Adora turned and pressed her back to the boulder, her mind spinning with counter maneuver's. Debating if she should split her strike team up? She would head after Tri-clops...with Max...Leave Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle to help Catra… or concentrate her forces on the two drones?

"Adora?" Lonnie's concerned voice drew her out of her head.

"I don't know what to do." Adora moaned, thumping the back of her head against the stone.

"That's new." Max huffed, crouching beside Lonnie. He turned and thumped his back against the stone beside her, gripping his stun baton close. As Lonnie leaned in close to Adora, crossing her arms over her chest. She cast her past leader a brief look of concern, before glowering down at the ground. Pep talks were not her thing and Adora's sudden need for assurance was startling.

"I am terrible at plans...they never work. Things always go sideways and then we're left improvising…and things just go downhill from there." Adora rambled and then sighed heavily, refusing to look at Lonnie. Keeping her focus on the ground also, balling her hands into tight fists at her sides. She had struggled silently for years as their Squad Leader, then with being a leader for the rebellion for years. Always putting on that brave smile everyday and making battle plans, doing what needed to be done day in and day out. Falling back into her calm bravado and fake confidence she had perfected back in the Horde. So the Princess's…so Glimmer felt she could rely on her to handle anything that came their way during the war. But now after

surviving the war, she was tired of pretending to be something she was never comfortable being. She needed to be honest with herself and with those she trusted.

She never wanted to be a leader, never wanted to be responsible for the lives of others. She had just wanted to follow orders, to fight, to protect others. Use the power she had been given to forge a better future for Etheria.

"What are you talking about?" Lonnie laughed nervously. Refusing to let on how Adora's sudden self doubt in herself was freaking her out!

Finally, Adora slid her eyes bitterly towards her.

"I am no Leader. I'm just a soldier…The last plan I came up with got Louis killed." She muttered, her voice thick with unshed tears of guilt and remorse. As her eyes fell to the ground in shame.

Rogelio growled, from his position crouched on the other side of the boulder, as Max cast him concerned looks.

"Adora…" Kylie reached out and grasped her shoulder, offering her a small sympathetic smile. "We never blamed you" He finished softly, as Adora slowly raised her watery blue eyes to meet his gentle ones.

"I blame myself...I was in charge, you guys depended on me to lead you to victory, to keep you safe on the battlefield. I failed…" Adora took a shaky breath, thumping the back of her head against the stone.

Rogelio's powerful tail curled up and around Adora's shin. Adora offered the lizard- kin a grateful smile. It was a comforting gesture she knew well, as Catra used her tail in the very same manner to soothe her.

"Get a hold of yourself, Adora!" Lonnie shouted sternly. She is very unnerved by Adora's lack of confidence in herself. She had never acted this way before...at least not when she knew her three

years ago. The blonde had always been so strong, self assured and completely unshakable.

Adora sighed, bowed her head and nodded. Needing to get herself focused and her emotions back under control.

It was the slowly increasing humming that spurned Adora back into action. Spinning around to raise her head just above the crumbling top of the boulder. Scanning the sky above the heath of tall grass, Catra and her strike team were hiding inside. Her blue eyes darted along the narrow ledges and ridges of the cliffs behind, desperate to track down the drones before they opened fire.

“We gotta draw their fire...before they see Catra and her team. Catra’s going to need the element of surprise for her teams attack to hit.” Adora glanced sideways at Lonnie and the other’s who nodded in agreement.

“Ok, let's break cover and fan out along the edge of the cliff here.” Lonnie commanded, pointing towards the burnt outcropping.

“Right.” Kyle reached for the dusty surface of the boulder, calling his magic to life. Turning himself to stone once more.

“Kyle...that didn’t help you before. Those things nearly blasted you into a fine powder. You are going to need armor far more powerful than that.” Lonnie commented.

Kyle growled and nodded, glancing around frantically as the humming grew louder. His fear and anxiety spiked and his search grew more frantic. Then his soft blue eyes widened with daring curiosity, as he reached for Adora’s magical shield.

“Kyle...what the hell?” Adora snapped her head down and to the side, eyes flaring in alarm as Kyle’s magic tapped into Sheana’s power. Suddenly she felt dizzy, as Kyle siphoned some of Sheana’s essence away and into his own body.

Kyle threw his head back and screamed in pain and exhilaration as the incredible power of Sheana surged throughout his body. His muscles flexed and strained under his long sleeve shirt, as they were amplified with magic power. His whole body felt electrified. A burst of power exploded from his body, like a concussion blast without sound. His eyes glowed a bright white, as his body morphed into the same ethereal metal as Adora's shield. The same gold eight sided star appeared upon his chest. As he stood tall, thrusting his chest out as a proud grin spread over his face.

"This feels amazing!" He exclaimed, thrusting two fists into the air. Accidentally sending a beam of prism light into the air.

"Oops…" He grimaced in dread, as the two drones shot out of the sky. Straight for their cover.

Adora was shocked, then scared. Staring down at her shield, that was still intact but the sheen was more dull. Kyle had stolen some of Sheana's magic. The sword of Despara vibrated angrily in her other hand. The red jewel flaring in rage. Adora squeezed her eyes shut tight, willing Despara to restrain herself. That Kyle didn't mean to imprison a fragment of Sheana in his own body. That he was just trying to help. Promising the goddess of destruction that she would get that fragment of Sheana back.

Kyle felt incredible, powerful, confident for the first time, that he could hold his own in battle. Basking in the mighty power now coursing through him. It made him more bold and fearless than ever before. So he broke cover, his boots pounding on the clay ground with a speed and strength he had never known before. He glared up at the black orb, his eyes glowing a fierce unyielding blue.

"Here...I am right here...come and get me!" He waved his hands over his head, screaming at the drones to notice him. He wanted to subdue those orbs all on his own and prove to everyone that he wasn't a screw up! That he was as capable and courageous as Adora. That he could keep his friends safe!

“Dammit Kyle!” Lonnie snarled, breaking cover with her quarterstaff fully extended. Rogelio, followed in quick succession. Dashing towards Kyle's side, just as the black orb fired.

Adora darted out of cover with Max, both of them rushing for Kyle. With her sword now sheathed once more as a bracer on her left wrist. Not wanting to chance that Despara might grow impatient or violent, and seek retribution against Kyle. She held Sheana’s shield low as she charged, intending to push Kyle out of the way and hopefully draw Sheana’s magic back from his body upon contact.

Kyle grinned triumphantly as the black orb fired on him, he raised an arm to block the energy bolt. The energy pulsed against his bicep, as he absorbed it. He swung his other arm, as if trying to punch the orb out of the sky. Sending an arc of light towards it. The white orb once again got in between and took the hit. Allowing the black orb to shoot off and retarget it’s new opponent. Kyle laughed boisterously as a smug, self-satisfied smile broke across his face. Bracing his hands on his hips and thrusting out his chest proudly. As the black orb fired on him once again. He took the hits square in the chest, laughing confidently in the face of death as he absorbed the energy blasts effortlessly. He thrust both arms out, sending two more arcs of light towards the black orb.

Before Lonnie and Rogelio could get to his side. Kyle raced off towards the field of tall grass that sheltered beneath a ridge of steep bluffs. Taking the plan into his own hands as he lured the orbs towards Catra and her team. His boots churned up the dried clay as he tore full speed into the grass. With the black orb in pursuit.

“Kyle!” Max shouted in alarm, as he skidded to a stop and watched Kyle run off.

Adora slowed her sprint to a staggering stop, gapping in both awe and uncertainty as Kyle ran past her. Charging down the bluff and diving into a forward roll disappearing into the grass. As the black

orb zoomed after him, firing on his heels. The energy blasts setting the field of dried grass a blaze. It was easy to kindle and with a mighty roar, it surged into an inferno. Kyle and the rest of the squad hiding in the grass, were instantly trapped inside a massive fire storm. Thick black smoke was soon collecting above the flames, concealing Kyle and the other half of their squad even more.

“Catra!” Adora screamed in terror. As Lonnie and Rogelio dashed up beside her, staring in horror at the out of control flames.

The white orb flew into the smoke, but it’s speed was slow, cautious. Two terrified squeals echoed from the inferno moments later. As Catra, Atila, Otis and Levi stumbled out of the smoke. Coughing and choking on the heavy fumes of burning grass.

“Kyle is still in there!” Lonnie screamed, now writhing in Adora’s restraining grip. As the blonde had sheathed the shield back on her right wrist and was grappling Lonnie around the waist to keep her from running into the flames.

Rogelio, eyes were narrowed. Being the least emotional and more logical of the three. He was debating the best way to enter the flames and find his boyfriend.

“Catra...can you magic those flames away?” Adora asked, her expression desperate and hopeful.

“I don’t know….I just know how to turn on the magic….I don’t really know how to do stuff with it yet…at least not on purpose” Catra ignited her flames anyway. Casting Adora a worried half smile. Adora nodded, totally understanding where she was coming from. Then Catra cautiously approached the inferno, wary that it was going to attack her. The sheer volume and ferocity of the fire was terrifying. As it was now devouring the whole of the hilltop, the flames shot up into the sky licking the edge of the cliffs that towered behind them. She glanced nervously down the hill they had walked up hours before, in rising fear. As the flames were now spreading, burning wildly. Walls of smoke billowed up into the

sky, swallowing the once clear blue sky in a thick, impenetrable black smog.

Angella's words echoed in her mind. This was her magic, she controlled it. Focusing on her intentions to Protect…strengthened by her will power to dominate, to control the wild elemental beast the flames had become. She believed she could summon what she needed. She just had to focus…draw upon what she had learned so far about how magic worked. Trust that Aldarion would heed her call and protect the ones she loved.

Taking a deep breath, calming her mind as she did before singing to Aldarion. She needed to do this, she needed to figure out how to control the flames...she needed to save Kyle! Catra cast her arms out towards the fire, as if she was trying to embrace it. Swallowing hard, as her eyes began to glow, mirroring the flames themselves.

The flames began to part, responding to Catra's will.

Soon a narrow corridor was created. It mimicked the corridor of flames that they had followed months ago to reach the Crystal pillars of the Fail Safe. Leaving Adora standing frozen for a moment, as she settled her sudden fear. Setting off that trap, had left a rather annoying trepidation when it came to fire. One that Adora was still dealing with. With a resolute nod. Dashing down the relative safety of the tunnel before doubt and fear could get the better of her resolve. Unfortunately, she was still working on trusting Catra. That nagging doubt that she wouldn't be there when she needed her. Still echoing in the back of her mind. She hated it! Wanted to banish those doubts and anxieties. But only Catra could vanquish those demons from Adora's heart. By keeping her promises…

Several minutes past, as Lonnie paced in front of the entrance. Her eyes darted to the corridor every now and then as she debated running in there herself. Rogelio stood near her, tapping

his left foot in growing agitation. While the rest of the squad hovered nearby, looking stricken and nervous. Catra ground her teeth, refusing to give into the waves of exhaustion now coursing through her. Commanding living flames proved to be rather difficult. The element was wild, stubborn and difficult to tame. It's hunger to devour was overwhelming. Constantly pushing against her will power to hold it in check. Like a willful, overzealous child that wanted what it wanted and would not back down.

"Hurry...Adora…" Catra ground out, squeezing her eyes shut tight as she struggled to contain the fire.

Adora moved cautiously down the twisting, narrow corridor. Walking deeper and deeper into the very center of the firestorm. The heat was intense, slamming against her like a wall on either side. The air was thin, caustic from the smoke rolling above the inferno. It burned her throat and left her eyes dry and stinging. Adora was forced to squint against the glare, her eyes burning. Tears streamed down her hot, flushed cheeks. She debated calling out to Kyle but breathing more heavily in the smoke would only damage her lungs. So she kept vigilant, scanning the burning grass on either side of her for any sign of Kyle.

It was the familiar golden glow that caught her attention. Hovering just beyond the fiery barrier to the left, atop a large boulder. A lanky figure was hunched over, holding two orbs in their lap. Protecting them from the flames, that were licking upward from the ground around the large rock. That Kyle had climbed to seek shelter above the fire. But now the boulder itself glowed like a red hot coal.

Adora nodded, setting her courage. As she called Sheana's shield back into her hands. She was more than a bit unnerved about having to push through another wall of fire. Ever since Mystacor when she nearly set herself on fire by stepping on that trap. Fire kinda freaked her out, she always needed to take a moment to push past the fear.

Despara’s bracer, vibrated with wrath as Sheana’s shield flared into her hands.

Adora glanced down at the silver accessory on her wrist anxiously. As the goddess’s anger began to ignite the nerves under her skin. She wanted vengeance...demanded retribution for the kidnapping of her partner’s essence.

The red rune stone, crackled with indigo lightning as Despara brooded.

Sheana responded by humming through the shield, soothing her partner wordlessly. Adora watched the silent communication between the two in awe.

As she felt calming waves engulf both her and the silver bracer. Once again Sheana tempered Despara’s rage.

‘“Ok...let's do this!” Adora encouraged, holding the large shield in front of herself and pushing through the flames. The flames parted along the edges of the shield, like fiery waves. As Adora moved through the wall of fire, the flames leaped away from her. Heeding Catra’s magical commandment not to harm her. Recoiling from the boulder, to the hillside further on. Creating a large ring of fire around the burnt clearing. Leaving nothing but smoke and smoldering remains of rock and ash behind.

Adora approached Kyle at a steady pace, as the ground was hot, melting the bottom of her leather boots. As she drew near, she found that Kyle was sitting cross legged upon a large boulder. Curled forward with his chin tucked tight against his collar bone. Adora gasped in horror at the gaping hole, burned through his stomach. He must have just stood there and took the black orbs energy blasts point blank. Trusting that his new armor would hold and he could take the hit, just to get in close and capture them. His reckless, fatal maneuver had proven successful though. His hands had morphed into large golden hammer’s and the two orbs were now trapped between them. They were not moving, slumped against each other and lying unmoving in Kyle’s lap. He

must have smashed them together…perhaps destroyed them or knocked them out? They were now either dead or unconscious. Adora couldn't determine more beyond that inside this firestorm. She determined that Kyle had used the cover of the smoke to sneak up on them. Laying in wait inside the fire, until they got close, then exploded out of cover to contain them. He had trusted that the armor he absorbed from Sheana would hold….but unfortunately his will power and stamina did not. His body was not conditioned to channel that powerful magic and he was unable to hold onto it for very long. That was what it had been like for her too at the beginning. It took her years of physical and mental training to hold onto Sheana's power for an extended period of time.

"KYLE!" Adora screamed, as she closed in finally getting a good look at his wounds. All the blood drained from her face, her blue eyes stricken, with fear and grief.

As Kyle slowly raised his head, his hair was singed away. What was left was standing up in dried, blackened tufts. His face was covered in a thin layer of black soot, patches of skin on his forehead and cheeks peeling away. His flesh was so badly burnt, it was oozing blood and puss. Which was smeared all over his face and down his neck. His shirt had been burned away, revealing the blackened, bloody mess that was his chest. The skin along his arms was just as gruesome, covered in large blisters. Oozing more puss and blood that was pooling on his thighs. He looked exhausted. Grey bruises were forming under his eyes, the ethereal light of Sheana's power was flickering.

"Adora...it hurts…" Kyle croaked, his voice barely a whisper.

Adora gasped in horror at Kyle's tragic state, sprinting for him, as Sheana's shield faded away. The golden bracer reformed on her wrist as she ran.

Adora was moving as quickly as possible, carrying Kyle in her arms. Not wanting to jostle Kyle too badly. He was curled against her chest, the orbs tucked securely in his lap. Her heartbeat was hammering inside her chest, the whole time they traveled the length of the fire corridor. As he seemed to fade in and out of consciousness, becoming delirious from the pain. Mumbling strange things, about small voices whispering in his head. He was growing weaker, laying so very still in her arms. She was scared he had already died.

Several excruciating minutes later, Adora emerged from the flames. Carrying a barely conscious Kyle, bridle style in her arms.

As she moved beyond the wall of flames, Catra released her hold on the fire. Finally allowing it to consume the grass down the hillside. The inferno roared to life once more, crackling menacingly at the magicat who had forced it to bow to her will. Catra crumpled to her knees, heaving for breath as she struggled not to pass out. She sluggishly raised her head a few moments later, catching sight of Adora and Kyle.

"Kyle!" Catra cried in horror, scrambling to her feet and dashing to Adora's side. As Adora set the dying young man on the ground amid the circle of stones on the cliff that overlooked the rocky shoreline. There was nothing left of their monument to their friends, but barren and cracked ground. Even the stones had blackened from the heat, when the fire engulfed the cliffside. If Kyle was going to take his last breaths, in a few moments. Adora wanted to lay him to rest where their epitaph once was. To honor him in the same way they had sought to honor the kids who died during training.

"Oh...my…." Lonnie gasped, as she fell to her knees before Kyle.

Rogelio howled in anguish at the grizzly sight of Kyle's burnt body.

The rest of the squad crowded around them, each wearing expressions of grief and horror.

Kyle’s hammers morphed back into hands as the last of Sheana’s light faded from his eyes.

The Blue Runestone on Adora's bracer, flared briefly as the magic returned.

Then Kyle gasped and began to shiver violently as he went into shock. His body finally felt the full effects of his fatal injuries.

“You….fearless...fool.” Lonnie moaned, tears streaming down her cheeks.

Lonnie reached out to touch his cheek, then hesitated, her finger curling into a fist. Her hands were shaking when she timidly brushed her fingertips against the side of his face a moment later. A strangled whimper escaped her tight lips. As she felt the moist ichor of Kyle’s blood upon her finger tips.

Rogelio knelt on Kyle’s other side, taking his hand in his. Wanting him to feel his touch and know that he was not alone. Tears streamed down Rogelio’s face, he couldn’t deal with how fragile Kyle was right now. He couldn’t accept that Kyle’s body was broken and that he could be taken from him any second.

“Ro...Ro...Lon…” Kyle whispered faintly.

“I’m here…” Lonnie whimpered.

Rogelio lightly brushed his clawed thumb across Kyle’s palm. His hands were the only part of him that was not damaged.

“So cold...Don’t hurt anymore...just really cold.” Kyle chuckled ruefully.

Lonnies’ shimmering hazel eyes flared in both horror and misery.

Kyle sluggishly opened his eyes, seeking both Lonnie and Rogelio’s. His eyes barely opened, to mere slits and he couldn’t really see either of them. His gaze was unfocused, as if he was already looking into the beyond.

“I’m afraid.” He whimpered, in a weak, fragile voice.

That admission gutted Adora, who rushed to kneel beside Kyle’s head. The orbs rolled out of his lap, hitting the hard, cracked clay ground with dull thumps. Catra moaned, standing stiffly behind Adora. Balling her hands into tight fists at her sides. Seeking to contain the pain and rage, at losing another of her bunk mates.

“Horde...control chips?” Max crouched down beside the white orb. His expression was grim, eyebrows furrowed in confusion. He lightly tapped the tiny oval piece of metal. That was attached to the underside of the orb, with a red diamond shaped control chip in the middle.

Catra sniffled, rubbing a finger under her nose as she fought to stay calm. Her eyes had welled up with tears that were threatening to fall. She had never thought she would cry again over another Squad-mate. She had thought she had hardened her heart to such tragedies. As they became more and more frequent growing up.

But Kyle’s imminent death was hitting her hard! Needing to distract herself from the tragedy and focus on something she could actually affect. She brushed her tail lightly across the back of Adora’s neck, before moving away to investigate the orb with Max.

Adora bowed over Kyle’s broken body. Staring down at her golden bracer, as her right hand was bracing Kyle’s head in her lap. Her gaze was transfixed upon the blue jewel, concentrating so fiercely she had blocked out everyone and everything else happening around her. She refused to let Kyle die!

She needed Sheana’s healing powers, but had no idea how to call them. Summoning the weapons had been easy, almost second nature. Having something physical to focus on, the power seemed

so much more solid and it was easy to pull that power into existence. But finding that metaphorical thread towards the healing aspect of Sheana's powers had always been more elusive. It required so much more focus and determination. But she had summoned it numerous times over the years, but always while transformed as She-Ra. This was the first time she was calling forth that incredibly powerful magic as Adora. It was terrifying...As She-Ra, she had the fortitude and protection of a goddess. Allowing her the strength and endurance to handle the physical and mental drain that kind of magic took from her. Would her human body and mind be able to handle the strain? Or would it permanently damage her...maybe kill her in the process?

That selfish fear of death was holding her back but only for a moment. Finding the courage to sacrifice herself for others was second nature as well. Thanks to how Shadow Weaver had raised her. So she swallowed hard, darting her eyes up for just a second to gaze fondly at Catra. Her blue eyes shimmered with tears, as she set aside all her hopes and dreams for that beautiful future. She had glimpsed back in the Crystal Castle a month ago on her way to the Heart. Hoping that if she did not survive this...that Catra could forgive her and move on and find happiness with someone else. Perhaps, Scorpia would be able to repair the damage Adora was about to inflict upon the magicats heart. Releasing a slow breath of resolution, she closed her eyes and committed to summoning the healing power. Leaning over Kyle, she hovered her right hand over the hole in his stomach. The silver bracer vibrated in warning on her left wrist. As her body began to glow with the familiar golden aura, she snapped her eyes open as Sheana's magic flooded into her. Her eyes sparked, then flared, an ethereal blue.

"Adora!" Catra snapped her head up from investigating the white orb, as she felt the full power of Sheana engulf her girlfriend.

Adora screamed in agony, as the power collided with something solid and unyielding. Her body was instantly on fire, golden lightning exploded from her golden bracer and arced across her body. As she convulsed, dropping Kyle's head. Curling up tight into

a ball in some desperate attempt to protect herself, as the magic dissipated back into the ether.

"Adora you idiot...what were you thinking?" Catra's voice was distant as she lost consciousness.

(**You are reckless and impulsive)** Sheana's gentle voice reprimanded her.

Adora groaned and rolled her head to the side, suddenly feeling nauseous. If she was going to expel what meager amounts of food she had in her belly, she did not want to choke on it. Since she found herself flat on her back, she could see out of the corner of her eyes. The gray smoke of the grass fire was rolling over the sky above. It's murky, dark visage suited her tumultuous mood.

(**We promised not to enter your soul until you are ready, if you want to summon my healing. Then you must weave a new thread to the magic...)** An image of Sheana's bracer flashed in her mind. Making Adora groan in embarrassment, as she knew this. She had used the Sword of Protection as a conduit, a reservoir for the healing magic. Before funneling just what she needed from the rune stone into her body. But in the heat of the moment she had fallen back into what she knew after destroying the Relic. When she had to channel all that magic threw her own body, since she no longer had the sword. Never thinking that the magic would deny her.

Adora rolled over onto her stomach and pulled herself up on all fours with a long drawn out moan of pain and humiliation.

"Adora?" Catra's worried voice was still echoing, as she felt the magicats hands grip her shoulders.

"I'm alright...just a misfire." She knelt up, flashing Catra a weak, embarrassed smile that resembles more of a grimace.

“That was one hell of a misfire!” Catra spat back, cupping her cheeks tenderly.

“Gotta, use the healing through the bracer..” Adora grunted, turning back to Kyle. Her eyes once again clear and determined, as she hovered her left hand over the blue gem. Instead of using her right hand to heal Kyle.

Catra nodded, giving her space. Adora was stubborn and headstrong, when she put her mind to something. Nothing was going to stop her from healing Kyle. Catra didn't want to lose the scrawny idiot either. So she stood by, keeping a close eye on Adora and their surroundings, not wanting the blonde to be interrupted by another attack.

Atila, elbowed Otis and nodded towards Catra. Noticing that she had taken up a guarding stance behind Adora. So they too, moved to flank the blonde. Keeping a close watch over the open cliff and blackened remains of the hillside. Soon Max and Levi followed suit, guarding the front of their little troupe.

As Rogelio and Lonnie knelt on either side of Kyle. As the runestone flared on Adora's right wrist. Warm, tendrils of golden energy pulsed from the Rune, up into the fingertips of Adora's left hand and soon engulfed her entire hand. When she had taken what she needed, she reached out then and pressed her fingers to the grievous wound on Kyle’s stomach. The blue gem flashed ever brighter and in seconds, Kyle's body was engulfed in the pure healing light of Sheana.

Chapter End Notes

Well, that all I got for now. I am working on the next part. You guys will get further updates as soon as it is all written and ready to post.

Until we meet again, Thanks for reading and supporting me! I will return, with Kingdom of Dreams soon.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!